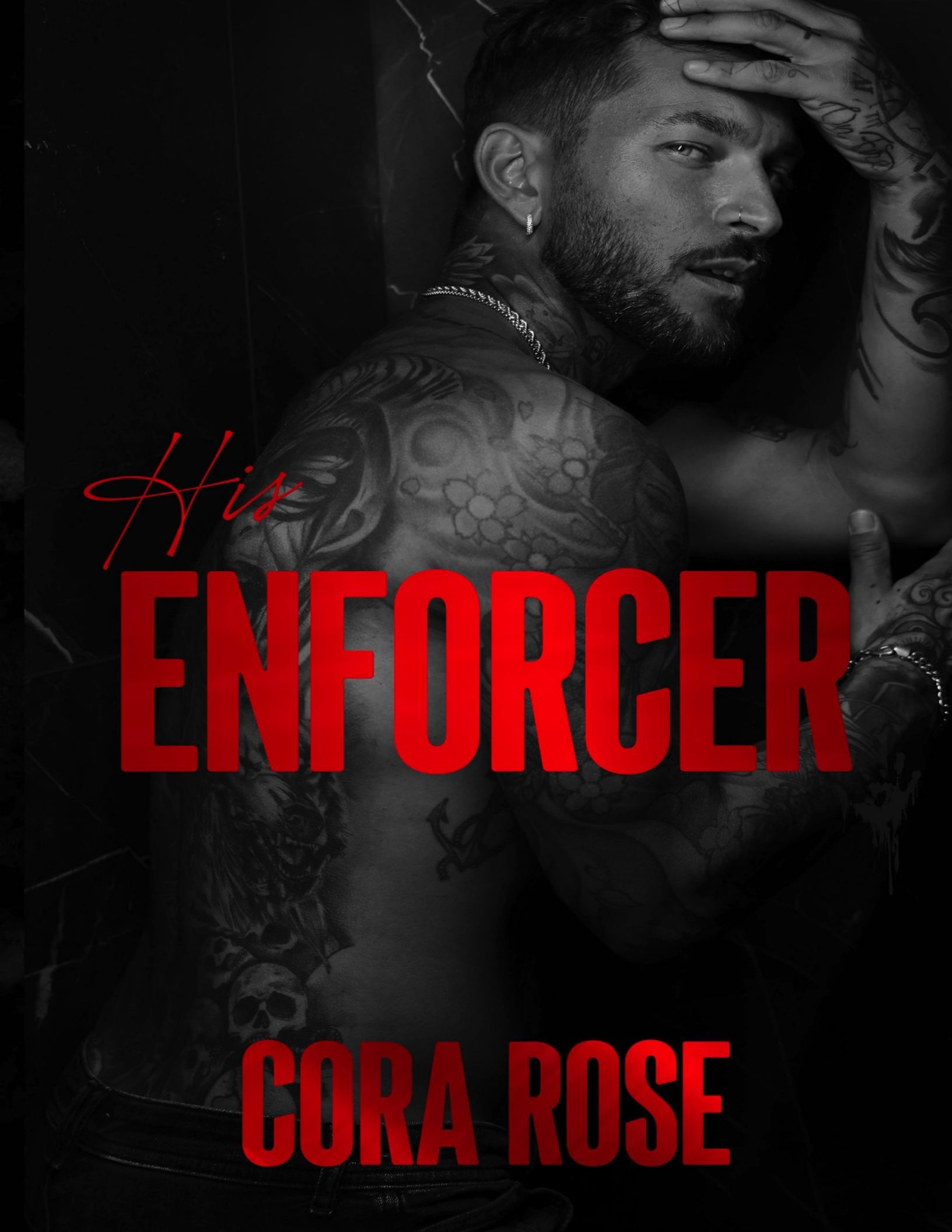
His
ENFORCER
CORA ROSE

HIS ENFORCER

CORA ROSE

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BLURB

Working for a notorious mob boss like Anthony Costello for fifteen years has taught me a thing or two about dangerous men. I myself have been chiseled and beaten into someone to be reckoned with. And I've even come to relish in the pain, to crave it. But no one gets under my skin quite like Luca Rossi, Anthony's right-hand man. I hate him more than words can express, I always have. He torments me and toys with me, just a plaything in his twisted and cruel game of control, until I'm feral with rage and barely able to contain myself.

But when a series of unidentified bodies begin showing up on our property and it becomes clear someone is trying to take the Costello family down, Luca and I are teamed up to solve the mystery. And working up close and personal with this man has me realizing that there's no one in the world quite as dangerous to me as him. Because the real reason I hate Luca so much, and maybe even the reason why I hate myself, is because he'll never really want me.

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To Lark. The one book you didn't read requires a dedication.
Half doesn't count.

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TRIGGER WARNINGS

This book is a dark rom-com with these trigger warnings:
Violence, blood, death, drug use, drug overdose, mild degradation and dub-con.

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CONTENTS

Prologue
Chapter 1
Chapter 2
Chapter 3
Chapter 4
Chapter 5
Chapter 6
Chapter 7
Chapter 8
Chapter 9
Chapter 10
Chapter 11
Chapter 12
Chapter 13
Chapter 14
Chapter 15
Chapter 16
Chapter 17
Chapter 18
Chapter 19
Chapter 20
Chapter 21
Epilogue

About the Author
Also by Cora Rose

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PROLOGUE

THREE YEARS AGO

VIKTOR

I make my way through the dimly lit room, feeling eyes slide my way, tracking up and down my bare skin. A shiver of anticipation moves through me and my teeth sink into my bottom lip.

I have a secret—one no one knows, but me.

A hand brushes against my waist and down to the firm globes of my ass, making me whimper slightly, the color of the collar around my neck indicating that I don't mind being used by the men in the room.

Free use, they call it.

I'm at their mercy, completely at their whim.

A finger traces up my ass crack and I'm pushed forward roughly, my hands grabbing onto the ornate wooden chair in front of me as the man behind me slots his dick at my hole and pushes in.

I groan at the rough intrusion, his thick cock entering my slick entrance without any warning or finesse. But that's why I'm here. I come here weekly to be used, to let off steam.

My job is stressful, my life always on the line, and so I find solace in not having to think. To just be used like a sex toy.

I want them to take the decision away from me. I don't want to have to make any while I'm here. I want to just *be*.

Skin slaps against skin as the man fucks me. My eyes close, dick throbbing between my legs, bouncing in the confines of my lace jockstrap. I can feel people positioned around the large ornate room watching me, some touching themselves, others fucking their partners as I get railed. Groans and gasps meet my ears, some of them my own, but most from the people finding pleasure in the scene before them.

There's a reason Eden is so expensive to join. It's a club that caters to the elite, offering up sin on a silver platter.

Normally, I wouldn't be able to afford such a place, but I received an invitation because of who I work for and was given an ample discount because of my preference to be used. Or, at least, that's what I assume.

One of the hostesses let it slip the first month that some of the men in attendance come here just for me.

"You're a fan favorite, Viktor."

The more I contemplate why I got an invite, the more I believe that it's my preference to let them fuck me however they want. It's the only theory that makes sense.

How they found out that I like this is beyond me, but I guess word gets around. And honestly, I wasn't upset by it. I may have preened at the sentiment of being the preferred bottom at the establishment, may have carried myself a little straighter when I walked through the dressing room doors and into the dimly lit space to change.

As I'm thrust into, I let my gaze roam, taking in the people around me. I don't recognize most of them. Usually I come here on Sunday nights, but I find myself here on Thursday after a particularly stressful day at work.

And work is always stressful as a soldier—or a bodyguard, as the mainstream likes to call it—for a mob family. Not that I tell anyone about my job, but that's what I do. Day in and day out.

And while the assignments I take on can be arduous, the majority of my stress comes from the underboss of the Costello family, Luca Rossi. *That man*… I huff loudly, my hole contracting around the cock inside of me. He infuriates me, drives me crazy. I hate working under him. I fucking *hate it*.

A groan slips from my mouth as my cock throbs between my legs.

No, I won't think of him while being fucked.

I refuse.

He makes me feel things—things long ago buried and yet deeply engrained, as if he's a part of me somehow. As if I've known him in another

life.

It makes no sense.

Nothing about him makes sense.

And still, I can't help the way he infiltrates my mind in the middle of the night, calling out to me, to my body, to my soul.

Fuck, I hate him.

Thankfully, before I can come to the thought of Luca's handsome face, the bulge of his biceps, and the thick outline of his cock, the man behind me groans and I feel him fill his condom before pulling out of me, leaving me to catch my breath and push myself upright. A twinge moves through my ass and thighs, and I let out a relieved breath. Fuck, that was nice. Just what I needed.

I adjust my hard length and move forward, striding toward the bar to order a drink. I'm mostly naked, but so is everyone else. We're all in some stage of undress, a few wearing nothing at all.

I just arrived at Eden and I'm already starting to relax. This is exactly what I needed tonight. Especially after the way Luca had accidentally touched me earlier, his hand unexpectedly brushing against mine. The way my skin broke out in goosebumps, the way I shivered.

The effect he has on me.

It's addictive. An addiction I need to satiate immediately, to drown, to expel. Which is why I'm here. It always helps. It always takes the edge off.

"Look who it is. Didn't expect to see you tonight," the bartender, Amir, says. His curly brown hair is wild on top of his head, his dark blue eyes twinkling. Fuck, he's cute and always smiling. He looks like he'd treat a partner well. If he were my type, I'd have him.

Sadly, he's not.

It seems I only truly want the one person I can't have.

The one who ultimately won't ever have me.

"It was a stressful afternoon," I reply, leaning forward and tapping my fingers on the shiny bar top. No one here knows what I do for a living, who I truly am. It would keep too many away from me, fearing for their lives. I'm glad I'm anonymous here. Just a hole to be fucked.

"Ah, so a double then?"

"Yeah, and maybe a hit of something if you have it."

He winks at me and then pulls a packet full of blue and white pills from his pocket.

“On the house,” he says, dropping a few into my palm. I pop one in my mouth, happy to have something in my system to help me relax. Don’t know what it is, but Amir always hooks me up with the good stuff.

Sex is always a major player in helping me feel good, but drugs can help too.

I don’t often partake, but today is one of those days. It’s been a long fucking week.

As Amir hands me my drink, a smirk pulls his lips up as another man approaches me from behind. He doesn’t speak a word, just spreads my cheeks and uses me. He’s thicker than I’m used to, longer and pierced, but it’s just what I need.

It hurts so good.

The pain, mixed with the pill just beginning to make its way into my system, is melting away the anxiety I’ve been holding onto all week. My nerve endings start firing and every thrust is heightened.

Arching back, I press into the movements, loving the sensations that slice up my abdomen. Bliss, want, ecstasy.

“Yes, take it,” the man whispers into my ear, and I shiver as I lean my head back slightly, letting him reach around and grab onto my aching cock. A moan slips from my lips as my fingers scramble for purchase on the bar top.

I can feel eyes on me, but I don’t care.

I come here for one reason.

And this, right here, is the reason.

Free, uninhibited sex. No judgment, no expectations except to be used.

With my job, a career I never expected to fall into, I don’t have a lot of time to meet people. Dating sounds exhausting, and I can’t really explain what I do for a living. It could get them killed if they let it slip. The only other option is to date someone I work with, and no one appeals.

Well, one does, but I loathe him.

The way he ignores me while simultaneously turning me on, flirting in that casual way he does, even though I know he’d never go for someone like me.

He plays with me and mixes me up.

I can’t explain the rage I feel when I look at him now. It didn’t always used to be this way. For years, it was just a blind infatuation, but year after

year of torment, the infatuation turned to disappointment and then to anger. I'll never have him, and that's made something inside of me feral.

I know I won't ever be going there. Because of the mutual loathing, yes, but also because the asshole is straight.

The man behind me comes with a grunt and then pulls out of me, leaving me hard and aching, completely unfulfilled. But I don't expect to get off. It usually doesn't happen until the end of the night. The men here rarely take the time to work me over the edge right away.

And I don't mind it.

That's not why I'm here.

I pick up my crystal glass with a trembling hand and bring it to my lips.

The clear liquid burns my throat, and mixed with the drugs in my system, I find myself relaxing even more.

"Men only, huh?" a voice next to me asks, and I turn to meet a woman's gaze.

I nod and take another sip of my drink. "Yeah."

"Shame," she replies as she crosses her long legs and winks at me.

She's beautiful, aesthetically pleasing to the eyes, with a slim build and long dark hair, but she does nothing for me. I sometimes think things would be easier if I were into women. But I'm not. As a kid, I always wondered if I was different from the men who came to visit my mom, their lurid grunts and filthy words making me recoil.

It wasn't until much later, when I saw *him*, that I knew for sure.

I'm gay.

"I haven't seen you before. This your first time here?" I ask, and she tilts her chin down, her lashes fluttering slightly.

"Ah, it's obvious, huh? I knew it would be, but I tried like hell to look confident."

"It's not that obvious. Just a little," I say as a low moan emanates next to me. Someone else is getting fucked thoroughly. "Who are you here with?"

"A friend. He wanted to show me the fun parts of the city. And when he told me he needed to stop by a sex club for some business, well…I had to see this with my own eyes."

A laugh escapes me at how candid she is, my eyes falling to her empty drink. "I like you. Next one is on me."

She accepts my offer, and I call Amir over, letting her place an order for a dirty martini.

“So, this guy brought you here and then left you? Kind of rude.”

“Like I said, business. He’s always working. All work and no play. Very dull and boring.”

“I know assholes like that,” I reply and then take in her tight-fitting dress, her neck absent of a collar, her wrist adorned with a gold chain.

“So, you just want to watch then?”

“Yeah, I think watching is good for my first time. And I’m very happy I am. Watching you is quite nice. I’m Alina, by the way.”

“Well, Alina, it feels quite nice to be watched, too,” I reply, and we grin at one another.

“I wouldn’t normally ask this, but,” she leans a little closer to me, her perfume drifting up to meet me, “How many guys do you normally take in one night?”

I shrug, the drugs and alcohol in my system calming the instinct to bristle at the intrusive question. “Depends on how horny everyone is. Sometimes five, sometimes fifteen.”

She leans back and whistles, taking the drink Amir has set before her, and nods.

“Well, then. That is quite impressive. I’ve only ever managed three, and I thought I was a rebel.”

“You’re not a rebel until you have four all at once,” I say with a smirk.

“Noted. Perhaps I’ll see you do that tonight.”

“Haven’t been here on a Thursday before, so who knows? Maybe I’ll beat my personal record. Maybe it will be five.”

She giggles at that just as someone approaches her from behind. I turn away, wanting to give her privacy. I don’t want to get involved with anyone she’s with. Nor do I want any drama.

I just want to be fucked.

Just as I think that, two men move up beside me, their strong hands turning and guiding me toward the middle of the room. They obviously want to put on a show and honestly, with the way I’m flying right now, that’s perfectly fine with me. I’m relaxed and loose, ready to take on anything or anyone.

Before me is an oversized velvet ottoman and I stare down at it, wanting to wait for these men to tell me what to do, to arrange me how they want. I

really don’t want to make any decisions. I like to be owned.

As I stand there and wait, I peer over my shoulder to glance at Alina, to see if she’s watching when I see him. The man who meets me in my dreams, the one who touched my hand today and made me rethink my entire life.

“Fuck,” I murmur when I see Luca Rossi standing there, a cigarette between his lips, his eyebrow cocked.

What the hell is he doing here? What the actual fuck!

I don’t have too much time to ponder it because I’m suddenly being pressed onto the cushions, ass up in the air, my head twisted to the side. And from my position, cheek smashed into the fabric, I’m forced to look at him, his gaze boring into mine.

Asshole is going to watch.

Goddammit, I hate this. I want to scream, to shout at him to leave me the fuck alone, but I can’t. Because I love that I hate it. Love that I want it.

He can watch. I won’t tell these men to stop fucking me. If Luca wants to see this, he can. There’s no shame in what I do. And honestly, this is *my* place. Not his. Whatever business he has, whatever brought him here, he can do it elsewhere.

The man behind me slides his fingers into my ass, and I grunt, my nostrils flaring, my dick leaking.

“He’s loose,” he says before adding another finger. “Think we can both fit.”

I turn my gaze back to Luca, who is still staring at me intently. He’s leaning forward in his seat, that lit cigarette hovering near his lips. He looks sinister, focused. I’ve seen him like this when he’s interrogating a suspect. It’s always that stance, the look he wears before he beats the shit out of them.

He lets out a puff of smoke and wets his lips.

Fuck him for being here. Really, fuck him for invading my space. But there’s no going back now. He already knows why I’m here. It’s obvious now. My ass is in the air, the collar is around my neck.

I know he’ll use this against me if I let him watch, but I also don’t want to leave because of him.

I don’t want him to win.

For some reason, the thought of him having even the tiniest sliver of control over my sex life makes anger and lust surge through me. It burns

through my chest, carving out an angry welt as my muscles tense and my flushed cock drips.

“Put in more,” the man behind me says as lube is stuffed inside of me, my fingers curling into the velvet beneath my hands. I will my eyes closed so I don’t look at Luca during this.

I’m not ashamed.

There’s nothing to be ashamed of.

This is my kink, not his.

He doesn’t own me in any way.

Suddenly, my collar is yanked back and I’m forced to stand, the men maneuvering me into position, one lying on his back on the ottoman and the other lifting me to sit on his cock. I take it easily, my channel wet and open from being fucked twice already.

I glance down at the burly man beneath me and lean forward as I feel the other cock slot at my entrance. I bear down, taking it with a low moan, my eyes flicking open and closed, my gaze falling on Luca once more.

He hasn’t looked away, his cigarette gone now as the men work me over, my hole taking a beating as they do. But I relish it, the pain, the sensation moving up my spine, down my thighs, and settling right in my balls.

“Fuck, I bet he could fit a third in here,” the man behind me groans as his skin slaps against my ass.

I bet I could. I’m just that good.

I turn to look at Luca once more, but see that he’s no longer sitting in his seat. Where the fuck did he go? Why the fuck did he leave? Questions swirl through my hazy mind as the men work their dicks in and out of me.

Alina is still watching, another drink in her hand. She holds it up with a wink just as the man behind me slams into me roughly.

I gasp, my back arching slightly as another man comes to stand beside me, reaching down to grab his dick from his pants and pulling my head toward him to thrust inside my mouth.

I moan at being used so thoroughly, the alcohol and drugs in my system making me so fucking high that my cock positively aches to come.

I want to. At least once tonight. I want to explode.

Groans and the slap of skin resonate around the room. Mostly from us, but some from the people watching and getting off on the show we’re giving them.

Thursdays are turning out to be better than expected.

If only Luca hadn't shown up to watch.

You fucking love it.

You crave his attention.

The man in my mouth comes first, ripping his condom off and exploding on my face. I gasp, blinking wildly as another man approaches, unzipping his pants and pulling out his hard dick. I open my mouth, and he slides in, using my throat and tongue until I'm floating. Just a body used for pleasure.

Luca is forgotten. His dark gaze, his tattooed hands. The way he watches me, the way he sneers.

All of it disappears into a puff of smoke.

I'm no longer Viktor, soldier for the Costello family, but a man who is taking it like a good boy.

I moan, my body being worked over by several other people until I'm left on that ottoman, my body splayed face down, covered in cum, eyes fluttering shut as I struggle to breathe.

I never did get off, I think as I feel my hard cock press against the velvet of the ottoman. But I'm too tired to move, to find any relief. I will just die like this, used and broken.

Suddenly, someone moves up behind me, and I instinctively spread my legs, but then I hear it—a low, threatening tone.

"No more. He's done."

Luca.

I thought he left. I was sure he'd gone.

"The collar's still on," the other man replies, but then I hear the distinct cock of a gun and a muttered, "Oh shit, man. I didn't know."

I try to lift my head to glance back at him, but I can't. Too tired to do anything but lie here.

"Please," I say, and Luca huffs.

"No."

A jacket is placed over my bare back, the scent of Luca enveloping me as I feel strong, familiar arms pull me up.

"Come on. We're going home."

"I'm not done," I rasp, my throat sore, body aching.

"You're done," he says lowly, almost deadly, so I lean into his chest as he guides me out of the club. His car is waiting at the entrance, a sleek

black Pagani Huayra that he looks so fucking good in.

The way I've imagined myself in the passenger seat, naked, leaning over and sucking his dick as he drives.

I step barefooted into it, his strong arms reaching over and helping me buckle in.

"My things," I croak.

"I have them," he replies, slamming the door and then sliding into the driver's seat.

As the car starts up, a low rumble that's powerful and full of unabashed sex, I pull his jacket tighter around my chest and close my eyes.

I don't know why Luca insisted I leave the club, but here I am—confused, still fucking high, and utterly exhausted.

"Where are you taking me?"

"Back to my place."

"I don't want to go anywhere with you."

"You're fucking going, Viktor," he grunts, and then his car accelerates down the road. "And when I'm certain you won't fucking die from whatever the fuck you've ingested, I'll have you brought home."

I can do nothing but agree.

I'm not ready to die.

Not yet.

I have so much more to do.

We never talk about what happened that night after Luca took me home.

It's never brought up, never mentioned. It's almost as if it never really happened. The only remembrance I get each passing year is a single black rose, hidden in my bag, waiting for me. A toxic reminder of what we did, of what I thought I had for that one night.

Part of me thinks I imagined it all, that the drugs and alcohol, mixed with the stress of work and the exhaustion from being fucked over and over again, caused me to conjure it all up.

The memory of Luca pushing inside of me that night, of him whispering those words in my ear.

"My little slut."

Perhaps I did just dream it.
Perhaps it was all a story I created in my head.
I don’t know anymore.
And I don’t care to remember.
But I do. And so does he. The rose is a reminder.
We can’t fucking forget.

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1

PRESENT DAY

VIKTOR

"Viktor, what the fuck are you doing?" Luca growls, peering over his shoulder at me as he crouches down in the dim light of the warehouse. His light brown hair falls over his face and he pushes it back with those thick, tattooed fingers. Those fucking fingers…the way I want them to wrap around my neck and squeeze.

The way they did that night.

"Stop dicking around and help me with this."

I wasn't dicking around. I was adjusting my dick because his ass looks good in those slacks. Much to my displeasure. Fucking hate that my body responds to anything regarding him. Three damn years and I can't quite calm down.

It's terminal at this point.

"Calm down," I murmur as I stare down at the body on the floor, a young woman. Her tongue hangs out of her mouth unnaturally, eyes staring up at me, unseeing. Clearly dead. She's one of ours, I suppose, since she's in one of our warehouses and was discovered by another soldier while he was making his rounds. Or maybe she's not. I don't fucking know. She has no ID on her and I've never seen her before, but I can make an educated guess.

Whoever she is, she's not where she belongs. That much is certain.

“I was keeping a lookout,” I reply angrily as I lean down next to him, jostling him slightly. Touching him makes something flutter deep inside my stomach.

Angry, razor-sharp butterflies. They slice at my chest and make those angry wounds reopen every single time. I do it anyway. I do it because I like the pain of it.

Luca huffs and knocks me back with his elbow and I nearly fall over. Right into something that looks concerningly like vomit.

“Fuck off,” I grumble, but he just ignores me.

“Shut the hell up and be useful. We need to call the cleaners,” Luca says. “Get rid of the evidence. Whoever is doing this wants her to be found and they want us implicated in it.”

“I’ll call Bane…”

“No, he’s too messy and loud. We have to call the Andromeda brothers now that they’re working with us.”

Well. Fuck. Me.

“Do we have to?” I murmur, and Luca stands up, pulling a cigarette from his coat pocket. He places it between his lips, and I stare at his mouth a little too long. I fucking hate those lips, the way they curve up when he’s feeling sinister, the way they can form just a few words that have me shriveling. And panting.

I hate that fucking mouth.

I hope it falls off. Right onto my dick.

“Do as I say,” he snaps, and I feel myself shrink back as my dick grows hard.

I fucking hate that I’m like this.

I really need to go to the club again and get this frustration worked out of me. But I haven’t been back since that night. I haven’t been able to make myself go. And because of that, I’m so close to the edge, teetering precariously. I’m a second away from falling completely. And while I have had some hookups in the years since, I haven’t stepped foot in the club.

Three years is too long.

Too fucking long.

Without a word, I pull the electric lighter from my pocket and hold it up to his cigarette.

He leans forward slightly, puffing on that stick until it lights up. The end ignites and he leans back as smoke billows around him, a gothic creature in

the middle of this concrete jungle. Goddamnit. He's so fucking hot. It's not fair. It's unjust. A crime against humanity and my entire body.

It leans toward him when he's near.

I disgust myself.

As he inhales, I drag my gaze away and grab my phone, slowly hitting the number for the Andromeda brothers, dreading this with every fiber of my being.

They answer with a purr.

Fuck, they're creepy.

"We have a cleanup for you," I bite out, and they pause.

"Hmmm. Do you have what we want as a form of payment?"

My cheeks flame and I peer over at Luca who is watching me intently. There's no way he can hear this. No fucking way. But I know that there's no way by the end of it, he won't know.

"Yes."

"We'll be there."

The call ends and Luca glances at me, wetting his lips.

Why the hell is he always staring at me as if he wants to devour me?

He needs to fucking look away before I punch him. He's been toying with me for over a decade, and the last three have been hell.

To give me something like that, to remind me of it every year, and to never give it to me again…

I glance away and take a step back, trying not to inhale the intoxicating scent of him. I hate how good he smells. The way it overwhelms me.

"They'll be here soon," I say, and he nods, inhaling his cigarette once more.

"They better be. I have shit to do."

I scoff and take another step back, my eyes scanning the warehouse to find a place to undress. Of course, I find nothing. It's completely empty, just cobwebs and a few empty crates stacked near the metal siding.

This is just my fucking luck.

"What the hell are you doing?"

"I'm just walking around to see if we missed anything," I lie.

Luca scoffs just as the Andromeda brothers appear, almost as if summoned through some kind of portal. Wouldn't be surprised if they're demons or some kind of paranormal beings. I know it's ridiculous, but I swear, they're not from this world.

They're identical twins, both tall and lean, their hair the color of midnight, their gray eyes the color of fog rolling over the bay. If I believed in the Grim Reaper, I'd assume they were related. Distant cousins, perhaps.

They set their black leather bags down by their sides in one swift coordinated movement and then stare at me intently, their hands folded in front of them.

"Well?" they say at the same time.

I know what they're waiting for. Fuck, I should have never let them fuck me that one time. But I was desperate and they were available. I'd always wanted to be with twins. Huge mistake. Now they're just demanding and very insistent.

My cheeks flame as their eyes meet mine.

"Fine. Fuck," I murmur and then glance around, feeling slightly helpless. I don't want to do this in front of Luca. I really don't. "I'll just go outside and…"

"No, we want to watch," they both say in tandem. "That's the stipulation," Ezra adds.

"Yes. The stipulation," Cain repeats with a slight nod.

Fucking hell. I was totally high when they fucked me, it's the only explanation. I mean, they're hot, but the creep factor is high with these two.

And yeah, they fuck like the devil, but once they had me, they grew obsessed.

And they always get what they want.

"What the hell are they talking about?" Luca asks, and I glower at him.

"You want to know why they agreed to work with us all of a sudden? This is why," I say as I kick my shoes off and then peel my dark, ripped jeans down my legs. Luca's eyes don't move from my body, smoke billowing from his lips. My shirt hangs over my ass, but I know he can see as I peel the lace panties off. They slide down my thighs and my entire body ignites.

I can't believe this is fucking happening, that he's watching me do this. But I can't back down, not if we want them to complete this job.

I stand up and hold them in my hands, the fabric still warm from my body.

Luca curses behind me, shuffling on his feet, but I don't look back. I refuse.

“Bring them here,” they say, and I exhale slowly, walking toward them in only my socks and shirt. This is fucking humiliating.

As soon as I reach them, I hold the panties out and Ezra takes them, bringing them up to his nose and inhaling deeply.

Cain peers over at his brother and then holds his hand out, doing the same thing.

“Well done,” he says as he stuffs the underwear in his bag and they get to work, leaving me to trail back to my pants and shoes with a flaming face.

“Fuck, you’re twisted,” Luca says with a small chuckle as I yank my jeans back on.

“Shut up.”

“I knew you were kinky as fuck, but this is even better.”

My fingers curl into fists, and he tosses the cigarette onto the ground and grinds it with his foot.

“When did you let them fuck you?”

“Doesn’t matter,” I murmur.

“So you say.” My knuckles crack, and Luca smirks at me. “Think twice about punching me, little slut,” he says, and fuck, the way my dick perks up at that. He hasn’t called me anything like that since that night. And even though he’s uttered it, I know he doesn’t mean it in the way I’m perceiving it. But it doesn’t seem to matter. My body is attracted to Luca Rossi and there’s nothing I can do to stop it.

“Let’s get the fuck out of here,” he says and leads the way out of the warehouse. I follow him, adjusting myself discreetly as we go, that name ringing in my ears. *“Slut. Little slut.”*

I’m so fucking hard by the time we make it to the SUV that I’m uncomfortable. We get in, me behind the wheel and him in the passenger seat, and he leans his head back, his gaze moving out the window.

“Who do you think she was?” he finally asks.

I don’t respond, my brain still stuck on that word.

“Little slut. Take it.”

“I’ll text Sabrina her picture,” he says as he pulls out his phone and sends a message. “I don’t think it’s one of her girls from the brothel, though. She looked a little rough. Maybe she’s someone from the club. I’ll ask Kianna too.”

He’s thinking out loud, but the sound of his voice is making my dick harder. I wish he’d just fucking shut up.

His phone vibrates and he glances down at it, his tattooed thumbs tapping on the screen.

"Neither of them recognizes her," he mutters and then leans his head back and murmurs, "*Fuck.*" The way he says it is like he's sinking into someone, into me, causing my hands to tighten on the steering wheel.

"She must have been placed there," I manage to say, my jaw set as I maneuver around traffic. It's always busy here in Southern California, but today, with the scattered showers, everything is a little more congested.

"Probably," he replies and then adds, "But why?"

"Doesn't matter now. The brothers will clean it up and it will be like she was never there. Never existed."

"And all for the price of your panties," he says with a huff, and I swear I want to pull over and make him walk home.

"You should be thanking me. They're the best in the business and they refused to work with us—until me."

He peers over at me, and I feel my cheeks flame.

"Was that planned? Your hookup? Or was your slutty hole just desperate for it and you took it without knowing they'd agree to work with us?"

The latter, I think, but refuse to answer him. It's none of his business what I do in my free time. That night, he took away the freedom the club held, and I had to go elsewhere—a hookup app that allows me to meet nameless men in the middle of the night.

"I'll make sure to let Anthony know how we came into possession of the brothers."

"Don't you fucking dare," I hiss. "What I do is no one's business."

He huffs a laugh and then looks down at his phone, his thumbs flying across the screen once more.

He better not be telling anyone my shit. I don't think he's ever mentioned that night at the club to anyone. No one's ever said anything to me, and there were no suspicious glances or backhanded comments in the following weeks or months.

Years.

It's been years. He must have kept it a secret.

I'm sure there's a reason for it.

Maybe it's what happened after.

I don't know, but I've been waiting three years for the inevitable shoe to drop. I bet he enjoys hanging it over me. Asshole.

I fucking despise him.

And even so, I'd still let him fuck me. *Again*.

Not that he'd ever, but a boy can have nightmares.

"Pull over here," he says, pointing to an ice cream shop on the side of the road. It's an older building, one that's been here for ages, but one that Luca enjoys frequenting.

"What the fuck? I'm not pulling over for fucking ice cream."

"I want a cone," Luca says, and I force my hands to turn the wheel.

"You're a fucking child," I murmur, and he grins at me.

"At least I have underwear on."

His comment is punctuated by the car jerking to a stop and me shutting it off with a jab of my finger. He slides out and strides inside while I wait for him to return. My eyes may slide to his tight ass once more, and I slam the palm of my hand against the steering wheel. I can't help how attracted I am to him, and I hate how I can't seem to rid myself of this obsession.

He's to blame. He started it, just by existing.

He's the reason I realized I was gay.

The way I thought of him back then, imagined him, after just laying eyes on him. That was all it took to seal it for me.

I hate the power he's had over me all these years, and I hate that it hasn't dissipated in the slightest.

When he returns to the car, he has a double scoop in his hand, and I swear to Satan that if he gets any of that vanilla on his lips, I may fucking lose my shit.

Just as I think it, his tongue slides out and licks at the ice cream. A small whimper escapes my slutty throat, one that's thankfully hidden by the sound of the ignition being turned on.

"Any other stops?" I ask, hoping my voice comes out less strained and more rough. I'm not sure I manage it. "Fast food? A play area?"

He chuckles and then laps at that fucking ice cream cone again. "No, I have what I need right here." He licks at it again, slower this time. "Mm, so fucking good."

A little bit dribbles down the corner of his mouth and he uses his thumb to wipe it up, leaving my cock looking just like that ice cream cone in his hands. Dripping and wet. It's clear. I really need to get laid.

I should go back to the club this weekend. I've been gone long enough.

I really fucking should. They've asked when I'd be returning, but I can't give them an answer. That night, *that fucking night*, changed everything.

"Can you stop fucking slurping like that?" I grumble.

Luca grins, his lips wet as his tongue snakes out again and drags up the scoop, like he's licking a dick. I imagine it's mine, and I hate that I want it.

He'd never do that, would never touch me like that.

But me? I'd loathe getting on my knees for him, but I'd moan like a whore while he fucked my throat.

I'd drool for it. And it makes me hate him even more.

"I'm fucking serious, Luca. Stop it."

He does it again and my hands grip the steering wheel so tightly it squeaks.

"Why does it bother you so much?" he asks, a glint in his eyes. "You thinking about me sucking your whore dick?"

That makes my cock perk up even further.

"Fuck no."

He chuckles lowly and then leans back, adjusting himself as his tongue swipes out once more. It's too much.

Especially when he adds, "Not that you're my type. Since you're a man and all."

I let out a low growl and swerve onto the shoulder of the road. I stop so suddenly his ice cream rolls from the cone and onto his pants with an audible *splat*.

He stares at it and then up at me.

"What the fuck? Throwing a tantrum? Who's the child now?" he asks, and I unlock the doors.

"Get the fuck out and walk home."

"No."

"Get the fuck out."

His jaw clicks and then suddenly his hand is in my hair, his fingers tugging on the strands tightly. "Not until you clean up the mess you made," he growls, wrenching my head down to his lap, that scoop of ice cream right there in front of my nose.

I bite back a groan as he pushes my head roughly toward it, smearing it across my cheeks in the process.

"Lick. It. Up. You little bitch."

I try to wrench my head back, one last sliver of dignity before I cave, but he holds me down rougher, a shock of pain moving through my scalp.

“Don’t make me do something I won’t regret.”

I grunt and struggle, but he’s stronger than me, holding me against his lap. My mouth reluctantly pops open, and I lap at the cold ice cream sitting against my lips. My eyes squeeze shut as the sweet taste of vanilla and almond hits my tongue. And even though I know this is nothing like it, my body can’t help but pretend it’s his cock.

“Good. Fucking take it,” he grumbles.

He presses me further into it, smashing my face into his groin and my own cock lurches in my pants.

“Every fucking drop. All of it,” he says lowly, holding me to him. And my tongue laps at his pants, devouring it. The angle I’m at currently is making my back twinge, but I know he won’t let me up until he’s gotten what he wants. He always gets what he wants.

He pushes me into him, my nose smashed up against his bulge. I inhale, the scent of vanilla and something masculine, feral.

Fuck, I feel my balls draw up in my pants.

Shit. No. *No*.

“Hm, such a little slut. Listen to you moan. I fucking love that sound,” he murmurs, and his words alone have me unloading right into my pants. Shame washes over me as I tremble deliriously, my moans resounding through the cab. And when I’m finally done, his fingers loosen and he shoves me away.

“Good boy,” he says with a small, victorious grin.

I sit up and swipe at my sticky face, my cheeks on fire.

“Now do your job and bring me back to the Costello’s. I have to debrief with Anthony.”

With shaking hands, I do as I’m told, humiliation and regret heavy in my chest and, at the same time, a thrill as well.

That’s probably as close to him as I’ll ever get again.

When we arrive at Anthony Costello’s sprawling estate, the one I landed in as a lost teenager fifteen years ago, I drop Luca off at the front door and

then sit in the SUV, trying like hell to figure out how I'm supposed to walk around with cum in my pants and a wet spot on the front of my jeans without anyone noticing.

Damn him.

I shouldn't have pushed him. I should have just let him eat his fucking ice cream cone and driven him to work.

But no, I had to tempt fate. I can't seem to help myself.

My head lands on the steering wheel and I turn my head slightly to look at the sprawling acres. The house sits before me, but the garden that Angel tended is just behind those trees. Further back is an orchard and a treehouse that Anthony built for his sons when they were little.

And now he uses it for other extracurricular activities.

I still can't believe this is my life, that I found myself here of all places. A boy from a trailer park who owned two sets of clothes is now a part of all this.

I never knew such wealth existed until I showed up here. Sometimes I still can't believe it.

A knock on the window has me jumping slightly, pulling me from my thoughts and when I peer over, I see Teddy, another bodyguard, standing before me. He's huge, with wide shoulders and a shaved head. He looks like he's ex-military, but I'm not sure about his history because he never speaks. I've never heard him mutter so much as a word.

Tatum says that he's nonverbal. But he signs, not that I've learned anything yet.

I really need to fucking learn because that's the decent thing to do. And I always told myself that coming here was a chance to do better than my parents, to be a decent person when it counts.

Learning American Sign Language would count.

I roll the window down and lean my head against the headrest.

"Hey, Teddy. You don't happen to have any extra pants, do you?"

Teddy's face turns to my messy jeans and his cheeks pinken. He knows what I did. I'm pretty sure that even though he doesn't speak, it only means he has more time to observe. I'm sure he knows how much Luca turns me on.

He nods slightly and then moves away, returning a few minutes later with a pair of sweatpants. He's bulkier than me, but I'll take it.

“Thanks, I owe you,” I reply and then hop out of the SUV and move into the house, the sweatpants in front of my crotch. Thank God no one is around to comment on this.

When I find the nearest bathroom, I quickly and thoroughly clean myself up, pulling the sweats on and tightening them as best I can. I look ridiculous, but it’s better than sitting in sticky cum the rest of the evening.

I stash my jeans under the sink and move toward Anthony’s office. I can hear him and Luca talking inside, and I mentally remind myself not to get hard when I see Luca.

I won’t get hard.

This obsession needs to die. It needs to fucking walk off a cliff.

I take a deep breath, and then, with a flick of my wrist, I knock and move inside. Luca is sitting on the couch, his thighs spread, his jacket off, and the sleeves of his shirt rolled up his strong tattooed forearms. His lips twitch slightly when he sees my new outfit, but I refuse to acknowledge him, turning to nod at Anthony, who is cradling Tatum in his lap.

Thank fuck they’re not having sex. The number of times I’ve seen them going at it…I’d rather not right now. But Anthony seems to like showing off his man, and Tatum has no qualms about it. So I just let them do what they want. I really have no say in it, anyway. Anthony’s the boss. Even Luca defers to him. Most of the time.

When he’s feeling very self-destructive, he disobeys.

The fights that ensue after are a shitshow.

“Nice of you to join us,” Anthony says as I move to stand near Luca, not wanting to get too close to him but needing to appear as a united front. I used to work solely for Anthony, but after he met Tatum, I’ve been relegated to Luca.

“I was speaking with Teddy,” I reply bluntly.

“Well, Luca was just catching us up on what’s been going on.” Anthony’s gaze flicks from my pants to my face, and my nostrils flare. “Seems I have you to thank for the Andromeda brothers.”

My teeth grind and I clasp my hands behind my back.

“A happy accident, I assure you.”

Luca’s grin is hidden behind his tattooed fingers, rubbing across his mouth. On each knuckle is a letter of his last name, and a large bloody flower on the back of his hand. I’ve always wondered what that was about but refuse to ask.

“Well, whatever makes them happy. They’re the best in the business and notoriously hard to get onto the schedule. But it seems your…incentive is benefiting me in very positive ways. Seems they’re willing to drop plans at a moment’s notice. For you.”

Tatum grins at me and wiggles around on Anthony’s lap, his robe falling open slightly, exposing his thigh to everyone. I turn my gaze away, not wanting Anthony to cut my eyes out for looking too long. Not that he would. He enjoys us watching, but still. No unnecessary ogling.

“Don’t tease Viktor. He’s embarrassed,” Tatum says. “He doesn’t want people to know he gives his panties away to strangers.”

“I’m not embarrassed,” I grumble, but I am. I can’t believe Luca witnessed me giving the brothers my underwear and then told our boss. They should be fucking grateful because, without me, we’d still be working with subpar contractors.

The last one left a limb on scene. Just completely forgot it.

Anthony had to contact his guy in the FBI to make that one disappear.

It was not a good day.

“Of course you’re not,” Luca says and then thankfully diverts the subject. “But back to Sabrina, the girl isn’t hers. So I think either someone is setting us up or this is just an unhappy accident.”

I peer over at Luca, whose lips are twitching.

Asshole.

“And you confirmed she wasn’t one of yours from the club?”

“Yes, I asked Kianna and she assured me that it’s not one of her dancers or the waitstaff. Besides, the place has been shut down for renovations for the past few months now.”

“Fuck,” Anthony says. “And the Fallen Aces? Does this have anything to do with them?”

“Tried calling Kit, but he didn’t answer.”

“Probably fucking around,” Anthony says, leaning forward and pulling out his phone. He dials a number, his free hand sneaking under Tatum’s robe, and I shift on my feet as I wait to see what happens.

“Kit. It’s Anthony. Pick up the fucking phone when Luca calls you.”

He leans back and Tatum turns slightly, his lips trailing up Anthony’s neck in a sensual dance. He loves to do this, tease his man until he breaks.

“He’ll send you the picture. You tell me if she’s one of yours,” Anthony grunts. “And don’t make us fucking wait.” He hangs up the phone, his hand

tangling in Tatum's hair. "Send the picture and let me know what he says."

Luca leans back, pulling his phone from his pocket, my eyes snagging on the mess on the front of his slacks. My dick perks up and I turn slightly, not wanting him to see the effect he has on me.

Not that he doesn't already know.

He knows far too much about me.

"He's going to pass it around with the guys and see."

Anthony groans and leans back as Tatum straddles him in his chair. The game between them is obviously over.

"Good. Now, unless you want a show, you can leave."

Luca stretches slightly before pushing himself up and moving past me. I'm left to follow, my eyes resolutely on the back of his head and nowhere else. When we make it out into the hallway, I hear Tatum cry out Anthony's name, and I curse under my breath.

"Horny fuckers," Luca chuckles, pulling out a cigarette and waiting for me to light it. But the lighter is in the pocket of the pants I've stuffed under the sink.

He arches an eyebrow, and I scowl back at him.

"Light your own fucking cigarette," I grumble.

Luca pauses a moment before he reaches out, his hand encircling my throat and shoving me back against the wall. His fingers tighten and I gasp, his face lowering to meet mine, his cigarette hanging precariously from between his lips.

"You seem to forget who I am," he says, squeezing me roughly, making me gasp for air, my cock lengthening even more at how close he is. "I'm your fucking boss and you need to start acting like it. Now be a good little pet and get my fucking lighter."

He releases me and I sag against the wall, inhaling sharply, hating that my dick imprint is clearly visible in these sweatpants. Especially because that little show of authority only turned me on. Majorly.

But he knows that. He knows what a slut I am.

I push myself away from the wall and stumble toward the bathroom, tucking my dick under my waistband as I go. When I bend down to grab the jeans, Luca leans against the doorjamb, watching me intently. One hand is tucked in his pocket, the other fiddling with that cigarette.

I pull out the electric lighter and hold it toward him.

He hates fire. Don't know why, but he despises it.

Hence this damn thing I carry around for him.

He inhales deeply as my arm drops to my side and he blows smoke right into my face.

I cough softly and force myself not to shove him backward. He's right. He's my boss. I should treat him with more respect.

But fuck, he makes it hard. He pushes all my buttons.

"What are you two boys doing?" a sweet voice says from behind Luca. I glance over his shoulder and see the housekeeper, Agatha, eyeing us. She's been around since I can remember and I love her more than I ever did my own mother. "Are you two antagonizing each other again?" She places a hand on her hip and stares at us until Luca finally breaks.

"I'd never do that," Luca replies, turning slightly and pressing a kiss to her cheek.

"Hmph, well, you know to treat sweet Viktor well, don't you?"

Luca glances over his shoulder and his lip curls up. "I treat him *very* well."

"So fucking tight, such a good boy."

"As you should." She pats him on the shoulder. "Now, come on. I have some cookies in the kitchen." She turns on her heel, expecting us to follow her.

Luca walks away, leaving me to watch him go, my eyes sliding down to his ass as he moves.

Fuck.

This is becoming quite the problem.

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2

LUCA

"Looks good, Carlos," I say as I scan the interior of the club I co-own with Anthony. Part of it burned down months ago, and despite feeling that it was arson, some kind of foul play because of who we are, we haven't been able to pinpoint what happened. To top it off, no one has been implicated in it and we have no leads.

Bane insists it was his old fuck-buddy turned enemy, Henry. The same one who conspired with the Aces to hurt Tatum. But no one can find him, and so all we have are loose ends and a shit-ton of questions.

"What do you think of the new design?" Carlos asks, and I nod. He's the contractor I hired to do the job because he's good at what he does and knows who to remain loyal to.

Me. Loyal to motherfucking me.

So far I haven't had any issues.

"Looks good," I reply as my gaze sweeps around the large space. The interior is different than it was before, with little touches added to make this luxurious VIP club even better. This includes the back rooms I had constructed after visiting Eden that one night three years ago. I'd wanted to make the changes sooner, but never had reason to until now.

A little competition never hurt anyone.

Even if that competition is myself.

My mind flits to Viktor, taking man after man, his back bowed, his mouth open in pleasure, before I push it away.

He’s been taking up far too much of my headspace recently. It’s been gradually increasing.

Three years ago was a mistake.

A fucking lapse in judgement.

And watching him take his panties off and give them to the twins… well, that may have ignited something inside of me I thought I’d buried.

Or maybe I’m lying to myself.

I exhale for a long beat and then follow Carlos around the building, letting him point out all the additions and upgrades he and his men have made, per my specifications and Sabrina’s very helpful suggestions.

“Grand opening is next weekend?” he asks, and I nod.

“That’s the plan.”

“We’ll have it ready.”

“Wonderful,” I reply, and then grab my phone and let Sabrina know. She’ll be bringing a van full of women for the back rooms, a little extra incentive for those who have money to spend. In the end, Sabrina and I will come out richer and the customers who want to utilize it will be happier.

Perhaps I should add men to the menu as well.

Just as I think that, Viktor appears, wearing dark jeans, black Converse sneakers, and a tight gray t-shirt. I let my gaze travel over his wide shoulders, down to his narrow waist, and stopping right at his groin. His dark hair and dark eyes are the perfect combination with his tanned skin. He shifts on his feet, and I feel my lips curl up at the corners as he fidgets uncomfortably. Good. I want him to be fucking nervous.

The way he’s been toying with me.

With my thoughts. With the way I dream.

I fucking hate being controlled like this.

I’d rather have a different soldier follow me around, but Anthony insisted.

He trusts Viktor, wants to make sure I have someone to watch my back after almost losing Tatum. Viktor Sodaro has been with the Costello family a long time, not as long as I have, of course, but still. He was Anthony’s main bodyguard for a decade, and he trusts him with his life. And so here I am, saddled with this fuckface. I shouldn’t hate him this much, not when he does things for me that most wouldn’t. Like carry about that fucking electric lighter, or kill spiders when they invade my space.

Or save you from a fire. Right in this very room.

A shudder moves through me and I push it away. I won't go there.

I won't fucking go there.

Flames lick at my fingertips and I pick up my pace, pulling a cigarette from my jacket pocket and placing it between my lips. I want a smoke. It's a terrible habit but it's the only thing helping me keep my anxiety at bay. I smoke so the demons inside stay buried. Right where they belong.

Viktor appears at my side and holds out the lighter, calming me almost immediately. It's not his presence that does it.

It's just the smoke invading my lungs.

"Good boy," I murmur, and his cheeks darken as I move forward once more. His blush makes it worth it. I like making him squirm. It's an entertaining pastime.

Even if it does remind me…

"Stop fucking saying that shit," he says as he trails after me.

I don't respond, letting him think I didn't hear him. Let him stew on it. I'll do what I want. I always have. He gets no say in it. He may have invaded my thoughts, made me lose sleep all these years, but he won't control the way I do business.

"Would you like to see the back rooms? They're coming along nicely," Carlos interrupts, and I nod, the three of us moving toward the back, taking in the dark tiled floors and the walls taped off for the painters. This is going to be quintessential sex—dark reds, blacks, and purples.

I can't wait to see it when it's done.

We make our way to the first room and step inside. Two men are working on painting the walls a dark rosewood, a small speaker playing music in the background.

"The bed will be over there," Carlos explains before adding, "And we have the equipment on order as well. Everything should be delivered tomorrow and will be set up after the painters get done."

"Good," I say and then flick my gaze over to Viktor. "What do you think?"

He scans the room but doesn't respond.

"My friend here is an aficionado when it comes to sex clubs," I tell Carlos.

"I'm not your fucking friend," Viktor murmurs.

I can't help but chuckle at that. He's not. He's my worst fucking enemy. There's no rhyme or reason for it, but I don't like him.

The way he makes me think about him when I don't want to be thinking. The way he's always around…

"Come here," I say, pointing to the middle of the room. I know this will only make it worse, but I do it anyway. "Bend over here."

Viktor's eyes darken. "What the fuck for?"

Carlos eyes me, questioning why Viktor is defying me, but I ignore those looks. He won't say a damn thing about this.

"Who's the boss, Viktor? Or do I have to remind you again who fucking owns you? Go bend over. Hands on the floor."

His knuckles crack, but he moves forward and does as he's told, arching forward, his ass out, his hands on his ankles.

I inhale and blow smoke from the corner of my mouth. Something twists inside of me. Like that night. It twisted and curled until I was helpless to give in.

"Hm, what do you think, Carlos?"

He doesn't answer, which is good. He shouldn't fucking say a word. Not if he wants to live.

"Can I fucking stand up now?" he hisses.

"Mm. Yes," I say, and then we follow Carlos into each room, inspecting them, and in each one, I make Viktor bend over in different parts of it, one time even insisting that he get on his hands and knees like a fucking dog.

By the time we make it to the last room, his dick is hard and he's fuming.

He fucking hates that he likes it. And I hate that I like making him obey.

We're both equally fucked up.

"Up against that wall, Viktor, arms and legs spread."

"Fuck no."

I reach out, pressing my fingers into his cheeks and squeezing tightly. His lips pucker and his cheeks redden in defiance.

"Listen to me."

"Fuck you," he murmurs through those pink lips.

My hand slides down his cheeks to his neck, and I squeeze it roughly, making his eyes widen slightly. Seems I like choking him. It's becoming quite the hobby.

"Don't forget who I am, Vik," I say, loosening my hand but keeping it against his neck. He inhales sharply and I move my face closer to him, breathing in the scent of him.

I remember that scent.

My thumb smooths over his Adam's apple, and his eyes go slightly glassy.

He may fight it, but he likes it.

"Do as I say, Vik," I say gently, and he nods, moving away from me and pressing his face against the wall, adjusting his arms and legs exactly how I want them. My eyes rove across his splayed body as I run a hand across my jaw.

It's not enough.

This isn't enough.

"I'm not getting the true feel for what this space will be used for. Pull your pants down."

Carlos shifts on his feet near me, clearly uncomfortable, but I don't give a shit. I pay him money to shut up and do what I want. I don't want his opinion on this.

"I'm not doing that," Viktor hisses, still not moving from his place against the wall.

I drop the cigarette onto the ground and grind it out with my shoe before stalking forward, reaching out and squeezing the back of his neck, shoving his cheek against the drywall even harder.

He grunts as my hand moves around to the front of his pants and I unbutton them, my fingers brushing against the bulge there. With a flick of my wrist, I unzip him and wrench his pants down his ass until they can't move an inch more.

I hold him steady as I step back and glance down, taking in his dark blue lace panties. His ass cheeks flex and I can't help but reach out and yank them up, the fabric moving up his ass crack. He gasps and then I hear it—a soft, desperate moan.

I step back, turning to look at Carlos, who is looking anywhere but me.

"What do you think?" I ask.

"Good, sir," he murmurs, and I huff out a dark laugh, moving my gaze back to stare at Viktor still pressed against the wall, his ass cheeks hanging out, his eyes shut.

"Don't fucking pretend you don't love this," I whisper into his ear before sinking my teeth into that fleshy lobe. His eyes flash open, and he scowls at me.

“I hate *you*,” he murmurs, and I can’t help the way my hand falls roughly on his ass cheek. It pinkens from the slap and Viktor purses his lips, his hips arching back just a fraction of an inch—almost invisible, but I see it.

I fucking see it.

“Pull your fucking pants back up. We have other places to go,” I grind out before turning back to Carlos, the two of us walking out of the room without a backward glance, leaving Viktor to scramble after us.

He’s pissed, fuming.

I like it more than I should.

When we get back to the car, Viktor’s cheeks are red, smoke coming out of his ears. Well, I’m unhappy as well.

I’m unsatisfied.

The things he makes me feel.

I pull out my phone, knowing that ignoring him bothers him more than he cares to admit, and that gives me a little thrill.

He starts the car without a word and we drive to the next location on our list, an MMA gym. Normally, I’d drive here myself, but I’m dragging him along today. I like the way he tries not to look when I’m shirtless, throwing punches in the ring.

I see the way he stares.

When we arrive at the worn-down building, one I’ve been using for years, I exhale a small sigh of relief. When I’m not boxing with Anthony, I’m here, blowing off steam and training for the underground fights I participate in when I feel like I’m going to explode.

My anxiety can only reach a certain level before I fucking need to cover it up with pain. The kind of pain that burrows under my skin and makes me feel alive again.

The only other time I’ve felt that was a night…three years ago.

“I’ll wait in the car,” Viktor says, but I point at him.

“No. You’re coming inside with me.”

“You don’t fucking need me. You have a bunch of men in there who’d kill for you. I can stay in the fucking car.”

“And Anthony asked you to protect me. Now, what would he think if I told him you weren’t following his orders?”

He huffs, but gets out of the car, pulling his jacket over the gun tucked in the back of his pants and following me inside. As we step over the

threshold, I'm greeted by a few burly men who also nod at Viktor. We stop and chat for a minute before we make our way to the locker room. It's there that I throw my things onto a bench and start to undress. Viktor's eyes slide from the lockers beside me to my body, lingering on my bare skin. I may undress a little slower because of those eyes on me.

"Why don't you step in the ring with me?" I suggest as I pull on my shorts and grab the tape for my hands.

"Because I don't want to fuck you up."

A laugh escapes me at that. "Or maybe you don't want to get too close to me," I say, stopping in front of him and leaning forward, his lips hovering near mine. "Wouldn't want you to come in front of everyone with my name on your lips. Or would you like that?"

He frowns, his cheeks darkening, but doesn't deny it.

And that gets me through my entire workout. Knowing he's watching me. Lusting after me. He tries to hide it, but I can see it. The way he adjusts himself as his eyes track over my muscles, the way he bites his lip as I land punches on my opponent. I may take a hit or two, but every time I do, I peer over at Viktor and see him wetting his lips. Like he wants to crawl into the ring and lick the sweat from my skin.

When I'm done, I hop down, wiping my face with a towel and moving toward the locker rooms.

"Need you to stand guard while I shower," I say, unable to help myself. He's so fucking fun to toy with.

He grumbles under his breath but doesn't talk back, just follows me to the communal shower and stands near the entrance as I strip my clothes off, tossing them at him until I'm completely naked. There are two other men under the water who nod at me as I enter, but I barely notice them. Because my gaze moves to Viktor as I squirt soap onto my palm and rub it into my hair and then down my body.

His nostrils flare and his hands curl into fists as I continue to wash. The other two men finish up and move past me, disappearing behind the lockers, leaving me alone in this large space. I lean my head back and let my hands trail down to my cock, cupping and tugging it.

Viktor clears his throat, and I peer through wet lashes to meet his searing gaze.

For some reason, the idea of him walking up to me and sinking to his knees makes my cock thicken.

I’ve never been obsessed with another man like this.

Anthony and I may have done things in the past, but that was strictly with Laura. It was never him who got me going.

Even if I did like watching.

It was always her.

But now…

“Like what you see?” I ask, my voice low.

“Fuck no. It’s disgusting.”

I let out a laugh and let my cock drop from my grip, rinsing off before turning the water off. He holds out a towel as I stride toward him, and I grab it from him, wrapping it around my waist and pushing past him, making sure to bump into him as I go.

He falls back slightly and then, without warning, he shoves me so hard that I stumble forward and fall into the lockers with a clank.

A few of the guys still changing peer over at us, and I hold up my hands, wanting to diffuse whatever that was. Perhaps I pushed him too far.

Perhaps I didn’t push him far enough.

I know how rough he likes it.

“It’s all good,” I tell them and then turn on my heel and face Viktor, whose chest is heaving, his eyes a little wild. “Touch me again like that and I will bend you over and make you regret it.”

His breath hitches and I can’t help but step toward him, reaching down and grabbing onto his dick. It’s hard and thick in my palm, and I squeeze it roughly.

His bottom lip is pulled between his teeth as I twist my wrist, making him whimper, his body shifting up onto his toes.

“I’ll make you hurt, kitten.”

I twist a little more and then let him go, moving to my locker without a backward glance, my lips twitching up and my dick half-hard.

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3

VIKTOR

My hand shuttles up and down my cock as I stand under the showerhead, trying like hell to make myself stop this, but unable to.

I saw Luca naked. He touched my dick. I've been in pain since this afternoon.

I need relief. Hence the desperate shower hand job in the hallway bathroom of the house on Anthony's estate.

Fuck. I need to stop this. It's only going to make this obsession I have with him worse.

But I can't. I press my face to the tile wall and let myself unload onto the shower floor, gasping and wincing as my orgasm nearly overwhelms me. My legs shake and my moan filters out of my throat, broken and ragged.

Like I sounded that night.

The way he ripped it out of me.

I bang my forehead on the tile and exhale deeply.

I needed that, needed to come undone, but I also know I need more.

More than I can ever have again.

Fuck him for making me like this. He did this to me.

He made me this kind of horny monster.

Washing quickly, I get out of the shower, not wanting to succumb to thoughts of Luca again. I move into the common area of the house that Anthony built for his guards to get some rest and spend downtime between shifts.

It’s a nice place with a fully stocked kitchen and a gym downstairs. I’m lucky to have a boss who cares for us, who cares about me, as much as he does. Things could have ended so differently when he found me.

I could have ended up just like my dad. Dead as a fucking doornail.

As I move, I see a few of the other bodyguards sitting on the large, overstuffed sofas, food set on the ottoman, a game on the TV. It’s loud and raucous, but I don’t mind it. Sometimes things can get so quiet that it’s overwhelming.

Sometimes I like to feel less alone when I’m here compared to the small, shared place I have off the estate.

I move past them with a small wave and make my way to an available bedroom, locking the door behind me and flopping down on the bed. I pull my phone out to check my messages and see I have a few from men I met on a hookup app, but most aren’t worth replying to. I’m not in the mood for anything right now. The work it would take to set something up…the probability it will end up being someone like the twins…no thanks. Perhaps later.

Without much thought, my thumb scrolls to my anonymous social media accounts, pulling up Luca’s page in seconds. This is my little secret. He uses a pseudonym so no one knows who he is, and the entire thing showcases his boxing skills and his body.

I knew it was him the moment I saw those arms from a screenshot.

Fuck.

He’s so damn good at everything he does.

Just looking at him makes my dick plump up. Apparently, my shower hand job did nothing to stem my libido. It wants to go again.

But I refuse to give in to my desires and decide to casually scroll through his pictures instead, zooming in on his ass when I can, and then on his face. His fucking face. That strong jaw, those beautiful eyes.

“God, he’s so hot,” I murmur as my hand snakes down my shorts and cups my dick.

I’m not going to get off, just going to hold it. It needs a little reassurance that I can do this. I can resist the pull.

I scroll to another, one where he’s doing a bench press, and my eyes can’t help but slide down to the obvious dick outline in those thin workout shorts. My fist strokes up and down my shaft as I stare at it, my tongue peeking out and wetting my lips.

What I wouldn’t give to have that down my fucking throat.

I’m so fucking thirsty for it.

I grunt and then mentally chastise myself.

No. I fucking won’t do this. I won’t.

My hand slides out of my shorts and I move my finger to shut the app down, but instead, I accidentally hit video call. I’m so shocked by this that I just stare at the phone ringing, my face in view of the camera, my eyes wide, my lips swollen and wet.

When I finally snap to, I end the call immediately, but shit, he’ll see it. My heart is racing, my entire body clenched with nerves.

Oh god, what did I do? He’s going to know.

Oh fuck.

My phone buzzes and I stare up at it, Luca’s handle appearing on my phone.

He’s calling me back.

I shouldn’t answer.

I *won’t* fucking answer.

He hangs up and then calls again, making my heart nearly thump out of my chest. It’s visible through my skin, cartoonish in nature.

Oh fuck, he’s not going to stop until he gets what he wants. I have to answer.

With regret and sluggish fingers, I swipe at my phone, seeing Luca’s face appear on the screen in seconds. He looks even hotter now, his eyes widening slightly before falling back into a hooded gaze.

“Fucking knew it was you, you little pervert. Were you looking at my videos, getting off to thoughts of me?”

“Hell no,” I murmur, hating that my voice comes out raspy, a telltale sign of what I’m truly feeling.

“You were. You can’t help yourself, can you?”

I don’t answer, just stare at him, my eyes boring into his through the screen.

“You just think about all the different ways I can fuck you. You imagine it, drool over it. Don’t you?”

I feel my pulse in my throat, swallowing roughly.

“I don’t.”

“You do. You want me to bend you over, spread those cheeks, and take you. Just like those men did that night. You want to be fucked so thoroughly

that you can't walk after. You want to feel it for days."

An ache builds between my legs.

"Let me tell you something, Viktor. With me, you wouldn't need ten men to take that ass. You'd only need me. But you already know that."

My hips are arching up, begging for it.

"Too bad you're not my type," he adds with a quirk of his lips and then the screen goes dark. Leaving me lying there in bed, with a drooling dick, and my libido so high my entire body is shaking. My phone falls onto the floor and I turn on the bed, groaning into the pillow in frustration.

Why the fuck does he insist on tormenting me like this? What the hell is his problem?

He must enjoy it. That's the only explanation because he's not interested in fucking me. Just fucking *with* me.

I sleep fitfully, waking up far too early and heading down to the gym before the sun is even up. I do my usual run on the treadmill and weightlifting before making breakfast and heading to work. As I approach the main house, I see Tatum on the swing outside, a cup of coffee in his hand, a blanket wrapped around his shoulders.

"Hey, Viktor," he says with a grin, his cheeks flushed from the cold morning air.

"Hey," I reply as he blows the steam away from his mug.

"You're up early," Tatum says.

"Couldn't sleep."

"Same. Had a nightmare and didn't want to wake Anthony. So here I am."

I stare down at his hand, the one missing a finger, and school my features. "Trauma doesn't let you sleep, unfortunately."

"It doesn't. But oh well. Anthony is worth it. I'd lose another finger if it means I get to be with him."

"I'd rather you kept all your appendages."

"Same," he replies with a laugh. Just as he says that, Teddy appears, standing sentry right next to him. He's rarely away from his side, taking Tatum's abduction earlier this year very personally. He won't let it happen again.

Without a word, he hands something to Tatum, who just sighs. "You're too good to me, Teddy."

He doesn't respond, just blushes as Tatum puts the warm scone up to his mouth and takes a bite.

"Oh god. Delicious. Did you make this?" He meets Teddy's gaze and then grins. "Of course you did. It's fabulous. I bet you went to culinary school in like France or something. You're full of secrets."

Teddy's blush deepens, and Tatum offers me a piece.

"No, you eat it. I'll grab one in the kitchen."

Tatum and I chat for a few more minutes before I move inside. Agatha is bustling around the kitchen, getting everything ready for the start of the day. We may have a fully stocked kitchen, but Agatha insists on making meals if we want them.

And even though I made myself breakfast already, the smell of those scones is making my stomach rumble.

"Oh, Viktor. Good morning. Did you eat?"

"I had breakfast, but you know I can always fit more of your baked goods in here."

I pat my stomach, and Agatha grins at me, handing me a plate of fresh scones.

"You definitely should. Put more meat on those bones. Here. Teddy made them, but have at it. You get them when they're fresh, before anyone else. Early bird eats the worm."

"Think it's *gets* the worm, but still works."

"That it does."

I swipe one off the plate and take a bite, flavor exploding across my tongue. Vanilla and chocolate. Damn, Teddy is a good baker. In another life, maybe he'd have gone into business for himself. Fuck knows, he'd probably do really well.

I swallow it down and then lean under the kitchen faucet for some water.

Agatha swats at me as I do, telling me to use a cup, but I don't want to dirty one. This works just fine.

From the kitchen, I move to Anthony's office, ready for a debrief to start the day. Usually, he tells his men what he wants to accomplish that day, starting with Luca and me.

And as soon as I step inside, I see Luca on the couch, in his favorite spot, his eyes meeting mine with a devious twinkle.

Ignoring him, I stand opposite him.

“We’re just waiting for Bane to arrive,” Anthony says. “He’s never on time.”

“Should teach him a lesson,” Luca says and then meets my gaze.

“He’d probably like that lesson a little too much,” Anthony says with a chuckle.

He would. That fucker likes pain.

A few minutes later, a hidden door behind the bookshelves swivels open and Bane appears, his hair a mess, his shirt stained with blood.

“Oopsie. Am I late?” he asks as he walks over to us, a skip in his step.

“You usually are,” Anthony says and then sighs when Bane sets something down on his desk.

“What is this?”

“Tongues. Just for you. If you want to display them. I put the best one in there. There’s even one with a piercing.”

Anthony picks up the jar and inspects it with a sigh. “I don’t know that Tatum would approve of this, but then again, it’s you…”

Bane grins and shifts on his feet. “So you like it?”

“I do.” He turns and sets it on the mantle behind his desk before looking back at us. “Now that we’re all here. Luca, do you have an identity on the girl yet?”

“It’s not one of Kit’s. He confirmed it last night. I was trying to do some more research into it but got a little sidetracked by an unexpected video call.”

His gaze meets mine, and I scowl at him.

“Right, well, then it seems she was either someone who wandered in and died at the warehouse, a total coincidence, or someone is setting us up. We had Doc take a look at the extensive pictures the twins sent us and he’s run a toxicology report from the blood they collected.” He pulls something up on his phone and sighs. “It seems there was an unknown drug in her system.”

“A new one on the market?” I blurt, and Anthony nods.

“It’s not from our supply. She got it from somewhere else, and either she broke into the warehouse herself, or someone brought her there to set us up.”

Luca runs a hand down his face as Bane wiggles around. “Oh. *Oh*. I have a thought.” He raises his hand as if in a classroom and waits for Anthony to call on him.

“Yes, Bane.”

“Well, what if we went undercover?”

“That would be a good idea if we knew who was doing it.”

“Right, well, when we find out, I volunteer. As tribute to the Costello family.”

I bite back a smile, and so does Luca, our eyes clashing and my grin falling from my face.

“Thank you, Bane. I’ll consider it. Although with the way things fell apart with Henry—”

“Do not mention his name!” Bane shouts and then shrinks back slightly, running a hand through his hair. “I’m still looking for him. The trickster. I will have my revenge if it’s the last thing I do.”

He raises his fist, and Luca lets out a small chuckle.

“Right, so our aim is to find out who is making and distributing this drug and take them down?” Luca asks.

“Sounds far too simple, but yes. Please reach out to the different clubs around town to see if they know anything. And take Viktor with you. I want someone to have your back.”

My eyes fall on Luca, and he smirks at me.

“Will do, Boss.” He pushes himself up and my eyes fall, for just a second, to his crotch, that dick outline doing things to my mind before he adjusts himself.

“Let’s go, Vik,” he says as he moves past me, whispering lowly, “And stop staring at my dick. You’ll never have it.”

“Vik, pull the car over,” Luca growls as we make our way to the first club of the morning. It’s raining slightly, and the road we’re on is narrow with no good place to stop. I’m not pulling over. We’d die if I did as he said.

“Why the fuck should I?” I grumble. Asshole just demands shit for no reason and expects me to obey.

My cock might like that, but my brain does not.

Mostly.

Okay, my brain likes it just fine, but I’m feeling obstinate after that phone call last night. He knew what he was doing. He can fuck off for all I

care. The fact that I have to be in the car with him all damn day is making me fucking miserable.

Luca reclines his seat as far as he can and points at the windshield.

“A spider. Now pull the fuck over before I put a bullet in your brain.”

I stare at the little black thing moving around on the glass and bite back a laugh.

“Hell. No.”

He turns slowly to stare at me, his hands flexing on his lap.

“You love that word, don’t you? *No*. Makes you feel powerful. You want me to give you a spanking?”

I shudder slightly, wanting that so damn bad, but refusing to admit it. Instead, I say, “When you’re an asshole, yeah, I do love that word. *No*. Deal with the spider. It won’t fucking hurt you. It’s just building a web. Minding its own business.”

“I hate spiders.”

“I know. You’re a baby about them.”

His face pales and he swallows roughly. “I don’t fucking like them.”

Ignoring him, I continue driving, my eyes on the road, the swish of the wipers loud in the cab.

“Pull over, Viktor.”

“If you say please,” I murmur.

His knuckles crack, but then he utters it, a small “*please*.”

That makes my heart flop around in my chest and my stomach flutter. He said please. I don’t think I’ve ever heard him say that. It makes me slightly uncomfortable. Why does he hate spiders so much? That’s something I’ve been wondering since I first captured one for him. I held it in my palm, and he inhaled sharply.

“It’s going to bite you.”

“No, it won’t.”

I tossed it outside and when I turned around to roll my eyes at him for being such a wimp, he was gone. From then on, I’m the one he goes to when he needs to rid his space of them. Not that it happens often, but he obviously can’t cope.

As soon as I can manage it, I pull off at the next exit, reaching over and grabbing the spider between my fingers, and tossing it out onto the ground. I’m not going to kill it this time. Just let it go. I’m benevolent like that.

“Happy now?” I ask, and Luca nods.

“Yes.”

He doesn’t thank me, not that he ever does. Asshole.

When I finally start the car back up, Luca’s eyes are closed, his breathing slightly labored.

“Why do you hate spiders so much?” I ask, and then add, “And fire?”

Why the hell not go there? I’ve never asked him this, I’ve always just taken care of him without questioning it. But with the way he’s been treating me lately, why be nice and accommodating?

“None of your fucking business.”

I want it to be my business, though. For some reason, I want to know.

“Now drive. We have an appointment with the Phantoms and you know Mick doesn’t like when people are late.”

“Yeah, I’ll let him know you squealed like a little girl because of a spider. So I had to pull over and put it outside.”

“You’ll fucking not.”

I don’t do it. I wish I could, but as much as I hate Luca, I don’t want to make him look weak in front of a motorcycle gang’s boss. That would just be stupid. It could put us both in danger. And with the mood his men say he’s in today, I have good reason not to press my luck. He’s one of the more dangerous bosses around, and I know he wouldn’t hesitate to put us in an early grave, even if it meant starting a war with us.

“Never seen this girl, but I’ll pass it around,” Mick says loudly, standing behind his desk, Luca next to him as I walk into the room. He’s a big man, with a long graying beard and a scar on his face. It’s said that it came from his brother, who was upset about him fucking his wife, but I’m not sure of the truth about that. Not that it matters.

I just want to finish business here and move on to the next destination.

Mick’s eyes meet mine as I step closer to the two of them, showing him the gun at my side. Mick’s lips twitch slightly at the sight of me.

“Ah, look, you brought the little slut with you.”

Before I can even respond, Luca’s gun is out, pressed under Mick’s chin, a knife to the side of his throat. The man standing sentry in the corner of the room quickly lifts his gun and points it at Luca, and so I do the same to him. Tension vibrates through the room, knocking off walls and making my chest heave.

“Say that again and I’ll gut you,” Luca growls, his voice tinged with anger.

Mick swallows, his eyes narrowing. “Didn’t know you had a difference of opinion.”

Luca presses the weapons into Mick harder before pulling them away and stalking over to me. He sheathes his knife and his hand comes up to wrap around the back of my head, pulling me forward, his mouth slanting over mine. And what ensues is the filthiest kiss I’ve ever had.

Open mouths, tongues, spit and clashing teeth. It’s drawn out so long that when he finally pulls away, I’m speechless and dazed, the room tilting slightly, my gun hanging limply at my side.

“He’s *my* slut. Now keep your shitty thoughts to yourself.”

That shuts everyone up. Mick tilts his head slightly in acknowledgment, and I make it through that meeting with an open mouth and a foggy brain. I don’t contribute anything at all. It’s all I can do to keep my gun in my hand.

He kissed me and called me his slut. In front of people.

What the hell is that about? What’s his game?

I can’t get my mind off it as Mick looks at the toxicology report Luca shows him and explains that the substances found in that dead woman are all indicative of a new drug on the market, one being distributed by an unknown seller.

“Ask around and let me know if you find out anything. I want to make sure no one is selling this shit on my turf,” Mick says.

Luca nods and shakes his hand, the two of us leaving side by side. As we do, Luca pulls out a cigarette, and I light it automatically without a word. I can’t stop peeking over at him, my eyes flitting to his lips.

Fucking hate the way they automatically draw my gaze.

“Shut that filthy mouth. That kiss meant nothing,” he says when I stare at him a little too long.

I snap my lips closed and glower at him. “I didn’t think it did. It sucked, by the way. Was the shittiest kiss I’ve ever had.”

“Your cock thinks otherwise.”

He glances down at it, and I shift away from him as we walk to the tinted black SUV.

“My cock has nothing to do with you.”

He gives me a smug grin. “Keep telling yourself that.”

I do. I keep telling myself that, despite my dick not listening. I’m on the verge of an orgasm as we drive to the club owned by the Sirens. It’s thirty miles away, but it takes us over an hour and a half to get there in traffic. By

the time we arrive, I'm vibrating with pent-up aggression and lust, and my stomach is rumbling from hunger.

And I hate being hungry. I grew up starving and I refuse to go hungry again. I pull out a granola bar and stuff some in my mouth.

I resent that Anthony has me working for Luca now that he's spending more time at home with Tatum.

I'm glad I have a job, working for a man I respect, but not at the cost of my sanity.

I pull the car into a dirt parking lot and the two of us walk toward the ramshackle building, motorcycles parked in a line outside, the neon sign flickering ominously. When we step inside, I take in the few men and several women lingering about in the smoky, dimly lit room. My hand moves to the gun at my side, and I nod at the bartender.

"We're here to see Tish," Luca announces.

Just as he says it, a woman with bleached-blonde hair appears.

"Well, look who it is!" She's not a day over forty, but she looks as if she's lived far longer than that. The Sirens are one of the toughest motorcycle clubs around and made up of mostly women. "Luca Rossi. As I live and breathe."

She moves up to him and kisses him on the cheek, smearing her pink lipstick across his skin as she does.

Luca grins at her, looking far too sexy for just having had his mouth on mine, and he strokes his hand over hers.

"Looking beautiful as always, Tish."

She preens and I fight back an eye roll. I don't want to make anyone upset at my clear lack of respect. The Sirens may be women, but they're fierce. Scarier than most, I might add. Almost like they have something to prove.

"Come on back to the office. Easier for me to hear you and less eavesdropping. They're all nosy bitches."

We follow her to an office down a short hallway and she opens the door for us, letting us walk inside first.

"What can we do you for? You said you had something you wanted us to look at?" she says as she closes the door and moves toward Luca.

"Yeah," Luca replies, producing a piece of paper and handing it to her. "Take a look at this and let me know if you've heard of any new drugs out on the market."

She eyes it and rolls her painted lips between her teeth. She takes far too long to respond. I don't like that. Not at all. The vibe in this room is off. "Not sure I do."

The way her eyes flick up to meet mine makes me think she's lying to me. But I can't call her out on it. I have to save my thoughts for later.

"You sure?" Luca asks.

"Do you mind if I make a copy of this?" she asks.

Luca nods, and I watch her intently as she scans it on her copy machine.

"I also sent you a picture of a woman we found deceased in one of the warehouses. Can you pass it around and see if anyone knows her?"

She nods and hands Luca the toxicology report.

"I'll keep in touch. Now, you want a drink before you leave? On the house."

Luca eyes me and then nods. "Sure. I'd love a drink."

She grins, lipstick smeared on her teeth, and we follow her to the bar where a burly woman is making drinks. Her biceps look like they could crush my head with one ill-timed movement.

"Hello, handsome," the bartender says to me, and I manage a small nod. "What can I get you?"

"He's not drinking," Luca says before leaning forward and wetting his lips seductively. "But I'll have an old fashioned."

"You got it," the woman says and then winks at him.

I sit down on the stool next to Luca and place my gun on my lap. I don't trust these women. And the unkempt appearance of the men lingering around makes me worried for civilization. Have they not heard of soap?

I bet their asses aren't clean, either.

"Tish is lying to you," I say lowly, and Luca meets my gaze.

"Maybe, maybe not. Now shut up and let me drink in peace." An angry growl escapes me, and he chuckles. "Now, kitten, don't be so upset. I'll still let you look at my cock and ass."

My hand tightens on my gun and I talk myself out of pointing it at his dick and firing.

"I have had much better dicks than yours," I murmur. "Yours is pathetic."

He peers over at me, the drink in his hand, his lips at the edge of the glass.

"Now, you know that's not true."

I swallow roughly and shift in my seat as he sips at his drink.

“If I remember correctly, that night, you moaned that it was the best fuck of your life.”

My lungs squeeze, and I feel mortification crash into me.

I don’t remember that. Fuck, did I really say that?

“I think we should get a hotel tonight. I don’t want to drive home in traffic and we still have several more clubs to hit tomorrow.”

“That would have been nice to know so we could have packed shit for an overnight stay,” I manage to hiss.

Luca winks at me and then pats my cheek roughly.

“Poor baby. But I think you’ll survive.”

That’s one way to put it. A hotel room with him? I’m not sure I will make it out alive.

By the time we make it to the hotel on the outskirts of the city, I have a headache. If he wanted to stay the night somewhere, he should have told me beforehand. I could have packed a suitcase. Now all we have are the clothes on our backs and the shit in our pockets. I’m going to start keeping a go-bag from now on.

“Why don’t you go to the corner store and grab us some toiletries,” Luca says as he hands me a key to the room.

“Why don’t you get them yourself, since you didn’t plan this trip out for shit?”

His tongue clicks and he cocks his head. “Or you can just be a good boy and do as I say.”

I snatch the card from his fingers and stomp off, adjusting myself as I go. *Fuck this*, I think as I make my way to the corner store and collect toothbrushes, toothpaste, and deodorant. The hotel should have shampoo and soap, so I don’t bother with those. It is a nice place. At least he isn’t forcing me to stay in some budget motel.

When I return, I nearly choke when I see Luca standing naked in the middle of the room, looking like a fucking god. All those tattoos and that tanned skin. And those muscles.

So many muscles.

“What the hell are you doing?” I ask, taking in the fact this room only has one bed.

Of course it does. This is just my fucking luck.

“And where the fuck is the other bed?” I manage to choke out.

He turns to look at me. “There’s a conference in the hotel today. We’re lucky we got this one. And as to the fact that I’m naked, well, today’s your lucky day, Vik. Put your clothes in that bag. The hotel will launder them for us.”

“This could have been dealt with by preparing for this trip or choosing a hotel that wasn’t packed full,” I say, peeling my gaze from him.

He wants me to look. He’s not into men, but he enjoys torturing me. It’s his favorite pastime.

Luca ignores me, moving toward the window and pushing it open before striding back toward me, his dick swinging between his legs, thick and heavy. I swallow, my throat clicking as I try to force my gaze away from him.

It doesn’t work.

He’s perfection.

He chuckles as he disappears into the bathroom, locking the door behind him. Like I’m going to try to go inside with him.

Fuck him, I think as I sit on the edge of the bed and wait for him to finish up. I clutch the sheets tightly and grind my teeth, trying like hell to keep myself from turning over and screaming into the pillow. This is absurd. Almost like he planned this entire thing.

He’s getting off on this, this fucked up game he’s playing. I know it. I just need to show him that I can control myself. That I’m not interested.

But all of that dissipates in a flash when he strolls out of the bathroom with the towel around his shoulders, his body still damp.

Everything is on display. All that muscle, all those tattoos, some newer than others, some faded with time.

“You can use the bathroom now,” he says, and I hold back a murmured curse.

I stalk into the bathroom, tossing my clothes out, wincing when I realize I was wearing another pair of lace panties and they’re now lying out there where Luca can see. Well, it’s not like it’s unexpected. He probably did this to embarrass me. He probably planned this entire trip and picked this exact hotel just to get me to take off my lace underwear for shits and giggles.

I really need to decompress, to let this stress flow from me, to not let him get to me. So I take a long, extra-hot shower and do *not* touch my cock the entire time. I won't give him that power over me. I'm taking it back. I'm in control now.

By the time I exit the bathroom, steam billowing around me, I feel slightly better. That is until I see Luca lounging on the bed, completely naked. He hasn't even bothered to cover himself up. He knows what his body does to me.

The way I begged for it that night.

I shut that thought down and move toward the bed.

I was high and exhausted. It had nothing to do with Luca. Not really.

"Come on, kitten," he says with that stupid smirk. "I won't bite."

"I'd rather sleep on the fucking floor than next to you."

His eyes slide down my chest to my dick that is tenting my towel. My hands fall to my crotch, trying like hell to hide it, but it doesn't work. He knows. He's seen it.

"Do you just walk around hard all the time? You need to get fucked badly, don't you?"

"Not by you."

He reaches between his legs and grabs onto his soft dick and strokes it.

"Good, because I wasn't offering. Perhaps you should go back to the club and let them destroy your ass. Seems that's what you like."

I grab my phone and move to the other side of the bed, whipping off my towel from around my waist and sliding in between the sheets.

"Thought you were sleeping on the floor," he says, mirth in his voice.

"Fuck you."

He chuckles as I turn onto my side and face the wall, scrolling through my phone. Minutes later, I hear it, the sound of porn emanating through phone speakers.

"Turn that off," I grunt, realizing he's turning the volume up slowly. He's taunting me.

When he doesn't answer, I peer over my shoulder and see him watching two men go at it on the screen.

"What the hell are you doing?"

"Trying to see what appeals," he says, cocking his head to the side and squinting one eyeball.

I turn over and try to swipe it from his fingers, but he maneuvers out of my reach, my hand flailing around in the air like a kite in the wind. It only infuriates me more. I push myself up and lunge for it again, but he holds it up and I'm left straddling him, aggressively batting it out of his hands. The phone topples to the floor, the moaning and grunting coming from the speakers making my dick throb. It's not what I need, especially right now, being naked in bed with Luca.

"Pick up my phone," he hisses.

I stare down at him and can't help the anger pulsing through me. Impulsively, I reach down and grab his neck, choking him roughly. His eyes widen, and then, with a loud grunt, he bucks up, flinging me onto my back, his body entirely on top of mine.

My hands are dislodged from his throat and he tries to restrain them, but I manage to avoid him, curling my legs around his back and trying to push him off of me. Not that I manage the first time, but I'm able to push him to his side, my hand shoved against his face and arching his neck back. His fingers curl into my hair and tug roughly, making me cry out.

I'm so pissed now. I can't help but breathe fire. We wrestle around on the bed, grunting and cursing, our bodies sliding against each other, the scent of him permeating my senses.

Fuck, he smells so good.

I loathe him.

It doesn't help that he feels good against me, his dick sliding against mine, the stimulation making him half-hard as well. I don't take it personally.

I know what he thinks of me.

Finally, Luca gets the upper hand and my arms are wrenched up above my head, his knees on my thighs, pinning me down. His hair is in disarray, his eyes wild as he stares down at me.

"You are such a bitch," he murmurs.

"Your bitch, you mean? Your slut?" I rasp.

He chuckles, his nails digging into my skin, his knees pushing into my thighs painfully. Fuck, I'm going to have bruises there tomorrow.

"You fucking wish."

Our eyes meet and his nostrils flare, and then I see it, spit forming between his lips, falling onto my cheek. He stares at it, and I curse under

my breath at the sensation of his saliva falling from my skin to the pillow beneath me.

"You look good wearing me."

"I *hate* you."

"And yet you want me to fuck you. What an interesting conundrum."

I turn my face slightly, closing my eyes, letting myself feel the weight of him owning me for just a moment before I feel the wet swipe of his tongue against my cheek.

My eyes pop open and I meet his glittering gaze.

"Stop licking me. If you keep this up, I'll think you want me."

"I only want to make you suffer," he replies and then he moves off me, rolling to his side of the bed and picking up his phone from the floor. The video is still playing but thankfully he shuts it off and then swipes at his phone screen.

"Want dinner?"

I drag my hand across my wet face and glower at him. I want to tell him to eat glass, but then my stomach rumbles. That granola bar did fuck all.

"I'll take that as a yes and since you want to be my little bitch, I'll order for you."

I grit my teeth and turn my body into the mattress, my face smashed into the pillow. I take care to temper my breathing, trying like hell to not think about the fact that Luca is right there next to me, naked and smelling like hotel soap and the deodorant I bought.

My mind moves to my breathing and I try to center myself, thinking about all the reasons my hate for him is illogical, but I can't quite make my mind believe it. I just don't like the guy. He infuriates me. How hot he is, how cocky and confident. How he speaks to me, how he treats me.

I hate that I'm so attracted to him and know I can't have him.

That I had him and won't ever feel that again.

A knock on the door an hour later has Luca standing up, and I may peek over from my place on the bed to watch his ass as he moves.

It's fucking glorious.

I turn my face back into my pillow and let out a loud sigh.

"When you're done making out with your pillow, your food is here."

I lift my head, cheeks flaming. I wasn't making out with my fucking pillow. But I swallow those words down, not even wanting to engage with him.

Luca lifts a few boxes from a paper bag and sets them on the small desk in the corner.

He points to one, “Yours.”

I sit up, put the towel around my waist, and approach as Luca lounges, bare-assed, in a chair, legs spread, exposing his cock and balls to me. He pulls out a burger, biting into it sloppily, some spilling onto his chest.

Disgusting, I think even as my mind envisions me kneeling between his spread legs and lapping it up.

Like a fucking dog.

I pry open my box and see a plain chicken breast on some rice. I peer over at Luca’s burger, and he winks at me.

“Have to keep that figure, kitten.”

I grab the box and make my way back to the bed, eating the food quickly and chugging a bottle of water, peering over at Luca, who is licking his fingers. Slowly.

He leans forward, his abs and biceps flexing as he goes, and grabs another box.

His tongue peeks out and wets his lips, peeling it open and grabbing a spoon from a wrapper.

“Crème brûlée,” he says, taking a small bite and licking it salaciously off the utensil.

I stare at him, stomach grumbling for something sweet as well. It has nothing to do with his mouth or the way he’s groaning.

“Can’t look away, can you? Want a bite?” he asks, holding out his spoon toward me.

I meet his gaze and see the spark of competition in it. Without a thought other than winning this one, I stand up, walk toward him, and straddle his thighs. The move surprises him, his arm faltering slightly as I place the entirety of my weight on his lap before leaning forward, grabbing his wrist, and bringing the spoon right up to my mouth. I engulf it, dragging my lips down the plastic silverware and popping off it with a moan.

“So good,” I rasp, and Luca’s nostrils flare.

“You think you’re so fucking clever.”

“Two can play this game.”

“I do love games,” he replies and then holds up another bite for me. I can’t believe he’s letting me sit on his lap like this, like two lovers spending a night together. We hate each other.

He slides the spoon down my tongue and swirls it at the tip.

“Such a cockslut.”

I huff and swallow, starting to move off him, but his hand grabs onto my hip.

“No, you eat all of it.”

I don’t know why he’s demanding this of me. But he likes control and, for some reason, I like being used. The perfect pairing.

“Fuck off,” I whisper as I open my mouth and he pushes another mouthful inside.

“Swallow.” And I do as he says, my body relaxing as he does this, demanding things from me, *making* me.

“Look at you, doing what I command. If I told you to get on your knees and suck my dick, you would.”

I don’t say a word, but he can see my answer in my eyes.

Oh fuck. Make me, Luca.

Make me.

“You’re a control freak,” I finally manage to utter, and his lips quirk.

“I control you.”

My tongue snakes out and captures the treat he’s holding out for me, and when I swallow it, he leans back slightly, his eyes roving over my chest and down to my cock.

“Touch yourself,” he says, his gaze slashing up to mine.

When I don’t move to grab my dick, he huffs slightly and then clutches my hand, licking a stripe up my palm.

My entire body shivers and he lowers it to my dick.

“Do as I say.”

“I don’t want to.”

“You do. Now do it, Vik. Touch your dick. You want it.”

My fingers wrap around my hard length and I start stroking, lust sliding through me. What is his endgame? Why is he making me jack off while eating dessert? Is this some kind of kink? I want to know, but not enough to ask. I just do as he says, letting him feed me until there’s nothing left and then letting him watch as I explode across his stomach.

My body curls in on itself, the orgasm intense and almost painful.

Through my lashes, I see Luca run his fingers across the mess I made on his skin, and he holds them up to my mouth, smearing it across my lips.

“Now, get on your knees and clean me up.”

His lips twitch slightly, and I'm almost positive he thinks I won't do it. But I'll show him. I move off his lap, kneel between his spread thighs, and lap up my cum. Every last drop, making sure to even lick a stripe up his dick for good measure.

His half-hard cock thickens when I do that, but before I can take in more of him, his hands tighten in my hair and he wrenches my head back.

"Enough. No more."

Our eyes meet in a clash of wills and I'm the first to back down. I yank my head to the right and push myself up, striding to the bathroom with shaking legs.

What the hell was I thinking?

What the hell was *he* thinking?

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4

LUCA

I can't breathe. It's so hot, flames licking at the small crawlspace I've squeezed myself into. Pulling my shirt over my mouth, I inhale, but there's so much smoke. It hurts. I turn my face away from the flames and see spiders scatter up the walls. One bit me already, my skin stinging around my ankle. I pull my legs up closer to my chest, squeezing my eyes shut and wishing for my mom and dad.

For someone to save me.

But no one will. They're all dead.

Images of my parents and two younger brothers bleeding out on the floor shoot through my mind, my mother reaching out for me, her lips forming the words to tell me to hide.

I heard them scream as the fire consumed them.

And now it's just flames.

It's so hot.

I can't breathe.

Can't breathe.

Can't breathe.

Can't…

"Luca!" A shout has me sitting upright in bed, sweat dripping down my body, my skin aching from where I swear I felt the flames scorching them. I turn my hazy gaze toward Viktor, who is staring at me with wide eyes.

My hand runs down my face, trembling slightly. I'm gasping, drinking down the air.

“What was that? A nightmare?”

I don’t answer; I can’t. My throat is parched, as if I swallowed the fire itself. He saw me vulnerable. No one sees me like this. No one.

Viktor sees me swallowing, my throat clicking loudly, and he sighs, standing up and returning a moment later with a cup of water in his hand. I take it and gulp it down, some missing my mouth entirely and sliding down my chin and chest.

And the entire time, Viktor just watches me, his eyes taking everything in.

I’ve never felt so weak in my entire life. I hate how much he sees.

The way he looks at me. He’s always fucking looking.

I hate it. But not as much as when his eyes are on someone else. I hate that even more.

“Lie the fuck down,” I murmur when he continues to just stand there, ogling me.

“I’m just making sure you don’t break down again,” he bites back.

“I wasn’t breaking down.”

But I was. Anyone would if they were faced with those visions, a nightmare revisiting me every few days. Those flames didn’t sear my body, but they seared my mind. I won’t ever come back from that.

“You were. You were crying.”

I swipe at my swollen eyes, and I swear I can feel the smoke agitating them. They ached for days after the fire, my vision blurry. The doctors thought I might have vision loss.

“I never cry.”

He huffs and rolls his eyes, moving to his side of the bed and crawling beneath the covers, turning his back to me.

“Whatever. Go cry in your sleep. I don’t fucking care.”

He’s pouting as I put my head back on the pillow and stare up at the ceiling. My heart is thumping abnormally fast in my chest and my skin feels as if it’s still melting from my body.

I’m on top of the comforter, trying like hell to cool down, but nothing is working, so I finally sit up and move to the bathroom to take a cold shower. The icy spray from the showerhead calms me somewhat, and when I emerge and slip back under the covers, I feel more or less back to normal.

The only problem is, Viktor is watching me intently, those dark eyes peering into my fucking soul. Even in the dark, I know they’re on me.

His hand reaches out and touches my arm, and I flinch back.

“You’re freezing.”

“Better than burning alive.”

He’s quiet for a moment and then, “What happened to you, Luca?”

“None of your fucking business.”

“Yeah, you’re right. Shouldn’t fucking care about you. I don’t know what I was thinking.”

Yeah, he’s got it now. It’s best not to care about anyone because when you do, you lose them. In the most horrible way.

The next morning, while Viktor is still asleep, I sit in the bathroom with the water running to drown out any noise as I call my aunt. She messaged me last night, almost as if she could feel the nightmare I had.

After the fire, my aunt and uncle took me in, and she would let me crawl into bed with her on the nights I’d wake up from those dreams. It was the only safety I ever felt after watching my family die.

I think of Viktor sprawled out on the bed in the other room, the steady thrum of his heart, the way his limbs go akimbo over the entire bed, the way he takes up so much space.

Fuck. Him.

“How are you?” my aunt says over the phone. “Is that running water? What happened?”

“Nothing, just got your message,” I lie, even though I know she can tell. She always knew when I was afraid. “Are you okay?”

“I’m fine, love. Just got a sense last night and you know your uncle. He insisted I message to check in. It’s been a while.”

“It has.”

“So, tell me how you’re really doing. You have that sound about you.”

I sigh and rub a hand across my face. “Had the dream again. It hasn’t happened in a while.”

She’s silent for a moment. “Do you have someone to take care of you when you wake?”

I don’t want to admit it, but I can’t lie to her. “Kind of.”

“Is that who you’re hiding from in the bathroom?” I don’t say anything, and she laughs softly. “You stubborn boy. Go back out there and let her comfort you.”

I don’t correct her immediately. She has no reason to think this person is a man. I’ve never given any indication it was a possibility. Until him.

Until three years ago.

My mind pictures the black rose, a representation of so many things.

I squash it and focus back on my aunt.

“It’s not a woman,” I murmur.

My aunt is silent, and then utters, “Oh. Doesn’t matter, love. Just let yourself be taken care of. You deserve it after everything you went through.”

I don’t tell her it’s not his job, nor is it consistent with who I am. I’m no longer that scared little boy. She doesn’t need to see the real me. No one sees that. Not even him. I won’t let him. But I let her believe what she wants to. Instead, I change the subject, making promises to see her and my uncle soon. I hang up, turn off the water, and move into the main room. I brew myself a cup of coffee as Viktor wakes up, and then I offer him one as well.

He takes it begrudgingly.

“Who were you talking to in the bathroom?” he asks, almost sounding jealous.

I don’t answer, just drink my coffee and let him stew on it. It sours his mood completely.

Good. Let him feel a fraction of what he does to me.

When the coffee has been depleted, we dress in our laundered clothes and grab a quick breakfast from the downstairs café before heading out to two other motorcycle clubs. One is on the outskirts of the city and the other is in the high desert. Both are dead ends. No one knows anything, and if they do, they lie to our faces.

“I’m telling you, the Sirens know something more than they’re saying.” This is the third time Viktor has said this to me today, but I’m grumpy and tired. The lack of sleep and the copious amounts of caffeine I’ve consumed are making me cranky. I can feel my eyeballs with each blink and my heart is beating erratically inside my chest.

I hate those nightmares. They come and go, making appearances when I least expect them. I should have known one would show up when I was

with Viktor.

“Yeah, you fucking said,” I murmur as I place a cigarette between my lips and wait for him to light it. He does it with deft precision, and I take that first drag of nicotine into my lungs. Fuck, that’s nice.

It’s a bad vice, but I won’t quit. No matter how much the smoke reminds me of that torturous night. Maybe that’s why I like it, why I continue to smoke.

To not let me forget.

I never did find who murdered them. Even with Anthony’s help later on, the trail went cold.

Not that I’ve given up. I’ll never give up, not until I find them and burn them alive.

Just like they did to my family.

Leaning my head back against the passenger seat, I watch the traffic come to a standstill and curse under my breath.

“We should go back and press the Sirens. I know you’ve probably fucked all of them, but that doesn’t mean they’re innocent.”

“I’ve fucked ten and a half of them,” I grumble. And none of them were very good. Each one just a passing fancy that ended in extreme boredom. Unlike Viktor. It’s him I love to play with. I never thought I’d be into another man like this, but there’s just something about him.

The way he grumbles and grunts and ultimately caves.

I want to see him give in completely. Again.

I want it *again*.

“Yeah, well…”

“Yeah, well, what?” I ask as my phone rings. I answer when I see that it’s Carlos.

“What’s up?” I ask and turn my gaze to the mountains and the traffic looming endlessly before us.

“Found a body out back. A woman. What the fuck do we do? I don’t do cleanup, Luca.” He sounds panicked, and I grind my teeth in frustration. This is not what I need today.

I sigh, pinching the bridge of my nose. “I know you don’t. Don’t call the cops. Cover her up with a tarp or some shit. We’ll be there as fast as we can.”

I stare at the brake lights in front of us and sigh again. “Another body at the club. Call the Andromeda brothers. Are you wearing your slut panties?”

“They’re not slutty. They’re just underwear.”

I stare at him long and hard. “I’ve never seen a man wear something like that.”

“Yeah, well, you don’t know the right kind of men.”

“Hm,” I say, running my hand across my jaw. “Apparently, I don’t. In any case, call the fucking brothers. I need them there ASAP. And we need a blood sample again. We need to see if this is an overdose with the same drug.”

But Viktor doesn’t sense the urgency. He takes his time calling them, speaking curtly through the speaker phone when he does. He’s trying to keep it professional, but they won’t let him.

“Do you have what we want?” they ask at the same time in the creepy way they do.

He huffs and peers over at me with those dark brown eyes. I can’t help but smirk.

“I do,” he grumbles, and they practically purr over the phone.

“Just so you know, we are making changes to the contract. Will discuss when we arrive.”

I grin as he hangs up and stabs at the controls for the music.

“Don’t say a fucking word.”

“I’ll speak if I want to. I’m your boss, which you seem to forget as often as you breathe.”

“You don’t let me forget,” he hisses and then turns up the music even louder. Some kind of angry rock band that is giving me a migraine. Reaching over, I turn it off.

“Can’t stand that shit.”

“And what do you like, huh? I don’t think you even like music. I bet anything pretty makes your ears bleed.”

“I like peace and quiet.”

He rolls his eyes and his grip tightens on the steering wheel. His dark brown hair hangs messily around his ears and I itch to touch it.

Love that it’s longer. Perfect for pulling.

“Fine, then we can roll our way to the fucking dead body in silence.”

I’m fine with that. And we do; the only sounds are the engine accelerating occasionally and Viktor’s muttered curses when someone brakes too quickly. By the time we’re at the club, the sun is setting behind the horizon and Carlos looks nearly apoplectic.

“There are two men here. Creepy fuckers,” he murmurs as he leads us into the back alley where a tarp covers a lump on the ground. “They wouldn’t leave.”

“Yes, they’re with me,” I say, and he eyes me, but I ignore him. He’s just a contractor. He doesn’t need to know anything more. “You’re dismissed. Thank you for keeping this discreet. You’ll find a nice deposit in your account later tonight.”

Carlos nods and then turns on his heel, leaving Viktor and me to face the body under the tarp and the twins who are kneeling next to it, vials of blood lying near their black boots.

“You made it,” one of them says. Don’t know which one, just that he’s ogling Viktor with lust in his eyes. My fingers land on my gun.

Could put a bullet between his eyes.

I could.

“Yeah, I know,” Viktor mumbles, moving behind a dumpster and returning with his panties. He hands the underwear to one of them, and the twin presses his nose into it, inhaling deeply like the creep he is, before handing it to his brother, who does the same thing.

“You smell like sex,” one of them says before placing the panties in his pocket.

“I smell like soap.”

They stare at him, not blinking before dismissing him entirely.

“Now that we’ve gotten what we want, we’ll get to work. The blood from the specimen is here.”

The twin reaches his hand out, and I grab the vials.

“Any idea of how she died?” I ask, and their eyes flick to me.

“Overdose, we assume. Nothing else points to foul play.”

“Fine,” I reply before moving up to the tarp and pulling it back, seeing the dead woman crumpled on the pavement. Her hair is a mess, her eyelids are closed, a bruise on her cheek. Other than that, she’s fully clothed and doesn’t seem to have any other injuries. Then again, it doesn’t matter. I’m not an investigator. I just want to get rid of the body. Whoever is placing these women here wants me to get caught.

I don’t think this is a coincidence anymore.

I turn to leave, but the twins stop us. “Our contract has changed.”

Viktor’s cheeks darken and his lips purse. “What the fuck do you want, then?”

“We want to watch. We want more than the souvenirs.”

Viktor glances away with a scoff, and I see his fingers tighten on his biceps.

“What do you want? Spell it out.”

“To watch you. Getting off.”

“Well, I’m not doing that here. In front of a dead woman. That’s disrespectful.”

They look unbothered by that, but apparently, Viktor has some principles. The brothers’ gazes slide up and down Viktor’s body and they cock their heads, waiting for him to counter. But he’s so flustered, he doesn’t. He just huffs and puffs. So I answer for him.

“I’ll record him and you’ll have it by tonight.”

Their eyes slam into mine and they consider it, some twin telepathy happening between them.

“Fine. By midnight or the contract is over.”

They turn and get to work as Viktor and I stride away, side by side.

“Why the hell did you offer that? I’m not letting you record me.”

“Oh, but you will. This is your *job*.”

“My job is protecting you, not getting off in front of a camera. That wasn’t part of the contract.”

My hand moves up to the nape of his neck and I squeeze roughly. “You’ll do as you’re told. For the good of the family. Or should I tell Anthony that you’re the reason we lost the brothers?”

He scoffs but doesn’t argue. He knows this is what he has to do. He slides into the driver’s seat and takes me home. Not a word is spoken until we’re inside.

And then my heart rate picks up.

It’s time.

“Do you have to be all up in my business?” Viktor asks as he reclines on my bed, his legs spread, hands covering his dick. He had undressed reluctantly and I recorded him the entire time. I want to make sure the Andromeda brothers have nothing to complain about. Knowing them, they’ll find fault in something and he’ll have to redo the entire thing.

Why does that thought have my cock twitching?

“If I want to get this video right, I do.”

He huffs and leans his head back, accentuating his throat, his Adam’s apple bobbing. He’s gorgeous in a very masculine way. Those lean muscles, the way his nipples pucker with the slightest change in temperature. Or when he’s turned on.

“Fuck. Fine. But don’t ever say I don’t do my job.”

His eyes refuse to meet mine as he grabs the lube and squeezes it on his cock, his fingers wrapping around his long length. *He does have a big dick*, I think as he spreads his legs slightly and shows himself off. It’s almost like it’s natural for him to do this, to put on a show.

No wonder he was a favorite at the club.

“Maybe you should be a camboy,” I say, and his jaw clicks.

“And why is that?” he asks as he shuttles his fist up and down his cock.

“Because you love being watched.”

“I do not.”

“You fucking do. You were hard as soon as there was mention of getting off in front of a camera with me watching. You crave it.”

He huffs but doesn’t deny it, just works his fist faster.

“Now, kitten, don’t get off too soon. You know they’ll bitch about it.”

He scowls at me, not listening. “They should be happy with what they’re getting. They don’t get to just change the contract like this. That’s not how this works.”

“It seems they can do whatever they want.”

“Yeah, they fucking can. Shit,” he says, twisting his wrist, trying for a different angle, but I can see his growing frustration. “I can’t just come on command. I’m not a fucking robot.”

“Oh, but Vik, you *will* come on my command.”

He growls, and I push the camera closer to his dick, getting a close-up of it. Wet and angry, the vein underneath pulsing.

“Back up, Luca. You’re in my fucking space.”

I glance up at him, not moving. “Fuck off, Vik. Don’t pretend you don’t like me this close.”

He grunts and switches hands, but he isn’t happy about it. His face is screwed up, his breath coming out in frustrated grunts.

“Maybe you should leave,” he says, but I refuse.

“No.”

He grunts and then kicks his leg out, knocking me backward slightly.

The camera is jostled and my nostrils flare. “You messed up my fucking shot.”

“Yeah, well, back the hell off me.”

“Fucking come then.”

“You just told me to go slower.”

“And you are. Slow as a fucking snail.”

He sits up, his hands falling to his sides, his slick dick sticking up between his legs, his eyes flaring with anger.

“Yeah, well, maybe you should get off then. Show me how it’s done.”

“You’d like that, wouldn’t you? Watching me get off?”

His cheeks darken. “It would be disgusting.”

But I see the way he wets his lips.

“I think you’d gag for it, like the slut you are.”

He meets my gaze with steel of his own, and I can see the kick before it reaches me. I grab onto his thigh with my free hand and wrench it to the side, holding it down as he squirms underneath me.

“You keep this up and I’ll make you fucking regret it.”

He grunts and tries to maneuver out of my hold, but I don’t move, just hold him in place, the phone still in my hand recording.

“I fucking quit then. I quit! This is shit.”

I let out a low, evil laugh. “You don’t get to leave, Vik. You die before you get out.”

And then my hand wraps tightly around his dick and strokes.

He arches up, his hips thrusting into my fist.

“Fuck, Luca. What the hell are you doing?” he pants.

“I’m getting you off since you seem to be shit at it.”

He frowns at that but doesn’t stop fucking up into my hand. “I’m not shit. I’m just…” A groan slips from his lips, and he fists the sheets beneath him.

“Yeah, you take it, little slut,” I murmur, and Viktor’s eyes slash to mine. They’re hooded and dark, his cheeks flushed as he thrusts up into my touch. “You’re gonna beg for it. Look at that cock, drooling for me.”

His little whimpers send a shockwave through my system, my nerve endings firing. I like how he looks, his skin flushed red and shivering with want. If I think hard about it, I liked how he looked that night too, taking it in both ends, over and over again.

Seems I like watching Viktor come.

Even when I was with Laura and Anthony decades ago, I never got off on watching him. It was always her. But then again, Viktor has always gotten under my skin. Even as a gangly teen, he bugged the shit out of me. But now that he's older, I want to peel him open and watch him cry.

I clutch his cock harder.

He cries out, his dick dark purple, the tip dripping.

"Fuck, Luca. *Fuck*," he murmurs as I twist my wrist. His lips are wet, dark red from where he's biting them. And for some reason, I want to crawl up his body and stuff my cock down his throat.

My dick likes that idea. It thickens in my pants, hard and insistent as I work Viktor toward the edge.

"You gonna come for me? You going to moan my name?"

He shakes his head, his fingers twisted up in the sheets, his entire body arching off the bed.

"Maybe I should edge you, make you wait for it?"

He moans and his eyes meet mine. Something moves through those dark depths, and I feel my cock jump.

I want him.

I want to make him gag around me.

Just as I think that, Viktor cries out and his cock shoots cum across his chest. His orgasm is drawn out, his dick jerking in my hand as I squeeze every last drop from it. When he's done, he falls to his back, his body sprawled across my mattress, his limbs limp and stretched out.

"Oh fuck," he murmurs as I stop the video and then send it to the brothers.

I don't say anything as I do it, just watch as his chest heaves, his eyelids shutting.

"That was terrible," he murmurs, but I know it wasn't. I know he wants more. I bet that wasn't even enough for his little slut ass.

I stuff the phone in my pocket and adjust my cock before striding from the room.

I need a fucking drink.

When I make my way back to the bedroom after a long, stiff drink, a smoke, and a call to Anthony to update him on what's been going on, I see Viktor still sprawled out on my bed. He's taking up the entire thing, slumbering peacefully. His abdomen is smeared with his release, his cock half-hard between his legs. If he was awake, he'd be begging for more. I guarantee it.

I lean against the doorjamb and stare at him, the defined planes of his body, the muscles of his arms and chest. Those long legs.

I should sleep on the couch, should let myself get some rest, as fitful as it normally is. But for some reason, I undress, pulling off my shirt and pants, clad only in my boxers, and slide in next to Viktor. He doesn't make space for me, just flounders a bit, making small huffing noises with his mouth as his legs and arms sprawl across me.

It's not comfortable, not at all.

I rearrange him.

He murmurs in his sleep and ends up sprawled out like a starfish.

With a grunt, I realize that the only way I'm going to sleep here with him is if I restrain him. So, with a few heaves, I move him against me, wrapping him tightly with my arms and legs, his back to my chest, his legs tangled with mine, and my face pressed against the back of his neck.

He sighs happily, like a baby being swaddled, and melts into me.

Well, fuck. *I didn't expect that*, I think as I inhale the scent of him. Something earthy and warm. My lips skate across his skin, and Viktor wiggles up against me. His ass hits my cock, and I feel it lengthen against him.

I probably won't sleep well tonight, I think as my eyes close, and surprisingly, darkness consumes me in minutes.

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5

VIKTOR

I wake in bits and pieces, my eyes slowly opening as my limbs try to stretch out, but something is holding me down. Something strong and warm. I grunt and hear Luca murmur behind me, his voice deep with sleep.

"Stop fucking moving."

I don't stop, trying to get away from him. Somehow, he ended up behind me in bed, holding me tightly to him. And now he's not letting me go.

"What the fuck?" I murmur, my voice catching slightly. This is not good. Not at all. It's making me want things I can't have.

I can't ever have him.

My dick enjoys it, though. It's hard and aching between my legs.

Luca's fingers tug on my nipple, and I bite my bottom lip so hard it stings.

He's playing with me. He is. There's no other explanation for this.

This is a game to him.

I'm a fucking pawn.

"Let me go," I grumble, despite my ass grinding into his morning wood, and for a split second, I envision him pushing inside of me.

He'd fuck me so good. God, the way he'd own me.

The way he did that night.

Oh shit.

"Shut up," he murmurs as his teeth sink into the skin of my neck, and I groan at the sensation. And he doesn't let go. He keeps his teeth there, his

tongue flicking out and wetting the skin his teeth have captured. Pain zings through me, down my arm, and up to my face, but fuck, I love it.

I love it when it hurts.

His fingers skate down my chest, over the mess I let dry there last night. His fingernails drag across my abs, assuredly leaving little pink lines as he goes, and despite hating it, I can't help but arch into his touch.

"Good boy, Vik. Such a good fucking boy," he coos lowly in my ear, and his hand wraps around my cock. The sensation of his hand on my dick makes me keen. I can't fucking help the deplorable sounds leaving my mouth.

I should tell him to stop, should save myself from this game I've found myself twisted in, but I don't. I bite back those words and let myself *experience* it. He gets everything just right, the way he grips me, the pace of his strokes. Everything about him is perfect.

As if he's been watching me just as much as I've watched him all these years.

It's been so many years.

"You like that, hm?" he asks, his lips trailing across my skin as he speaks. "You like it rough or a little soft?"

When I don't answer, he growls. "You don't like anything soft, do you? You just want to be owned. Well, guess who owns you right now, kitten?"

I nearly purr at that, hating myself for letting this happen, but unwilling to stop it. It's been so long since I've gotten some. Granted, it happened last night, but still. I'm a horny fuck and I need more than one orgasm a week.

"Say my name when you come," he commands as he twists his wrist and makes a muffled cry leave my lips. "Say it. Fucking say it."

I bite my bottom lip so hard it bleeds, but his name doesn't come out as my release explodes from me. Instead, I swallow it down, letting it burrow inside of me.

Luca. Luca. Luca.

His hand leaves me abruptly and my orgasm ends with a cry of frustration. I feel sensation pulse through me, and not the good kind. I should still be riding out my orgasm, but he left me hanging.

It's because I didn't say his name. Didn't moan it like the whore he wants me to be.

"Fuck you," I manage to murmur, tasting the blood from my lip as it hits my tongue.

“Not a fucking chance in hell,” he says, moving off the bed. I roll over and watch him go, grabbing onto my dick and tugging it gently, but it’s too late, the orgasm has been ruined.

“Asshole,” I murmur as he disappears into the bathroom.

His only response is, “Throw the sheets in the wash before you go.”

Well, fuck. I shouldn’t have fallen asleep last night. I should have gotten up and left after he recorded me, but I didn’t. And now here I am, embarrassed, leaving his house with my tail between my legs. I shouldn’t listen to him, should just leave the sheets on his bed for him to deal with.

Just as I think it, Luca exits the bathroom with a towel wrapped around his waist, his skin damp from the shower.

“Don’t make me put you over my fucking knee,” he says as he eyes the still-made bed.

“Fuck off,” I grunt, realizing I’m still naked and covered in my own mess.

He moves up beside me and his fingers drag up my arm to my shoulder. I feel his fingertips dig into my muscle and I hold my breath as he speaks.

“Don’t forget who I am,” he says, his lips brushing against my ear.

I shiver and when he steps away, I move toward the bed, wrenching the sheets off and balling them against my chest.

“Where the fuck do I put these?” I ask, not meeting his eyes. I refuse.

“Down the hallway,” he says, turning into the closet and leaving me to move out of the bedroom. I stuff the soiled sheets into the washing machine and turn it on before leaning against it and glancing down at my naked body, cum still on my skin from last night and this morning.

I need a fucking reality check. And a shower.

And what I really need is to get out of here.

Pushing myself up, I return to Luca’s bedroom and quickly search for my clothes. I can’t be naked around him any longer. Bad things happen when I am.

I grab my wrinkled clothes from the floor and tug them on just as Luca appears from the closet, looking as suave as ever in a three-piece suit.

“I have a guest arriving soon,” he says, and I stare at him. “So I won’t be needing you to stay.”

I don’t say anything, just button up my jeans, tug my shirt down my chest, and run a hand through my messy hair. I need a fucking haircut.

“Fine,” I grumble, and Luca’s lips quirk slightly. He likes me flustered. And I am. I’m fucking curious what he has going on this morning that doesn’t require me.

Not that it’s any of my business. I’m not burning up at the thought he might have a woman coming by.

I’m not.

I turn on my heel, stopping at the front door to toe on my shoes. Luca is right behind me, his presence almost suffocating.

Hate that he’s so big, that he makes me feel so much.

With a twist of my hand, I pull the door open, startling a beautiful woman on the other side. She’s wearing a sleek pantsuit, her hair done up, her lips bright red.

“Oh, you surprised me,” she says with a small laugh, a hand to her chest.

“Come on in, Alina. Right on time.”

“I remember you,” she says to me and then holds her hand out for me to shake.

I manage a small smile and a nod. “Nice to see you again.”

She squeezes me gently and then cocks her head. “I haven’t seen you at the club since.”

Luca clears his throat behind me, and I force myself not to look. “I’ve been busy.”

“Shame. It was quite the show you gave us. Luca talked about it often.” That makes my head snap back, and Luca grumbles under his breath. “It seems you made quite the impression. On both of us.”

“Alina,” Luca grumbles. “Enough.”

“Alright,” she says with a sly grin, and then leans forward and presses a kiss to my cheek. “See you around.”

I frown as Luca presses his hand against my lower back and shuffles me out of his house. I’m standing there as the door shuts in my face, Alina’s laugh on the other side of the door ringing out.

Fucking hate him. Hate this shit.

Why do I even put up with it?

He’s probably invited her over to fuck her. He’s just playing with me, toying with me.

I know this.

I knew it, and still, I let him touch me again.

The way it makes me ache. It hurts.

It fucking hurts.

I glare at that door for far too long, trying to figure out how I keep getting into these fucking messes with Luca.

Eventually, I stomp to the SUV, trying hard not to squeal my tires in this pristine, gated neighborhood. I'm sure that would only get Luca in trouble with the neighbors. The thought makes me press on the gas, and I rev the engine as I approach the gate. The heavy wooden doors swing open, and I make sure to flip the guard off as I drive past.

I hope they know who I work for. That Luca Rossi is my boss. I hope an angry Karen shows up at his door and gives him hell.

The thought makes me grin.

Without a backward glance, I hightail it back home. I need a fucking long shower and then an even longer workout to get this man out of my mind.

"Why the fuck are you in such a mood?" my roommate, Jax, asks. He's currently sitting on the floor doing sit-ups, and I can't help the scowl that lines my face. Our apartment isn't the nicest, but it works, and we can afford it on our bodyguard salaries. Most of our time is spent at the main house anyway, so for living off-site, this works just fine. And honestly, I like to save my money. I want to make sure I have a nice nest egg if things get hard.

I think about Luca's sprawling house, the opulence in excess, and my lips turn down even further. I don't know why he needs such a big place. It's not like he has a family or kids. He doesn't even have a pet.

Maybe he has wild orgies there when he's not working, I think, and feel my jaw click.

"I'm not in a mood. Just tired."

Truth is, I'm entirely well-rested. I slept like a baby with Luca wrapped around me. The way his legs and arms snaked around me, holding me tightly. I don't know what possessed him to do that, but the fact he did makes me even angrier.

He has no fucking right. He had no fucking right to hold me like that.

Like I belong to him. Like he cares.

My phone buzzes and I look down at it, seeing a picture of my panties in a drawer with several others. Fuck the Andromeda brothers.

I should have never let them fuck me.

TWINCEST:

We enjoyed the video. And our contract has changed. For all future work, we expect you to send a video. Preferably with Luca Rossi.

I don't even reply. Fuck that. I like my job, but not this much. I'm not going to let Luca touch me again.

I'll speak to Anthony. He'll see reason.

Possibly.

The brothers are the best in the business. They're hard to schedule.

Shit. Maybe he won't see reason. He expects loyalty from me. I mean, he deserves it. He took me in when I was a homeless teen on the streets. He gave me a family and a purpose. I owe him everything.

"Who was that?" Jax asks.

"The brothers. They won't leave me the fuck alone."

Jax is mid-sit-up when he shrugs. "I mean, they're hot in a gothic creep kind of way. Didn't you let them fuck you that one time?"

I stare at him and huff. "Yeah, unfortunately."

"So, I mean, you kinda asked for it…the obsession, I mean. You're pretty hot and a good fuck."

"Yeah, well, this shit isn't part of my job description."

Jax ignores me, hopping up onto his feet and moving to the metal bar situated perpendicular to the floor and placed between the doorframe leading to the hallway. "Yeah agreed, but you know, we do it for the fam. Anyway, what do you think about me learning how to pole dance?" He asks this so seriously that I don't answer for half a second.

"What? What the fuck?"

"Yeah, you know, I heard it's a great workout," he says before he pulls himself up, his muscles bulging. "So, what do you think? You think it's too gay?"

I stare at him. "Jax, you fuck dudes occasionally. You've fucked me. That's way more gay."

"Yeah, but like. Is it though?"

I can’t cope with this shit. Not Jax, not the brothers, and not even myself.

I need to get out of here. Workout? Get fucked? I don’t know exactly, but I shower, pull on new clothes, and head out. I end up in the gym on the estate for a while, working out so hard that I nearly pass out. Then I shower again, trying not to think of Luca naked and wet with his big dick pressed out from his body. It doesn’t work. I think of it constantly. When I finally get dressed, feeling slightly better, I head out to get something to eat before driving home. Jax isn’t in the apartment when I arrive, possibly at a pole dancing class that isn’t gay. So, I putter around the apartment, watching a few hours of TV before the ache builds inside of me. It settles between my legs, making my balls heavy and my cock hard.

It leads me to Luca’s social media pages once more. I hate myself as I scroll, telling myself I shouldn’t look. My dick is throbbing and aching by the time I shut my phone off with a huff. Damn him. I mean, I shouldn’t have looked in the first place, but I did and now I’m hot and bothered, remembering him touching me.

For a straight man, he touches my dick far too often.

My hands slide down my face, and I grunt in frustration.

What I really need to do is get fucked. I need to go back to the club. My dry spell has lasted too long. I can’t just wait around, horny and miserable.

You know what? That night didn’t matter. Fuck this and fuck him. He’s held me hostage for far too long.

I stride into my bedroom with a purpose and open my drawer, pulling out a lacy outfit, one that accentuates my ass and chest. As I pull it on, I peer in the full-length mirror, adjusting my hair into a semblance of a style before rubbing lotion on the rest of me. When I’m done, I make sure to prep, getting myself ready for the fucking I’m going to take. My ass is filled with a silver plug, opening me up for tonight.

I’m going to get fucked *all the ways* tonight.

I need it more than I need to breathe.

Luca doesn’t own me. Not anymore.

As I think that, I grab some athletic pants and pull them on before shrugging on an overcoat. I look fucking ridiculous right now, but I don’t need anyone to see this lacy bralette I’m wearing. The only ones who will see it will be the people at the club.

As I stride to my car, my phone beeps. If it's the brothers again, I may have to change my number. But it's not them. It's Tatum.

Hell, this may be even worse.

TATUM:

What are you doing? I'm bored.

Fuck. *This never ends well*, I think as I stare down at my phone. I could ignore him, pretend he doesn't exist, but he does. And he's the boss's man.

I can't fucking pretend anything.

ME:

About to head out.

TATUM:

Oh? Where to?

The eyeball emoji pulls a curse from my lips. He won't let this go, will he? He's worse than a dog with a bone.

TATUM:

Let me go with you. Anthony and Luca are in meetings for the rest of the evening and I'm dying of boredom. Please, Vik. Pleeeeease.

I groan and press my forehead to the side of the car. I'm going to get murdered for this. Anthony will have my hide. Or Bane, most likely.

ME:

What if I say no?

TATUM:

You won't. You never say no to me.

Yeah, there's a reason for that, I think before my fingers fly across the screen.

ME:

You can come if you bring Teddy.

TATUM:

Deal. Meet you outside? Where are we going? What should I wear?

I don’t respond to that, not wanting him to be even more unbearable if he knows where I’m headed. I should skip out of going to the club, but what else would I do with him? Maybe this will do him some good. I know he’s a bit of an exhibitionist, so maybe he’ll like watching as well.

Fuck it. This is probably the safest place I could take him. They have more security there than a police station.

When I pull up to Anthony’s estate, Tatum is waiting outside like he said he’d be, wearing tight jeans and a see-through shirt. Teddy looms behind him, a frown on his face, his sunglasses covering his eyes.

Probably for the best that he doesn’t speak. I’m sure he has a lot to say right now and I’m not in the mood to hear it.

“Oh, I’m so excited,” Tatum says as he clambers into the front seat and buckles in. “Where are we going? You never answered me about what I should wear.”

I roll my eyes and purse my lips. “You’ll see.”

“Oh, but you’re dressed like a spy,” he says and then leans over and tugs on my jacket. It peels open and he gasps. “Oh. *Ohhhh*. Teddy, he’s dressed like a whore. I need something like this too. If I’d known, I’d have worn something sluttier.”

My skin turns red, burning hot. “They have stuff there you can wear. You can change.”

“Fuck yes.” He pumps his hand slightly, and as we drive away, I turn to look at him. “Does Anthony know where you are?”

“Oh, sure. He’s tracking me. Total red flag, psycho material. But it’s so hot, so I allow it. Also, I didn’t tell him exactly where I was going, but if he looks, he can see where I am. He’s a little overprotective after I lost my finger. But a boy has to live, you know?”

“Am I going to get in trouble for this?”

“Oh, no, of course not. Just me. I will get in so much trouble.”

He wiggles in his seat, and Teddy huffs behind us. He’s not happy about this and neither am I, but then again, I can’t say no to him. Anthony explicitly said we’re to give him whatever he wants, within reason. And my reasoning is Teddy accompanying us and the club has tight security.

Tatum will be safe.

Teddy and I will make sure of it.

And if I know anything about Anthony and Tatum’s relationship, it’s that they like to play cat and mouse.

Often.

I keep my gaze focused on the road before us, navigating the freeways to our destination.

When we finally park and walk in, the hostess, Olive, grins at me before turning her gaze to Tatum and Teddy.

“Hi there, Vik. It’s been years.”

Three, to be exact.

“It has. But here I am.”

“So glad you’re back. We’ve missed you.” She gestures to Teddy and Tatum. “Friends of yours?”

“The Costellos.”

Her grin slips slightly and then she nods. “Oh. Of course. We will need an NDA signed, but come on in and get ready while I pull up the paperwork.”

Tatum follows next to me, his eyes wide, taking in the luxurious decorations surrounding us.

“Wow, this is real nice. I had no idea this place existed. Does Anthony know about this place?”

“I’m sure he does. Mr. Rossi is the owner,” Olive says.

My footsteps falter and I stare at her, my blood pressure rising.

“When did the change of ownership happen?”

Olive peers over at me. “Oh, about three years ago. It was kind of sudden, but yes. He bought Roberto out.”

“Okay, sorry to interrupt,” Tatum says. “But Viktor said I could get some sexy lingerie here.”

Olive nods. “Of course. We have a variety to choose from. You can try on anything that suits your fancy in the changing room.”

“Perfect. Show me the way,” Tatum says, and I grumble under my breath as we move to the changing rooms, my mind still reeling at the fact that Luca owns this place. Fuck. Why didn’t he tell me? Why did no one say anything?

Chandeliers hang from the ceiling as we enter and oversized lockers line one wall. A wardrobe sits open with new lingerie for men and women hanging inside, and Tatum moves toward it, *oohing* and *ahhing* as he flips through the various outfits.

He pulls one off the rack and holds it up to him.

“What do you think?” He’s asking Teddy more than he’s asking me, so I just wait for Teddy to nod in agreement.

Tatum grins and moves to a private stall where he puts on the outfit, returning in a see-through lacy bodysuit.

“Look how pretty,” he says and then turns around and waggles his ass. “I think Anthony will like it when he shows up.”

I swallow as I take my jacket off. “He’s coming right now?”

“Oh, you bet your ass he is.”

He grins at me, and Teddy huffs in frustration. So this was just a ploy to get Anthony to pay attention to him. Yeah, fine. Whatever. This is how they operate, and Anthony lets Tatum get away with murder.

I kick my pants off, and Tatum whistles when he sees my outfit.

“Oh, you look good, Vik. Love the lace.” He links his arm with mine and pulls me forward, Teddy following closely behind. But before we exit, I stop at the drawer with the collars and jewelry.

“You need to pick what you want to wear. It tells people what you’re willing to do.”

“Do?”

“Yeah. You want to watch? Be used? Men only, women only? No preference?”

His hands trail over the items and then sighs. “Definitely just watch.”

I pick up a bracelet and place it on his wrist before grabbing a collar and placing it around my neck.

“This stays between us. Whatever you see here is confidential.”

Just as I say that, the hostess returns with some iPads, and Teddy and Tatum sign the contracts before the three of us move into the dimly lit space. I see Amir behind the bar and he offers me a smile as he uses the shaker to mix a drink. He hasn’t changed at all. He looks the same as he did three years ago.

“Want a drink?” I ask, and Tatum shakes his head.

“Oh no, I’m good, but you go ahead. I want to take a *long* look around. This is so kinky and fun.”

He links arms with Teddy, leaving me at the bar. It’s not as busy tonight, but that doesn’t mean there aren’t people who’re ready to fuck me.

“Hey! Long time no see, friend. You’ve been gone a while. I thought maybe you canceled your membership,” Amir says as he approaches and stands before me.

“No. Just had a bit of a busy schedule.”

That’s a lie and Amir seems to know it because he grabs a bottle of vodka and pours me a shot.

“Well, welcome back. Go ahead. On me.”

I fling it back and lean against the bar, ass out as we catch up.

“So, what have you been up to?” I ask him.

He shrugs. “Nothing much. Same old, same old. Still living with my mom and grandma, and still working here almost every night.”

“Good for you, man.”

“Want anything?” he asks, patting his vest pocket.

I shake my head. “Nah, I’m good. But thanks. I think just drinks for me tonight.”

“Yeah, the last time you were here high and drunk, Mr. Rossi didn’t look pleased when he picked you up and dragged you out.”

“Yeah, well, I didn’t ask him to do that.”

“Seemed like you didn’t have a choice.”

I glance around, not wanting to talk about this anymore. It’s making my stomach clench. “Olive said that Luca owns this place now.”

“Yep. Change of management.”

“Fuck.”

“It’s been good. We got a raise. He’s not a bad boss.”

Not the experience I’ve had with him. “It’s not busy though.”

“Yeah, you caught us on a slow day, but don’t worry. I think you’ll find someone who’s interested in giving you what you need.”

“Seems no one is interested.” In fact, it seems my ass is not being used at all. Is no one interested?

“Yeah, about that,” Amir says, leaning forward slightly. “If I remember, there was a memo sent out not long after that night he took you out of here, about you being off-limits—”

“What the fuck?” I murmur, my heart racing. Is this why no one is touching me?

Did he really fucking do that? Is that why he bought the club after that night?

Amir’s lips squeeze into a thin line suddenly, and I sense someone moving up behind me.

I know who it is without looking. I can smell him.

Luca.

“Viktor. What are you doing here? And with Tatum, of all people.” His voice is a growl, his hand grabbing my hip, nails digging into my skin.

“Tatum wanted to come with me,” I grind out as my dick hardens at his nearness. Amir seems to sense my frustration because he hands me another shot, and I take it, tilting my head back and shooting it. He shrugs at me, not feeling sorry for me in the slightest, and I bite my bottom lip in frustration.

“Anthony is furious.” Luca jerks me back slightly, my ass hitting his groin, his hand snaking around to cup my hard dick. “He thinks you should be punished for this.”

I huff and then hear a familiar groan emanating from somewhere behind us. I don’t even have to look to know who that is.

“Seems Tatum is getting exactly what he wanted.”

Luca chuckles, his hand leaving my dick and dragging up my chest to the collar.

“He is. Anthony plays into everything he wants. It’s weak and pathetic.”

His fingers curl under the collar and he pulls me to the side, guiding me over to a velvet chair, one that I’ve been bent over many times before.

He sits down on it and yanks me between his legs, my knees abruptly hitting the floor. Pain shoots up my thighs, and I grunt as he tugs me further, making me crawl toward him.

“Fuck you, Luca.”

“You’re wearing the collar, kitten. You’re mine to do with as I please.”

I huff, indignant, but my dick aches at the sentiment. That pet name makes me slightly feral.

“You may be the boss of this place, but you’re not the boss of me. We’re not at work now.”

“Shut the fuck up, Vik. Hands behind your back,” he grinds out, his fingers loosening around my collar and settling on his thighs.

I resist for just a second, but then cave, doing as he says, frowning the entire time, really showing him how much I hate this. I really fucking despise it.

“Eyes up here,” he says, and I feel my cheeks redden. “Now, Anthony told me to take care of this. You know what happened last time Tatum went out with you…”

“You were there too. You’re the one who brought him.”

He leans forward and shoves two fingers between my lips, pressing against my tongue, and I can do nothing but suck on them.

His eyes darken as he wets his lips.

“You brought him this time. Now shut your fucking mouth or I’ll make you.”

I suck on his fingers roughly, and he cocks his head, watching me.

“Such a fucking slut,” he says, pulling his fingers from my lips and leaning back, looking very much like an arrogant king.

I scowl at him. I’m shaking, my mind screaming at me to get up and walk away, but my body stays right where he put me. Because I want whatever punishment he’s going to dole out. I want it.

I want him. As much as I tell myself I don’t, I know it’s all a lie.

A lie to save myself from the inevitable hurt in the end.

“Now, what to do with you…” He taps his fingers on the arm of the chair, the same ones I sucked on. They’re slick with my spit and my gaze only slides away from them when he catches me staring.

“You’re not going to do anything with me.”

He narrows his gaze at me and then leans forward, wrenching my neck to the side, forcing me to look at Tatum and Anthony. Tatum is on Anthony’s lap, bouncing on his dick while people watch on. His head is thrown back, and Anthony’s hand clutches at his throat and his hip. The two of them exist in a bubble. No one else is here but them.

“I think I will. Anthony commanded it. I always do as I’m told.”

I huff at that. I can assure you, he does not.

His hands fall from me and he leans back once more.

I turn back slowly, my jaw cracking as I grind my teeth.

“They seem to be perfectly happy here. Tatum knew what he was doing when he left the estate. Anthony needs to let him off that leash or else Tatum is going to get bored with him.”

Luca’s eyes narrow even further and then he grabs onto my hair roughly and pulls me toward him. My face is smashed into his crotch, and I scramble against his thighs as I crawl closer.

“Love this long hair.”

“I’m going to cut it off.”

“No, you fucking won’t. Now take my dick out. We’ve got to keep your sassy mouth busy, it seems.”

“No,” I whimper, but even as I say that, my tongue sneaks out of my mouth and wets my lips in anticipation.

I want it. I want it so fucking badly.

He lets me up just enough to unbutton his pants, and the first thing I notice is the bulge between his legs. He’s hard.

Oh fuck. The thought that he’s into this makes me moan.

Carefully, I unzip his pants and tug them down slightly. His fingers tighten in my hair, his breathing growing slightly more labored as I work his cock through the slit in his boxer briefs.

When it appears, long and hard, I groan when he pushes my head down toward it.

“We’re going to keep you nice and quiet. Those insolent thoughts you have could get you killed. So, really, I’m saving your life,” he says as my lips spread across his crown and sink onto him. I take him as far back as I can, his dick tunneling halfway down my throat and then back up again.

I make the most obscene sound as I pull off him and then am rammed down on his cock once more.

Oh fuck. My eyes roll into the back of my head, my fingers finding each other behind my back as he uses me.

“Good boy,” he murmurs as he shifts slightly, getting a better angle down my throat. I just whine and gag, my dick ridiculously hard and aching between my legs. I want to reach down and stroke it, but he won’t let me. I just know it. This is my punishment.

I feel someone move up behind me and I arch my ass out, feeling fingers start pulling the plug from me before Luca stiffens and holds me tightly against him.

“Don’t you fucking touch him,” he says, and then the man behind me grumbles.

“He has the collar.”

Luca lets go of me for a second to remove it and tosses it aside.

“There. Anyone touches him again, I’ll put a bullet through their fucking brain.”

His cock is still in my mouth and I don’t move, just breathe, lust coursing through my body as his fingers curl into my hair once more and he shoves me down on his cock.

I smell the scent of smoke and I assume someone lit a cigarette for him.

Typical. Blow jobs and smoking at the same time. Just like he's sitting at a café and having a cup of coffee.

Well, fuck him, I think as I continue to suck him down my throat. I'm going to give him the best fucking blow job he's ever had.

Hollowing out my cheeks, I suck the soul from his body. Or at least I think I do. Not that he gives me any indication of what he's feeling. But there is a tightness in his thighs and a slight tremble to the hand tangled in my hair.

He's getting close. He's trying to hold back, but I'm too fucking good. So I continue to work him closer and closer to the edge, all the while trying to stave off my own orgasm. Because I'd be lying if I said I wasn't loving this. I'm moaning and drooling, my throat and jaw sore from working his big dick like this, but hell, I'd get on my knees again for him. If he made me.

Even if I do hate him.

You don't hate him. Hate is the farthest feeling you have.

My arms are growing numb, my knees aching, and I can feel my orgasm crawling up my thighs, but then Luca slams my face onto his dick, and I feel his hard length pulse as he empties directly into my stomach. He holds me like that for a few seconds, my body trembling with a pent-up orgasm before he lets me up, his hand falling to his thigh as I sit up, sputtering.

My fingers touch my sore throat as I blink up at him.

He inhales deeply, smoke seeping from his nose as he breathes out with clenched lips.

"Passable," he says lowly, and I nearly claw at him, but then he leans forward, tucking himself away. "Now on to your punishment."

He inhales again and holds the smoke inside, pushing it out slowly, most of it hitting my face as he does. But I don't respond. I'm too angry, too horny. I want to get off, want to suck his dick again. I want to be used until I can't think anymore.

"That *was* my punishment," I rasp, and his lips twitch.

"Oh, kitten. No, it wasn't."

He stands up and tugs me to my feet. My dick is pressing against my panties and when his hand wraps around the back of my neck and he pulls me closer to him, I whimper.

"The things I'm going to do to you."

He pulls me forward, my feet slapping on the floor as he leads me down a hallway, rooms on either side.

“You can’t make me do anything,” I murmur even though I’m nearly purring at the thought of being used by him.

No, not purring. *Growling*.

I attempt to have my throat make that sound, but it doesn’t work. Not at all. I just moan as he pushes open a door and thrusts me inside.

“I don’t think you understand, Vik.” He closes and locks the door. “I own this fucking place. Me. Not Anthony. Me.” He grins at me, sinister and feral. “I can do whatever the fuck I want to you.”

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6

VIKTOR

I'm an animal caught in a cage. Not a literal one, but this room is like one, dark and suffocating. Fuck. Fuck. What's he going to do to me?

"Why did you buy this club? Tell me the truth."

He chuckles as he stalks toward me, my vision narrowing imperceptibly until it's just him I see.

"Because I could."

"I heard you bought it three years ago. After that night…"

He reaches out and grabs my pecs, squeezing them roughly, making all cohesive thoughts flee my mind.

"Fuck," I murmur.

"Look at these tits," he says and then pinches my nipples almost painfully. A gasp leaves my mouth and I arch up into his touch. I hate that I like this. That I want more.

The way he speaks to me is even worse. It has my heart rate elevating and as much as I tell myself to take a step back, I can't. I'm rooted in place.

I've moved past pathetic and am now just plain desperate.

Luca chuckles and reaches down, and with a flick of his wrist, he rips my panties off. I bite my bottom lip at the sting of the fabric being pulled from my skin, and my lashes flutter when I catch his eyes tracking across my chest and down to my leaking cock, which is still hard and pressed out from my body.

His gaze lingers there for a long, drawn-out moment before he moves to a cabinet against the wall. I know what's in there. Toys. A variety of them.

I've been here when they've been used on me. Everything from plugs to whips to wax.

What's he going to use on me? What's my punishment going to be?

Not knowing excites me.

Thrills me.

Luca returns a minute later, something clutched in his hand, and when he stops in front of me, I force myself to meet his glittering gaze.

His lips twitch as he takes a step closer and produces a silicone cock ring in the palm of his hand.

Oh fuck.

His fingers drag down my stomach before wrapping around my already sensitive dick and sliding it on, pulling it over my balls, and creating pressure at the base of my cock.

"I could leave," I hiss, and he grins sadistically. "I could."

"You fucking won't. You're too much of a slut to do that. You want whatever I'm going to give you."

"I hate you."

"And you love this."

With that, he spins me around, walking me toward the bed on the opposite side of the room. And I go willingly, much to my displeasure.

"Feet on the floor, hands on the bed," he says, and I fight back slightly, mostly for the shred of self-respect I have left inside of me, but am overpowered by him as he pushes me onto the bed, my legs dangling off the side, my face smashed into the mattress. "Always fucking fighting," he growls as his hand lands on my ass cheek with a crack. I let out a small exhale at the sensation pulsing through my skin.

Fuck, I love being spanked. I want my ass red. I want to feel it for days.

"Look at that," he says as his finger brushes against the plug I put in my ass before I left. He pushes against it, and I groan. "You want so badly to be fucked. But you won't come. Not until I say you can. And it's going to be only me who gets you off. No one else. Understand?"

"I—fuck—you," I murmur, wishing I had something better to say, but I don't. I've got nothing. He's right. I want to be fucked so badly. I want him to use me. I need this. I fucking *need* it.

Luca says nothing, just adjusts my feet on the floor, kicking them apart, until I'm spread wide, face and chest still smashed into the mattress. Then

he grabs my arms and wrenches them behind my back, securing them with some kind of rope.

I try to free myself, but the ties are secure. Goddamnit, I should have left when I had the chance. He slides his hand under me, across my stomach, and down to my cock, pulling it out and down, so it's perpendicular to the floor. I'm fully exposed now. He can see everything.

The heel of his palm drags down my shaft, making me moan, and I bite at the sheets when he does it again. I hate that he's seeing me so weak, so needy, but then again, I knew this would happen the minute I walked into the club with Tatum.

I knew he'd come with Anthony, and I did it anyway.

Luca moves away from me, and I hear the click of a camera phone.

"Are you taking pictures of me?" I grunt, and he pinches my ass in response.

"Don't pretend like it doesn't thrill you." And then his hand comes down on my ass in a painful slap. "Maybe I'll show this to everyone so they know what you do in your free time."

I can't answer, just arch forward, my dick pressing against the side of the mattress, my body shaking with desire. And to make matters worse, his hand drags down the underside of my cock, sensation blooming through me just as another slap lands on my ass.

He does this over and over, alternating between spanking and torturing my dick. He's deriving some kind of sick pleasure from this. There's no other reason why he'd do this. Why he's been toying with me all this time. And yet, I'm letting him.

Of course I'm letting him.

I'd let him do anything to me.

Anything.

I'm panting now, groaning, frothing at the mouth. I'm a rabid animal. I should be put down.

But I can't come, as much as I want to, the cock ring is keeping me from completely falling over the edge. I ache, pleasure pulsing through my thighs and up my spine. I positively shiver from it.

I fucking yearn for more.

"Listen to you, begging for it."

"I'm. Not. Begging," I lie. I was begging. I am begging. If not with my mouth, then my body is a telltale sign. It arches back toward him, asking for

more.

A slap reverberates around the room, his palm hitting me right between the cheeks, jostling the plug.

My ass is sore, surely pink from the way his hand has landed on it over and over, progressively harder each time. *His palm must sting*, I think as I smell the scent of smoke wafting over me. Who the fuck lit that?

I don't know. It wasn't me. Is someone else in here watching us?

God, I don't know and I don't care. I just don't want him to stop.

Please don't stop.

"Look at that cock, turning purple, dripping. It wants to come."

"Oh god," I moan as he steps away from me and returns a moment later. I don't know where he went or what he has in his hands now, but I'm at his mercy.

Literally.

Don't pretend you don't like it.

"Hopefully, you learn your lesson after this," Luca says as he pushes against my plug roughly, making me cry out before he slowly drags it out of me. It's bigger than it appears, and I know as soon as it exits my body that my hole will be gaping.

I hear the plug fall to the ground with a clunk and can feel Luca just standing there, staring at me.

"So sad this won't be used tonight," he says, swirling his finger around my rim. Just once, but enough to have me nearly sobbing with pleasure. "Sad little kitten. No one will hear you scream."

And then a painful slap lands on my ass from something hard. A leather paddle, I'm guessing. My hips buck against the mattress, my cock throbbing as he smacks my ass over and over again until tears line my cheeks, my dick feeling as if it will explode if I don't get to come.

"That's it, you little slut. You whore. Scream for it."

I bite down on the sheets, trying to muffle my pathetic sounds, but he hits me again, my ass jiggling from the force of it.

He hits the other side and then the backs of my thighs, making me arch my chest off the bed.

"Say it. Say my fucking name."

I refuse. I fucking refuse. He spanks me again, my ass aching. It will hurt tomorrow.

I feel the tip of the paddle slide between my ass cheeks, pressing against my hole.

“You want to be fucked, don’t you? You want my cock in this greedy little hole.”

My entire body shakes, my cries muffled as he tugs on my balls. The sensation shoots through my dick, and I feel precum slip from the tip.

He moves off me and seven more slaps hit my ass in quick succession, making me cry out, my eyes screwed shut in pleasure, my knuckles white from holding onto the sheets.

And then suddenly, it’s over, his hands smoothing over my hot skin, squeezing my cheeks roughly before moving up to my wrists that are still bound. He lets me go, my numb arms falling to my sides as he removes the cock ring gently.

Oh god. Oh fuck.

I am desperate to come. I need release, but the evil glint in his eyes tells me he won’t be the one to get me there.

This is the punishment. He told me it was going to happen and I went willingly.

I obeyed.

Pushing myself up, I swipe at my cheeks, feeling the twinge in my ass cheeks as I stand up.

Luca’s right next to me, the cigarette in his mouth almost burned down to the butt.

“So that’s it then?” I ask, my voice wobbly and slightly hoarse from moaning like the whore I am.

He pulls the cigarette from his mouth, his tongue sliding across his teeth, and he runs a hand across his jaw.

“Yeah, it’s over. I think you’ve had enough. And, Viktor,” he says, moving closer to me. “You won’t come again until I say so.” He throws the cigarette to the ground and stubs it out with his shoe. “And trust me. I’ll know if you do. So be a good boy and do as you’re told.”

I bite back a whimper as his hand comes down and strokes my cock, just once.

At this point, I may not make it through the night.

I walk out of the room completely naked, Luca having pulled off the bralette I was wearing before we exited. My dick is still painfully hard, and for the first time since arriving at this club, I feel ashamed.

Ashamed I let Luca get the best of me.

And ashamed everyone can see my red ass as I make my way to the changing rooms. As we walk, I see Anthony and Tatum curled up on a chair, Tatum still in his lingerie, looking satiated and happy from being well-fucked, while Teddy looms over them protectively. Tatum catches my eyes and winks at me, but I don't wink back.

I can't even fucking look at anyone right now.

They know what happened, what I let happen. It's written across my body for all to see.

"Don't look so glum," Luca says softly as his hand falls on the back of my neck. He leads me forward as we move into the locker room and then he watches as I get dressed, his eyes never leaving me. But I refuse to make eye contact as I shove my feet through the leg holes of my pants and tuck my hard cock under the waistband. It's miserable. *I'm fucking miserable*, I think as I pull on my overcoat.

"I'll drive," Luca says, taking my keys from me.

"Fuck that. I'll just get a rideshare home," I murmur, but then he's in front of me, his nose pressed against mine, his lips so close to my mouth. I could lean forward and kiss him. I should, just to take back some of the power. But before I can, I feel his fingers thread through my hair, tugging painfully as he whispers, "Obey."

I glance away, feeling the heat of him pierce my body. *I hate this. Fucking despise it*, I think, as he leads me out of the club to my car. Like he demanded, I don't drive this time. He slips into the driver's seat and thankfully so. I'm so disoriented, the pain in my ass coupled with the throbbing of my cock is making my mind spin.

All I can see and hear is Luca. He's omnipresent. In my mind, in my body. All my senses are consumed by him. I say I hate it, tell myself over and over, and yet, here I am. Wanting it. Wanting more.

As we sit in traffic, waiting for the exit, Luca glances over at me.

"Take it out," he says lowly, and I huff, turning my gaze out the window.

"No."

"Take it out and stroke it. You know you want to."

“I’m not fucking doing that,” I reply as my hand curls against my thigh. “You’re getting off on torturing me. And I won’t let you keep doing it.”

I can almost feel him grinning. “Viktor, take out your fucking cock before I pull over and spank that pretty pink ass red in front of everyone.”

My teeth sink into my bottom lip so hard I taste blood again. “Fine,” I grumble as my fingers snake down to my pants and I pull my dick out, thankful that the windows are tinted so dark no one can see in, and at the same time, thrilled that I’m doing this publicly.

“Good, stroke it, but don’t come. You don’t get to do that. Yet.”

“Is this my punishment, too?” I grunt, trying to sound angry, but it comes out more like a plea.

“Yes.”

I slowly jack myself, angry and boiling with sexual frustration as we drive along the freeway, crawling home at a glacial pace until he finally tells me to take my hand away from my dick. At this point, I’m so miserable, my dick so hard and balls so full it’s painful. I’m getting a headache behind my eyes.

And I was so focused on not coming that I didn’t realize we’re not at my place after all, but Luca’s.

“Why the hell am I not at my apartment?” I ask, tucking my hard dick away and trying to clear my mind enough to think clearly. It doesn’t work.

I’m in a fog of lust.

“I want to make sure you follow the rules. We do know how you like to break them,” he replies as he parks the car in his large garage and slides out. I watch him move into the house without looking back, and my head slams into the headrest.

Fuck this, I think as I stare down at my dick tenting my sweat pants. I’m not going to survive the night. I’m going to have to break his rules and get off. I won’t sleep otherwise.

But I also can’t sit here forever. So I follow him inside and see him at the kitchen counter, pouring himself a drink.

“Would you like one?” he asks, and I shake my head, folding my arms across my chest and glowering at him.

“Why the sour face?”

He knows why. I don’t want to be here. I don’t want him controlling me.

You liar. You crave it. Crave him.

“Why don’t you go shower and get into bed?”

“I’m not getting into bed. Not with you.”

He scoffs. “I didn’t say we were sharing a bed.”

My cheeks flame at that, my hands falling to my sides and curling into fists.

“Now be a good boy and do what I said.”

“I’m not lighting your fucking cigarettes anymore or killing the fucking spiders. Just know that. I’m done.”

“Oh, but you will.”

We stare at each other for a long moment, and then I ask the question again, the one that I can’t let go of. “Why did you buy the club after that night?”

Luca takes a sip of his drink. “That’s none of your business.”

“I heard there was a memo—”

“Go the fuck to sleep, Vik. I’m not answering your questions.”

“You never do. Fuck you, Luca.”

I stalk past him and find a random guest room, locking the door behind me and pressing my back to it. My hand slides down my pants and I grab my dick, shuttling my fist up and down my shaft, but before I come, I stop.

I hate that I’m obeying him, but I have to.

I want to.

I go to bed miserable, furious with myself, and hating Luca even more.

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7

LUCA

Viktor left my house early this morning, which is fine by me. I didn't fucking sleep a wink knowing he was right down the hall, his pretty cock hard and aching, leaking onto the bed. I could almost feel his frustration and it took everything inside of me not to crawl into bed with him, flip him over, and give him exactly what he wanted.

He's seeped so far into me that I'm not sure I can extricate him anymore.

Working so closely with him is a detriment to my mental health. Viktor has always been a part of the family. I know he's extremely loyal to Anthony, and that he feels he owes Anthony his life.

And in a way, he does.

Anthony took him in when no one else would, but then again, he's always been a bit of a sucker for kids who need a home.

When he was younger, Viktor used to watch me intently, his eyes never leaving me when I was in the same room. Anthony joked he had a crush, but I never got that impression. Maybe a bit of hero worship, if anything.

But then that awe started to morph as he got older, and I could feel the hate emanating from him.

I don't know what I did, but something about me agitates him. And in turn, he has me all twisted up inside.

I don't like to be twisted.

Twisting others…I quite enjoy that.

The problem is now that Anthony is working less, things are being delegated to me, and Viktor is now a constant presence in my life. Inescapable.

The image of Viktor bent over the bed, his ass red, his cock pressed against the side of the mattress, dripping and angry, pops into my head, and I reach down and adjust myself.

I quite liked that. Making him cry and beg.

And watching him suck me off…

Perhaps I should make that a daily ritual.

The thought appeals. He was quite good at it. Probably at the better end of the blow jobs I've received throughout the years.

I huff and shake my head.

Probably one of the best ones I've gotten, if I'm honest.

No time for honesty, I think as I move into my bedroom and change. I have a meeting with Anthony today and then I'm heading to the fighting ring.

I pack up my duffle bag and peer at myself in the mirror. I look fucking tired. But after the fight, I'm sure I'll feel alive. Maybe I'll get some sleep tonight. Some would call me self-destructive. Seems I might be. At least I'm not boring.

The doorbell rings and I move toward it, my heart rate increasing as I pull the door open, seeing Viktor on the other side, looking just as tired as me.

Seems he didn't sleep well either.

Good. We can both be miserable.

He scowls at me, and I can't help the way my lips twitch in happiness. I love riling him up, love getting him so frustrated his cheeks turn pink and his hands tremble.

Love how horny he is for me, despite hating it.

"You're late," I say, and his nostrils flare.

"I'm fucking not."

"You are. I'll have to let Anthony know about this."

His hands fist near his sides. He looks like he's going to punch me. Fuck, I'd love a chance with him in the ring, down and dirty, no holds barred. I want to watch him bleed while I hold his face down on that dirty concrete floor and fuck his ass raw.

Maybe I'll make him come with me tonight, make him get a taste of what he could have. The temptation is overwhelming. I know he can fight. We've sparred in the past.

But now, knowing him the way I do? Knowing what noises he makes when he loses control…

It has me wanting to go a few more rounds.

The thought percolates as he drives me to Anthony's house and as I sit in Anthony's office, discussing what we found at the clubs. Doc confirmed that the other woman had the same drug in her system, and the bartender at the club last night who was flirting with Viktor mentioned to Anthony that a new drug has been circulating with customers.

"He called it Pink," I tell him.

"Pink?"

"Yes. He said that he's heard it mentioned a few times. He doesn't know where to get it, though. He said he'd ask around."

"Guess that's something then," Anthony says.

"We can't do anything until we know more about it, who's supplying it, and who is buying it."

"Exactly. I'll call my informant in the police force and the Senator to see if they know anything." We stare at one another, and Anthony sighs. "So, what do you propose we do now?" He leans back in his chair, eyes serious, brow furrowed.

"I don't fucking know. Vik thinks that the Sirens have something to do with distribution, and I sort of agree. But I'm hesitant to think they're responsible for the bodies. We've known them for ages. We've never had issues with them."

"And yet, look what happened to Mikhail. His close friend tried to kill him. Seems you can't trust anyone these days."

His eyes bore into mine, and I lean back, crossing my ankle over my knee.

"Fuck off with those inferences. You can trust me. Don't fucking think that shit."

His lips crack slightly and he offers me a conciliatory grin. "I know I can, and I also trust Viktor."

"I know." I leave that vague. I have nothing else to say.

"I think he may be on to something with his suspicions. With his past, he has good instincts."

He does. I know a little about his background. I remember when Viktor showed up, a scraggly teenage boy who Anthony took in off the streets. Anthony told me a bit of what he'd been through. It's been fifteen years since that day, and Viktor has been nothing but loyal.

And still, there's just something about him. Something that draws me to him. Something that makes my blood heat.

"And he's saved your life more than once," Anthony adds.

"Yeah, I know that."

"Maybe we should put some surveillance on the Sirens, just to see what they're moving. It's been meth for a while, but maybe they're looking to expand the market."

"Could be. We'll give it a shot and see. Put Anna on it. She's probably the best fit."

"Good idea." He grabs his phone, sends off a text, and then sets it down.

He stares at me, and I stare right back. "What the fuck is that look for?"

"Just waiting for my right-hand man to tell me what's going on."

"Nothing's going on."

"I saw you with Viktor last night."

"Yeah."

"Didn't know you were into men."

"He's good at sucking cock."

Anthony huffs and then shifts forward slightly. "Don't fucking hurt him, Luca. You're like a brother to me. I'd hate to have to send you to Bane."

I scoff. "I won't do anything he doesn't beg for."

Anthony seems to be appeased by that. He has a soft spot for his soldiers, especially Vik. He has two sons, but Viktor has managed to worm his way into his heart.

"Good. Now get in contact with some of the informants on the streets to see if they know anything we don't."

"Will do. We done?"

"We are. You going to the Shadows?"

"Yeah. Need to get this itch out of my system," I say.

"Or you could just fuck him. You'd feel better and you'd end up less injured." I scowl at Anthony, and he chuckles. "Like I said, better than getting your face bashed in. At one time I thought you were pretty, but now you're just looking rough."

"This has nothing to do with Viktor. I just need the rush."

He doesn't believe me. I can tell by the way he watches me leave his office. But I have nothing else to say.

Boxing with him is nothing like the bare-knuckle fight I'm about to have.

As I walk through the house, I run into Agatha, Teddy, and Tatum in the kitchen, Tatum perched at the island watching Teddy and Agatha bake.

Viktor is nowhere to be found. That agitates me more than I'll ever admit.

"You looking for your boyfriend?" Tatum asks, a sparkle in his eyes.

I huff at that and then ruffle his hair. "You just like starting shit."

"And so do you," Agatha pipes up, pursing her lips at me. "Two peas in a pod."

I smirk and then move toward Agatha, pulling her into a tight hug. She's been like a mother to me since mine was taken from me all those years ago. I may be a Rossi, but the Costellos have been my family for all of my adult life, Agatha included.

"Where are you off to?" she asks, and I shrug. I'm not telling her a thing. She'll only nag.

"Nowhere. Do you know where Vik is?"

"Ah, so you *are* looking for your boyfriend," Tatum says, and I arch an eyebrow at him. "Looking to do some heavy-duty smooching?" I stare at him, and he waggles his eyebrows at me. "Dick smooching?"

Agatha hisses at Tatum, and he giggles at that.

"No cookies for you with that potty mouth."

Tatum blanches, and then Teddy looks up at me from the cake decorating and points outside.

"Thank you," I tell him and then turn on my heel, exiting the kitchen and the house entirely. As I step outside, the gardens Angel spent so much time in when he lived here sprawl out before me. They're now being maintained by the gardeners, so when he visits, everything will be as it was.

Anthony insisted upon it.

As I traverse the gardens, I find Viktor on the other side with a few of the guards, Jax, Quincy, and Rocco. All of them are talking and laughing. My steps falter when I catch Viktor smiling.

He looks good like that. He looks happy.

But as I approach, Viktor's eyes slam into mine and my gait slows for just a moment. The way those eyes make something inside of me shift, dark

and hidden.

A monster waiting to play.

Maybe I *should* just fuck him.

But I shake that thought away. I won't do that again.

I can't.

Everyone straightens as I approach and their chatting fades until it's just the wind rustling the trees. I glance up and see the dark gray clouds hovering above us. Seems rain may be coming once again.

"Vik, let's go," I say and then turn around, knowing that he's following me. I can tell by the tingle blooming across my skin, the way the back of my neck prickles from his glare.

When we make it to the SUV, Viktor is deathly silent, getting in the driver's seat and following the directions I input into the navigation system. We move through the busy streets and onto the freeway, moving through puddles and around slow trucks.

"Where the fuck are we going?" he asks as rain spatters on the windshield.

"Your job is to not ask questions."

"Fuck that," he says as I slide a cigarette out of my pocket and hold it to my lips.

"I said I wouldn't do that anymore," he bites out, but I can feel him start to break. He can't help himself when it comes to me.

With a sigh, he lights it for me, and I inhale deeply, the nicotine sinking into me. Heavenly. Almost as good as him sucking my dick.

The thought of it, him between my legs has my cock perking up.

Perhaps I should make him do it again.

Or maybe what I'm about to do will satiate the lust. Maybe Anthony is wrong and fucking him won't be better for me.

It ruined me once.

I won't go there again.

"Park here," I say when we pull up to a warehouse. I point to a concrete wall and two crooked parking lines. Viktor maneuvers between them, and I hop out, grabbing the duffle bag and moving toward the entrance, rain pelting me as I go.

As soon as we push inside, it's humid and hot, the scent of blood and sweating bodies permeating the space. The sounds of cheering and skin and

bones being pummeled ricochet off the metal siding, and I can feel Viktor's look of concern drilling into my chest.

I brush it off. I don't need anyone worried about me.

I've been taking care of myself for far too long.

We move through the crowd, some people recognizing me and slapping me on the back, jeers and words of approval as I move toward the changing rooms.

"What the fuck is this?" Viktor hisses when we're finally alone.

"Nothing you need to worry about. Just stand there and look pretty."

His jaw tightens, his frustration evident in the way his hands bunch near his sides. Fucking love it, love that I can get to him.

I change quickly, pulling on just a pair of athletic shorts and nothing else, my chest and feet bare. My tattoos and scars are on display, and I see the way he looks at me.

He likes what he sees.

He always has.

I slide a mouthguard between my teeth and grin at Viktor, who narrows his eyes at me.

"You're doing some kind of fight club shit?" he hisses as he follows me back out toward the crowd.

I just wink at him as I make my way over to the man who runs this—Agro, a mean son of a bitch with a penchant for blood and broken bones. He's made quite the living off this. I don't blame him for leaning into it. And I appreciate that he's offered me a chance to fight and get this anger out of me.

"You made it!" he shouts, slapping me on the back. "You're up next."

He glances over at Viktor, his eyes sliding up and down his body. "You bring another fighter?"

"No, he's here to watch. He's a bit of a fan."

"I'm not," he grumbles, but I ignore him, turning my gaze out to the men in the ring, blood dripping from their mouths. It's violent and unhinged, and I *crave* it.

I started this up a year ago and haven't looked back.

Anthony objects to it in his silent way, but he can't stop me from attending.

I do whatever the fuck I want.

The crowd roars when one man topples over, his head knocking against the cement. Agro moves into the circle and lifts the other lilting man's arm in the air as the crowd goes wild.

Adrenaline washes through me as a few men pull the knocked-out guy off the floor, blood in his wake, and then the announcer shouts out my fighting name, Mantus, and the name of my opponent.

Boulder.

A man much bigger than me. He comes lumbering out from the crowd and his arms flex. They're as big as melons.

Fuck, this is gonna hurt.

Viktor's fingers wrap around my wrist and shockwaves shoot up my arm at the touch.

"He's going to murder you."

Concern lines his words and all I can do is smirk at him.

He has no idea what I'm capable of.

The smell of blood filters through my nostrils as my head whips to the side, pain lancing through my cheek and mouth and down to my neck.

Fuck, Boulder got me good, I think as I stagger back, sweat marring my vision. He's bigger than me and has an advantage, but he's also slower. And I'm a mean fighter. Growing up the way I did, scrapping for everything I had after my parents and brothers died, boxing with Anthony when we became friends, joining the MMA gym—I know I'll win this.

I'll just be sore after, and very bloody.

I'm not getting any younger. Forties are no joke.

I swipe at my eyes and gather up my strength, my feet spread as I bend my knees and lift my arms.

Duck, punch, kick, my bones and tendons snapping as flesh meets flesh. The man stumbles back, and I aim for his throat, trying to punch the air out of him, but he manages to fall to the right, making me hit nothing but the breeze.

The crowd jeers, and I spit blood onto the ground as Viktor catches my eye. He's standing between two men, spittle flying from their mouths as they shout, their cheeks red, bills clutched in their hands.

Viktor’s jostled slightly and his eyes narrow at me.

He’s pissed.

I can’t help but wink at him, irritating him further.

His frown deepens, and I whip my head around, ducking just in time to avoid the blow Boulder is trying to land on me.

But even though he misses this time, he manages a few more hits, one right to my kidneys, the other to the side of my arm, and one well-placed kick to my knee. But then I’m able to launch myself onto his back and choke him out, my legs wrapped around his waist, my arm strangling him.

He falls to the floor with a thud, passed out, me on his back like some kind of avenging king riding into battle, and Agro moves toward me, lifting me from Boulder and holding my arm in the air as the crowd goes wild.

Viktor is *not* one of them.

His anger grows as he marches toward me and pulls me to the locker rooms, his grip rough on my biceps, his face set in stone.

I pull my mouthguard out and spit blood to the side, pretending I don’t like the way he’s gripping me.

“Why the long face, Vik-baby?” I ask and chuckle when he shoves me down onto the bench.

“Anthony would have fucking killed me if you ended up badly hurt. And you did it anyway.”

I slide a hand through my wet hair, slick with sweat, and manage a sly grin at him. “I did. And I fucking won.”

“Fuck. You,” he spits and then squats down so that we’re eye to eye. His hand moves to my bloody mouth, his thumb gently brushing against the split lip. “We have to get you cleaned up.”

The way he’s touching me so tenderly makes something squeeze in my chest, and I almost can’t breathe. I wrench my head away from him, and his hand falls to his side.

I stare at him and he meets it before huffing and standing up.

“You done here then?” he asks, his words rough and frustrated.

“Yes. I got what I needed from this.”

He purses his lips and then gestures toward the door. “Fine. Then grab your shit and I’ll take you home.” He’s cursing and grumbling as I reach behind me and pull my shoes from my duffle bag before shoving it into his arms.

“You grab it,” I say, and he grinds his teeth. He watches as I toe on my shoes and then we’re pushing through the crowd. We make our way to the SUV, rain pelting us until we’re finally inside the cab. He turns on the heat full blast as he drives me home. Everything is oddly quiet except for the swish of the windshield wipers. My head is swimming slightly from the punches I took to the face, my torso throbbing from the knuckles that drove into them.

But even so, I feel fucking alive.

My therapist said I have issues.

He didn’t live long after that.

The car suddenly shuts off and Viktor hops out, moving to my car door and wrenching it open. Rain hits his already damp shirt, one that looks far too good on him, accentuating his chest and arms, and I let my eyes sweep over him as I step out, my skin growing wet as I just stand there. Never did bother to put on a shirt.

“You going to take care of me, Vik-baby?” I ask dryly when our eyes catch. He just turns and stalks toward the front door, unlocking it and doing a small sweep of the premises as I follow him inside, my vision growing hazy from the way I ache.

“Doc is gonna be here soon,” he explains as I close the door behind me and lock it.

“Fuck that. I don’t need to be looked at. Tell him not to bother.”

“No. You’re an old man, Luca, acting like a fucking asshole going into a ring with a man half your age and twice your size.”

That grates on my nerves. “You saying I’m fucking old? I’m not. I fucking won.”

He huffs in annoyance and folds his arms across his chest. The shirt pulls slightly and an ache builds inside of me.

Maybe the punch to my head knocked something else loose.

Or maybe it’s always been there with Vik.

It seems fighting did nothing to abate the lust building inside of me.

“Sure. What the fuck ever, *Mantus*. But right now, you look like you’re about to keel over. You have a concussion. Doc will confirm it.”

“Fuck off. Get out of my house,” I hiss.

He doesn’t leave, just seems to grow more resolute. And it only makes me hornier. He takes up far too much space. In my house. In my head. In my fucking aching heart.

“Can’t do that. Don’t want you dying of stupidity.”

I huff a laugh and pain ricochets through me, forcing me to lock my jaw to keep a gasp inside.

“Told you so. And you’re bleeding all over the fucking floor.”

“Come here,” I rasp. He steps toward me and as soon as he’s close enough, I reach out. My fingers curl around the nape of his neck and I drag him into me. His hands fall to my waist as I slant my mouth over his.

He stiffens before sagging into me, my tongue thrusting into his mouth as his nails dig into my skin. The way he tastes, a moan moving from me into him. He swallows it and leans into me further before I pull back, his lips smeared with my blood, and fuck, I like it.

The way he looks covered in me.

His tongue sneaks out and wets his lips, making me want to do it again, but he just grabs onto my arm and pulls me toward the hallway.

“Don’t fucking kiss me again. Asshole.”

“You fucking loved it,” I say, adjusting my hard dick.

Seems I liked the kiss, too.

“Get in the shower,” he grumbles, and I watch as he leans forward to turn on the water, his shirt pulling up slightly, showing off a sliver of his back. He reaches in and cups a handful of water before splashing his mouth with it, ridding himself of me.

I cock my head, unable to move my eyes from him as he straightens and meets my stare.

“Get the fuck in.”

I don’t move. I just stand there until he starts to undress me. His fingers skirt over my sensitive skin, and I shudder.

He can’t fucking stand it.

He can’t stand me.

I want nothing more than to push him onto his knees and watch my cock disappear down his throat.

It’s made worse when he kneels before me and helps me out of my shorts.

My fingers slide through his hair and tighten as my cock appears, right in front of his face.

Viktor glances up at me, his cheeks pink, his pupils dilated.

“Let go of me,” he grinds out, but I can’t. Don’t want to.

I jerk him toward me, and his mouth parts as the tip of my dick slides between his lips.

“Suck.”

He groans around me, his tongue sliding out and slipping across my slit. The sensation of it, the feeling of that warm, wet heat surrounding me.

I want more. I want it all.

I pull him harder and more of my dick slips between his lips. His eyes slash up to mine, and my nostrils flare as I fist his hair even tighter.

“Fuck,” I moan as I pull him forward and feel his nose brush against the skin of my groin. He swallows around me, his body going slack, his gaze growing hazy, and then I pull him off me, letting him breathe deeply before repeating it. I feel the wet suction around my cock, pulling me closer and closer to the edge with each thrust down his throat.

He’s loving it, his moans sinking into my skin and making my orgasm crawl higher and higher, to the point that I’m trembling with the need to come.

But then I hear it.

Someone in my house.

Viktor’s eyes flash back to reality, his body stiffening.

“Luca? Viktor?”

Fucking Doc. Has the worst timing.

“Oh shit. I didn’t—well, fuck, I didn’t know you were into men, Luca.”

I turn over my shoulder to see Doc grinning stupidly from the doorway.

“I’m not.”

Viktor pops off my dick and stands up, shoving me slightly.

“Get in the fucking shower. Doc can wait. You smell.”

My lips turn down at that as I glance down at my dick.

“I don’t fucking smell.”

He shoves at me once more, forcing me to stumble into the shower and wash haphazardly while Doc and Viktor talk in the doorway to the bathroom.

I don’t like that at all.

Doc is handsome and accomplished, and the way he looks at Vik…

“What the fuck are you two talking about?” I shout from my place in the shower.

They ignore me as I rinse the shampoo from my hair and finally step out, grabbing a towel and rubbing it across my skin as I make my way over

to Vik, who looks a little too happy to be chatting with someone other than me.

Doc's eyes meet mine, and I can almost feel the grin he's hiding.

"Let's get you checked out. Seems someone has been cage fighting."

"Not cage fighting. Just bare-knuckle fighting…"

"On a cement floor with no protection in a fucking warehouse. It's shady as fuck."

Doc chuckles and then guides me to the bed. I sit down, the towel lying across my thighs as he grabs his bag and checks me over, bandaging the cut on my forehead with some tape and then placing some cream on my lip.

"Keep this clean. And yeah, you have signs of a concussion. Nothing too bad, but I'd keep an eye on him tonight, Viktor."

"Fuck," Vik mutters, and I like that he's bothered by it, by me.

I want him to squirm. Against me. Beneath me.

My dick starts perking up and the towel tents. Doc notices, but says nothing as he stands up straight and packs his things away. Always the professional.

"Call me if you think things have taken a turn for the worse. He is in his forties. Not someone who should be out bare-knuckle fighting. And sex… well, maybe make sure he's not too invigorated."

Viktor doesn't like that at all.

"I'm not having sex with him."

Doc just pats him on the shoulder and nods. "No judgment here. You two take care."

He nods and then disappears down the hallway, letting himself out of the house, leaving Viktor and me alone in the bedroom.

"Fuck. Why are you such an idiot?"

"I'm not an idiot. I'm your boss. Treat me with respect."

"Yeah, and why don't you treat me with respect?"

I lean back slightly, the towel slipping from my thighs, and Viktor's eyes slide to my dick.

"You don't want to be respected. You want to be owned. And who can own you, Vik?"

He wets his lips and I can see the bulge in his pants as he eyes me.

"Me. That's who," I answer when he doesn't respond.

"Fine, asshole. I'll stay, but I'll sleep on the floor. I'm not sucking your dick again. That was a mistake."

I lean back even further and then tug the comforter back. “Get the fuck in bed, Vik. And check the ceiling for spiders while you’re horizontal.”

He grinds his teeth but does as I say, clearing the room of any of those infernal arachnids before kicking his pants off, revealing the sexiest pair of panties, and sliding beneath the covers.

“Just stay away from me.”

I let out a chuckle as my eyes close, envisioning the ways I could rip that delicate piece of fabric from his ass. “I’ll stay away, but guess who will come crawling back to me?”

He doesn’t answer, but I can feel his breathing pick up.

“You. You’ll come crawling back. That’s who.”

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8

VIKTOR

Fuck him. *Fuck him*. I hate this. *I hate him*.

I want him. I want him to own me.

I can't fucking sleep because he's so close to me.

No, it's not because of that. I'm awake to make sure he doesn't die. Not because I'm fighting with the ache deep inside of me, spiraling slightly as I think about what I could do to him. Of what he could do to me.

Own me.

Make me his.

He shifts near me, turning onto his side, his leg brushing against mine. The sensation of him against me sets my skin on fire.

Fuck. Anyone but him.

I think back to when we first met. I was straight off the street, haggard and beaten, when Anthony took me in. One of my eyes was swollen shut when I first laid eyes on Luca. He was younger than he is now, almost thirty, but he was just as potent, and I hated myself for having an instant reaction to him. For letting my eyes follow his every move, for letting my hormone-riddled mind conjure up scenarios.

Alone with him.

Him touching me.

He never looked my way, though. I was just a kid then, a kid with a silly crush. He never paid me any notice. And with each ignored encounter, with each brush-off from him, I got angrier.

I despised myself for wanting someone I could never have. Hated him for making me feel this way.

I'm prideful and arrogant, and I hate that the man I want doesn't want me in return.

And yet, here I am. Still lusting after him.

But you did have him. For a few minutes, you were between his thighs, submitting to him.

I won't go crawling back to him. He's wrong. I fucking won't.

I throw an arm over my eyes and try to sleep, but it's elusive, a slippery thing. It's only made worse when he turns slightly and his hand brushes against my skin. He does that a lot—touch me.

It's gotten worse over the past three years.

It's almost like it's on purpose.

"Fuck. *Fuck*," I murmur as his fingers curl against my abdomen.

I can't take it anymore.

Shoving him off me, he rolls onto his back, his eyes snapping open.

"Vik, what the hell?" It comes out on a grunt, and I sit up, pushing the heels of my palms into my eyes.

"Please stop fucking touching me."

He's silent for a moment and then I feel the crawl of his hand up over the back of my neck and into my hair.

"Come here."

I try to shake him away, but don't manage. He just pulls me closer and *closer* until my face is pressed against the skin of his abdomen. I can feel the ripple of muscle beneath my cheek, the scent of his soap and I whimper slightly.

"I'm not crawling," I murmur, but he doesn't respond, just pulls me closer to what I want—his dick, hard and straining against the curve of my lips. I can't help but engulf it. The weight of it on my tongue, the taste of him, makes everything else I was previously struggling with disappear. Evaporating instantly.

I'm nothing but the mist of need between us.

Everything seems to fall into place as I suck him, and I fucking hate that it's Luca I want.

I turn slightly at the same time he does, an orchestrated move, slotting his cock right down my throat.

He groans low as I swallow around him and then proceed to let him fuck my mouth. Over and *over* until I'm mindless, a toy to be used. A hole.

For his pleasure.

For him.

Always him.

And even so, my own body is at the precipice of falling, of exploding into a million pieces. My cock is so hard it throbs in my lace panties as he continues to take me, use me, make me his.

I didn't crawl, I think as he wraps his leg around my shoulder and arches his hips up into me. The way he tunnels inside of me, the way I'm drooling for it.

The sounds I'm making.

Feral, unhinged, desperate.

His fingers tighten in my hair and he whispers my name as he empties himself down my throat. I drink all of it, keeping his length in my mouth as I will my own body not to release. To hold onto that euphoria for a little bit longer.

As I lie there, his cock softens against my tongue and still, I don't move.

Not yet.

"Greedy boy," he murmurs, his fingers no longer tugging, but carding through my hair. Making me almost purr at the tenderness of it.

Luca's never touched me like this.

What's changed?

Maybe that knock to the face did it.

"Did you come?" he asks after a few minutes of me continuing to tongue his dick.

I make an indiscernible noise and his hand stops moving.

"Take your dick out and come."

It's like my entire body was waiting for his permission. I turn slightly and arch into the mattress, grinding frantically, unloading in seconds. Shudders wrack my body, my moans vibrating around his cock.

Luca. Luca.

He pets me through the shudders and when my body is finally satiated, I feel my eyelids start to droop.

I'm going to regret this in the morning, I think as I curl up against him, not letting myself pull away from him entirely.

And he doesn't make me. He lets me stay.

I fall asleep with the taste of him still on my tongue.

The way Luca looks at me the next morning makes my skin flame.

I want him to never look at me again.

I've made a huge mistake.

"You should be resting," I say, grabbing my cup of coffee from the kitchen counter. "Doc's orders."

"I don't rest, Vik. You should know better."

I sip on my coffee, my throat sore from last night. But I'd be lying if I said I didn't like it.

He's right. I'm such a slut.

But we knew this.

I turn my gaze away from him and out the window, watching the rain patter on the ground. Seems it's going to be a wet winter. I remember ten years ago when we had a winter surge like this one, watching Luca run into the house, his body soaked from the rain. The way his white shirt stuck to his skin, revealing the tattoos hidden beneath the fabric.

He'd caught me staring then.

The smirk he gave me made me not look in his direction for an entire month after that. I didn't want him to see the way I wanted him.

"I received a phone call from Sabrina while you were snoring."

"I don't fucking snore."

He smirks at me, and my dick hardens between my legs. Fuck.

"Anyway, I need to approve some…design choices she has for me for the big reopen."

I know who Sabrina Nightingale is, and the fact he has a meeting with her rubs me the wrong way.

She's never bothered me before, but she is beautiful and runs a sex-worker business, and I know that when she's near Luca, she tends to flirt.

A lot.

Luca must see something in my expression because he says, "And no, I'm not going to fuck her. Or anyone else there. In fact, you're coming in with me. I also have some contracts to go over with her for opening night."

“Fine,” I say and then add, “And I don’t give a shit who you fuck, by the way.”

He sets his coffee mug down and pulls out a cigarette, placing it between his lips. I grab the lighter in my pocket, and he inhales deeply when it’s lit.

“See, the thing is, Vik, you may not care who I fuck, but it seems I care who you fuck. We keep this between us.”

I stare at him in disbelief, and he grins.

“Like I said, I own you now.”

“No. You don’t.”

He cocks his head to the side and steps closer until his chest is pressed against mine. His hand cups the front of my neck, his thumb tilting my head to the side. And then his lips are on my skin, sucking roughly, making my eyes roll into the back of my head.

I know what he’s doing.

He’s marking me.

Showing everyone I’m his.

His teeth drag against my sensitive skin, my body trembling, a tightness forming between my legs. A minute later, he pops off, his gaze solely on where his mouth just was. His finger reaches up, brushing across the smarting skin.

“Better. Now let’s get ready to go.”

With shaking hands, I finish my coffee despite the sting of my skin and the weight of those words. He owns me? Who the hell does he think he is? And why am I going along with it? Why did I let him mark me?

I know the answer. I’m really far fucking gone. *I need to find someone else to fuck*, I think as I move out to the SUV and grab my go-bag, showering, dressing, and brushing my teeth in record time. I refuse to look at the mark he put on my skin when I glance in the mirror, just flip the collar of my shirt up so no one can see it.

By the time I’m done, Luca is ready to go, looking suave and put together in his three-piece suit. His eyes move to my hidden hickey and he smirks.

“You can pretend all you want, Vik, but we both know the truth. It was crystal clear to me last night.”

I grab the keys and stalk to the car.

I don’t know what he’s talking about.

Not a fucking clue.

As I start the ignition and back out of the driveway, Luca flicks his cigarette out into the rain and sighs.

“You know, I remember when I first met you,” he says as I follow the GPS to Sabrina’s office. “All knees and elbows. Swollen eyes, dirty clothes.”

“Yeah, that’s what happens when you’re starved and tortured.”

His eyes land on me, and they don’t move from the side of my face.

“Tortured?”

I swallow and purse my lips. “Yep.”

“What happened to your parents?”

“Didn’t Anthony tell you?”

“He did, but I admittedly didn’t pay much attention at the time.”

“They were drug users. Got into a lot of bad shit. Dad overdosed when I was eleven. Mom died in prison shortly after that.”

“And then?”

“Foster care until the abuse there had me running away. I lived on the streets awhile.”

Luca’s silent a moment and then he turns his gaze forward. “I’m assuming Anthony took care of the foster parents?”

“He did.”

“Good.”

We’re quiet for a moment, and I twist my fists on the steering wheel. “Just because I suck your dick now doesn’t mean you have to give a shit about me.”

He huffs a low laugh. “You think that’s what this is?”

“I don’t fucking know what it is.”

He doesn’t answer, and I’m left wondering what he wants from me the entire drive to Sabrina’s. Does he want to continue to play with me? Is this some kind of game for entertainment? Something he’ll eventually grow bored with? I have no idea what his end goal is. I don’t know if I want to know either.

When we finally arrive, Luca turns his body toward mine in the car and adjusts my collar.

“You don’t hide it. You’re mine.”

“I’m not,” I reply, even though my stomach flutters with those razor-sharp butterflies at his clipped words.

“You are, kitten.” His finger smooths over my bottom lip and then he steps out of the car, his phone to his ear as he speaks to someone. I can’t help but follow.

The place Sabrina operates out of is on the outskirts of the city, in a secluded building near the beach. It’s a wealthy area and offers privacy for her repeat customers, but it’s not too far away from the amenities the city has to offer. It’s the perfect place for those looking for a good fuck before going out on the town.

“Ah, you made it,” Sabrina says as she flips her long black hair behind her shoulder. “And you brought Viktor. Wonderful. He can assess the men I’ve provided.”

“*Design choices*? What the fuck, Luca?”

I stare over at him, but he doesn’t look my way, just runs his tongue along the front of his teeth. He doesn’t meet my gaze as we follow Sabrina to a large back room. Standing inside are a dozen women and a handful of men, all scantily clothed, wearing nothing more than slips of fabric over their private parts.

As our gazes scan over the people, Sabrina leans into Luca a little too closely, saying something in his ear that only he can hear. I don’t like that. Not at all.

Always fucking flirting, the two of them.

Hate it.

“Gorgeous,” Luca says a moment later, his eyes flitting over the women before him. I purse my lips and move away from him, not wanting him to feel my jealousy. My eyes land on the first man standing before me. He’s large, tattooed, and oiled up. I take a step closer to him and he offers me a small smile.

“Hi,” I say softly, and he winks at me.

“Hey.”

Well, he’s hot, I’ll give him that. And he seems nice. Why can’t I want someone like this?

I peer over at Luca, who is, of course, ignoring me, and my jaw clenches.

I’m fucked up. So fucking fucked.

“Will they be working the floor on opening night?” I ask, and Sabrina wrenches her gaze away from Luca and nods.

“Yes, and some in the back rooms as well.”

I move to the next man. He's not as big, but just as gorgeous, with nipple piercings and a six-pack. I wet my lips and stuff my hands in my pants pockets, moving down the line, taking in each man, their differences and their beauty. Sabrina has good taste.

"You approve?" she asks, stepping toward me.

I turn to her and see Luca watching me from behind her.

"They're perfect."

Luca's eye twitches, and I can't help but add, "How much for the night?"

Sabrina blinks at me and then shifts out of the way when Luca moves to my side, his hand grabbing the front of my neck.

His thumb presses against the hickey as he drags me closer, tilting my head up and slanting his mouth over mine.

It's an open-mouthed kiss, our tongues tangling for a minute before he pulls away. I'm left panting, the front of my jeans tight.

"You were saying?" he growls, and I wrench myself away from him and walk outside, gulping down lungfuls of air as I try to right myself. He keeps kissing me, claiming me. What the fuck is he doing?

I'm not his—

Suddenly, a van screeches up to where I'm standing and the door slides open, a body rolling out and landing with a sickening thud on the ground.

I'm dumbfounded for just a second before moving into action, grabbing my gun with one hand and snapping pictures of the disappearing vehicle with the other, all while rushing over to give aid to the person lying face down on the ground.

With a punch to my phone screen, I call Luca and shout at him to come outside, my fingers looking for the nonexistent pulse of the young man before me.

Fuck. He's dead.

Who the hell was that?

Why did they dump him here?

Are the police on the way? Shit.

Shit!

I lean back on my haunches just as Luca steps to my side, pulling me up and wrapping his arm around my waist.

"He's dead. They dumped him right in front of me. We need to move him. Right now," I say in a rush.

Luca's gaze never leaves the body. Sabrina moves up next to us and is on the radio immediately, asking for someone to put the body inside.

"Call the brothers," Luca says as Sabrina's guards appear and drag the young man inside. My gaze follows them until they disappear, and then I move my eyes back to Luca.

"I got some pictures of the van. I may have caught the license plate number as well."

"Send them to me. I'll have my contact in the police force look up who it belongs to."

I do as he says, airdropping the pictures and hoping it's enough to get an ID. When I'm done with that, I call the brothers. I don't mince words.

"I know you want a video. But can you meet us at the address I just sent you?"

They hesitate a moment. "That was quite rude."

I roll my eyes so hard they stick in the back of my head for a whole second. "*Please*."

"Of course. We'll be there," they say in tandem.

They hang up and Luca leads me inside the building. The guards stay outside, surveying the area intently. They don't show it, but they're armed. Sabrina doesn't mess around when it comes to her employees.

Luca deftly swipes through the pictures on his phone as we move, calling up his contact within a few minutes and rattling off the plate number I provided for him.

"It's probably a fake," he says.

"Yeah."

"He'll get back to me with information. For now, all we can do is wait."

"Seems to be all we do these days."

"It seems that's mostly what the mafia is. All boring business deals in back rooms, contracts, and the occasional strong drink. There is very little action anymore."

"You're such a thug," I tease.

Luca huffs a small laugh as Sabrina comes over to us, looking completely put together despite the earlier action.

"I have the security footage of the drop being looked over now. Hopefully, we'll have something useful to give you. It shouldn't take long. How about a drink?"

"Please," I say, and Luca turns toward me slowly.

His voice lowers and he leans into me. “You say please so prettily.”

A scowl overtakes my face, and Luca smirks, reaching down behind me and squeezing my ass cheek roughly.

It still smarts from the spanking he gave me, still hurts to sit.

He has to know this. He does it anyway.

Sabrina pours us a drink, something strong, and I throw it back, needing something to keep me from rubbing up against Luca and begging. I won’t give him that.

“Would you like another?” Sabrina asks with a smile.

“No, he doesn’t,” Luca responds for me, and I know he’s right. I have to drive.

Fuck him for answering for me though. He’s not my father.

“But he will have something to eat.”

I glower at him, knowing where this is coming from. “I don’t need anything.”

“Get him a fucking snack. Please, Sabrina.”

Sabrina nods and walks to a cabinet, grabbing a few items and depositing them in my hands. All are luxury snacks, surely from overseas. I nod my appreciation, and her eyes sparkle.

She knows what this is, what Luca is doing.

Before I can say anything, a woman appears from the hallway, her hair up in a messy bun, her jeans ripped. She ignores us completely, speaking entirely to Sabrina. “Got some info. Not much, but more than we were expecting. If you want to see, I have it up.”

Luca, Sabrina, and I move to a small office where a few computer screens are set up. The woman pulls up some footage of the van, the quality better than I was expecting, and zooms in.

“We got a partial face,” she says. “It’s not that clear, but maybe you recognize him?”

Luca and I lean in further, our cheeks nearly brushing as we peer at the man’s face in the photo. It’s half-hidden, but something about it is familiar.

Someone I can’t quite place.

“Print that out—or better yet, send it to me,” Luca says, his hand landing on my ass once more.

Can’t keep his fucking hands off me.

The woman nods and a moment later, Luca’s phone pings as he receives the image.

“I’ll ask around. Thank you for getting that to me.”

We all move out of the small room, and Sabrina eyes us.

“Let me know who it is. They’re messing with me and my employees now.”

“I will.”

Luca’s gaze travels to mine and then snaps behind us when the twins appear, being escorted in by the two guards. I don’t know how they arrive so fast, but they do. It’s like they travel through a wormhole or something.

I’ll have to look into that.

Because if they’re stalking me, I may have to give them to Bane.

Teach them a lesson.

“Do you have a portal you come through?” Luca asks, as if reading my mind, and the twins turn their heads to stare at him.

“No. Why would you think that?”

He huffs and then points toward the hallway. “This way.”

I follow behind Luca, and the twins move to my sides, crowding in around me.

They both inhale deeply, and I can’t help but growl. “Are you sniffing me?”

“Yes,” Cain replies. “You smell like smoke.”

“Like him,” Ezra chimes in and points to Luca, who is standing near the body.

I don’t say anything in response, just move to where Luca is standing, looking down at the shape of a person, a sheet over him. At least Sabrina has some respect for the dead.

The twins approach it and peel the sheet down, examining the man.

“He’s hot,” Ezra says.

“He is,” Cain replies.

“Please stop talking about a dead body like that,” Sabrina says, but she goes ignored.

Ezra peers closer as Cain ruffles around in his bag, grabbing some clear vials for blood, when all of a sudden, the body gasps and gurgles.

Ezra leans back, and Cain snaps upright. The room is deadly silent as the young man we all thought was dead takes in a deep lungful of air.

“What the fuck?” I murmur.

“Ooh, he’s not dead,” the twins say in tandem. Cain reaches out and pokes him in the arm, and the young man’s wide eyes swivel toward him.

“He’s not a corpse,” Ezra adds, leaning in and sniffing long and hard, like a dog.

The man’s eyes are wild now, his hand moving up to his chest, as if feeling his heart beating. Or maybe he’s freaked out by the twins being all up in his space.

Luca pulls out a cigarette and places it between his lips, and without thinking, I light it, letting smoke filter across my face.

“Fuck, we should get him on an IV,” Sabrina says, snapping her fingers. “Call Doc and get him over here ASAP. We need to know what he knows.”

One of the guards pulls out his phone while Sabrina pushes her way forward, jostling the twins slightly.

They’re bothered by this, apparently fascinated with the resurrected man before them.

“Do not touch us,” Ezra hisses, but Sabrina is unbothered.

“I don’t know you assholes, and this man is hurt. So move the fuck out of my way. We need him alive.”

Cain grabs Ezra’s shoulder and moves him to the other side, the two of them kneeling at the same time. Their heads cock as they watch him, eyes never leaving him.

“Where am I?” the man manages to ask after a long moment, and Sabrina presses a hand to his shoulder.

“You’re safe. You were dropped here. Do you remember what happened?”

He shakes his head. “No. I don’t—I don’t remember anything. I can’t remember—”

He looks panicked, his eyes wild and round, but then Ezra and Cain reach out and touch him.

The man’s eyes swivel to where he’s being touched and he looks frightened.

“We will take care of you.”

They say it in unison, and Luca huffs out a laugh. “Fucking creepy. Think I’d rather be dead than with those two.”

He murmurs this but the accuracy makes me bite back a smile.

“Leave him alone, for god’s sake. He needs a minute to breathe and a doctor,” Sabrina bites out.

“No. He’s ours now. We found him.”

“Technically, Vik found him,” Sabrina counters. The twins’ eyes snap up to mine and they narrow, as if challenging me to a game I want no part in.

“He’ll share. He’s good at that.”

My cheeks flame when Luca chuckles.

“Viktor, control your goons. I’m about ready to murder them,” Sabrina says, but I don’t move to help. I won’t accomplish anything by interfering. The twins always do what they want.

“We aren’t goons. We are the Andromeda brothers.”

“I don’t give a fuck if you’re Jesus. Just stay the fuck out of my way,” Sabrina counters, but the twins just ignore her.

They continue to hover over the man until Doc arrives. Sabrina is agitated by their eerie presence, but Doc’s arrival makes everything a little less tense. He thoroughly checks the guy out, questioning him a bit from which we get no new info—not even a name—and then gets a blood sample before giving him a clean bill of health. Just memory loss and dehydration. There is the stipulation that he’ll need to be watched over for a few days, and the twins volunteer.

Luca leans toward me. “What are the chances they leave you alone now?”

“Hopefully.”

As if hearing me, Ezra turns toward me and cocks his head. “We heard that and still require payment.”

“Prostate stimulation,” Cain adds, and the poor guy hooked up to the IV stares at me in confusion. “That is what we require. By him.”

They point to Luca, and I hear a small huff of acknowledgment.

“Seems they’re not through with you yet.”

“And we have specifications,” Cain says.

Everyone is staring at me now, making me cross my arms over my chest and square my shoulders.

“Send them to me. I’ll make sure it happens,” Luca says.

I scowl at him and watch as he pulls out another cigarette.

He can light his own this time, goddamn him.

“Ass up,” Luca says, and I glare at him from over my shoulder.

I’m naked on his bed. Once again.

The list of things the twins want to see in this video is absurd. They can’t keep asking this sort of thing from me.

I won’t do it.

But they’re expecting it, so I have to.

I’ll take one for the team.

That’s the only reason I’m doing this. It’s not because I’ll enjoy it.

“Spread your legs. Ass up further.”

“What is this? Some kind of porno?”

He huffs a laugh. “I mean, yeah.”

I can’t help but send a glower his way once more, which only ends with my ass being slapped.

The sting of it has me arching back slightly. Traitorous body.

I hear the cap of the lube being flicked open, and I push my face into the pillow, breathing deeply when he trickles it down my crack, his finger swirling around my rim.

It flexes under his touch, and when he pushes two fingers in, I can’t help but let out a small groan. Pain mixes with pleasure and my cock throbs.

“Look at that,” he says as he twists his wrist slightly and scissors me open. “Look at how good you take it.”

“Just…shut up and…oh fuck.”

A helpless moan slips from my mouth as he spreads me, making my hole open wider for him.

“What are you doing?” I gasp.

“Trying to find it,” he murmurs, and then his finger brushes over that little bump, and I arch my back, gasping, my fingers curling into the sheets.

“*Luca*.”

“There it is,” he says, not letting up, not giving me any reprieve. Not that I want it. Oh fuck, this feels so good. So, so good. And it’s made even worse by the fact he’s the one doing this to me.

He’s the one inside of me.

“You are always so responsive.”

His fingers continue to move inside of me as I writhe beneath him. I’m not going to last. I’m not going to make it.

This is too good.

“He’s tight. Wet,” Luca narrates.

Oh god. I am. I *so* am.

“He could take more. Want to see?” I feel him push three fingers into me, and I gasp as I push back against him.

“There it is, pretty boy.”

I melt at those words, unable to stop the full-body tremble that slides through me. I never want this to end. I want him to stay inside of me until I expire.

He presses against my prostate again, and I cry out, pulling the corner of the bedding off the mattress and pressing my forehead into the pillow to keep myself from screaming.

But then suddenly the sensation stops and his fingers slip from me.

I turn to stare back at him, my throat dry from groaning.

“Wh—”

“Turn over, kitten. They want to watch you come.”

“Oh, fuck.”

He just stares at me through hooded eyelids as I flop onto my back, my legs hanging off the side of the bed. Luca spreads my thighs farther apart and then grabs my right leg and places it over his shoulder, opening me up to him once more.

His eyes meet mine, his cheeks flushed slightly, his throat bobbing. He angles the phone down, and I follow it, seeing the bulge in his pants.

He likes this, fucking me with his fingers.

Just like he liked it three years ago.

He puts more lube on his fingers, bringing them to my already open hole, and pushes inside.

I gasp, fisting the sheets once more, needing something to hold me down, to ground me. Because when he touches me, anytime he lays his hands on me, I feel like I’m flying. My cock jerks between my legs, and I reach out to touch it, but Luca clicks his tongue at me.

“No touching. Remember?”

Oh shit, yes, I remember. Those sick fucks want me to come untouched.

“Hands above your head.”

I do as he says, my body stretched out before him as he continues to torture me, my hole flexing around his fingers, my cock leaking as he slowly works an orgasm out of me.

But it’s not quick. He draws it out, almost as if he knows exactly what to do to drive me insane. He derives pleasure from it.

His finger presses on my prostate in quick succession, making me bend my knee and arch my hips up.

“You want more?” he asks, and I bite my lip and nod.

“Look at that face. Look how desperate he is for it.”

The camera is trained on me, as are Luca’s eyes, and I know what he sees—pupils dilated, my lips dark red from where I’ve bitten them.

He slows his movements, and I writhe against him, my dick leaking profusely.

He angles the camera on my cock, his eyes intent on it as he watches it leak. He’s fascinated with my response to the stimulation.

I hate that he likes watching me.

Oh fuck, I love him watching me.

“Come for me,” he says, and then whispers, “Kitten.”

That sets me off, my cock twitching between my legs, and a steady stream of lust pulses through my veins and straight out of my cock. My body shakes with such force that my neck arches back, cum spilling over the head of my cock.

My knuckles crack as I hold on for dear life, and when he doesn’t let up, just keeps massaging my prostate, I let out a shuddering breath.

“One more. They want two.”

“Fuck them,” I wheeze, but he only shifts closer, my leg straight up now, my cum-smeared abdomen flexing as I feel pleasure move through me, my muscles relaxing and yet tensing at the same time.

Luca’s phone is moving from my face to my chest, to where his fingers disappear inside of me.

“You’re such a desperate little slut, I know you can do it.”

“I can’t,” I gasp, but he doesn’t let up, his fingers continuing to toy with me, his face turning slightly, his teeth grazing my calf. The way his mouth feels on my skin makes something inside of me twist.

His tongue flicks out and then his teeth sink into me, making me moan.

The pressure against my prostate grows, and I’m almost crying now, my entire body taut and ready to snap.

“Such a good boy,” he whispers, and that pushes me over the edge, a pathetic burst of cum sputtering from the tip of my cock. It’s embarrassing, really.

He wets his lips as he trails the camera over my body once more, catching everything from my watering eyes to my puckered nipples, to my

cum-splashed stomach.

“We got what we needed.”

He thumbs at his phone, his fingers still inside of me.

“Sent.”

I can’t move, my eyelids fluttering as I flex around him.

“You can—you can take your fingers out of me.”

He hesitates a moment and then slowly pulls them out.

I feel his absence. It almost hurts. I want more.

“I’m going for a smoke,” he says, his voice rough, his pants tight. He’s hornier than he wants to admit in this moment.

But I don’t offer to suck his dick, even though I’d let him slide down my throat. Instead, I just lie there, watching as Luca disappears from the bedroom before I close my eyes and drift off.

The smell of smoke wakes me, my body jerking upright, my mind in a fog. My gaze swivels over to the chair where I see Luca slumped over, a glass of alcohol on the ground, tipped over, small flames lapping at the rug where I’m sure his cigarette fell.

That asshole probably fell asleep with it in his hand. I jump from the bed.

“Luca! *Luca*!”

The flames seem to be growing larger, and suddenly Luca is sitting upright, his legs pulled up to his chest, his eyes wide. He’s paralyzed.

I grab the blanket off the bed, flinging it over the small fire and stomping on it before dragging him off the chair and toward me. He stumbles, his fingernails digging into my skin, his breathing raspy.

He looks like he’s miles away, not truly present. He’s back in his nightmares.

“It’s okay. It’s okay. It’s out. The fire is gone.”

He doesn’t seem to believe me, so I pull the blanket back and see the charred rug, but no embers, no flames.

“See. It’s gone. It’s fine.”

Luca lets out a shuddery breath, and I see his hands flexing next to his sides.

Oh fuck.

“Hold on. Just—”

I rush to the window and pull it open. The sound of the rain outside drowns out the sound of his panicked breathing.

“Come here. Come on,” I say as I approach him. His eyes are glued to the place where the flames had started to lap at the upholstery of the chair he was just in, so I pull him into me once more. He stumbles to the right and my arms wrap around him. I feel the tremble of fear move through his entire body, making his teeth rattle.

I don’t know what happened in his past that made him so afraid of fire. I don’t know because he’s never told anyone that I know of. Anthony might know. I should ask him, despite knowing he may never tell me. The two of them are as close as two men can get.

Like brothers.

I grab my phone off the bedside table and lead a rigid and silent Luca from the bedroom.

“Let’s go somewhere else.”

Halfway dragging him into a guest room on the far side of the house, I open the window so he can hear the rain, and then pull him to the ensuite bathroom. I turn the shower on, knowing he’ll want to wash the smell of smoke from his body. The smell reminds him of it, whatever happened. And I want to bring him back to the present. I strip him until he’s completely naked and help him inside. I use my hands to scrub at his skin, the fresh smell of soap washing everything else away.

Fuck. I should probably shower too.

I’m still naked from earlier, so I just step into the narrow stall with him, leaning into his wet body and holding him to me.

He’s quiet, so I just let him be.

I get it.

I fucking *get* it.

The way certain things trigger me. Trauma has a way of burying itself deep inside, worming its way into your bones, and never leaving.

My hands move up his back, and he leans into me. My fingers spread across his shoulder blades and he turns his face into my neck.

“Let me wash myself and then we can lie down,” I say gently, and he huffs.

He probably hates that it's me in here with him, comforting him, but fuck it. I'm the only one here.

I pull away for a moment, scrubbing the bar of soap over me and rinsing off before turning off the water and stepping out. Luca is just standing there, his gaze on me.

I toss him a towel and he catches it, holding it against his chest. He makes no move to dry off, so I do it for him, dragging it over his skin until he's no longer wet.

Then I pull him into the bedroom and onto the mattress, tugging the covers over us.

It smells like rain in here, wet and earthy. The sound of it pounding the ground outside has me relaxing slightly. Not that Luca is. He seems to be back in that dark place, his gaze slightly far away. So I pull him into me, both of us on our sides, our knees pressed together, my arm wrapped around him, and my hand settled on his back.

Our foreheads are just inches apart, and I press my nose against his.

"Come back, Luca. You're safe. You can come back now."

He blinks up at me, those dark eyes meeting mine.

But he says nothing, so I just press in closer to him. I can feel his heartbeat against my chest and I drag my fingers across the skin of his back.

He shivers, so I do it again.

"How about we play a game?"

When he doesn't answer, I add, "I'm going to draw a letter on your back and you guess what it is."

He swallows and so I drag my finger over his back.

A moment later, he murmurs, "C."

"Yeah. Okay, ready for the next one?"

He nods, that faraway look starting to disappear. I draw another letter on his back.

"O."

"Mhm. Next?"

He nods and my fingernail traces a shape on his back, bumping over his spine as I go.

"C."

I huff a laugh, and his lips start to turn up. "Such a fucking slut."

"I am," I say, my own lips turning up as I draw out the last letter.

"K."

“You guessed it. Want to go again?”

He nods, his hand bringing my leg up over his hip, our bare cocks slotted together, our lips too fucking close.

“Will it be another dirty word?”

“Maybe,” I say, and his nose brushes against mine, his hand dragging up the side of my thigh to my hip.

My fingers slide up and down his back, spelling out dirty words, making him shiver and smile.

By the time he’s fully back to the present, our lips are brushing with each exhale.

“You saved me,” he whispers, his hand sliding into my hair and tugging on the strands gently.

“That’s my job.”

“It’s more than the job,” he adds, and I swallow roughly. “Admit it, Vik.”

I don’t. I can’t. Instead, I just say, “Tell me what happened. Tell me your secrets.”

“Admit it and I will.”

I hesitate a moment, not wanting to give in, but also wanting to know more about him. It’s detrimental to me in the long run, the way he’ll use my truth against me, but I do it anyway.

“Fine. It’s more than the job. Right now, it’s more.”

He huffs but accepts my admission.

“You start,” he says, his fingers massaging my scalp, making tingles erupt across my back.

“Why do I have to be the one to fucking start?”

“Because I’m your boss and I say so.”

The way he murmurs that, with such authority, makes my cock perk up. Hell, who am I kidding? I was half-hard just from being near him, but this pushed me over the edge. Blood flows to it and it settles between our bodies, pressed against his stomach.

He feels it, I know he does, but he doesn’t say anything. Just watches me intently.

“Fine. I have siblings in Oregon.” He blinks at me, and I sigh. “They’re much older than me. I didn’t even know about them until a few years ago. Anthony looked into it and found them.”

“Have you met them?”

“No. I don’t know if I want to. Me showing up in their lives would only ruin things.”

“Are they good people?”

I roll my lips between my teeth. “You first. Tell me something. I can’t be the only one with secrets.”

“I have many, but you only get a few, kitten.”

“Fine.”

His lips move against mine, a soft brush and I hold my breath when he pulls away.

“My parents and sibling were murdered.”

I don’t breathe as he opens up, just a crack, but it leaves me wanting more.

“Where were you?”

“I was there. Hiding. That’s when the fire started. I almost didn’t make it out but the firefighters came.”

He shudders, and I rub gently at his back.

“Did you find who did it?”

“No.”

He closes his eyes, and I can’t help but stare at him. Fuck, he’s so beautiful.

Something possessive moves through me, but I squash it. This, right here, means nothing.

“I like the sound of the rain,” Luca finally says, and I let my hand thread through the hair at the base of his neck.

“Me too.”

His eyes open and meet mine, something intense flickering through those depths.

“Kiss me,” he whispers, those words piercing my chest.

I can’t help but do it. I lean forward and press my lips to his, gently at first and then it grows more urgent. Luca’s fingers dig into my skin, his hard cock brushing against my abdomen, and then he rolls me onto my back, his body on top of mine.

His arms bracket my face, his teeth sinking into the flesh of my lower lip.

Our eyes are still open as he licks his way into my mouth. The taste of him, the way his warm breath tunnels down my throat.

The way he possesses me.

He’s had me in a chokehold for years, almost half my life, if I’m honest.

I let out a shaky breath as he grinds his hips into mine. I didn’t realize this closeness, this awareness of him, would bring me so close to the precipice, but I’m teetering right there. The feel of him, the way he kisses me, filthy and domineering.

Everything about him is my kryptonite.

My body arches up, my legs tightening around his waist as my fingers sink into the flesh of his ass, and I explode on a cry.

Luca swallows it down, grinding into me as wave after wave crashes over me.

And when I’m done, lying there, sucking in deep breaths, Luca stares down at me, his pupils blown out. Our lips hover centimeters apart, and then I open wide for him.

His lips twitch and he crawls up my body, slotting his cock at my mouth and pushing inside.

I hold onto him tightly, forcing his cock down my throat as I swallow around him. He groans, his chin on his chest, his eyes watching me take him.

When he comes, it’s with a low moan, his body trembling over mine. I hold him inside, breathing through my nose as he softens against my tongue.

His finger traces a line up my cheek as he slowly pulls out of me, a string of cum slipping from my lips as he falls to my side. He reaches over and swipes at my swollen lips, smearing his release across my skin.

“You’re mine.”

I just stare at him, as a flutter builds in my chest.

Fuck.

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9

LUCA

I watch the dark gray clouds move across the sky as I blow the smoke from my cigarette up into the air.

Vik lit it for me as we lay there in bed.

His body is bruised, his hair in disarray. So fucking wrecked. Ruined.

I did that. I owned him at that moment.

I lean back and sip at my coffee.

I didn't bother getting dressed. I'm naked on my porch, the one overlooking the golf club.

The cool breeze on my skin makes me feel alive. Like I'm not suffocating in the heat of the fire.

Last night, I slept well, cradled against Vik's back, the thrum of his heart calming. But when I woke, overheated and overwhelmed, I panicked and found myself out here.

I called my aunt and spoke with her for a while, processing what happened.

"I want to meet him," she said. "He's special."

I couldn't admit it, but he is.

I knew it three years ago and I know it now. I told her I'll bring him when I visit. She told me she'd have a room waiting.

Footsteps have me turning my head, and I see Viktor standing there, a blanket around his shoulders, his hair still a wild mess.

Fuck, he's hot.

He doesn’t move toward me. Something between us shifted last night. I can feel it. He can too.

Mine, my body thrums as I stare at him, owning him with my gaze, marking him with my body.

“Come here,” I say, spreading my legs slightly.

He hesitates a moment before walking toward me, lowering himself to his knees between my spread thighs.

My free hand moves into his hair, threading my fingers through those soft strands. His cheek lands on my thigh as I pet him. I swear I can almost hear him purr.

“You’re such a good boy, aren’t you?” I say huskily.

He peers up at me, a cute little scowl on those red lips. The bottom one is swollen from the way my teeth sank into it last night.

“You won’t admit it, but you love it, don’t you, kitten?”

I take a drag of my cigarette and exhale the smoke, watching it disappear into the air around us.

A golf cart drives by in the distance, just as it starts to sprinkle.

“You think they’d see us if I stuff your mouth full?”

He shudders and peers up at me with those pretty eyes.

“You think they’d stop and watch?” I ask.

His face moves slightly toward my dick, which is lengthening just from him being nearby. It seems he owns me just as much as I own him.

I told myself I’d never be beholden to another, and yet, here I am… giving in.

Viktor shuffles even closer and my hand guides him to it, watching as that pretty mouth engulfs me. He’s so fucking good at this. My body starts relaxing almost immediately, letting him work me toward the edge. Effortless. He hums happily around me, and I stroke his face while he takes me.

And when I come, it’s slow, a gentle rolling of my hips, a small gasp as he swallows my release.

Then he lays his face on my thigh and licks his lips.

“This doesn’t change anything,” he says softly.

I don’t stop touching him.

“Oh, kitten, this changes *everything*.”

“What are you doing down here?” I ask Anthony when I find him beneath the house in his secret little photography studio. He’s hunched over his equipment in the darkroom and doesn’t even look over at me as he pulls a piece of film from the solution and begins hanging it on a drying rack.

“Just working on developing some pictures I took of Tatum.” He peers at me now, his eyebrow arching. “And you?”

“Was trying to find you,” I say, moving over to the pictures he has displayed, eyeing a completely naked Tatum splayed out in each of them. They’re beautiful, the angles, the lighting. Anthony has a great eye.

I’m glad he’s back to doing this, despite losing Laura all those years ago. I thought this hobby of his died with her.

I move around the room and see a wall dedicated to her. I make an appearance there too.

I remember those days. The three of us.

Together in many ways.

“Do you ever think of her?” I ask. It’s a stupid question. Of course he does. I do. Not as much as I used to when she died, but she appears sometimes in my mind when I least expect it. Almost as if to remind me she’s still around in her own way.

“Yes. It helps that Tatum likes to talk about her. He brings her up quite often.”

“You’re lucky,” I say, moving my gaze away from her piercing smile.

It always made my heart flutter. In much the same way Viktor’s seems to do.

When he smiles at me, that is. Which isn’t often.

Or ever.

I huff, and Anthony asks, “What was that for?”

“Just thinking.”

“Of who?”

“Why do you think it’s someone?”

“Because I think it’s Viktor.”

I don’t say anything, and Anthony moves up beside me, his arm brushing against mine.

“You’re obsessed with him.”

“I’m not.”

“You are. You have that same look in your eyes. You want to chase him, want to overpower him. You want to take him.”

My skin tingles at the thought, but I just stay silent.

“I’ve never wanted a man before.”

“Who says it matters? Male, female. If it works, it works.” I peer over at my best friend, and he smirks at me. “And the sex is fucking nice.”

I think about Viktor, his tight ass, his clenching hole, the way he begs for it.

“Anyway,” Anthony says, disrupting my fantasies. “How is the club coming along?”

“Should be ready to go for the re-opening Saturday. Are you and Tatum coming?”

“I’d rather stay home but he wants to attend. Will security be enough?”

“It will be better than enough. No one is getting in without verification and the guards have been doubled, both in uniform and those in plainclothes.”

“Good. Are you bringing Viktor?”

I shift on my feet. “He’s my bodyguard now, isn’t he?”

“I meant as a date. If he’s sucking your cock, you might as well make a gesture.”

“Fuck gestures. I take what I want.”

Anthony nods toward the door, and I follow him. As we move, he eyes me. “Just don’t forget the romantic parts. Sex is good, but you also need to remember most people need more than that.”

I’m not sure Vik does. He’s a horny slut, but the way I stroked his face this morning, the way he nearly purred against me, makes me think I should do a little better. It’s been so long since I’ve even tried that I don’t know what to do.

I’ll think about it later, I tell myself as we make our way through the tunnels with the lights flickering above us as Anthony leads me to Bane’s lair.

When we arrive, we find Bane in his cluttered office, his dick out, his hand stroking it.

Anthony clears his throat, and Bane looks over, a grin spreading across his face.

“Hey, Boss. I’m just looking at porn right now. Georgiy is avoiding me. I think he’s afraid of commitment, which has just led me to being very horny.”

I huff a small laugh and pull out a cigarette, feeling slightly forlorn that Viktor is topside right now and not able to light it for me. Fuck, I should have had him follow me down here, but he was busy, so I made my way below by myself.

“Put your dick away, Bane. I have a job for you.”

He sighs but does as Anthony says. While he’s zipping up his pants, I take in the jars of human remains littering his bookshelves. I’m pretty sure that jar of ears is new. I haven’t seen that one yet.

“How can I help you, Boss?” Bane asks, standing up. His dick straining at the front of his pants. “I have a nice dick, huh? Dicks are just all-around amazing. I have a jar of them somewhere in here.”

Anthony clears his throat, and Bane turns back toward us, shifting on his feet. “Oh yes, right. What is this job?”

Bane eyes me, but I don’t say anything, because I have no fucking idea what Anthony wants from him. This is as much of a surprise to me as it is to him.

“The re-opening of the club is on Saturday. I’d like you to attend.”

“Oh. *Oh*, a club! Like with dancing? Or a sex club? What do I wear?”

“Not a sex club and I’ll have Tatum handle your outfit. But I’d like you to watch over Tatum when I’m not around. Luca has assured me security will be tight, but I need several people watching him specifically. We all remember the fire there several months ago.”

Bane huffs. “I do remember that and I’m telling you it was Henry behind it. But anyhoo, I can do that. But I *was* hoping you’d be suggesting something with those back rooms Luca had put in.”

He’s pouting now, and Anthony arches an eyebrow at me. “You can have sex, Bane. When Tatum is with *me*, you’re free to do what you like.”

“Oh, goodie.” He pulls out his phone and taps on the screen. “I’m just going to let Georgiy know, so he can be very jealous that my ass is going to get it. Probably. Most likely.”

He waggles his eyebrows at his phone and then sets it aside. “Oh, and I almost forgot.” He shuffles to the back of the office and reappears with something dangling from his hands.

“I made this.”

He hands us both what look like leather bracelets.

I take it from him, and he wiggles slightly, obviously excited. “It’s from the skin of our enemies.”

He beams as Anthony holds it up to his face. “Thank you, Bane.”

“You’re so welcome. Now put it on.”

We both do, snapping them into place and listening as Bane giggles. “Oh, that looks nice. Next time, I’m going to embroider something onto it. A design of sorts. What do you like? Oh, don’t tell me! I’ll surprise you.”

“Thank you. And get in touch with Tatum. He would like to help you pick out an outfit, I’m sure.”

Bane nods, bouncing on his feet. “I’ll go now. I want one with no fabric over my nipples.” He pulls his shirt up, showing us his lean and extremely pale torso. “Besides my dick, I think these are my best assets.”

We stare at his small, puckered nipples, and then Anthony sighs. “Right. Luca and I have business to attend to. Thank you, Bane.”

“Anytime, Boss.”

We turn and make our way out of Bane’s office, through the tunnels, and into the house. Tatum is waiting for us in Anthony’s office, perusing the library there. Since getting together, Anthony has made sure to have multiple of Tatum’s favorite authors present. The only thing is that Tatum has to find them. Like a hide-and-seek scavenger hunt.

“I found one special edition,” Tatum says and then launches himself into Anthony’s arms, placing a long kiss on his lips.

I turn away and move to the table with the alcohol on it. I pour myself a glass and take a sip, waiting for Anthony and Tatum to finally peel apart. When they do, several minutes later, they appear, looking flushed and horny.

“Viktor was looking for you a few minutes ago,” Tatum says with a sly grin. “Or should I say *your boyfriend*?”

I don’t correct him. After last night…well, what would he be other than that?

“Where is he?”

“I don’t know. Just that he looked irritated at your sudden disappearance.” Tatum’s eyes move to Anthony and to his arm. “Oh, what’s this?”

“Bane made it,” Anthony says, and Tatum’s hand retracts.

“Oh god, that’s human skin, isn’t it?”

“From the bodies of our enemies,” I add and I can’t help the laugh that escapes me.

“I mean, it’s sweet. In theory.”

Just as he says that, the secret door opens and Bane appears.

“Hey, we were just admiring the gifts you gave Anthony and Luca,” Tatum says.

“Oh, isn’t it pretty? Would you like one?”

Tatum grimaces and then schools his face, nodding as Bane bounces over to him. “Oh, and did they tell you? I need you to help me get ready for the club on Saturday.”

“I did know, but now that I get to dress you? I am even more excited.”

Tatum tugs Bane out of the office, the two of them chattering endlessly as they go.

Anthony stares at me, and I shrug before swallowing the rest of the alcohol.

“Well, I’m off to find Vik.”

“Wait, I need to discuss the issue of the bodies with you first. Do you think I should call Diablo and his friend Lex in to help?”

“I know you don’t like involving them if you can help it.”

“I know, but they could put an end to this once and for all.”

“Sit on it. Let’s see what we can gather on our own. We don’t need to involve Diablo and put him in more danger.”

Anthony nods, scrubbing a hand over his face. “He’s a little shit.”

“He is.”

“He’ll get himself killed.”

“Skylar will protect him.”

“That’s true. He’d die for him.”

We’re silent a moment and he glances up at me. “You’d die for Viktor too, right?”

I don’t say anything, not sure how to answer that.

“I need to find him. Unless you need me for anything else?”

“No, I’m good. I’ll decide on Diablo and Lex later. Give it a little more time.”

Before I’m able to leave his office, he stops me. “And don’t forget romance, Luca. Consider it. Open up and let him in. You’re not so bad, deep down.”

“Fuck off.”

His dark chuckle follows me out into the hallway.

I find Viktor with a few other men on the perimeter of the estate as they patrol. This isn't Viktor's job, but he always helps out when he can. And he seems to be chatting happily with his friend Jax.

I don't like how he's smiling at him.

Far too many teeth are showing as he laughs.

Those teeth slip behind those full lips as I make my way toward them, my eyes intent on him, on the way he stiffens, the way his eyes flick over to me. I feel that gaze through my entire body, from the tip of my ears to the bottom of my feet.

"Viktor," I say as I approach. "I need to speak with you." Jax nods at me and then scuttles away, moving to the other side of the perimeter to keep watch. He glances back at us a few times, so I don't touch Viktor the way I want.

The way I want to possess him.

"What is it?" he asks.

"Tatum said you were looking for me."

"I wasn't." He folds his arms across his chest and then adds, "I mean, I just asked where you were. That's all."

I take a step closer to him, my arm hitting his.

"It's okay if you were worried."

"I'm not fucking worried."

I lean forward, my nose brushing against the shell of his cold ear. I hear the intake of his breath, the way he shivers slightly, and that's when the first raindrop hits us.

"Come on," I murmur, pulling him forward as it starts coming down in droves. Our hands link, fingers entwined, and I can't help but squeeze him roughly. The way his hand fits in mine, the feel of it.

I like it more than I thought possible.

I pull him under the covered gazebo at the far end of the gardens, surrounded by wisteria, smelling so sweet, enveloping us both. In this space, we're hidden, just the two of us.

"What the fuck are you doing?" he breathes as I let go of his hand and we stand facing each other. He has raindrops on his face, dripping down from his hair to his cheek. My hand reaches out and brushes them away, dragging my thumb to his lips in the process.

His teeth surround the flesh of my finger and he bites down, pupils dilating.

I can’t help the growl that exits my throat as he sucks on it, dragging his tongue over the tip and down the side. I want to push him to his knees and slide my cock down his throat.

Fuck, he’s good at that.

I drag my finger from his mouth and he lets out a long exhale right before I slant my lips over his, our bodies colliding, cocks hard, fingers grasping.

He moans into my mouth, and I swallow the sound, my nerve endings firing, my entire body alight with need. He fucks me up, twists me around. I don’t know which way is up, down, or sideways. I’m in a spiral.

My fingers thread through his hair and pull roughly, making him gasp, his tongue tangling with mine. I drag my hands down his back to his ass, pulling his hips into me, over and over. He whines, like an animal in heat, in need.

I want to lower him to the ground and fuck that right out of him.

I want to own him. Want to possess every part of him, inside and out.

I’m feral.

But before I can rip his clothes off and do what I want, a scream has the two of us pulling away from each other, both of us moving our hands to our guns.

Fuck.

“What was that?” Viktor asks, moving to the entrance of the gazebo, adjusting his cock, and swiping the back of his hand across his swollen lips.

“We need to get to the house. Now.”

We move in tandem, our adrenaline high as we make our way forward, guns drawn. I can hear the sawing of my breath as I think about everything that could go wrong. Is it Tatum again? Anthony?

Fuck, don’t let it be either. Anthony because he’s like a brother to me and Tatum because Anthony would never recover.

But when we approach the house, we see Tatum zipping past us, his mouth turned up in a laugh as he skids around the corner, his arms windmilling dramatically as he tries to catch his balance.

Anthony appears on the porch a moment later, his cheeks flushed, his tie undone.

Seems they’re playing that infernal game of cat and mouse.

Viktor swears and flicks the safety on his gun, meeting my gaze for a second before looking away.

Our adrenaline is still high, our hearts still racing.

It only makes me want him more.

I want to fuck right into that tight ass.

And I would have if these fuckers hadn't interrupted.

I turn to look at him, all wet hair and flushed cheeks. My heart patters in my chest in time with the rain hitting the ground.

"Saturday," I say gruffly, finding my voice. "You'll come with me to the club."

He nods. "I know."

I grind my teeth and fiddle with my cigarette in my pocket. "I mean, you're coming. *With* me."

He stares, confusion crossing his face. "Yeah, I fucking know."

My hand reaches out, clutching his neck tightly, feeling the thrum of his pulse under my thumb.

"With me, Vik. As mine."

His eyelashes flutter and he glances away, those red spots on his cheeks making an appearance.

"No."

I brush over his pulse lightly and press my forehead to his. "Yes."

He doesn't say no again, just lets that command sit between us, heavy and insistent.

The way he looks at me the rest of the day and into the night, sneaking small glances, does something to my heart, makes it expand and crack, reshaping itself into something new, something different.

Possession fills me, feral and greedy.

Mine, it says.

All mine.

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10

VIKTOR

I do my best to avoid him, confusion melting into my bones and leaking into my chest. My heart can't stand this. It doesn't know what to do. Fifteen years of nothing, and now this.

I sneak glances at him as we work, standing several feet away to keep his hands off me. Because I know the minute he touches me, I'll crawl. Beg.

I'll pant like the slut I am. For him.

"Walk me inside," he says lowly when I pull up to his house, the car idling quietly. My fingers are tight on the steering wheel, my eyes boring into his front door. I know what will happen if I go in there.

I know what this means.

My cock aches.

I fucking want it.

"Come on, Vik," he adds as he steps outside onto the wet concrete of his driveway. The way he moves, lithe and predatory. I'm at his mercy. I can do nothing but turn off the car and follow him to the door. His fingers brush against my ass as I open it and step inside. He waits patiently as I clear the house before moving toward the exit to leave.

I really mean to. I mean to walk right through the door and not look back.

But he stops me with a flick of his fingers on the button of his slacks, a pull of his zipper. I hear it. It makes my skin tingle and my mouth water. His eyes meet mine, and I hear the wheeze come out of my throat, desperate and disgusting.

I fucking hate how much I'm drooling for this.

"It's just a date, Vik. No need to be dramatic about it," he says as he lowers himself onto a kitchen chair, his thighs spread, the dark golf course looming behind us through those large-paned sliding doors. Anyone could be watching this, seeing what he's about to do to me.

He lifts his hips, pulling a cigarette from his pocket, and places it between his lips.

My fingers itch to pull the lighter from my pocket, but I curl my toes into my shoes and keep myself steady. I will not rush over to him. I won't show him how badly I want this.

His eyes flash to mine and then his free hand snakes into his pants and pulls his cock out. It's hard, angry, and fucking perfect. I let out a wobbly exhale, my throat swallowing around nothing.

"Come here, pretty boy."

I inhale a shaky breath and nearly trip as I move forward. Luca sees it but says nothing, just watches as I come to a stop right before him. Our knees knock and his eyes slide up my chest.

"Take off your shirt. I want to see those tits," he says lowly.

I shiver and tug my shirt off, tossing it onto the ground behind me.

Luca wets his lips, his eyes roving over my chest, his hand stroking his dick, making me swallow roughly.

"So fucking pretty," he says around his unlit cigarette. My fingers move to the lighter and I pull it from my pocket and lean forward. His eyes never leave mine as he inhales.

Smoke billows around him, making him look so much hotter than he has any right to be. "Now your pants. I want to see that perfect ass while you suck my cock."

"I'm not sucking it," I manage to say, even though I'm already undoing my pants and kicking them off, leaving me only in tight lace panties. Off-white, sheer, completely see-through.

The corner of Luca's lips turns up as he eyes me. "On your knees, Vik. You've avoided me all day."

I turn my gaze to the right, looking out at the darkness outside when he reaches out and pulls me closer. My knees buckle and I fall to the floor, unable to hold it together any longer. My hands run up his thighs and tug his pants down further. Luca growls as he lifts his hips, and when his cock

and balls are free, I moan, falling on them, choking myself, gagging, but I don't let up. I'm fucking feral for it.

He doesn't touch me, just lets me show him how much I want him, despite saying I don't. He's proving me wrong just by existing.

"Such a good boy," he says, inhaling deeply, smoke filtering over me as he lets out a breath. I'm groaning loudly now, my cock leaking in my panties, my hole flexing around nothing. I want more. I want his fat cock in my ass. I want him to own me in every way.

"Such a slut for it. Listen to you moan."

I grow louder because of it, his filthy words. The way he undoes me.

"That's right. Make me come," he growls again and then groans low when I take him into my throat and swallow. He shifts his hips up in short bursts, and I find myself delirious, my vision whiting out as I feel him start to shake. It rolls through him, his cock lurching inside of me.

Moments later, he's unloading into my mouth, and I swallow all of it, gulping in deep breaths, trying to find my center once more.

It doesn't work. He doesn't give me time. He stubs out his cigarette and rights his pants, and then leans forward, wrenches my head up, and kisses me. Tongue, spit, and cum move from my mouth to his and he inhales it, making my mind spin with the force of the kiss.

Then it ends and I'm sinking back on my heels, panting as he watches me.

It's a long, drawn-out moment filled with just the sounds of our breathing.

Finally, he says, "Come here."

I can barely push myself up, my legs wobbling as I stand before him. His hands slide up the backs of my thighs, his fingers curling in the waistband of my underwear. Slowly, he drags the lace down, my cock arching toward his face.

It's too erotic, him being so close to me. I almost collapse.

"Look at it, so fucking wet," he whispers, his tongue peeking out and running across his top lip. My hands land on his shoulders to keep myself steady. I can't fucking move.

His fingers dig into the globes of my ass as his lips brush over the tip of me, and I feel my legs start to tremble, my mouth making the most obscene sound on the planet. I should be catapulted into outer space for this. It's embarrassing and wrong.

I can’t help it.

Luca chuckles and his tongue swipes out, licking my head and sweeping up the drop of precum sitting on the tip.

I gasp, my chin falling to my chest as I watch him, my entire body shaking with need.

He’s licking my dick, his tongue is on my cock.

I can’t breathe.

Those dark eyes meet mine and his mouth engulfs me. I cry out, my fingers digging into his shoulders as I try to hold my orgasm back. He’s not even taking much of me, just teasing me by sucking on the head, but it’s enough. The fact he’s even doing this has me moaning like the whore I am.

He pops off me and I wheeze, a deplorable sound.

“You taste like mine.”

His mouth goes back onto me, and he pulls me in a little deeper. I can do nothing but watch, another inch of my cock disappearing into his mouth, sitting heavily on his tongue as he tortures me. He knows exactly what he’s doing, what this means.

He knows and keeps doing it.

I’m shaking now, my arms and legs, even my teeth are clattering in my head as I groan loudly. Luca’s finger moves past my taint to my crack and drags down it.

When he finds my hole and presses against it, I cry out, my cock twitching between my legs and unloading into his mouth. Luca doesn’t move, just holds me inside of him as I come, letting my release hit his tongue in waves until I’m slouched over, my legs weak, my eyelids fluttering in shock.

Luca pulls off me, holding my release in his mouth before leaning over and spitting it out in the palm of his hand, staring at it. I try to find words, to apologize for coming without warning, but he just meets my gaze, his eyes bright.

“Come to bed, Vik.”

He stands up, wiping his hand on the side of his pants before pulling me forward. I stumble, trying to remember how to walk when he just sucked all my abilities out of my dick. He huffs a small laugh and then turns around and picks me up. My legs wind around his back and I tuck my face into his neck.

He’s so strong, carrying me like I weigh nothing.

This is bad, so detrimental to me, my heart, my soul.

He sets me in bed, strips down to nothing, and crawls in next to me, his hand on my stomach, his leg over mine. His lips are right near my ear and I can hear him breathing. It's gentle, calming, soothing.

After several long moments, his fingers drawing lines on my skin, he whispers, "Do you feel like mine now?"

I swallow and sink into him further, the answer coming out before I can stop it. It's a lie, the worst kind.

It sounds like one. Everyone can hear it. Even God is shaking his head right now.

"No."

He laughs lowly.

"Don't worry, kitten. That will change with time."

That one word ruined everything. Luca is even more infuriating now, always touching me, kissing me, making me crawl between his legs at night and suck him off before he touches me with his lips, his tongue, making me arch into him, making me beg.

I said *no*, and it's made him more resolute, more determined.

I didn't mean it, and he knows it.

He just wants me to admit it.

"Love the hickey on you," Tatum says as he wiggles into a tight pair of pants and turns to the side, examining himself in the full-length mirror. It's finally Saturday evening and we're getting ready for a night at the renovated club. Well, Tatum is getting ready; I'm just sitting here watching.

I refuse to dress as if this is some kind of date.

That's not what this is. No matter what Luca says.

Avoiding him and his stupid mouth and hands. The way those eyes glitter when he stares at me, the way he wets his lips as if he's imagining devouring me whole. My cock is hard in my pants all the time. It's in a perpetual state of this now. I'm fucking miserable.

"Shut up. It doesn't mean anything," I murmur, peeking at the bright purple spot just below my chin in the mirror. He did this last night, bit and sucked, grinding into me until I was coming loudly.

I need to stay away. I need to stop sleeping over at his place.

Jax is wondering where I am.

I can't tell anyone. No one knows what is happening between us.

"Seems he wanted to make a point about who you belong to. Anthony does it too. I have a bite mark on my ass cheek from two days ago."

Before I can respond to that, Bane appears through the secret door in the wall of the bedroom and bounces up to us, his hair in disarray, blood smeared across his cheek. He's grinning maniacally and leans down to press a kiss to my lips, but I shove him away.

"Not with blood on your face, Bane," I grumble, and he sighs.

"Fine. I can respect that." He eyes me and pokes at my chest. "You look good, Viktor. Love all the black. Very mysterious and form-fitting. Luca is going to drool when he sees you. Maybe unbutton those top buttons." He reaches out, trying to undo my shirt, but I swat his hand away. There are even more hickeys on my chest and I don't need either of them seeing the array lining my collarbone and around my nipples.

"Someone is in a bad mood. Oh hello, Tatum. Love the tight pants. I can see your penis perfectly."

"You can," Tatum says, arching his hips forward, and Bane giggles.

"I would like pants that tight and a see-through shirt."

"Didn't you both go shopping for tonight?" I ask and Bane shakes his head before nodding.

"Well, yes, but no. I couldn't find anything slutty enough and then I had to get back to work. I had a very busy project down below."

"But I found one after a few hours of browsing. Just look at this," Tatum says and then points to some clothes on the bed. "I know you wanted holes for the nipples, but I think the chest harness will be really hot on you."

"Oh," Bane gasps and then holds it up. "Help me put it on?"

"Sure, but first, shower. You have blood all over your face and who knows where else."

Bane glances in the mirror and sighs. "The last one was very messy. Sorry. I'll clean this up."

He moves to the bathroom, and Tatum sighs. "I wish Anthony wouldn't murder people so much."

"It needs to happen. Fear works better than communication," I explain.

Tatum peers over at me as he pulls a crop top over his head. "Do you know who's down there right now?"

“Nope. That’s Anthony’s business.”

He turns to look in the mirror and bats his eyelashes.

“Fair enough. I’m sure they deserve it. Whatever they did.” His eyes meet mine in the mirror. “Would you like to put on some eyeshadow? I have a color that would make your eyes pop.”

I stare at him. “No.”

“Luca would love it, I think.”

“Luca can fuck off.”

I don’t mean that. I don’t want him to fuck off. I want him to fuck me. But I won’t admit it. It’s been fifteen years of pining, of imagining what it would be like for him to own me, and now that I have him, I’m feeling… I’m feeling some kind of way about it.

I don’t trust that I’m not just a toy, something for him to play with because he’s bored.

I don’t know what to feel. I don’t know anything anymore.

“This love-hate thing you both have for each other is very hot,” Tatum says and then waggles his eyebrows at me.

“It’s not love. It’s hate. Pure and simple.”

“Even better,” he replies with a grin. He continues getting ready and then pouts so prettily at me that I cave, letting him apply some smokey eyeshadow on my eyelids and some pink gloss on my lips. By the time I’m done getting a mini-makeover, Bane strides out of the bathroom completely naked.

I blink at him and then squeeze my eyes shut.

I’ve never seen him nude before. His skin is almost blindingly bright white and there are scars on his arms and legs, some deep and long, others just short and surface-level. I’m not sure if those are self-inflicted or a hazard of the job.

“I’m ready to be fabulous,” he says, striding over to us. “I’ve decided to take after you, Viktor, and get some lace panties.”

He holds them up and steps into them, almost toppling over as he wiggles them over his damp skin.

They’re a dark blood-red and he turns this way and that, staring at himself in the mirror.

He has a nice ass, I’ll give him that.

“Snap a few pics. I’m going to send this to Georgiy.”

“Hasn’t he been ignoring you since you came home from visiting Angel?” Tatum asks.

“Yes, well, he can’t ignore me forever. And I didn’t come home of my own free will. They shipped me home. In a box. It was very rude. Now get a good angle. I spent a lot of money on these panties.”

He arches his ass out and then hands Tatum his phone. As Tatum snaps pictures, I pull mine out and stare down at the screen.

Luca has messaged me a few times today and I’ve left him on read, not responding for a slew of reasons.

Mainly my pride.

The way I act when I’m around him. It’s insufferable, degrading, and totally who I am deep down.

He’s eating it up.

LUCA:

Almost ready for tonight?

I can’t wait to see which slut panties you’re wearing.

My perfect toy.

I scowl and, at the same time, bite my bottom lip, feeling those flutters through my stomach. It’s harmful to my mental health and yet, I won’t stop it.

“Oh, a toy,” Bane exclaims, looking over my shoulder, snooping. “Is that what you are? How exciting.”

I shut my phone off and glower at him. “Shut up, Bane.”

“I can’t do that. It’s too hard.”

His phone pings and he glances down at it gleefully. “Oh, it’s Georgiy. Oh, he’s not happy with me. I think that’s what this message means.”

He wiggles around and bounces on his feet.

“What did he say?” Tatum asks, peering over his shoulder. The two of them are silent as they read and then squeal.

“Do you really think he’ll get on a plane?” Tatum asks.

“I hope so. I have been a very bad boy.”

They grin at each other and I take my leave. The two of them can get ready together without me. I’m done anyway.

As I make my way down the stairs, I wander around, not looking for Luca—really I wasn’t—but finding him in Anthony’s office. The two are sitting at his desk, feet kicked up, drinking whiskey from crystal tumblers.

When I stand in the doorway, Luca's eyes move to me and stay there. I can't move. The way he looks at me is so predatory and sensual, I start to melt from the force of it. I think my feet have disappeared into the floor.

"There you are, pretty boy. Come here," he says softly, and I huff as my cock hardens in my pants. Oh, who am I kidding? It's been hard this whole time. Now it's just throbbing.

Anthony chuckles as I make my way over to Luca, my eyes following the slant of his jaw, the way his Adam's apple bobs, the tattoos peeking up over the top of his shirt.

He looks hot and he knows it.

He places his legs on the ground and points to his lap. "Sit that ass right here."

I peer over at Anthony, who is grinning from behind his glass of whiskey. *Fuck him too*, I think as I huff and lower myself onto Luca's lap. I want him to know I hate this. This is terrible and awful.

All the bad things.

It all goes ignored on his end. His hands wind around my stomach, pulling me closer to him, his face tucking into my neck and his teeth gently sinking into my skin.

"Isn't he pretty, Anthony?" he asks, and Anthony, thankfully, says nothing.

I couldn't cope with the embarrassment of my boss— and honestly, a man more like a father than anything—answering.

Luca growls low under his breath and then whispers in my ear. "You put on makeup for me."

"I didn't," I murmur. "Tatum held me down and non-consensually applied it."

"I like it."

I huff and feel my cheeks heating.

"Don't get used to it," I add, and he chuckles but doesn't respond.

Fine. Good riddance.

"So, how is Luca treating you?" Anthony asks, his eyes sparkling.

I huff and roll my eyes. "Terribly."

Anthony arches an eyebrow. "Is he really? Because you know I said I'd protect you."

"He doesn't need protecting from me," Luca huffs.

“You know you can come to me, Viktor,” Anthony continues, ignoring Luca entirely. “I know what a shit Luca can be.”

My heart swells at this, my eyes stinging. He said something similar when he took me in all those years ago.

I’m here for you. I’m on your side.

“I’ll let you know.”

“Just so you know, I am treating him exactly the way he wants to be treated.”

My cheeks flame as his fingers slip under my shirt slightly, toying with my skin.

“I’d rather not hear the sordid details.”

“I’m not giving them. Just that he’s well-looked-after. The romance isn’t dead after all.”

“What romance?” I ask, eyeing him over my shoulder. “There’s nothing romantic about this.”

Luca makes a face, his fingers pinching my skin. “I give you flowers.”

“One flower. Once a year.”

“It’s more than I’ve ever given anyone before.”

Anthony huffs a small laugh behind the desk. “That’s true. Laura always wanted them and he refused. Count your blessings, Viktor. One flower is one more than anyone else received.”

My eyes lower to the ground, to the intricately woven pattern by my feet.

“And we have a date, don’t forget, kitten.”

“It’s not a date.”

“It is.”

Before our banter can continue, Tatum and Bane make an appearance, Teddy in tow. Anthony’s gaze drifts over to his man and his lips turn up at the corners.

I’ve never seen him this happy before.

I’m fucking glad he has Tatum.

“So, what do you think?” Tatum asks, turning around and showing Anthony his ass. He wiggles it slightly, and Anthony arches an eyebrow.

Bane slaps it roughly and unexpectedly, my eyebrows rising when Anthony glowers at him.

“Sorry, got excited,” Bane murmurs, looking sheepish. “Please don’t cut off my hands. I need them for my job and for my penis.”

“No one is cutting off anything. Anthony is fine. Aren’t you? Are we all ready to go?” Tatum asks, and Anthony nods, standing up. He finishes his drink and sets it on the table, pulling Tatum into his chest and kissing the top of his head.

“Are you sure security is tight?” Anthony asks Luca.

“I’m positive.”

Luca’s hands tighten on me a moment before he lets me go, and we meander out into the foyer. Shoes and jackets are put on before a few other guards join us, Jax being one of them.

He sees me standing there and his eyebrows meet his hairline in surprise.

He didn’t expect me to be all dolled up.

I wish I’d never let Tatum convince me to do this.

No, he didn’t convince me. It was non-consensual makeup.

Luca’s hand lands on the back of my neck, and I lean into his touch a moment before pulling away.

I need to focus, maintain my composure, and I can’t do that when he’s touching me.

We all pile into the SUVs, Jax and Teddy with Tatum and Anthony, while I drive Bane and Luca to the club. As I navigate the highways, Bane sits in the middle seat in the middle row, his body tilted forward, chattering nonstop.

“So, I am very excited about the club tonight. I haven’t had my dancing shoes on in ages.”

“Since when have you ever danced?”

“I watch videos and practice. The people in the basement think I’m very good.”

“They only say that because you’re about to murder them,” I reply, and Bane gasps.

“No! I’m very good. They wouldn’t lie.”

Luca huffs a laugh and reaches over, touching my thigh. He leaves his hand there, his thumb stroking absently back and forth, driving me wild.

“You know who also said I was a good dancer? Henry, the little shit. He gave me pointers and everything.”

His bottom lip juts out, his fingers digging into the leather of the middle console.

“He had very good moves. In bed and out.”

“Should you be thinking of him now?” Luca asks. “It could ruin your night.”

“I want to think of him. Because if I see him tonight, I will have the anger of a thousand suns. I will incinerate him.”

“What was so good about Henry, anyway?” I ask, and Luca squeezes my thigh.

“Should we really be doing this?” he asks lowly.

“He started it.”

Bane is murmuring to himself, his nails digging deeper into the console, carving out little white lines as he goes.

“He was fun and sexy and good in bed. That’s all. I didn’t like him that much.”

“We should change the subject,” Luca says, grabbing onto Bane’s hand and pulling it off the leather. Bane slots his hand in Luca’s and holds on, sighing happily.

“Don’t be jealous,” Bane says after a moment. “Holding hands with Luca isn’t a big deal.”

“I’m not jealous. I don’t care.”

“You care,” Luca replies, and I roll my eyes. Because I do. He’s never done this with me. Irrational and annoying jealousy surges through me. The sheer number of times younger me had wished he’d do this to me, the dopey daydreams I’d had while watching him.

But I don’t want him to hold my hand. I really don’t.

When I finally park and step out onto the wet pavement, Luca strides over to me and the hand that was clasping Bane’s slips into mine.

I don’t like this at all. I hate it so much that my fingers tighten around his and my heart pitter-patters.

“Don’t worry, kitten. I know what you want. I can be romantic.”

His thumb smooths over the back of my hand and I purse my lips, forcing myself not to smile. Because it is romantic.

“Wow, that line is insane,” Tatum gasps, eyeing the queue that is nearly wrapped around the building.

“It’s a good opening night,” Anthony says and then glances over at Luca. “Well done.”

“You know me and my investments. I don’t fuck around,” Luca replies. “It seems people missed this place. Which is good for our pockets.”

“Very good,” Anthony says with a sly grin. The drugs that are handed out tonight are from Anthony, so I know he’s making a profit as well. Not that he’d say that out loud, but it’s how the two of them operate as partners. Luca manages the businesses and Anthony makes sure the customers are plied with designer drugs.

As we walk up to the bouncers guarding the entrance, they nod at us, letting us in seamlessly. We hear jeers from the line wrapping around the building, but they go ignored.

And I don’t notice much at all because Luca doesn’t let go of my hand as we walk through the crowd of people toward the VIP lounge. My eyes move up and I see naked dancers on small platforms above the dance floor. Servers float around the space, wearing sheer lingerie and exaggerated makeup, offering people drinks and other things.

Illegal things.

My mouth waters. Perhaps I should take something to help me get through the night. If Luca keeps holding my hand like this, I may need something to help me relax.

“This is amazing. Even better than before,” Tatum says and then nudges me. “Right, Viktor?”

I don’t want to think about last time. When Anthony found out I had driven Tatum here, he almost executed me. And then Luca got caught in a fire, and I had to save his ass. Again.

He’d been so comatose during the rescue that I punched his face to snap him out of it. It worked.

Perhaps I should have done the same thing the other night when he accidentally set the rug on fire. But I wouldn’t have. Things are so different than they were. The night of the warehouse fire, dragging him from the flames, I’d punched him out of anger and fear.

The fear of never seeing him again.

It was enough to have me cocking my fist back and planting it right on his eye.

Luca’s hand slips from mine, and I watch as he moves toward Alina, that beautiful woman from before. I can’t even dislike her. She’s so nice. She smiles at him widely, and he leans forward, pressing a kiss to her cheek. Something ugly rears its head as my stomach clenches. I know what this is. I’ve felt it a thousand times before.

As Alina and Luca chat, her eyes flash to mine. She smiles softly at me, obviously reading the jealousy on my face before striding over and pulling me into a long hug.

“Hello there.”

I offer her a small sheepish nod, my cheeks stained red as she pulls away and moves back to Luca, whispering something in his ear.

I hate how close she is to him. Hate that they may have been a thing once upon a time. Not that I’ll ever know. I don’t want to. Not really. I’m sure Luca’s past is riddled with beautiful women, and I don’t need to be reminded that I’m not one.

When we all arrive at the VIP section, the bouncers let us in without a word. As we walk up the steps, we see Sabrina is already here, a drink in her hand.

“You made it,” she says with a grin, her painted lips looking flawless in the dim light.

“How’s everything going?” Luca asks.

“Everything is going very well. My girls and boys have been *very busy*.”

“Good to hear that,” Luca replies as Alina slips her arm through Luca’s.

“And who is this?” Alina asks, interest in her eyes.

“Sabrina Nightingale. A friend of ours. Sabrina, this is Alina.”

“Nice to meet you,” she greets, her eyes twinkling.

As the two of them begin speaking with Sabrina, Tatum and Bane move toward the bar with Teddy and Jax in tow. This leaves me with Anthony, who is eyeing me curiously.

“Alright, Viktor. I think this calls for a drink,” he says, and I purse my lips. I shouldn’t drink. Not around Luca, but I also need it.

Like I said earlier, I need something to help me relax. I’m in knots.

Anthony must read this on my face because he disappears and returns with two filled shot glasses.

“Vodka,” he says and then throws it back. I do the same, swallowing down the high-shelf liquid without any trouble.

When our eyes meet, Anthony nods toward a standing table in the corner of the room. Everyone else is preoccupied with other things and so I follow him.

I don’t know what he wants from me, but he is my boss and the man I look up to in so many ways. His hands fold on the table before us, and I

stare down at them.

“Remember when you were eighteen and you stole liquor from my locked cabinet?”

I snort a laugh. “It wasn’t that good of a lock.”

“It was meant to keep kids out.”

“Well, it didn’t keep me out.”

“And you suffered for it. Doc lost several nights’ sleep watching over you, as did I.”

I huff and look at him. “You didn’t need to do that.”

“I know, but you were a favorite. I didn’t want you to die.”

My chest constricts at that. I’ve always known he had a soft spot for me, but we never talk about it. Never utter the words. Perhaps his being with Tatum is changing something in him, making him more vulnerable.

I’m not sure that’s a good thing in this business.

“But really, Viktor, how are things?” he asks, his brows set in concern.

My gaze flicks up to him, and he cocks his head. He’s been like a father to me in so many ways, but this is still the mob, and I have my place.

I don’t have these kinds of conversations with him often.

“Fine.”

“And with Luca?”

I huff and glance away.

“You’ve had a crush on him for years.”

“I have not.”

He chuckles, and a moment later our shot glasses are refilled. “You have. I saw the way you’d watch him. You were enamored.”

I need that shot now. I gulp it down and run the back of my hand over my mouth. My gaze turns toward Luca, who is still chatting with Sabrina and Alina.

The three of them get on well.

The thought sours my stomach.

“Leave the bottle,” Anthony calls to the server, and a moment later, the vodka sits between us like a monument.

Anthony refills my glass, and I let my finger trace the rim.

“I might have been infatuated when I was younger, but I realize now that I don’t know anything about him,” I finally admit. “It’s hard to know him.”

“It is. He doesn’t open up to many. He’s had a rough life.”

“So have we.”

Anthony nods and meets my gaze. “Can I tell you something?” He doesn’t wait for me to answer. “I haven’t seen him this content since Laura. You’re important to him.”

“I’m nothing more than a piece in some game he’s got going.”

“You’re more than that. I can see it in his eyes.” He pauses and then runs a thumb over his bottom lip. “Do you know how Luca and I met?”

The question is so surprising that I just blink at him. “No.”

“We met when he was eighteen and I was a couple of years older. At university. We were inseparable.”

“I didn’t know he went to college,” I say, and Anthony chuckles.

“We both did. Business majors. We learned enough to keep these various businesses we have running successfully. Luca went on for his MBA.”

“Fuck, don’t make me impressed with him,” I mumble.

“He is impressive. He’s been a formative part of my life and business. He’s saved my life more times than I can count. He was there with me when the boys were born and when Laura died. I know this man I cherish is letting you in. Do not hurt him, Viktor. He’s fragile.”

I snort at that, and Anthony points to my still-full shot glass.

“He is. When I met him, he put on a front that he was strong and indestructible, but deep down he’s still that traumatized little boy. Did he tell you what happened to him, to his family?”

I swallow the liquid and nod. “I know about the fire, about the murders.”

“Well, then you know you and him have similar pasts, different traumas, but trauma all the same. I think you two can help one another heal.”

“Mine is nothing like his. You know it.”

“I know, but it’s just as bad. Different, but the same.”

I wince and feel dread well up inside of me. It happens whenever I think about it for too long. The things that happened to me when I was younger, the abuse, the beatings. I would say no, beg for it to end, but it only ended in harder beatings.

It was better to stay silent and just take it. To get it over with as fast as possible.

“What happened to him after the fire?” I ask, wanting to divert this conversation back to Luca. Anthony seems chatty tonight and I want to ply

him for any and all information I can.

I don’t know if Luca would tell me this on his own.

“He was sent to live with his aunt and uncle out in the Midwest. It was secluded and quiet. He was able to heal there, to find his way back to the living. Not all the way, but some of it.”

“And he told you all of this?”

“Yes. And some of it came from Laura. He told her too. We shared…a lot.”

I watch Anthony as he sighs and pours us both another drink.

“He loved her, cared for her in many ways that I couldn’t. When she died, he was devastated.”

I can’t even imagine losing someone you love. I’ve never loved anyone in my entire life. Anthony is the closest person on Earth who ever deserved it.

“It’s amazing what a good partner can do to heal someone broken.”

“I’m not healing anyone.”

“It’s a lot to ask, but I can see it in his eyes. He’s happy when you’re around. And that, in itself, heals many wounds.”

The two of us turn at the same time and find Luca watching us with narrowed eyes. He has to know we’re discussing him. He must see it on my face because he stands up and moves toward me, the room spinning as he approaches. I don’t know if this is the alcohol or just him.

He does things to me, terrible things.

“What are you talking about all alone over here?” he asks, eyeing Anthony and then me.

I roll my lips between my teeth and refuse to say a thing.

“I was telling him all about you,” Anthony replies, and Luca glowers at him.

“Those aren’t your secrets to tell.”

“They aren’t, but I did it anyway.”

Luca’s jaw clicks and his gaze moves over to me.

“What did he tell you?”

“Nothing much,” I manage to say before he pushes into my space, his nose hitting mine, his fingers cupping the back of my neck. I shiver against him and arch into his touch, the alcohol making me sway into him.

“How much have you had to drink? We just got here.”

“You were ignoring me.”

Luca’s grip tightens on me, and I whimper.

“I was conducting business.”

“You said this was a date.”

His eyes bore into mine and his lips curl up. “You said no. You told me it wasn’t and now it is?”

I don’t reply to that, just twist my hands into his shirt and hold onto him tightly.

“It doesn’t matter,” I mumble.

“It does. Anthony told you things about me. Now I want something in return.”

His lips slant over mine, his tongue plunging into my mouth, making me moan before drawing back.

“What do you want?” I ask.

“I want you to act like you’re mine. The entire night.”

I stare up at him, still tasting him on my tongue.

“I can’t do that.”

His hands slide down and grab my ass. “You can and you will.”

I glower at him, knowing I won’t win this, so I give in. Just for tonight, I give in.

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11

LUCA

Viktor said he couldn't act like he was mine, but he is. He's all over me, and I can't stop the way my chest expands from it. The way he leans into me, touches me, pulls me down for desperate kisses. Everything about him screams that I own him. From the way he tastes to the way he smells. To the way his body is pinned against mine.

But is this all pretend? Is he proving a point? I don't know. It could be the alcohol he had with Anthony or it could just be him letting loose. Letting me experience what it is to be his.

For him to be mine.

I wrap my hands around his waist and pull him into me as we move toward the back rooms. We spent far too much time in the VIP rooms, chatting with Bane and Tatum ad nauseam.

So after another drink and a cigarette, Viktor leaned over to me and whispered that he wanted to see the rooms I had built, the ones made for filthy things. He wants to see what's inside.

"You excited, kitten?" I ask, my lips at his ear as the bouncer lets us into the dark hallway that leads to the rooms. It's exclusive to certain members, the ones who pay handsomely for it and are bound by silence.

I may have taken notes after purchasing Eden.

Everyone back here has signed an NDA.

As we move, his body pressed against mine, we hear moans, the slap of skin against skin, and Viktor's hand snakes down my abdomen, pulling my

shirt from my pants and trailing his fingers across my skin. His nose hits my neck and he inhales, breathing me in. He has to be fucking with me.

I know it will end as soon as we step out of this club, when this charade is over, but fuck it.

I let it happen all the same.

“You like this?” I ask, and when he doesn’t answer right away, I add, “I bet you do. I bet your cock is hard.”

He groans and arches into my palm as I stroke his stiff length over his black jeans.

He didn’t dress up for me. I know he was proving a point when I asked him to come with me to the club opening, but I saw the makeup on his pretty eyes. I want to watch it melt down his cheeks as I wreck him.

The things I want to do to his beautiful face.

“It’s so dark,” he whispers in my ear as I continue to stroke him.

“All the better to hide with,” I reply, glancing around. The lights are dim to make it difficult to see anything clearly. It’s all just shapes and shadows as we come to a stop in front of one of the viewing windows.

The room reminds me of when Viktor crawled to me. The anger on his face that day made my cock twitch in my pants, a sign of things to come. Now it’s hard and hungry. It wants more than it’s being offered. It wants it all.

Viktor’s hands slip from my stomach as he steps toward the window, watching as a slender man gets spit-roasted by two burly guys.

Viktor’s hands spread on the windowsill as he leans forward, his ass pushing into my groin as I take my place behind him.

My fingers twist in the waistband of his pants. I could peel them down and push inside of him.

He’d let me. He’d want it. I bet he came prepped and ready.

I shift closer, pulling his back to my chest and dragging my other hand up to his neck. It’s my favorite part of him. One of them at least. I feel his Adam’s apple bob against my palm and feel the vibration of a groan hit my skin.

“What is it you want, pretty boy?” I ask as I slide two fingers into his mouth.

He sucks on them slowly, his tongue twisting around them, leaning into my body as he does.

I hold him up, feeling the wet pressure against my fingers and knowing that could be my cock.

The obsession I have with him is unreal.

His eyes never leave the men in front of us as I fuck his mouth faster.

“You do know already that I won’t share,” I say. “You let another man touch you and I’ll skin them alive. You’re mine. All mine.”

My tongue slides up his neck and I bite down on his jaw, releasing a strangled cry. I could pull him into a room right now and bend him over, could stretch that hole open with my cock and make him scream.

“You like that, hm? Me owning you? I bet you’d let me put you on a leash and make you crawl. Like the dog you are.”

He whimpers, and I bite at his earlobe.

“Say it, Vik. Tell me who you belong to, like a good little boy.”

My fingers slip from his mouth, and he blinks over at me. His spit-slick lips move as he rasps, “Yours.”

I step away from him, and he turns to look at me, confusion lining his face.

“Come on,” I say, grabbing his hand and pulling him forward. He stumbles behind me, past two women, one on her knees, the other leaning against the wall and moaning.

The sounds of sex are everywhere, permeating the spaces between the cracks in the walls and ceiling. But then again, that’s why I created this. For this purpose.

Seems the clientele are enjoying themselves. Sabrina’s employees are working hard.

The money I’ll get from this. The way our businesses will thrive.

And yet none of it seems to matter because Viktor is here. Owning him will be worth so much more than all of this.

As I step forward, guiding him to the empty room on my left, several people exit the door to my right. By the way they move, I can tell they’re high on drugs and drunk on sex.

Their staggering movements cause them to fall into us and it breaks my contact with Viktor. Within seconds, he’s jostled away from me. Agitation slides through me as I crane my head to find him, but he’s not there. The group of people who stumbled out have carried him away.

I can’t even see him, and he hasn’t made his way back to me.

What the fuck?

I inhale sharply and something familiar wafts over me, the faint scent of gasoline. That, coupled with the dark hallway, makes something inside of me flip sideways. I know it could all be reasoned away, but at this moment, I can't adhere to logic. At this moment, I'm just that little boy again.

Trapped.

My breath catches and I push forward, not sure what's happening but feeling that tingle of panic at the base of my neck.

It's the same dread that seeped into me when I saw those men all those years ago on my front porch, ski masks covering their faces, gas cans in one hand, guns in the other.

I'll never forget those eyes. They were hollow, dead.

They felt nothing as they burned my family.

The scent of burning wood, flesh.

Everything suddenly narrows.

I can almost feel the fire rushing toward me, my body so hot it hurts.

My mind spins and I feel faint.

My body sags against the wall and I gulp down long breaths.

Where is he?

Where the fuck is he?

He's fine. He's fine.

Someone knocks into me roughly, their elbow digging into my skin, and I snap upright, pain jolting through my abdomen. I gasp and pull in a breath, grabbing my gun at my back and pushing forward.

Panic can come later.

I won't let myself go out like this. Or him.

Not him.

My brothers' faces, eyes unseeing, blood spurting from their gunshot wounds appear in my mind, and I move faster.

I nearly run onto the dance floor, the space pulsing with people and a low, sultry beat.

My eyes scan over the crowd writhing before me, lights flashing, but I can't find him.

Where the fuck is he?

My heart is thumping in my ears and my hands are trembling.

And then all of a sudden, I see him, his head thrown back, his hips moving with the beat of the music. He's sweating, drops rolling down his temples, his shirt rucked up around his waist.

I shake my head, clearing my mind of the swirling, anxious thoughts.

He's alive. He's fine. Everything is fine.

My gaze narrows and I push forward, moving everyone out of the way as I approach. He sees me, his pupils blown out, his cheeks flushed, and he smiles sweetly at me. Without a care in the world.

"Baby," he mouths and presses into my chest, making my heart race. His fingers curl into my hair and his lips hit my cheek.

I can't help but wrap him up against me, tucking my face into his neck and inhaling.

Fuck. What the hell happened back there? Why is he on the dance floor and not with me? Was I panicking for that long? I must have been. I must have been out of it far longer than I thought. And Viktor, he's too drunk to think clearly.

Fucking Anthony. He should know better than to ply him with shit.

"I'm your baby now?" I murmur, my lips hitting the lobe of his ear as I breathe in the salty scent of him.

"Mhm," he says as he slides his leg between my thighs and grinds. The feel of him against me has my cock hardening, my chest swelling in excitement.

Then I notice the beat of his heart against my palm. It's too fast, and the weird way he's breathing is the same.

My fingers move to the pulse in his neck, and I feel the erratic pounding there, too.

"Vik, did you take something?"

"Sure did."

"What the fuck did you take?"

His head is resting on my shoulder now, and I'm hugging him to me. With a shake, he straightens and his eyes meet mine.

"Just some E."

"Some? How many?"

He wets his lips and then shrugs. "Few."

"Are you sure it was fucking E?" I ask, and he nods, his lashes fluttering, before he shakes his head.

"Dunno. Think so."

"Shit. You think so? Who gave it to you? If it was from Anthony's supply, it would have come from the servers."

“Someone else. I don’t know. Funny…guess he kinda looked like Henry?” he slurs, his body trembling now.

Henry? Fucking, fuck. He’s not supposed to be here. Does he have a goddamn death wish? Some kind of vendetta? “What color were the pills?”

“Dunno. Red?”

“You fucking took shit from a random without checking? Goddamnit, Vik.”

“Had to make it through the night with you. Needed to survive. Like you too much.”

My arm wraps around him, and I try to carry him to the exit, my hand fumbling with my phone. But it’s hard. Vik is big, almost overbearing when he’s sagging and limp like this, and it doesn’t help that the crowd seems to surge around us at that exact moment, jostling us endlessly.

Suddenly, in my periphery, I see Tatum, Bane, and Teddy on the dance floor, and I stagger toward them, Vik stumbling beside me.

“Hey!” Tatum says with a grin, Bane wiggling his ass next to him. The two of them look like they’re having a great time, but Teddy, not so much. He looks worried, his eyes meeting mine before shifting to Viktor, who is completely out of it now.

“I need you to call Doc. Now!” I shout, and Teddy is suddenly next to me, picking up a sagging Viktor in his arms and cradling him to his chest. Thank fuck he’s so strong.

Tatum and Bane freeze for just a moment, taking a second to process all of it, before shooting into action.

Before I know it, I’m in the car with Jax and Bane and we’re flying down the highway toward the estate, Doc waiting on standby.

He better not have fucking taken anything that is going to kill him. It better not have been that fucking drug, Pink.

“Did he really say Henry was there?” Bane asks, turning around from the front seat and staring at me.

“Yeah, but who fucking knows? Vik was incoherent at that point. There’s no way Henry would have shown up at my club. Unless he had a death wish.”

“The bouncers knew not to let him in, right?” Bane asks, and I nod.

“They did. They know what he looks like. We’re all searching for him, Bane. It couldn’t have been him.”

I say that even though I'm not certain, even though I'm second-guessing everything. Could it have been him? Does he have an in with one of the bouncers?

"I'm worried though," he says, and then crawls into the backseat with me and Vik, wrapping his arms around me.

"I'm sorry. I'm such a cumslut. I shouldn't have ever let him fuck me. Tatum lost a finger because of him and now Viktor is going to die."

"He's not going to die," I hiss, but I can tell Vik is not okay.

His breathing is erratic and his skin is clammy. He doesn't look well at all. Fuck, is this all my fault? If I hadn't been so consumed by my past, by the panic, I could have found him sooner, could have protected him. I don't have time to stew on it for long because a moment later, Jax pulls into the driveway and then we're out, dragging Viktor to where Doc is waiting.

"You think it's Pink?" Doc asks, his voice clipped and serious.

"No idea, but maybe. Fuck, I've never seen him like this."

"Alright, let's get him into the room. I'll get him on an IV and monitor him."

Jax and I help bring him inside, and I situate him on a bed.

"Will he be okay?" I ask gruffly, trying to keep myself from cracking wide open.

Doc eyes me from behind his glasses, pulling on some latex gloves.

"Yes, I'll make sure of it. You got him here quickly. Would you like to stay in here while I work?"

I nod and lower myself into an overstuffed chair as Doc inserts the IV into his arm and places a monitor on his finger. The beeping infiltrates the room just as the rain starts to come down in droves and thunder rolls across the sky.

It's going to be a long fucking night.

I don't sleep that night, watching as Viktor lies in bed, the beep of the machine monitoring his heart the only balm for my anxiety. The thunder cracking and lightning rolling across the sky make this seem far more ominous than it probably is.

Viktor is stable. He's fine. The weather outside isn't a sign of things to come.

Anthony makes an appearance in the early morning and lowers himself next to me, offering me a bottle of water.

"I'm too old for this shit," he murmurs, and I nod, opening the water and taking a long swig.

"Me too. Why did we get involved with men half our age?"

"Fuck if I know. They're addicting, I guess."

He leans his head back. "We have someone looking at the footage from the club. We'll find out if it was Henry."

The two of us turn our gaze to the monitor.

"And Doc says he's fine. He's just sleeping it off. He took a blood sample and will let us know what the results are."

"Yeah," I murmur, still not completely sure what the fuck to do. Doc has never been wrong before, but this entire thing shaved a few years off my life.

"Viktor usually isn't this irresponsible," Anthony says, and I eye him.

"He is. He's a self-destructive asshole."

"Seems you're both a great fit, then. How is the underground fighting going, by the way?"

I huff a small laugh and lift my water bottle in a salute. "Touché."

We're silent a moment and then, without looking at my best friend, I ask, "Tell me about him, Anthony. The bad shit. I need to know it all."

Anthony is quiet for a moment and then sighs. "He's had a rough go of it. He wasn't born into this life like us. He was just unlucky enough to meet me."

"He doesn't regret it."

"He doesn't. He's proven to be very loyal, despite being raised with parents like his. As unfaithful and unloyal as they come."

"He told me some about his parents."

"Yes, and they're dead now."

I nod.

We're silent for another beat and then Anthony shifts in his chair, his voice lowering. "They beat him, badly. They'd throw drug-fueled parties, and their friends—high as fucking kites—would be given permission to hurt him as well. I found one of them several years ago, gave him to Bane. He confessed to all of it."

“What did he say?”

“He told me the names of the people who’d show up at the trailer. How they used Viktor like a punching bag, how he’d try to hide, but they’d find him, drag him out, punch and kick him. It was a game to them. Cat and mouse.”

This makes my chest constrict, and I feel my hand clenching the water bottle far too tightly. “Where are they now?” I grind out.

“Underneath us.”

I lean my head back and let out a long breath. “Thank you.”

“It was my pleasure.”

“Does Viktor know you killed them all?”

“No, but he doesn’t need to know. All he knows is they’ll never hurt him again. I made sure of that.”

I nod and sip at my water, listening to his heartbeat through that dark screen. It’s a balm for my aching chest, the only thing keeping me still.

“What about the foster parents?” I ask after another moment of silence.

“Mm. They’re gone too. When I met Viktor, he was traumatized, quiet and ashamed. But after a few years, he opened up about what happened. One of the dads was a creep. I made sure to cut off his cock before shoving it down his throat.”

That soothes something inside of me.

“Good to hear.”

“It was quite nice to watch.”

Our eyes turn back to Viktor, and Anthony reaches out and squeezes my knee.

“He’s damaged, but so are we. He needs someone to fight for him, to care for him, to be gentle when he needs it.”

I think of the way I’ve fucked with him, the way I’ve driven my cock down his throat, the dirty things I’ve said, and guilt wells up within me.

He liked it though, I tell myself. He likes it like that.

“I can be gentle.”

“Can you? Sometimes I think we weren’t made like that. That it was bred out of us.”

“You’re gentle with Tatum. You were gentle with Laura. Your sons.”

“I know.”

I sit with that a moment, and then Anthony adds, “You were gentle with Laura as well.”

“She deserved it.”

“So does Viktor.”

“I know.”

I lean my head back and my chest expands as I take a deep breath, letting all these thoughts filter through my mind. The abuse Viktor went through, the way he copes with it now. The way I should treat him moving forward. Owning him and yet being gentle. Rough when he begs and soft when he needs it.

“How did this all start between you two?” Anthony asks.

He’s staring at me intently, and I know I’m going to have to give him something.

“I saw him at a club three years ago. Things happened afterward. Things I won’t talk about. Things only he and I know. But I tried to forget and move on.”

“What the fuck happened? What did you do?”

“I was an asshole.”

The way he’d taken me, his body and heart opening up for me. Fuck. I should have known better than to mess with someone as lethal as him.

Now he’s slithered under my skin, and I’m a mess.

More than usual. I’m a fucking disaster.

“He’s been in love with you forever. Don’t fuck this up,” Anthony says quietly.

Those words sit heavily on my chest and after another hour of idle chatting, Bane appears, his hair mussed, his lips swollen, blood on his torso.

“Where the fuck have you been?” I ask.

“I went back. Gave three blow jobs and someone told me it *was* a guy named Henry at the club. I also may have killed someone.”

“Jesus, Bane,” Anthony grunts as he stands up and moves toward him.

“I know. I’m sorry but they were very rude and insulted you and Tatum. They had to die.”

“Do we need to do a cleanup?”

He shakes his head. “No. I have it taken care of.”

“Are you sure?”

“One hundred percent.” He sighs and runs a hand through his hair, making it stand up at odd angles. “But it was Henry, Boss. *Henry*. What do we do?”

“Did you find him?”

“No, but security is scouring the footage to see if we can get a lead on what he’s driving or who he’s with or where the fuck he went!”

“I know, and right now that’s all we can do,” Anthony says calmly.

Bane peers over at Viktor and his face falls. “Will he be okay? Shit, this is all my fault.” He looks like he’s going to cry. Anthony lays a hand on his shoulder, and Bane peers up at him. “And Georgiy didn’t fly down to see me like he threatened.”

He sniffles at that admission, his heart clearly bruised and broken.

Anthony removes his hand and then nods toward the door. “Let’s get you something to eat. You need something in your stomach besides cum.”

Bane sniffles and moves out of the room, leaving me alone with Viktor. I stare at him from my seat across the room and then push myself up. I approach his bed and look at his slumbering form.

“Fucking wake up, Vik,” I whisper, my fingers reaching out and touching his. He’s warm and alive, and I curl my hand around his. But he doesn’t do what I’ve demanded, so I’m left to wait.

“Oh my god, they’re so cute,” a giggling whisper wakes me, pulling me from my dreams.

Ones with fire and Vik and smoke.

My eyelids fly open and I see Tatum and Teddy standing in the doorway, Tatum grinning happily while Teddy watches on.

I realize that they’ve caught me in Viktor’s bed, my body wrapped around his. Even in a drug-induced coma, he manages to lie akimbo. As I come to, I feel Viktor start moving as well, his body sliding against mine, and relief filters through me. And with it comes anger.

Fucking Viktor. Taking shit in a club from someone he doesn’t know, doesn’t trust.

Someone who was most likely Henry, a man who is hellbent on ruining us.

I push myself upright and stare down at him, his flushed cheeks, his droopy eyes. He’s never been more beautiful than at this moment. Alive and awake.

“What happened?” he rasps when he takes in the bed and the IV in his arm.

“You fucking took drugs you shouldn’t have and passed out. You could have fucking died.”

My words are gruff and stiff. I want to strangle him and kiss him. I want to make him beg for forgiveness.

He blinks at me, confusion marring his handsome features, and then he swallows. “Oh. Yeah.”

“That’s all you have to say about it?”

My voice is clearly angry, and Viktor just stares up at me. “Why are you yelling at me?”

“You could have fucking *died*,” I repeat.

My heart is racing now, and I suddenly feel something ugly well up inside of me, something dangerous. I peel myself away from him and out of bed, standing up and adjusting my rumpled shirt.

“I take drugs, Luca. It’s not all the time, but it’s not a big deal.”

“But it is when you take it from *Henry*.”

Viktor freezes and runs his hand across his face. “Did I?”

“Yeah. And why the fuck did you leave me in that hallway? You were safe and then you fucking disappeared.”

Viktor glances away and his eyes screw shut. “I don’t know…I can’t remember.”

His eyes open and his troubled gaze meets mine. Before he can say anything else, Jax moves into the room, pushing past Tatum and Teddy, his face filled with relief when he sees his friend awake. He sits on the bed and hugs him roughly.

“Fuck, man. I thought for sure you were dead. We were all worried.”

Viktor glances up at me, and I can’t help the rage that moves across my face. I know he can see it. He has to. It’s clear as fucking day.

I need to punch something.

“Luca…” Viktor begins, but I’m already striding from the room.

Be gentle with him, I think as my vision reds out.

I can only be gentle after I fucking wreck something. As I move toward the gym, I pull out my phone and call Agro.

“Yeah?” he clips when he answers.

“Can I get on the books tonight?”

“Yep. I’ll put you in.”

The phone disconnects, and I feel relief almost immediately.

I’m still going to work out this anxiety, but tonight I’ll expel it completely.

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12

VIKTOR

I find Luca in that shady warehouse, his face bloody, his knuckles red. He's been pummeled, and the man he's fighting is just as bad, if not worse. The man staggers back after taking a punch to the jaw, his mouth open as he sucks in breaths, his chest riddled with blood and bruises.

"What the fuck?" I murmur as Bane and I make our way through the crowd. It's hot and sweaty in here despite the chill outside. Just like last time. I catch sight of Jax, who trails slightly behind us, his eyes sweeping around as if looking for danger. And he should be. This place is foul. I can feel the tension in the air. It's thick and oppressive.

How Luca managed to find his way into fighting here, I have no idea. But then again, I don't know him that well.

I just know how he likes his cock sucked.

And a little about his past.

And that he's slightly self-destructive.

That he saved my life last night.

"You sure you want to be here?" Jax asks, and I nod. I want to be here. I need to. It's a deep pull, luring me toward him. I want to save him like he saved me.

Save him from himself.

This morning, after waking from my deep slumber and watching Luca storm from the room, I waited for him to return, but he never did. I lay there, poked and prodded by Doc until it was determined that I was fine. The Pink they found in my system had passed, and I was able to go about as

normal. And with Doc's and Anthony's permission, after reassuring them I wouldn't take random shit from strangers again, I left the house in search of him.

Anthony told me where he was.

But I knew without asking.

I push my way to the edge of the screaming crowd and as I do, a man who doesn't like the way I'm moving in front of him, shoves me and Bane roughly. We trip forward, knocking into a burly woman with a mullet. She scowls at us, and I offer her an apology as Bane scowls at the aggressive man behind us.

I can see the restraint on Bane's face, the twitch of his eye, and the flick of his hand. He's trying to play it cool, to keep it together, but it's a thin tether. It won't last. He's still upset about Henry, so close and yet out of his grasp. His temper is hanging on by a thread.

So when the man flips us off and sneers, Bane snaps his fist back and punches him straight in the nose. It pops and cracks, blood pouring from it. The sight makes Bane cackle as he pumps his fist in the air.

"Broke it. One shot! Booyah!"

"Fuck," I murmur as the man, after moving past his initial shock, lurches forward and grabs Bane by the neck. But he isn't there long because Jax comes up behind the man and wraps his meaty arm around his neck, placing him in a headlock. That leaves me to fight off a guy behind me who is whipped into a fury over the sight of blood.

They're all feral, frothing for it. They want a fight, they want the pain.

Someone grabs my hair, and I grunt as my elbow meets ribs.

"Get the fuck off me!" I shout and then whip around and put the thin man attacking me on his ass. He blinks in confusion as I fend off two more people making their way toward me. And in the middle of it all, I see that Bane has launched himself at the man who shoved him and is gouging out his eyes, his thumbs pressed into the man's eye sockets, his legs wrapped around his waist.

"You're going to die! I'm going to cut you up! But not without these eyeballs! Those are mine!" Bane screams, his hair wild, blood seeping from the man's sockets as he struggles to get Bane off him. Those eyes are surely gone now. My gaze catches on Jax, who grins at me before punching a man in the face to his left. His knuckles are raw, blood spattered on his face. I'm sure I look the same.

This is violent and dangerous, but this is where we thrive.

Maybe I'm not so different from Luca after all.

Suddenly, the crowd surges, as if they were just waiting for a reason to do so, and I feel my body squish between two men as they throw fists blindly. I narrowly avoid a punch to my jaw and manage to shift slightly to my right when I'm pulled away and out of the crowd.

Right into Luca's arms.

"What the fuck?" he spits, blood coating his lips, his hair a sweaty mess, his eyes wild. His mouthguard is nowhere to be found. "What the fuck are you doing here?" he slurs.

"You're such a fucking idiot!" I shout, rage moving through me. I shove him, making him stumble backward. He glares at me and then rushes toward me, his hands hitting me on the chest, curling into my shirt, and pulling me into him.

"Don't push me away, Vik," he growls and presses his face into my neck. My hands go to his back, hugging him tightly before wrenching away. I won't be distracted. He did this. He fucking did it.

"You're so fucking stupid. You should be at home. With me! Why are you here? Why are you doing this?"

He stares at me, looking stupidly hot despite the blood dripping from his mouth and cheeks.

He parts his lips and then closes them. Something moves across his face, through those eyes, and I move closer to him, cupping his cheeks gently. He meets my earnest stare and almost whispers—a secret, an admission.

"I didn't fight for them and they died. It's my fault. I didn't fight."

My heart cracks slightly, a fissure tearing me in two. But before I can assure him it wasn't his fault, that he was just a boy, Agro rushes up to us, his mouth frothing, spittle hitting my cheeks as he roars.

"What the fuck is this? You fucking ruined it, you piece of shit! You think you can fuck up my shit? I'll fucking murder you, you ass—" He's in a rage and makes a move to grab Luca, but my gun is out and aimed at his head before he can.

"You fucking touch him and I'll kill you," I say, my arm steady, my eyes laser-focused.

Agro eyes me, not moving, his jaw ticking. He's ready to burst. His hands come up slowly, and I press the tip of the gun to his forehead,

grabbing Luca by the back of the neck, just like he does to me. Owning him. Possessing him.

"Never speak to him like that again or I'll take you apart. Piece by piece. You'll wish for this bullet."

Luca's watching me intently, and I know I've shown all my cards, but right now, I don't care.

Agro takes a step back but my gun doesn't waver. It stays trained on him until Jax barrels by, Bane over his shoulder.

"We have to go!" he shouts. "Fucking move!"

I stare after them for a second, watching a crowd of people surge toward us, Agro doing the same. *Fuck. We're going to die*, I think as I grab Luca's hand and we burst forward, passing Jax, who is slowed down by Bane, and rush toward the locker rooms.

"My eyeball!" Bane cries. "I dropped one!"

"Forget the fucking eye!" Jax grunts as we turn toward the rickety entrance, all following Luca inside.

"I need my shit," he grunts, shutting the metal door behind us and locking it. The pounding that proceeds, rattling the door on its hinges, makes my heart race.

"Hurry," I hiss as Luca grabs his bag and leads us toward the back door.

We push through it with a clang, Bane murmuring under his breath about his missing trophy as we rush toward the cars.

Jax and Bane end up in one, and Luca and I in the other. We peel out of the parking lot as Luca leans back in his seat, chest heaving.

"You're an idiot," I say again, wanting him to really hear it, to know how angry I am with him.

"So are you."

Silence moves between us, and Luca huffs out a laugh, the fear and tension bleeding out of us the farther we get from the warehouse.

"Fucking Bane. Why did he come anyway?" Luca finally asks.

"Apparently to wreak havoc." Luca chuckles, and I add, "I didn't know he was in the car until I was on the highway. He popped out of the back like a fucking goblin."

"Shit," Luca replies, his laugh growing. "That asshole. We were right to have him shipped back home in a box. He would have found a way to return if we hadn't."

"He always does. He's like a cockroach."

We chuckle on and off about Bane and his antics until we pull up at Luca's house, and then the reality of it all comes crashing down. Suddenly, the adrenaline is absent and I can feel the drop palpably. It makes me shiver slightly, my body temperature falling as we sit in the car.

"Will Agro end up here? Do we need to call for more security?" I finally ask, staring at his front door in concern.

Luca turns toward me. "You'll protect me, right, pretty boy?"

My cock hardens at that and I turn off the ignition and get out, schooling my face into something serious as I open his car door.

"Will he, Luca? Will he show up? Does he know where you live?"

"No, we're safe. Plus, I have you."

"It's my job to make sure you don't die. Now get the fuck out, Luca. You need a shower."

He follows me into his house, his hand reaching out for mine as we move. I can't help but pull it up and look at his bruised knuckles, brushing my thumb over the broken skin.

"You're too old for this."

"I know."

"You're going to stop doing it."

"You telling me? Giving me an ultimatum?"

I don't answer as we walk into his bathroom and I turn on the water, letting him strip down and step under the warm spray. Blood from his wounds rushes down his body and the reddened water swirls and disappears down the drain. His bruised hands move into his hair, and he arches his head back, closing his eyes. At that moment, he looks like a fucking god. All that wet skin, the tattoos.

I strip down and join him.

I don't even hesitate. Don't think twice.

"Move," I murmur, and his eyes pop open, staring at me under the running water. Those long lashes, that golden rim around his irises.

He's fucking perfection.

"Look at those marks on you. From me. So pretty," he says about my hickeys.

"Shut the fuck up," I hiss.

He smirks at me and then runs a hand across his chiseled chest. "You like what you see?"

"I hate it," I murmur.

With a chuckle, he moves over and I'm able to rinse off, watching as Luca slowly soaps himself up. The tantalizing way his hands run across the tight planes of his body, the way his cock thickens between his legs, makes my mouth water. I'm so fucking screwed. My attraction to him is visible.

"My turn," he says, handing me the soap and standing under the water, rinsing himself off.

His eyes never leave mine, and I can't look away either, letting the soap move over my body in rigid swipes.

"Why did you come tonight?" he finally asks.

My hands stop moving, and I just watch him.

"You trying to save me? I don't want to be saved, Vik."

I swallow and set the soap down. "I don't either. So what do we do? Just let each other self-destruct until we die?"

He leans his head back and water flows down the sharp line of his jaw. I want to lean forward and bite him. I want to mark him like he's marked me.

When he finally meets my gaze again, he blinks away the water on his lashes. "I'd rather like it if you didn't die."

"Same. So stop getting your head knocked around in a fucking ring full of criminals."

"We're criminals."

"Not like that."

"We have morals?" he asks, stepping from the water and letting me move under it once more. "You're delusional if you think we do. We have a semblance of them, our own sense of justice, but we're not better than those guys, Vik. Remember that."

I huff and stare at him from under the spray for a moment. "Maybe you're not, but I am."

Luca glances at me, his lips turned up in a small grin.

"Is that so? You were ready to put a bullet between Agro's eyebrows. And for what? Calling me names?"

I turn away, but he pulls me back, his fingers on my chin.

"You were going to murder for me, baby."

"Fuck you."

"But you don't want me to fuck you, do you?"

What the hell does that mean? How did he gather that from my angry statement? But before I can ask, he adds, "You want me to make love to you, don't you? Like that night years ago?"

He brushes his nose up my cheek and whispers in my ear. His words are crisp and clear over the sound of the water.

“You want me to be gentle with you, pretty boy?”

My cock throbs and I let out a shaky exhale. *Fuck, fuck me.*

“Everyone is so rough with you. You like that too, but sometimes, you want me to be gentle with you.”

My eyes blink open and I see the glittering force in those dark depths.

“You don’t need to admit it.” He reaches behind me and turns the water off. Stepping from the shower, he grabs a towel, handing it to me before taking another for himself.

“I’ll be on the bed, waiting.”

He dries off as he goes, and I’m left to stare after him, my heart thundering in my ears.

What the hell? What the fuck is happening?

Those razor-sharp butterflies have dulled their wings, and instead of a biting cut, it’s a dull throb, an ache.

I can do nothing but follow him into the room, my body still damp, my hands unable to do anything more than the bare minimum.

Luca is lounging on the bed, his elbows propping himself up, his hair a wet mess, his cock perfect and hard between his legs.

“Come sit on my face,” he says lowly and then wets his lips. “I’m going to make love to that slutty hole.”

It clenches in anticipation, and despite telling myself not to, my feet carry me forward, my body turning to straddle his chest, my ass in his face, my eyes on his hard dick.

His hands grab my cheeks and squeeze before spreading them apart, taking a good look at my hole.

“Have you done this before?” I wheeze when he continues to just stare at me.

“No, but I think I’ll take to it quite well,” he murmurs and then leans forward and licks a stripe up my crack. The sensation of being touched there by him makes me fall forward, my hands on his thighs as I hold on for dear life.

His tongue is dragging down my crack now, slowly, before landing on my hole, the tip of it wet and prodding. It swirls around the puckered rim, memorizing it for a moment before his lips kiss it. Tender, almost sweet.

“Oh god,” I groan, unable to help the shudder that moves through me. My fingers curl against his thighs as he continues to make out with me. I can’t hold in the moans. They slip from me effortlessly, fluidly, until he finally puts me out of my misery and gently pushes his tongue inside of me.

The sound that leaves me has me blushing, my skin on fire. His tongue gingerly works itself in and out of me until I’m panting, my mouth open in delirium, my eyes screwed shut as I just experience it. He wasn’t lying when he said he’d make love to it.

He is. He’s slow and gentle and it’s driving me crazy.

I want it to stop. I want *more*.

His mouth leaves me and it’s replaced with his finger, a slow slide inside my slippery hole as he finds my prostate, making me arch up and fuck back on his finger. His hand grips my hip and he stops me.

“No, not so rough. Gentle, baby. Soft.”

I whimper and slow the roll of my hips, instead letting him work me closer and closer to the edge until I’m breathing as if I’ve run a mile, as if I’m going to expire from the wait. And then his tongue is back, entering me as well, that sloppy wet kiss to my entrance.

And when I come, I’m trembling, my release gushing out of me like a slow, lazy geyser. It flows over the tip of me and drips down my cock until I’m slumped forward, trying to catch my breath.

My arms are shaking so badly that I flop to my side and blink up at the ceiling, Luca’s face looming over mine. His lips are swollen, his pupils blown out. He looks so hot like this.

Perfect, like always.

“You did so good,” he says softly, his hand moving to stroke my cheek. “Now let me make love to that pretty mouth and throat.”

He feeds me his cock, his hands cradling my head as he rocks gently into me, making my eyes roll back in my head, my dick perking up once more. Sensations overwhelm me and I can’t help but reach out and hold onto him. My anchor.

I hate him, and yet I want him.

I need him.

I have since I was a boy. And it’s only grown, a deep insatiable craving.

When he comes, he says my name, a whisper, a plea before he pulls out and cradles me from behind, his legs tangled with my own. The way his

hand cups my heart, as if he's holding it, makes something inside of me unfurl.

This is a dangerous game we're playing.

And yet, I still let him hold me, my eyes shutting and my mind drifting off to sleep.

I wake to Luca's body wrapped around mine, his warm breath hitting the skin of my neck.

Fuck, he's addictive, making me think of things I shouldn't.

"Let me go," I say, my voice hoarse from sleep, from the fucking he gave my throat.

"Not yet," he grumbles, his leg moving over mine a little tighter, his hand moving from my chest to my stomach, his fingers dragging through the hair at my groin.

It makes my already-hard cock jump.

"Good morning, kitten," he says softly as he teases me. "How did you sleep?"

"Fuck off with this domesticated bullshit," I reply, but my heart likes it far too much.

"So, you slept well then," he says with a dark chuckle, his fist wrapping around my cock and stroking lazily. "You need a nice wake up?"

A disgusting groan leaves my throat as I reach back and thread my fingers through his hair. His lips trail across my neck and I feel a shudder move through my entire body. Everything about him is toxic…intoxicating.

But before anything can progress, his phone chirps loudly and he pulls away from me, grabbing it and then shooting from bed, his gun in his hand. The speed at which he moved has me racing after him, realizing I'm nude, but also knowing that this is more important than clothes.

"Fuck!" Luca shouts as he flings open the door and aims his gun, pointing it at the van peeling around the corner before dropping it to his side.

On the ground is a young boy, probably no older than fifteen, his lips blue, his clothes a mess.

“He dead?” I ask, and he sighs, leaning down and pressing his fingers to his neck.

“Yeah. Fuck!”

His eyes trail from the boy to me, and he runs a hand across his face.

“Who the fuck is dumping them? I want to fucking know.”

He fists his hands at his side and clenches his jaw.

“We’ll find out, but now we know you can’t stay here. You need to stay with Anthony. I don’t want you to be next.”

His eyes slam into mine and his lips twitch. “You care about me?”

“Shut the fuck up,” I say, moving back toward the bedroom to grab my phone. I know I need to call the twins.

I need this gone from Luca’s yard quickly.

They pick up, and I roll my eyes, bracing myself for their purrs, but this time they’re absent.

“We’ll be there,” they say and the phone hangs up.

I walk out to where Luca is. He’s dragged the body inside and is now making himself a cup of coffee.

“Want one?”

“Yeah.”

He hands me a mug and leans against the counter, the two of us still naked, but neither in a hurry to get dressed.

As I sip from the hot liquid, Luca stares down at his phone.

“Shit,” he murmurs as it starts to ring.

“What? Who is it?”

His eyes meet mine and his cheeks flush. “My aunt. Just give me a minute.”

He puts it up to his ear, and I watch as his face softens.

The same aunt who took him in, I assume. She must be special to him.

“Yeah, I’m okay,” he says into the phone. “Had a busy night. And I have company. Can I call you back?”

He listens to something she says and his eyes roll. “No, you can’t speak to him.”

I hear the faint murmur of a voice on the other line, and Luca sighs. “Fine. But two minutes and no more.”

He holds the phone out to me and I can’t help but take a step forward, taking it from him and placing it at my ear.

“Hello,” I hear her say. “I’m Luca’s aunt, Lyla. It’s so nice to meet you, Viktor.”

“Nice to meet you, too.”

My gaze meets Luca’s, and he arches an eyebrow at me.

“Tell me everything about you.”

“Everything?” I ask and I hear her hum.

“Yes, as much as you’d like to tell me. Luca is smitten with you and I want to know about the man who’s captured his heart.”

My cheeks flush and I blink over at Luca, who looks annoyed at the intrusion.

“Yeah, um, I don’t know about that.”

“Oh child, I can hear it in his voice when he speaks about you. Now go on, tell me something. Anything.”

“He said two minutes.”

“Oh, he’s not the boss of me. We can chat as long as we want.”

My mouth twitches and I can’t help but let out a small laugh. “Yeah, okay. What do you want to know?”

“Shit,” Luca murmurs and reaches for the phone, but I twist out of his way, moving to the bedroom to pull on some clothes. I won’t be speaking to her while naked.

And Luca doesn’t fight me on it either. Lyla and I end up chatting until Luca tells me the twins are here. She’s easy to talk to. I can see why Luca found some healing while in her care.

When I hang up, with a promise to chat again, I hand him his phone and he scowls at me, playful and still slightly annoyed.

“I now know a lot about you when you were a young boy. Really gives me the full picture.”

“Shut up,” Luca grumbles and then hands me a bagel sandwich. While I was chatting, he made breakfast and packed a suitcase for his stay at Anthony’s.

He told me he would stay there if I stayed with him.

I told him I wouldn’t, but he knows I’m a fucking liar. His aunt knows, too, because we had this conversation while on the phone with her. She laughed and told me to stop fighting it so hard.

If only she knew how easily I gave in already.

We walk to the front door, and Luca pulls it open, the twins waiting on the other side.

“Hello, Viktor,” they say at the same time. Their eyes rove over me, and I feel my cheeks heat. “What a pleasure this is.”

“It’s something,” I reply, and Luca touches the back of my neck gently.

Their eyes travel to where our bodies meet and they cock their heads. Everything about them is so similar. The way they dress, the way they speak. Even the way they fuck.

I should have never let them have sex with me.

“We enjoy your videos together. For this cleanup, and since you took us away from *him*, we’d like Luca to give you a blow job,” Cain says.

“Stop fucking complaining. Your boy is safe with Sabrina,” Luca replies, but he goes ignored.

“That is the stipulation. Take it or leave it. Oh, and it has to be deep-throating,” Ezra adds.

My entire body tightens as I wait for Luca’s response.

“Fine,” he replies, and I let out a breath I didn’t know I was holding.

“You don’t have to agree to that. We can negotiate,” I whisper when the twins turn their backs and get to work.

“I said I’m fine with it,” he replies and then removes his hand from the back of my neck and moves to where the twins are working. He hovers over them until they produce a vial of blood, placing it in his palm.

“Deep, deep-throating,” they remind him.

He nods, and my cock twitches in my pants.

There is no way he’s going to deep-throat my dick, I think as we leave the twins to their work and head to Anthony’s house.

As I drive, Luca calls his contact at the police and sends him the footage of the van from his security cameras. Not that it did any good last time. It was a burner plate and led to nothing. I’m assuming the same can be said for this as well.

But it’s worth a shot.

“You should get Diablo on this,” I say as I take his suitcase from the back of the SUV.

“Anthony’s considering asking him and Lex.”

I remember Lex. He used to come over and visit with Diablo. Both are little shits, but they do good work.

“But I should see if he’s made up his mind on involving them,” Luca adds as I park the car. We walk inside Anthony’s estate, and Luca nods toward the hallway. “Pick a room you’re comfortable with.”

“I’m not staying with you.”

“Like fuck you aren’t,” he murmurs and then pulls me in for a filthy kiss. He backs me up against the wall and licks into my mouth, setting my entire body on fire and making my horny dick pulse.

When he pulls away, he presses his thumb to my swollen bottom lip.

“Pick a fucking room, kitten. Stop fighting me on this. I want you in bed tonight, next to me. I sleep better when you’re near.”

I wheeze loudly at his admission as he stalks away, looking over his shoulder and shooting me a sultry wink. “And come to Anthony’s office when you’re done. We have shit to discuss.”

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13

LUCA

"Why the fuck are you all the way over there?" I ask when Viktor makes no move to sit on my lap. He's about ten feet away, his body turned away from mine, as if trying to resist me by sheer will.

Well, it seems he has no idea how persuasive I can be.

When I want something, I get it.

"I'm fine sitting here," he murmurs, his cheeks flushing. We're all sitting in Anthony's office, the two of us discussing our plans for this week, but Viktor's stubbornness is distracting me.

And Anthony watches it all from his place behind his desk, saying nothing, but obviously deriving pleasure from watching me squirm.

"Get over here, Vik," I murmur, pointing to my lap.

Viktor scowls at it but doesn't budge.

"Vik," I warn.

"We're in a fucking meeting, Luca. I'm not sitting on your fucking lap," Viktor grumbles.

My jaw clicks and I stand up, moving toward him and wrenching him up from where he's reclined. My hand lands on his ass in a quick slap before he falls into me, his hands on my chest, mine on his hips. I spin us around and he ends up right where he should have been the entire time.

On top of me.

"Fucking hell," he murmurs as Anthony laughs lowly.

"Tatum would love this," he remarks as I adjust Viktor on my lap, getting us both comfortable. I don't plan on him moving anytime soon. As

we sit there, my hand snakes up his shirt, touching his warm skin, and I feel him lean back slightly, grumbling the entire time, but loving it, nonetheless. He'll never admit it, but he wants this.

He wants it so fucking bad.

"You ready to continue now?" Anthony asks, and I nod.

"Yes, now that he's behaving."

Viktor curses under his breath but doesn't move, just sits there like the good boy he is.

"Now, where were we?" Anthony pauses a moment and then adds, "Ah yes. Diablo and Lex. We've tried all the conventional ways of finding out who is behind these murders and the distribution of Pink, but I think it's time to ask them to assist. I'll also ask them to comb over the footage from the club to see if they can see Henry there."

"Good," I say as my hand unbuttons Viktor's jeans and my finger slides down that trail of hair near his groin. "Has the boy found at Sabrina's said anything?"

"No, he still can't remember anything. He doesn't even know his own name."

"Well, fuck," I murmur, continuing to tease that bit of skin on Viktor's lower abdomen.

"Our contact in the police force isn't much help either but Senator Ruiz is now aware of what's currently happening on the streets."

"And what the fuck is he going to do?" Vik asks as I lower the zipper of his pants and cup his growing erection.

"They can do many things," Anthony replies. "Draft legislation, limit certain drug trades, etcetera."

Viktor huffs and leans back further, wanting more, but I don't give it to him. Just hold him in my hand.

"Right, and we need him to know that it's not us distributing this. Have you spoken to Raphael?" I ask.

"I did make him aware. He's also looking out for whoever may be behind it. So far, there's nothing. Just Viktor stating it was Henry who gave him the drugs and Amir from the club, who said he may know someone. Although we haven't heard anything from him, so it may be a dead end."

Viktor shifts on my lap, and I squeeze his hard length, making him huff loudly.

“Has this drug crossed state lines yet?” I ask, and Anthony runs a hand along his jaw.

“I’m not sure. I’ve been meaning to call Declan MacKenna and see if he knows anything that’s happening in Nevada.”

“And Craig Wells in Arizona,” I offer.

“That’s a good idea.” Anthony eyes me and arches an eyebrow. “I’ll make those calls while I look for Tatum. He’s been suspiciously absent today. And that way, you two can have the room for a bit before I return.”

He stands up, and Viktor grumbles under his breath once more but still doesn’t move from my lap.

When the door closes and we’re alone, Viktor huffs in annoyance.

“You can stop touching my dick in front of my boss, asshole.”

“I don’t want to and you like it, so shut the fuck up.”

I bite his neck roughly and he groans. My point has been proven, and I squeeze his dick roughly once more before letting go.

“You fuck,” he mutters as I tap him to stand up.

He does, adjusting his cock and placing it beneath the waistband of his pants.

“Why can’t you just leave me alone?” he asks.

“Do you really want me to?”

He swallows and glances away, unable to admit he wants me all up in his space. He wants me. Plain and simple.

“I’m not going to stop playing with you, Vik. I want you fucking ready when it’s time for me to put my mouth on you. You’re not going to last long,” I say and then kiss him roughly, making him melt into me. He pants and grinds against me, his body working into a frenzy until Bane suddenly appears through the wall.

“Oh hello,” he says as he approaches, his eyes taking us in, two jars in his hands, both sloshing precariously. “Are you going to have sex? If so, I’d love to watch.”

“No,” Viktor said. “I was just…we were just talking.”

Bane’s eyes widen. “I like that kind of talking. Maybe we can talk someday, too.”

I grab onto the back of Viktor’s neck and squeeze. “You won’t be talking to Vik like that, Bane. Or I’ll make you scream.”

He gasps and then wiggles on his feet. “You promise?”

“Jesus, Luca. You’re just turning him on. Stop it.”

I can’t help but laugh at that. “You’re a twisted fuck, Bane.”

“I know. I can’t help it. I was born this way.”

I pause a moment and then add, “You won’t be watching me fuck Vik the first time. But maybe one day I’ll let you watch. If you’re a good boy.”

Bane bounces on his toes.

“Promise?”

“Promise,” I say, and Bane grins so wide his lips squeak slightly.

He shoves the glass jar of blood into Viktor’s hands. “I have a gift for you.”

“What is this?”

“A nice collection. If you’d like to stare at the blood of your enemies.”

Viktor’s eyes meet mine, and I can’t help the smile I give him.

“Thank you,” Viktor says, and Bane presses a kiss to his cheek.

“Anytime. Now where is Jax? I need to give him this eyeball.”

He wanders out of the office, leaving Viktor standing there with a jar of blood and a half-hard cock.

“Come on, we have some work to do, and then tonight…” I whisper, pressing my nose to his and nipping at his top lip. “Tonight, you’re all mine.”

You’d think I’d be nervous about sucking another man’s cock, especially deep-throating, but for some reason, I’m not. I like seeing Viktor all worked up, his breathing growing more erratic with each passing minute. By the time we’re showered and in bed, he’s panting, his pupils blown out, his cheeks red, and I haven’t even touched him yet.

I tug the towel from around my waist and watch as Viktor visibly trembles when it falls to the floor. My hand runs across my abdomen and he wets his lips.

“You ready, pretty boy?” I ask as I move toward him, grabbing onto the piece of fabric covering him and tugging it.

It falls away, revealing everything underneath. Those long legs, that long, hard dick, the curve of his ass.

“Look at you,” I whisper, bringing him in for a kiss. Our tongues tangle for a minute before I pull away, my hands dragging through his dark hair

and arching his neck up in the process. I suck on his skin there, feeling his Adam's apple bob as he moans. My thigh moves between his legs, and I grind against him, both of our cocks hard.

When he's trembling, I take a step back, admiring my work.

"You look like you want to come."

He blinks at me but doesn't say a word.

"Say you want it. Say you want me to suck your dick."

He opens his mouth and then his admission floats between us. "Yes."

My lips quirk slightly as I reach out and lead him to the edge of the bed, handing him my phone in the process. His hand shakes so badly, I wonder if he's even going to be able to hold onto it for long.

He fucking better get this on video because if not, we'll have to redo it.

Although, that won't be so bad.

I think I'm going to enjoy this very much.

"Are you sure?" Viktor asks as I sink to my knees before him.

My eyes meet his and I run my tongue across my teeth.

"Yeah, I'm fucking sure."

He lets out a shaky breath, his cock reaching for me, his fingers twisting in the sheets. The phone is already discarded to the side, forgotten. He hasn't even managed to hold onto it for a minute.

"The phone," I say with a grin and he bites his bottom lip, picking it up and pressing record. He holds it over my face, that tremble in his limbs still evident.

"You nervous, baby?"

"Nervous it's going to suck," he says, but that's a lie.

"Oh, don't worry. I'm good at everything I do."

I spread his legs a little wider, reaching out and tugging on his balls.

"Look how much you have in here." I roll them across my palm and Viktor gasps, his hips arching up slightly. "You're going to make such a mess."

I stare down at his swollen head, and I lean down, my tongue peeking out and swiping across the tip. An unholy groan leaves him, and his dick weeps.

"Mm," I murmur and then pull him into my mouth, his cock hard and heavy on my tongue. Viktor swears as I drag him further and further into me, enjoying the scent of him, the taste.

But then again, I do seem to like Viktor quite a lot.

Especially the sounds he makes when he's lost in this orgasmic haze.

"Fuck. *Fuck*," he moans above me, those words making goosebumps crawl across my skin. "Oh shit."

He says that as I bring him all the way to the back of my throat. I hold him there, experiencing the sensation of a dick being somewhere it's never been. *It's not half bad*, I think as I grab onto the rest of his cock with my hand, slowly jerking him off. He whispers my name, like a prayer, a plea.

"Luca. Oh fuck. *Oh fuck*."

I drag the entire experience out, loving the sweet whimpers he makes as I swallow him over and over, taking him as deep as I can, my free hand dragging up and down his thigh, tugging on his balls, and dragging across his taint.

"Luca. I can't—," he cries when I press a finger to his rim, pushing inside slightly. I feel the pulse of that ring around me and the jerk of his cock on my tongue. "Oh shit, if you keep this up, I'm going to—oh goddammit!"

I drag my mouth off him and when I glance up, his eyelids hooded, his chest heaving, I realize the camera isn't even pointed at me.

"Camera, kitten," I rasp.

He blinks at me, confused for a movement before realization dawns. He fumbles for it, lifting the phone and holding it over me once more.

"We need the money shot," I say. "I'd hate to break the contract."

He swallows and then gasps when I pull him back inside. He's not touched me since this started, but now his hand is in my hair, tangling gently as he guides me up and down his hard shaft. I gag as the head enters my throat, my mouth dripping, the wetness spurring me on. Saliva falls from his cock to my bent knees as I suck him harder and deeper. My cheeks hollow out, my tongue dragging up the underside of him, along that pulsing vein.

I feel when he starts to come, the way his balls draw up slightly, his dick jumping against my tongue.

"I'm com—" he gasps and his fingers tighten against my scalp almost painfully. I feel his release hit me. I hold it on my tongue as I pull off, that warm salty cum spreading across my tastebuds before I spit it out into my palm.

I look up and he's watching me, his body lax, his eyes almost closed.

“You’re right. You were good at that,” he finally whispers, and I huff out a small laugh, realizing my throat is slightly sore.

“I told you. I’m good at everything, kitten.”

I wipe off my hand with a towel and pick up my phone, seeing that it’s still recording, so I stop it and send the video to the twins. As I stand up, I watch Viktor lick his lips when he sees my stiff dick.

“You want it?” I ask, and he nods, beginning to open his mouth, but I just shake my head.

“Not your mouth. Not this time. You have such pretty legs.”

I shove him back and grab the lube from the side table, wetting my dick, which makes Viktor pant.

“What are you going to do?” he asks, his pink hole contracting slightly as I stare down at it.

He thinks I’m going to fuck him.

Silly kitten.

I lift his legs and throw them over my shoulders. Grabbing his muscular thighs, I squeeze them together and slot my cock where they’re joined, pushing through with a groan. I don’t need much to get me there. Sucking him off did it for me. So I just fuck his thighs, the veins in my arms bulging, my face turning to find his skin and biting at it roughly as I bring myself closer and closer to the edge.

“Please, Luca. *Luca*,” he groans as he pushes forward, wanting more. He’s such a whore for it.

“You want it, slut?”

“Yes. *Yes*.”

That’s all it takes. His admission, the way he pants my name. I unload onto his chest with a roar.

As I watch my release sink into the crevices of his abdomen, I can’t help but reach down and drag the mess up to his nipples, swirling it around those pink, puckered nubs.

“So fucking pretty in my mess.”

“Oh god,” he whispers as his legs drop from my shoulders, and I fall onto him, kissing him roughly. His legs tangle behind my back and my hands fist his hair, the two of us rolling around on the bed, pulling the sheets off the edge of the mattress, making a mess of it all. We do this until we’re ready to go again. Reaching between us, I jack us both off until we’re both frothing and panting like dogs in heat.

And finally, when we're done, I pull him against me and tuck him into my chest.

"So, so good for me."

"Mm," he murmurs, half-asleep already.

"Yes, baby, sleep."

He sighs and drifts off, happy and satiated. I push my face into his neck and inhale.

Mine, my heart thinks.

Always mine.

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14

VIKTOR

I wake up to Bane snuggling against my chest, his soft snores pulling me from my dreams.

"Mmph, Bane. What the fuck?" I murmur as he snorts himself awake. I realize that he's pressed up against my cum-stained chest, not that he has any issue with bodily fluids, it seems. He was probably lured in here by the scent of sex.

"Oh. Hi," he says with a yawn and then snuggles into me further. He's fully dressed in pajama bottoms and a white t-shirt, but still, I can feel his morning wood pressed up against my own.

Behind me, Luca is starting to wake, and I feel his hand travel up, bumping between Bane and me.

"Why the fuck is there another man in our bed?"

"It's Bane."

Luca is silent, but pats Bane's side, making Bane wiggle even closer.

"What's wrong? Why are you in bed with us?" Luca asks.

"Georgiy is back to ignoring me, and Teddy erased his number from my phone when I told him how toxic he was. So I think it's over."

"It's not over until you're dead," Luca replies, which I find very unhelpful. Stupid man.

"Luca," I murmur, but he's rolling over and sitting up.

"Maybe you should find someone else to fuck, for now at least. Georgiy is just playing games with you," I say.

Bane sighs and rubs his nose against my collarbone. “I think he is, too. I was thinking about maybe asking Jax for some sex company. He has nice muscles and has thrown me around a bit. I think he could maybe give me what I need.”

“God, not Jax,” I say.

“What’s wrong with him?”

“He’s a walking red flag.”

“I love red flags. That color looks good on me. I think you need something better than that for me to stay away.”

I sigh, and he grabs my hand and places it on his back. “Also, I’d love a back rub. I’m very sad.”

My hand absently rubs up and down his bony spine, and he sighs.

“Why did Teddy feel the need to block him?”

“Well, he said Georgiy is just playing games and that I’m better than that.”

I stare down at the top of Bane’s head. “Wait. How do you know what he says? Teddy never speaks.”

“I know ASL. Don’t you?”

He blinks up at me like this is something everyone should know, and I feel suddenly ashamed I don’t. I roll onto my back and sigh. “No, I don’t fucking know it. What other languages do you speak?”

“I mean, you don’t speak ASL, you sign it. And the Deaf community has a really large population in the US. You should learn it.”

I peer over at him, and he shrugs.

“Okay, enough preaching. Um, what other languages? I know Spanish. I’m learning Russian because, you know…Georgiy. Although, perhaps I shouldn’t bother with that after all.”

“I had no idea you knew so much, Bane.”

“I know quite a bit. I’m amazing.” He flops onto his back as well and stares at the ceiling. “Since I’m so amazing, can you suck my dick? I’ll be gentle, I promise.”

“No one is sucking your dick, Bane. You’ve had Viktor for long enough. I think it’s time you leave,” Luca says, appearing from the bathroom, his tattoos looking quite sinister in this light. I want to lick my way across his chest.

“Are you sure? We could manage a quick threesome,” Bane begins, but Luca points to the bedroom door.

“Get the fuck out.”

He sighs and then signs something I can’t make out before standing up, adjusting himself, and disappearing into the hallway.

“Let me know if you change your mind,” Bane coos as Luca slams the door.

He turns to face me and his lips quirk when he sees the sheets pooled at my groin, my abs flexed.

“Never thought I’d want a man, but your body…”

A grunt leaves me and I flop backward. I fling an arm over my eyes, letting those words penetrate me. Of course he likes my body. I work hard for it. It’s nice. But for some reason, I want more than just physical appreciation.

Luca steps toward me, and I can feel the whisper of his fingertips across my leg.

“…the way you fight me, your stubbornness, your resolve. It makes me want to break you. Own you. Even more than I already do.”

I move my arm off my face and stare at him.

“Now get the fuck up. We have to go meet Raphael. We need to approve the shipment he has, plus I have some questions for him.”

“And after?”

He chuckles, stroking my ankle. “Anthony messaged. When we get back, Lex will be here. He’s going to help us find Henry and we’ll find out if he’s tied to Pink.”

“Oh god, Lex. Last time he was here, I found a camera in the bodyguard bathroom,” I murmur, and Luca tugs on my leg, dragging me closer to the edge of the mattress.

“We’ll keep an eye on him. Now get up. We have to go.”

I roll up and do as he says, washing up and getting dressed in record time. As we’re leaving, Agatha hands us a paper bag with breakfast inside.

“For the cute couple. Luca was insistent you eat before you leave,” she says, which makes Tatum giggle behind his cup of tea, that little shit.

By the time we’re in the SUV on the way to the warehouse, Luca is feeding me bites of quiche with a fork, taking bites himself in between.

It’s disgustingly romantic, and I want to hate it, but I can’t.

The teenage boy in me can’t help but puff up that my long-time crush and obsession is acting like this toward me. He’s taking care of me in his own way. I never thought I stood a chance.

We finish both quiches, and he stuffs the paper bag in the back seat before grabbing his coffee and sipping it.

My hand is clutching the middle console, unsure what to do with itself when Luca tugs on it gently, turning it over and threading his fingers through mine.

I let out a shaky exhale and peer down at our entwined hands, something inside of me starting to bloom. It's a dangerous game.

Or maybe it's not a game at all, maybe it's more.

That's even more frightening.

We eventually make it to the warehouse that Raphael manages, our hands falling apart as we step out of the SUV and make our way up to the armed guards standing outside.

They recognize us immediately and step aside, pressing the code on the door to let us in.

As soon as we enter, we see Raphael striding toward us with a purpose. He's a bigger man with a barrel chest and graying hair. He's quite formidable and has been with Anthony for ages. He is as loyal as they come.

"Ah, he sent you two. I see Anthony is nearing retirement?" He pulls us into rough handshakes as he says this. "I never see him anymore."

"He's in love," Luca says, tucking his hands into his pants pockets.

"I know what that's like. I've been with Beth for decades. Wouldn't change it for the world. Now come. I have the product."

He turns around and we follow, my gaze moving around the packaging facility. Male and female workers stand in long lines, getting work done as efficiently as possible. I recognize some of them, but there are new faces here too, the others having been killed in the attack months ago. All that damage, all that blood. It's amazing how quickly Raphael managed to get everything back in working order after that. It's almost as if nothing happened.

"Anthony told me about the new product on the streets," he says as he opens his office door and leads us inside. "It's causing trouble for you?"

"I don't think it's affecting the drug side of things, but they do have a terrible habit of dumping dead bodies in our places of business."

"Are they trying to implicate you in murder?"

"I have no fucking idea why they're doing it or who's behind it, but we have a hunch. Remember Henry?" Luca asks.

“That young shit with the earring? Always did have a big mouth and a bad attitude.”

Raphael grabs a brick of cocaine, and I watch as Luca pulls out a knife from his pocket and cuts the end delicately. White powder spills from it, and I see Luca wet his lips in anticipation.

“He was also involved in getting Tatum hurt. Contributed to it, at least. Anthony’s out for blood now. You’ll let us know if you see him?”

“Will do, Boss. Will do.”

Luca puts the knife up to his nose and sniffs the white powder from the tip before taking a bit more and rubbing it across his gums.

He closes his eyes as Raphael watches.

“Always the good stuff. You never disappoint,” Luca says, opening his eyes, his pupils blown out, his lips curling up at the corners.

“Would you like some?” Raphael asks me, and my stupid gaze turns toward Luca as if asking for permission.

“I’m his driver,” I reply, even though the temptation is real.

“He is. Driving,” Luca says before adding, “Driving me crazy.”

His hand lands on the back of my neck and he leans forward, rubbing his nose up my cheek.

“Will you go into retirement?” Raphael asks dryly as he watches us. “Since you’re in love?”

Luca chuckles and before he can respond, I answer for him. “This isn’t love and no one is retiring.”

It’s quiet, my words hanging awkwardly between the three of us. Luca’s hand slowly falls away from me.

“See, he told you how it is. No love. No retirement. He’s just a slutty hole for my cock.” Luca’s words are clipped with an undertone of anger.

What the hell? Did I say the wrong thing?

Raphael’s eyebrows meet, his gaze pinging between us and then he shrugs, not one to get in the middle of drama. “Alright, come on. Let me go over some logistics. Anthony will want to know what’s happening in Colombia.”

We walk out of the small, cluttered office, Luca ignoring me the entire time.

And I can’t peel my eyes away from him, watching the stiff set of his shoulders, the way his gaze skips over me every time I end up in his line of sight.

By the time we leave, I'm on edge. I can feel his anger pulsing off him in waves.

"Come on, *Driver*," he drawls, sarcasm heavy in his tone as we make our way back to the SUV. "Go on and do your job."

"Luca, did I say the wrong thing in there?" I ask, but he doesn't respond, just pulls out his phone and begins swiping at the screen. Whatever high he had is wearing off and he's leaning back in his seat as if he doesn't have a care in the world. But he does. He cares.

"You know we need to communicate," I hiss and then peel out of the parking lot, feeling something akin to fury building up inside of me. Anger for upsetting him and caring that he's having feelings in general. I'm not used to this side of Luca.

"Are you just going to ignore me the rest of the way home?"

He continues to just stare at his phone.

"Fuck this," I whisper and turn on the radio, letting harsh music pour through the speakers, wanting to get a reaction from Luca, but getting nothing.

He gives me nothing.

By the time we arrive back at Anthony's house, I feel rage boiling up within me.

But it's tamped slightly when we arrive in Anthony's office and see Lex there, two computers set on the desk, an iPad showing Diablo on the other end of the screen, the two of them clacking and chatting away about Warhammer.

"Where's Anthony?" Luca interrupts, and Lex peers up, his bright pink hair in stark contrast to his all-black outfit.

"Probably fucking his boyfriend in the walls."

"Don't talk about my dad like that," Diablo says from the screen. "I don't need to envision it."

"I only speak the truth. They disappeared behind the bookshelves and then I heard a door close."

"Shit," Luca murmurs, and Lex nods.

"Shit is right, you're distracting me. Shoo, sexy tattooed man. I have work to do."

I bite back a laugh, my anger subsiding slightly at the way Lex told Luca off.

It makes me feel slightly better.

“I’ll go find them,” I say, but Luca is already striding to the wall behind the bookshelves.

I follow after him, accidentally stepping on the back of his shoe as I go. His foot comes out and he stops, glaring at me.

“Fix it,” he says, and I clench my teeth, folding my arms across my chest and cocking my head.

“You fix it.”

We stare at one another, long and hard, until he reaches out and grabs onto my neck, squeezing roughly.

I maneuver out of the way, not letting him hold me down. Not this time. I’m not going to just let him kiss me into submission. I want to talk. At least a little conversation about what happened back in the warehouse.

Me moving out of his way only irritates Luca further. He pursues me until I’m against the wall. His body crowds mine, and I shove at him, needing space. When he’s like this, I melt. He knows what it does to me.

He steps back and then pushes forward once more.

“Are we going to talk about it?” I growl, and Luca’s face darkens. “Or are you just going to fight me?”

His eyes flash and he steps forward once more.

My hands connect with his chest, and he falls back. I see the anger in his gaze, dark and unyielding.

“*Viktor*.”

“Just say what’s bothering you,” I hiss as he prowls toward me once more. “Why are you acting like a fucking crybaby?”

“Let me go find Anthony,” he counters, but I shove him again and this time, he charges toward me, knocking my breath from my lungs as he pins me against the wall.

“Yoohoo, fuckfaces,” a voice says behind him, and I turn to see Lex, hand on his hip, his head cocked in annoyance. “You’re being very disruptive. Can you take this mating dance elsewhere? I’m trying to find the bad man.”

Luca doesn’t move from where he’s holding me, but I manage a small nod and a response.

“Yes.”

Luca doesn’t let up, but I eventually pry his fingers from me and we push the hidden door open and slide into the caverns which lead beneath the floors.

As soon as we make it to the bottom of the stairs, I turn toward Luca again.

“Stop being like this and tell me,” I hiss, but he doesn’t respond, just pulls out a cigarette and places it between his lips.

I scoff, lighting it despite not wanting to. I want to make him wait, just like he’s made me suffer.

But I don’t. I’m a sucker for him.

He inhales and blows smoke from the side of his mouth, his eyes meeting mine in the dim, flickering lights above us. It smells like earth down here, damp and wet. And now it smells like him.

“What’s there to tell?” he murmurs, and I frown at him.

“I said or did something to piss you off. I need to know what.”

“Why? Do you care, kitten?”

I fold my arms across my chest as he inhales once again.

“I do. Much to my eternal regret.”

“Fine,” he says after a long, drawn-out silence. He flicks his cigarette onto the ground, where it’s snuffed out in a puddle. He takes a step toward me, shadows falling across the sharp cut of his jaw, his eyes shining in the orange light. His strong fingers cup my chin and tighten. “You’re more than a slutty hole. And I better be more than a big cock.”

I swallow at his honesty, my heart swelling in my chest.

Oh fuck, this is so, so bad.

“Fine,” I murmur as his thumb brushes against my bottom lip, pulling it down slightly.

“Fine,” he repeats and then his hand falls from me and he turns on his heel, moving quickly through the tunnels, leaving me to follow closely behind.

As we round a corner, we hear a moan, and Luca’s steps falter.

“Fuck, Lex was right. They are having sex.”

“Anthony!” Tatum cries, his voice echoing through the chambers. “Yes. Right there. Right there!”

“Yes, what he said!” I hear Bane chime in, and Luca huffs a small laugh.

“God, that horny fucker,” he murmurs as we turn another corner and see Tatum bent forward against a wall, Anthony’s cock tunneling in and out of Tatum’s ass. Bane is watching from the side, a cowboy hat on his head, backward.

“What are the chances that hat is made from the skin of a victim?” Luca asks me, and I snort softly.

“Probably.”

“Can I help you?” Anthony asks when he sees us approach. He stops fucking into Tatum and holds himself inside. I force myself not to look. I’ve seen them fuck far too many times, the two of them enjoying us watching.

Bane grumbles under his breath as he not-so-subtly adjusts himself. “You’re ruining the show.”

“We have things to report to you. Lex said you were down here.”

Anthony turns his gaze and runs his hand up Tatum’s back, making him tremble.

“We will be up shortly. You can take Bane with you. He’s getting far too bossy.”

“I’m not being bossy! I have preferences!”

“You can keep your opinions to yourself,” Anthony grunts and then pulls out of Tatum and pushes back into him, making him groan.

Bane’s bottom lip juts out, but he skulks toward us, glancing back as the fucking continues.

“Won’t be long! Oh fuck!” Tatum cries out as we move back through the tunnels.

“I’m sad I’m missing it. They are very fun to watch, but want to see something cool?”

We glance at each other as Bane grabs our hands and pulls us forward.

“I can’t keep it a secret any longer. Anthony said I could expand the cells. Want to see the addition I’m having made?”

We can’t say no, so we just go silently through the worn, rickety cells and past his usual butchery. There’s someone chained to the chair in the center, head and arms missing.

I bet he’s taking them apart and saving the body parts in those jars of his.

“I’m going to have an interior designer come in and make this place really homey,” Bane explains as he sweeps his hand out before him. It’s just a dirt cave at the moment, and I really can’t envision anything but what it is currently.

“You think that’s really the right move?” I ask, and Bane’s eyebrows meet his hairline.

“Why wouldn’t it be? I want people to feel comfy before I take them apart.”

Luca lets out a small laugh, rubbing at his jaw. “You serious?”

“Of course I am! I’m a great host!”

“We weren’t saying you aren’t, just…surprised is all. This is a new level of fucked.”

Bane gasps and looks around, his eyes wide before he giggles.

“It is. But I like it. I want a washable rug and some nice art on the walls.”

“If that’s what you want, then who are we to stop you?”

“Exactly. Georgiy gave me the idea. His place is so nice and fancy. And anyway, I want an upgrade. I’m a hard worker and deserve it. And a raise. I definitely deserve that.”

Luca’s eyebrows rise. “Don’t you already make more than most? I remember Anthony telling me this.”

“Yes, well, *this* is my raise. This makeover. I asked for it and I’m going to get it. So what colors do you think the walls should be in here? Blue? Purple? I’m thinking something soothing before I take out their fingernails.”

“God,” I murmur, and Luca laughs, the sound warming my insides.

“God is one thing they’ll be begging for when I get my saws out. Want to see them? Diablo sent me one that I really like.”

We let him show off his tools for a while until Anthony and Tatum appear, both looking slightly wrecked and out of breath.

“Oh, you’re done. How was it?” Bane asks.

“Very nice,” Tatum replies and then waggles his eyebrows. “But I’m exhausted. How an old man like Anthony has such stamina, I’ll never know.”

Anthony glowers at him, but goes ignored.

“I get it. I ponder this as well,” I say, and Luca’s eye twitches.

“I do worry about their knees sometimes,” Tatum adds, and I snort softly.

“I worry about their backs.”

“Oh god, I know. Pretty soon they’ll be using walkers with little green tennis balls on the feet.”

Anthony growls and pulls Tatum into him, kissing him fiercely and leaving Bane shifting on his feet in excitement. Their chemistry ratchets up

the temperature in the room by at least ten degrees.

Luca peers over at me and wets his lips.

“I’ll show you just how much stamina I have when we’re alone.”

Bane squeals, fanning himself with his cowboy hat. “Do you want company? I can watch and give pointers.”

“No company and your cowboy hat was on the wrong way,” I say, grabbing it from him, turning it around, and putting it back on his head.

Bane pouts and blinks up at us. But before he can say anything, Anthony interjects.

“We should get back upstairs. If we leave Lex alone for too long, he’ll have this whole place bugged.”

“I told you. Little shit,” I murmur as we all move out of Bane’s space and back up the stairs.

“What if he’s put cameras in our bedroom?” Tatum asks as he links his hand with Anthony’s.

“Then we’ll put on a show,” he replies.

Luca peers over at me and his finger slides up my palm before he twists it around one of mine. We walk like that until we return to Anthony’s office. There we find Lex still on his computer, a teacup in one hand, his mouth stuffed full of food.

“Oh, hi there, horny fucks. That big bodyguard came in here and tried to seduce me with scones.”

Tatum giggles and flops down in the chair next to Lex.

“I had to let him down gently. I’m already taken.”

“I think he was just being nice,” Tatum says and then waggles his fingers. “Did you find anything?”

“No, neither of us have. Yet. But don’t worry, we have a plan.”

“We have thoughts of a plan,” Diablo interjects.

“Thoughts and prayers.”

Tatum laughs and then scoots his chair closer. “I want to see how this all works.”

“Oh, it’s terribly boring, but you’re welcome to stay. Would you like some tea?”

He points to the teapot, and Tatum takes him up on it, leaving Anthony to move behind his desk and take a seat, chatting with Diablo as he goes.

Luca peers over at me and steps closer, his pinky curling around mine.

“Should we take a nice walk?”

“Your back doesn’t hurt? Your knees?”

He scowls at me and leans in, his lips at my ear. “I’ll show you how capable I am, slut.”

I shiver and let him pull me out of the office, hearing Lex jeer as we go, making lewd comments, but they go ignored.

I want Luca to prove me wrong.

We take a long walk around the perimeter of the estate, slowly, our hands linked, stopping occasionally to let him push me up against the fence and kiss me senseless. It’s intimate, personal. I feel like he’s cracking my chest wide open and embedding himself inside of me. It happened three years ago, that night he sank into me, whispered filthy things into my ear…

Oh fuck. I’m ruined.

There’s no going back now.

This is it for me.

“So, you’re no longer grumpy?” I ask, and he bites my bottom lip, his eyes sparkling with mischief.

“I was upset earlier. Not grumpy.”

“You were pouting. Behaving like a child.”

He meets my gaze, his fingers trailing up my arm and curling into my hair.

“You hurt my feelings, Vik. You know I’m a sensitive man. My aunt told you so.”

I roll my eyes, the cold wind whipping around us as I pull him in closer.

“Fine, but tell me this. Are you playing with me?”

“I do like a game.”

“But me. Am I a game?”

He kisses me softly, his tongue sliding into my mouth. I suck on it, moaning around it before he pulls away. I wait for his response, wondering what he will tell me. Wondering if I’ll stop this if it’s nothing more than the chase for him.

“This isn’t a fucking game, Vik,” he finally says.

I let out a relieved breath. “What is it then?”

He presses his forehead against mine and our noses brush.

“Something more.”

“You sure?”

“Yes. And what am I to you?”

I kiss him again and whisper, “Something more.”

He grins against my lips and then pulls back, grabbing a cigarette. “What would you do without me?”

“Drown.”

I light that damnable thing and watch him inhale, smoke billowing around him.

“You know, this is a terrible addiction.”

“It is, but I’ve been smoking since I was twelve. There’s no stopping it now.”

“Jesus.”

“I’ve stopped a few times, but I quite like it. I’d miss it too much if it were gone completely. And what’s your vice, Vik?”

I bite back that it’s him, that he’s the man I’ve been unhealthily obsessing over since I was a teen. Instead, I swallow the truth.

“I guess sex.”

“You *are* a horny boy.”

I blush as his fingers move to my groin, stroking me. Arching up into him, I reach out and grab onto his shoulders.

“Oh fuck,” I moan, sensation traveling down my spine.

“Yes. Fucking. You love it, don’t you?”

“I do. Are you going to show me how you can keep up with me? That you’re not a decrepit old man?”

He chuckles and squeezes my cock roughly.

“I’ve shown you plenty. But I’ll make sure you know. Tonight. Maybe I’ll stuff that wet hole with my cock. Would you like that? Would you whine like a whore?”

I gasp as he spins me around, my face up against the fence, my ass against his cock. He grinds against it, the scent of wet grass and smoke filling my lungs.

“Say you’re a whore. My whore.”

I groan and nod, forcing those words from my mouth.

“Will you let me fuck you again?” he asks.

“God, yes.”

“Mm, I’ll make sure I fuck you so good you can’t walk straight the next day,” he says, making me shiver. He arches up against me, the hard shape of his cock dragging against my ass before he pulls away, leaving me trembling and silently begging for more. He presses a kiss against my neck when his phone pings.

He sighs and I let out a shaky breath, feeling topsy-turvy.

“We need to get back to work, pretty boy. Anthony just messaged and told me Lex and Diablo found something.”

“Fuck.”

“I know. He has the worst fucking timing. I wanted to watch you come in your pants.”

I huff and push off the fence, facing Luca who is grinning smugly.

“I wouldn’t have come in my pants, asshole. I have control.”

“You have a hair trigger when it comes to me. I can’t wait to feel that hole flex around my cock tonight. Strangle it.”

A wheeze leaves me as he brushes his hand across my cheek and then links his fingers with mine.

“Come on. It’s good news. Let’s go get this fucker.”

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15

LUCA

"Pink is for sure being distributed out of a sex club in Palm Springs," Lex says, looking slightly smug. He grabs a donut from the tray sitting on the desk and stuffs it in his mouth. Diablo is missing from the iPad screen, his chair swiveling slightly as if he rushed off. Who knows where he went, the little demon.

"A sex club?" I ask.

"Yep. Palm fucking Springs. Can you believe it? I'm going to see if William wants to go check it out. He's on his way over. You get to meet my snack of a man."

"How did you find out so fast? Just minutes ago, you had nothing," I say, grabbing a donut and taking a bite before offering the rest to Viktor. I feel his lips brush my finger as I feed it to him, and I can't help it when my dick swells in my pants. Outside was something more, the promise of splitting him wide open tonight making my entire body grow warm with desire.

And the fact he admitted he's mine.

Well, that's just the icing on the cake.

"Oh god, don't even ask that." Lex's face screws up and he sighs. "Martha and Vikki told me when they called to check in."

I peer over at Viktor, and he shrugs. He has a crumb on his bottom lip, so I reach over and swipe it off.

"Who the fuck is that?" I finally ask.

“They’re little old ladies who have far too much arthritis to be going to sex clubs or knowing about the sale of illicit drugs! Apparently, they found a way to elude me and went last weekend. She called to catch up and when I told her what I was doing, she gave me all this info.”

Just as he says that, his phone rings, and he swipes at the screen, putting it on speaker.

“Martha, hello again. Are you going to give me another heart attack? What have you done now?”

“Oh, love, don’t worry. I’m not doing anything naughty. I just thought of something else.” She cackles, and Lex pinches the bridge of his nose in exacerbation.

“Oh, lord have mercy.”

“Don’t worry. It’s not bad. In the grand scheme of things, that is.”

“That is not helpful, Martha. Tell me before I get a stomachache.”

Anthony grins from behind his desk as Martha cackles loudly once more. And I can’t help but smile at the ridiculousness of it. I think I’d rather like this old lady if I ever met her. She’s a wild card.

“Well, Vikki reminded me of this. When we were at the club, there was this guy there who was selling the drugs. He was quite the talker and he told me a few things. Not that I can remember what he said. My memory isn’t like it used to be. But we took a picture with him. Would you like me to send it to you?”

“Yes.”

“Shoot, how do I send a picture again? Vikki! Where are my glasses?” she shouts and then the phone clatters as if someone dropped it.

“Jesus,” Lex murmurs as he closes his eyes. “I can’t cope.”

We hear the commotion over the phone, and Tatum giggles as he waits for the big reveal. It takes far longer than we expected. Lex has to slowly go over how to send the picture and has to do this multiple times until we finally hear a *ping*, and Lex pulls the image up.

“Did it send? I think I deleted something on my phone and now all the apps are gone.”

“Good fuck,” Lex murmurs as he holds the phone up, showing two old ladies with blue and pink hair in a seedy club with a man between them.

A guy with a pierced ear and a smug smile.

“Henry,” I growl, and Lex stares down at the phone, shooting the picture off to me and Anthony before he pinches the bridge of his nose

again.

“Thanks, Martha. And please promise me you’ll stay away from Palm Springs. And sex clubs, and for god’s sake, tell me you had the guy use a condom.”

“Who said it was a guy!” Martha shouts, and Lex rolls his eyes.

He takes the call off of speaker and stands up, moving out of Anthony’s office as he chastises her gently for being so irresponsible. When he’s gone, we turn to one another and the seriousness of the situation looms.

“Who’s going to tell Bane?” I ask.

“Not it,” Tatum chimes in as he leans back against Anthony’s chest. “He will lose his mind.”

Anthony takes the glass of bourbon from his desk and takes a sip, thinking this through.

“Viktor and Luca, I want you to take a few men and go to this club. Lex has the address. I want to see if we can catch Henry in the act. I want Bane to have a chance with him as well. I’d love to know what the fuck he thinks he’s doing messing with us like this. And I’ll send that picture to Declan and see if he recognizes him. Fuck. That little shit. He’s messed with the wrong family.”

“Is he the one dumping the bodies?” Vik asks, and Anthony shakes his head.

“No fucking clue. But I wouldn’t put it past him. Seems he has a grudge against us and wants to take us down.”

I run my tongue across my front teeth and then reply, “He won’t be able to.”

But Anthony seems unsure. “We can’t get complacent. He’s more dangerous than we realize.”

“Especially if he’s behind the body dumps,” Tatum adds, and Anthony pulls him closer.

“Exactly. We don’t know his motive, which makes him a liability.” Then he whispers quietly to Tatum, “You okay, Little Light?”

Tatum turns slightly, blinking at him over his shoulder.

“Yeah. I am. I’m safe with you.”

Anthony pulls his hand up, the one with the missing finger, and brushes his lips across it.

“Good. I won’t let anyone hurt you again.”

“I know.”

The trust they have, the love, it makes me realize that something inside of me is broken. I think it died that day my family died. My aunt and uncle rebuilt some of it during the years I lived with them, but I was too broken by the time I arrived. I still am. I can't ever give anyone what they need, what they want. I peer over at Viktor, who is texting on his phone, probably gathering some more guards to go with us to Palm Springs, and I feel my chest expand.

I don't know if I can ever love someone the way they need, ever fully give someone what they want. I'm too fucked up. But Viktor, perhaps he's different. He's just as broken as me.

I think together we can make something work.

Or at least we can try.

"What?" he asks when he catches me staring.

"Nothing, just wanted to remind you to bring lube for the trip."

He scowls at me, but I can see the way his cheeks redden.

"I won't fucking forget that," he grumbles and then nudges me. I pull him into me slightly, grabbing onto the back of his neck and massaging him gently. "Anyway, I have Jax, Quincy, and Rafe on call. They're ready to head out with us."

"Good. Keep me updated," Anthony says and then presses his face into Tatum's neck. "I want to be kept in the loop for all of it."

"Will do," I say and then move to the office door. I'm ready for this trip, to put an end to whatever this little shit has planned for us. And more importantly, ready for tonight when I can get Viktor all to myself.

I'm going to make him scream.

The drive to Palm Springs takes over two hours due to traffic and by the time we check into our hotel, Viktor is grumbling about how hungry he is.

"You get hangry, don't you?" I say with a smirk as I touch his lips gently.

"I'm fine. It was just a long drive."

"Let's grab something to eat and then we can ask some of the staff questions about what's been happening locally. We have plenty of time to get to the club."

“Fine. I could eat.”

I touch his stomach and feel the muscles flex under my palm.

“Good boy,” I murmur and then lead Viktor and the three guards to the café in the hotel. As we grab a seat, we see Bane appear through the front doors, his gaze drifting over the lobby as if looking for someone. When he sees us, he grins and waves.

“Fucking hell,” Viktor murmurs as I narrow my eyes at him.

“Hello!” he shouts as he bounds over to us. “Fancy meeting you here.”

“How did you get here, Bane?” I ask and then look around the table, trying to figure out who snuck him into the trunk. No one looks guilty though, so I turn my gaze to Bane, who is pulling a chair up next to Jax.

“Oh, this is just a happy happenstance. I don’t know how I got here.”

I arch an eyebrow, and Bane leans his head against Jax’s shoulder.

“Did you sneak him into the cars?” I ask the bodyguard.

His cheeks flush and he shakes his head. “No, Boss. I just put the suitcases in. And a large duffle.”

“And what was in the duffle?”

“I assumed the weapons.”

I huff and then shake my head. “No, those were already secured in the SUV. I wouldn’t put them in a duffle bag. Shit. You put Bane in the trunk.”

Bane wiggles in his seat and then leans forward, unable to sit still.

“Don’t be mad. I tricked them all. I meant to let you know once we were far enough away, but I fell asleep.”

“Jesus, Bane. Anthony didn’t want you here for a reason.”

Bane’s lips wobble. “I know, but I must have my revenge. You can’t ask me to stay back and just wait.”

“You would have had your turn eventually. But we don’t want you showing up and ruining it.”

“But it’s a sex club. I love sex! And clubs. I even brought my chest harness and butt plug.”

“Jesus,” Viktor murmurs and then peers over at me. He’s hiding his smile behind his hands, and honestly, I can’t even be upset right now. Viktor’s thigh is pressed against my leg, his ankle hooked around mine. Bane’s random appearance can’t take away from the way I’m feeling right now. Content. Happy even.

“You can come to the club, Bane, but you will behave. Jax, you’ll watch him, understand? He’s your responsibility.”

Jax nods solemnly. “Will do, Boss.”

“Good. We aren’t fucking this up. No matter how much we want to murder him on sight, we won’t. We keep it under wraps until Anthony tells us what to do. I think this goes beyond Henry. I can’t imagine that little shit could manage an enterprise this large.”

“You think it’s large?” Vik asks.

“Don’t you? It’s obvious that this is being distributed outside of L.A. and into the high desert. And who knows if it’s traveled to Nevada or Arizona.”

“Hopefully Declan knows something we don’t,” Jax says just as the waiter shows up. We haven’t even had a chance to look at the menus. Apparently, Bane knows what he wants, though, because he pipes up.

“Oh, hello! I’d like a Silly Goose Martini, a hamburger rare, a side of bacon and oh, oh, you have cheese fries. I’d like those with jalapeños on them. Oooh, and can I have a glass of water as well with a lemon? Oh, and a slice of pie.”

We stare at him as he rattles this off, the waiter quickly punching in the items on his screen. When Bane’s done, he lets out a loud exhale.

“Alright, I think I’m done.” He glances down at the menu and then adds, “Oh, and some onion rings. The ones with the good sauce.”

“You done?” I ask, and Viktor muffles a laugh. I like that sound a little too much. I want to make him do it again.

“I think so,” Bane says and then smiles, patting his stomach. “I have an insatiable hunger.”

He waggles his eyebrows, and Jax snorts, ruffling his hair.

“You’re fucking weird, Bane.”

“I know, but you adore me and want to fuck me, so I can’t be that bad.”

Jax’s cheeks darken and he stammers. “No, I don’t. I’m not gay.”

Viktor snorts so loudly at that he almost chokes. I side-eye him and then lean over.

“Do I need to murder him, Vik?”

His eyes meet mine and he shifts closer to me. “Why would you need to murder him?”

“Have you fucked him?”

My voice lowers, possession pulsing through me. I don’t want Viktor to fuck anyone but me. I don’t even want to know about other men having him. It makes something ugly shift inside of me. “Tell me.”

Vik's eyes flick across the table at everyone watching us. Jax looks slightly nervous, but I pay him no mind. My focus is solely on the man next to me, the one who has wormed his way into my body and has set up a home.

I can't evict him now. Squatters rights and all that.

"I can tell you later, if you promise not to overreact."

"So that means yes."

My hand lands on his thigh, and I squeeze it roughly.

"Was it as good as me?" I whisper in his ear, not even caring that we have an audience.

His cheeks flame and his eyes meet mine.

"No. You ruined me for anyone else, Luca."

My nostrils flare and I feel my chest puff up.

"Good. Now pick something to eat. I don't want you hungry."

He peers down at the menu, and I let my gaze swivel around the table. They all avert their gazes, but I can see the smirks on their lips.

Assholes. They know what they just witnessed.

The fall of Luca Rossi.

"Now, let's order dinner. We need to be well-fed before we get to the club. No drinking. No drugs, and no fucking." I peer over at Viktor and squeeze his leg before meeting Bane's gaze.

"No fucking, Bane."

He pouts, his eyelashes batting. "Are you sure? We drove all this way."

"You snuck in. You didn't drive. You napped."

Bane's pouty lip disappears and he wiggles in his seat. "I just need you to lower your expectations, Boss. I can't promise no sex. I just can't do that. I may get swept up in all the hormones and do something I don't mean to do."

"That's not a thing," Viktor says, and I arch an eyebrow at him. "What? I have perfect control over my body. I don't just go around fucking people."

Bane giggles and then leans into Jax once more. "It's fine. I just need you to really lower that bar when it comes to me."

Pursing my lips, I give a subtle nod. It was a Hail Mary. I didn't actually think he'd listen to me. He never does.

"Fine, but be aware of your surroundings, and for fuck's sake, don't let Henry's dick anywhere near you."

Bane gasps, holding a hand up to his chest. “I would never! He’s dead to me! I can’t wait to get my hands on him and take him apart. I’m going to start with his nose and move down his body. Slowly.”

Bane shivers as the waiter appears once more, taking all our orders. When the food arrives, we eat slowly, conversing and going over the plans we have for tonight. They’re loose and malleable, but they’ll do. We have no idea what we’ll find when we arrive.

Bane moans around his food as we discuss all of this and manages to consume his plates in a matter of minutes, which is truly impressive. You’d think he hadn’t eaten all week with how much he just put down. He sits back and lets out a small burp, looking content.

“Do you feel better now?” I ask.

“Oh yes, that nap really made me famished, but I’m feeling revived now. I’m ready to find that bitch and murder him.”

“There’s a chance he’s moved on from this place. The old ladies saw him last week,” Viktor says, trying to temper Bane’s expectations.

“I know, but we’re on the scent. I will find him. Justice will be mine!” He raises his fist, a fork still in his hand. Patrons glance over, and I reach across the table and pull his arm down.

“Enough, Bane. Save that for when you actually find him.”

He huffs and then reaches his fork over to Viktor’s plate and snags a bite of eggs.

“Have a little more room,” he murmurs, and I move Vik’s plate out of reach from his grabby hands.

“Find another plate to eat off of.”

“Fine, bossy bitch,” Bane says, and Viktor hides his smile behind his hand once more.

“Eat up, pretty boy,” I whisper in his ear, and his eyes sparkle. “You’re going to need it when I finally get you alone.”

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16

VIKTOR

After speaking with some of the hotel staff and finding nothing of importance, we get ready for the club. Arriving is anti-climactic, much to Bane's frustration.

"This is boring," he says, looking at the worn-down building. "And kind of creepy."

Luca glances over at Bane as we get out of the SUV, the guards trailing after us.

"Creepier than your butchery?" I ask.

"Yes, that's home. Duh. This is a worn-down building with ants."

He rolls his eyes and then strides forward, wearing this chest harness and a short skirt.

"He has nice legs," Jax observes, and I nudge him.

"Don't even fucking go there. Georgiy will murder you."

Jax blushes and nods, the group moving toward the large, guarded metal door. We can hear the low beat of music coming from inside, but it's not loud and raucous like a club. More sinister, though, in an odd way.

The bouncer, a large bald man wearing all black, eyes us suspiciously.

"You have the password?"

We glance at each other, and Luca sighs, stepping up, a knife in his hands. "Let us in or we'll dispose of you in the dumpster out back."

The man stares down at Luca, unbothered. Apparently, he's some kind of cyborg and has no fear.

"No password, no entrance."

Bane giggles as Luca eyes him.

“Don’t even try it, Bane. I’ll handle it.” Luca eyes the bald man once more and says, “We’re with the Costello family. I’m sure your boss knows who we are. We’re here on business.”

The bouncer looks unsure, his eyes flitting over us, landing on Bane, who is bouncing on his feet. But he finally pulls out his phone and calls someone, talking in clipped tones. When he’s done, he hangs up and the door swings open.

“Apologies,” he murmurs, and we push past him, Luca the last to go through.

As we step into the dingy and dark room, I can smell it, the scent of sex and booze. My ass clenches around the plug I placed in there earlier, my body eager for whatever Luca will give me later.

But right now, we need to be vigilant to find Henry and figure out what the fuck he’s doing, what his motives are, and most importantly, his end game.

Really, anything we can find out about Henry would be important. Hopefully Lex and Diablo dig something up soon. We could use anything at the moment.

“Find me if you see anything,” Luca tells everyone. Quincy and Rafe each take a corner of the room, blending into the shadows, while Jax moves toward the woman working the pole and glances up at her longingly. Bane follows him but sneaks away shortly after, disappearing down a hallway.

I should say something, but I don’t. I let him do his thing.

“Let’s go talk to the bartender,” Luca says, his hand landing on my back as we move toward the bar. It’s not as crowded in here as Eden, but there are plenty of people fucking within view. Enough to make my pheromones increase, to make my cock perk up and my breathing grow labored.

“What can I get you?” a woman says, her breasts nearly spilling out of her top as we come to a stop at the bar.

Luca eyes her tits for a second before meeting her gaze, his hand moving from my lower back, beneath my waistband and down to my ass, two fingers sliding between my crack and pressing on the plug sitting there. I bite back a gasp as he plays with it, pressing against the flared base.

“Who do we speak to about…product?”

The woman leans forward, her hands sprawled across the bar top.

“You cops?”

Luca chuckles darkly. “Far from it.”

“How do I know?”

“You have someone else we can speak to? I’m sure your boss already knows we’re here,” Luca says, his hand pulling away from my ass and resting on the counter. I inhale shakily, stepping closer to him, wanting him to touch me again.

Fuck, why did he have to do that here?

I can’t fucking think now.

“I haven’t heard shit,” she replies.

“Better check then,” Luca replies, and she arches a thin eyebrow and purses her lips, pulling out a phone and calling someone.

She speaks quickly, her mouth set in a frown, and then she freezes, her eyes widening slightly.

“He’ll be right out,” she says and swallows roughly.

“Good,” Luca replies, turning his gaze toward me, his lips curling at the corners. “I didn’t realize you had a plug in that pretty ass,” he whispers into my ear. “You wanted to be ready for me, didn’t you? You want me to just slip inside.”

I stare at him, feeling my skin flame. “Yes.”

“Then let’s get this over with so I can remind you how good it can be,” he replies, just as a stout man appears with an ill-fitting suit and a lopsided mustache.

“You must be Mr. Rossi. Welcome. Welcome.” His eyes flit toward me, and I stand up a little straighter, trying to behave like a fucking bodyguard and not some kind of needy slut.

Luca nods. “Thank you for meeting with us. This is Viktor, my partner. Do we have somewhere we can discuss this in private?”

“Yes. Yes. Right this way.”

My heart flutters at that word.

Partner. Is that what I am to him?

I don’t have a chance to ask. The man turns on his heel, and we follow him through the crowded room and down a dimly lit hallway. He unlocks a door, and we step into a small, cluttered office. He walks around to the other side of his desk and spreads his hands in front of him.

“How can I help you?” he asks, looking slightly nervous.

Luca cocks his head, his hand pulling the knife from his pocket and flicking it open.

“We’ve heard that you’re selling a new product here.”

The man nods, his throat bobbing. He’s starting to sweat. “Yes, yes, of course. There’s no need for the knife. I’ll tell you anything you’d like to know. Would you like to see it? Henry assured me it’s the best since it came from you.”

Luca freezes, his silence permeating the room.

“What do you mean?”

“I mean…Henry told me the Costellos were the supplier. He was just distributing it.”

Luca takes a step closer to the sweating man, who takes a step back.

“We aren’t supplying anything,” he says, and the man nods.

“Of course. Of course.” He makes a gesture like he’s zipping his lips and throws away the key. It only causes Luca to roll his eyes.

“Not like that, you dipshit. I mean, we aren’t supplying this new drug. He lied, played you like a fool.”

“But…but that’s the word…that’s what I’ve heard. That’s what everyone is saying.”

Luca’s rage boils over, his hand reaching out and grabbing onto the man, smashing his face into the desk. Blood spurts from his nose as the knife is held up to his eye.

“Tell me the fucking truth,” he hisses, his voice deathly low, a growl.

It does things to my libido. A terrible time and place, but fuck, I want him to push me over this desk and fuck me. Right now. Blood and all.

Luca’s eyes flick to me and his lips curl when he sees my straining erection.

“Later, pretty boy. I promise.”

The man grunts as Luca’s knife moves closer and closer to his eyeball.

“Now, tell me everything and maybe, if I’m feeling gracious, you’ll leave here with both eyes.”

The smell of piss infiltrates the space, and I screw up my face at the scent.

Not that it’s unexpected. People piss themselves far too often when they’re faced with Luca. The only good thing about it is it tampers my libido slightly.

“He just…he told me he worked with you. I confirmed it with a few clubs.”

“Which ones?” Luca asks, and the man grunts.

“Shit. The Sirens. They vouched for him. Said the family was supplying this drug and moving it through them.”

“Who vouched?”

“Tish!”

“But we have someone planted there. Tish must be withholding. I suppose it’s a smart move. Keeping her circle tight.” Luca’s gaze meets mine, and he bites his bottom lip. “You were right, baby,” he says, his eyes darkening.

“I’m always fucking right,” I reply, and Luca wets his lips.

“You’re gonna get rewarded for that.”

I shift on my feet and grab my dick at that promise.

Luca’s focus moves back to the man once more. “And where is Henry now?”

“I don’t fucking know. I don’t! He stopped showing up, left the product with me, and I haven’t heard from him. Just have his bank account details for payment!”

“We need that information. Now.”

The man nods, and Luca lets him up. He fumbles with a pad of paper, shakily writing down numbers. It takes him far too long, making mistakes, scratching them out and starting over. When we finally get it, Luca snaps a picture and sends it to Anthony and Lex.

“Are you sure you don’t know where he went?”

“I don’t. He didn’t say. You can ask my employees. They may know. Fuck. I’d tell you.” The man looks as if he’s going to pass out, and Luca looks pleased.

“If I find out that you’ve withheld information, lied, or obscured the truth, I will be back. And if I have to sit through that shit traffic to get here, there won’t be any pieces of you left to find.”

He nods and shakes his head. “I told you everything I know. I promise.”

He looks like he’s about to cry, and Luca steps up to him, grabbing onto his oversized shirt and bringing him closer.

“The Costellos have nothing to do with this drug. You make that known.”

He nods, his cheeks jiggling as he does, and Luca tosses him aside, moving toward the door and flinging it open. He steps out, and I follow, the two of us moving down a dark hallway toward the main room. Bane is still nowhere to be seen, but we easily find Jax, Quincy, and Rafe.

“We’ll tell them what we’ve found and then leave,” Luca says. “There’s nothing more we can do until Anthony or Lex find something substantial with those bank details.”

“Are you sure?” I ask as his hand cups my jaw.

He leans in and kisses me slowly, his tongue dragging against mine, making me almost dizzy with need.

“I’m sure, pretty boy. I want to fuck you while we wait for more information to go on.”

I groan as he reaches between us and cups my hard cock.

I swallow and nod, following Luca toward the guards and listening to him explain the plan. The three of them will stay, keeping an eye out for Henry and making sure Bane doesn’t get into any trouble. And if they find any more information, they’re to let us know immediately.

They nod solemnly, and Jax winks at me as I hand the keys to the SUV to Quincy, and then Luca and I make our way to the exit. The cold air calms my overheated skin, and I let out a relieved breath when Luca calls for a car.

When we get inside, Luca’s hand moves to my cock once more and he massages it, his gaze on the road ahead of us, driving me crazy with each stroke. By the time we arrive at the hotel, I’m in a state. Unhinged and feral.

I can barely walk, my body supported by Luca as he drags me to the elevator and pushes me up against the wall once we’re inside, kissing me filthily until I’m panting.

When we make it to our room, he shoves me onto the bed, and I can do nothing but let him stare, his eyes slightly wild, his cock straining from the confines of his pants.

“Look at you. Desperate for it.”

“Yes. *Yes*.”

“You want me to destroy that pretty hole?”

“Please.”

He leans over and kisses me, licking into my mouth before pushing up and ripping my shirt from my head. His fingers drag down my heaving chest to the button of my pants. He drags them down my thighs, pulling my shoes off in the process, leaving me only in my socks and my jockstrap.

His nostrils flare, his fingertips trailing across my thighs, pulling them open, exposing me to him.

My knees hit my chest, and Luca’s fingers press against my plug.

“Is this what you were doing in the bathroom before we left for the club?”

“Yes.”

He grins as he starts to pull it out, my hole flexing around it as it’s extracted. It’s a thick and long plug that will make it easy for Luca to push into me without any resistance.

“Look at you,” he murmurs as he stares at my hole, open and wet, lube trickling out. “You wanted it to be easy, didn’t you? A quick fuck.”

I nod and let my legs fall to the sides, his fingers trailing down my taint to my open hole, and he pushes two inside, finding my prostate and working it gently, making my back arch up, my cock leak.

“You want it fast. I’ll give that to you, Vik, and then I’m going to fuck you slow. I’m going to fuck you so many times tonight. Tomorrow you’re going to have trouble sitting, walking. You’re going to think of me with each move you make.”

“Please,” I moan. “Please. *Please*.”

He chuckles and then pulls his fingers from me and undoes his shirt, giving me a slow striptease, exposing each muscle, all those tattoos.

I’m wild with lust now, my cock almost close to exploding just from the thought of him fucking me again. A repeat of that night.

The night that changed everything.

When he’s naked, his hands wrap around my legs and he pulls my ass right to the edge of the bed. His cock slots at my wet hole, and he pushes inside. His eyes fall to where he’s entering me, and I can’t help but watch the way his jaw clenches as he sinks into me.

“I remember this. So fucking tight,” he murmurs as his big dick tunnels into me, bottoming out in seconds. He holds himself inside of me, his eyes meeting mine. “I’ve dreamt of this.”

I blink up at him, my entire body on fire.

“Have you, Vik? Have you touched yourself to thoughts of me?”

“Yes,” I admit, my secrets no longer that. Just open and honest.

He drags out of me slowly until just the tip is at my entrance and then he pushes back in. He moves with purpose, slowly, as if memorizing everything about this. It makes this so much more than a quick fuck.

“Look at you swallowing me up. Look how filthy you are.”

I grab the sheets to ground me as he continues to torture me, his dick stretching me wider, my body loosening and tightening with each slow

thrust forward. It's maddening.

"More," I moan, begging, clawing at the mattress. Luca pulls my legs up over his shoulders, his hands lifting my hips as he continues to make me writhe beneath him. He's enjoying this, the way I'm mindless with lust, the way I've lost the ability to speak or breathe.

And then suddenly, he pulls out and snaps his hips forward so hard I cry out. My neck arches, my back bowed off the bed as he does it again. And *again*. Pain pulses through me, zinging up my spine and down my thighs, and at the same time, pleasure infuses with it, creating a beautiful anomaly.

Only he can make me feel this way.

He continues to fuck into me at a brutal pace, the veins on his arms and neck bulging, his muscles straining as he uses my body as a toy, a hole, a thing to fulfill his needs.

Pleasepleasepleasepleaseplease.

I'm moaning, pleading, my cock leaking profusely. It drips down my length, and he bends forward, the new angle making my eyes cross. His face is above mine, my knees at my ears, his dick pistoning in and out of my hole.

"You ready to come, pretty boy?" he whispers, his lips brushing against mine.

"*Please*."

It's all I can say as my hand moves to my cock between us. It takes only a few strokes and I explode, stars swirling behind my eyes. My hole clenches around him, and he grunts, his lips meeting mine in a desperate kiss as he empties himself inside. I feel it, the way he marks me.

Luca's.

His.

He falls on top of me, my legs sliding down his sides until they hook behind his back. His dick is still inside of me as we kiss softly, our tongues tangling in a slow, tantalizing dance.

When we finally pull apart, my lips spit-slick and swollen, Luca stares down at me.

"Was that good?" I ask, needing to know. "Was it as good as the first time?"

"You know it was," he says. "And we're not done either. Now that we've started this, I'm not going to stop."

He pulls out of me with a shift of his hips, and I feel his release leave my body. He falls to my side as I push myself further up on the bed, and his fingers trail down my stomach to my softening cock. He smears the release into my abdomen and then moves down to my hole. He slides two fingers inside, as if pushing his release back inside of me.

The possession he has over me…

I sigh, and he kisses my shoulder.

“How do you feel?” he asks.

“Wonderful,” I say as he touches my prostate. He massages it for a few minutes until I’m whining before he pulls his fingers from me and touches my cock, tugging on it, making it harden in his palm.

“Luca?” I ask, turning into him slightly, our legs tangling, his hand moving to my hip.

“Mm?”

“Why do you give me the black rose every year?”

It’s a silly question, one that I’ve always told myself I’d never ask, but I want to know.

His nose brushes against mine, dragging me closer to him so we’re touching in every possible way.

“Black roses mean the death of something, but they can also mean rebirth.”

His eyes meet mine, those dark, sparkling depths.

“What died?” I ask, and he kisses me gently.

“When I fucked you that night, the way you felt around me, the way you clung to me…” he breathes deeply and then adds, “…I knew I wasn’t straight. That part of me died that night.”

My chest swells and my eyes sting. “And what was reborn?”

“Me. I was. I tried to fight it, and you did too, but we knew this was inevitable.”

I can’t help but lean forward and kiss him, everything I’m feeling bleeding into it, letting him inhale it.

“Inevitable,” I finally say, and he grins at me.

“You’re mine now, Vik.”

“Yours.”

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17

LUCA

I fuck him while he's still asleep, sliding my cock into his lubed hole and listening as he wakes with a moan.

"Yes," he groans, his tight hole enveloping my cock.

I remember that first night three years ago. The way he felt against me, smelling like soap, like something entirely him. I couldn't help myself then. I gave in.

And here I am. Giving in again.

Viktor's back is to my chest, his ass to my groin. Before he fell asleep, I worked more lube into him as he sighed, knowing this was the end goal. That I was going to fuck him until he couldn't move without thinking of me.

"Oh god, so good," he moans as he arches his hips back, meeting my forward thrusts.

The way he engulfs me, the easy way he takes me.

My little slut.

I knew it that night and I know it now. Only this time, I have him. He's not fighting it.

My hand reaches around and shuttles up and down his cock as I slowly fuck into him, feeling the clench of his ass against me, the way he sighs and murmurs incoherently as I drag him closer and closer to the edge.

"Tell me how much you love it," I whisper into his ear, his hand moving behind him to grab at my hair. "Tell me how much you need it."

“Love it. Need it. Love. Love,” his words slur as I continue to bring him toward the edge.

And then I stop, holding myself into him, squeezing the base of his dick and making him whine.

“Not yet, baby. Not fucking yet.”

He whimpers, and I drag my teeth across his neck, waiting until he’s writhing back against me, making me grunt. It’s only then that I start to tunnel back into him. It’s slow and torturous, the two of us panting by the time I finally let us both fall over the edge.

He burrows his head into the pillow and almost sobs, my fingers moving back into his hole and once more pushing my cum back into him.

We’re messes, completely and utterly wrecked. But then I knew that would happen the minute I gave in. It’s why I resisted it for so many years.

“I’m not done with you,” I tell him, and he gasps as I continue to play with him, toying with him until I’m hard again. I push inside, fucking him from behind, his body sprawled out flat on the bed as I use him, alternating between slow and fast, between urgent and drawing it out.

By the time I find release for the third time tonight, I’m sure I won’t move again. Maybe I am too old, maybe my stamina isn’t up to his needs.

My eyes close, and Viktor snuggles up against me, wrapping himself around me.

“I’m not done with you,” he whispers as my mind moves into a dream state.

He’s right.

He’s not done with me.

I didn’t think he would be, not with his sex drive. Not with his need for me.

He begged just like he did that night, only this time he was unrestrained, open. He was hiding nothing.

My mind shuts down, and I sink into sleep, feeling relaxed for the first time in ages.

The flames lick at my skin and I curl in tighter, trying to escape them. I feel the sting of the spiders biting me, trying to kill me before the flames get me.

My mom said they're poisonous. I bet I die from that first.

I hear a rattling and groan, and I unfurl, peering out of the crawlspace.

Viktor. He's there, his face bloody, his hand outstretched.

I cry out, my fingernails scraping at the wooden confines, but I can't get out. I'm trapped. I watch as the fire crawls toward him, enveloping him, taking him from me.

I let out a scream that matches his, my heart caving in on itself…

"Luca. Luca!" a deep voice says, breaking me from my nightmare.

I blink my eyes open, seeing Viktor's beautiful face hovering over mine. My shaking hands move to his cheeks, holding him against me, feeling the warmth of his skin, the pulse in his neck.

"You're okay. You're fine," he whispers, and I pull him toward me, his body falling on top of mine, my hands dragging down his back, feeling his steady inhale.

"I dreamt you were burning," I choke out. "I dreamt I couldn't get to you."

"I'm here. I'm fine."

A shuddering, humiliating breath escapes me. I shouldn't have told him that, but I did. He had to know.

We're more than we were.

"Fuck."

He lets me hold him until my heart rate evens out and my breathing steadies. That's when Vik says it.

"I know you hid. But I did too."

His words hit my skin, sinking into my chest.

"There was a small cubby under my bed. I'd crawl in there and wait everything out. My mom was high so much that she never found me, never figured it out. It was my safe space. I heard so many things happen when I was in there. The beatings my mom took…but all I could think was, at least it wasn't me."

I don't say anything.

"It was okay to hide, Luca. I know you probably feel guilty. That you should have fought harder, but we were just kids. We did what we had to, to survive."

I don't respond, just let him comfort me with his words.

"I know you're probably against it, but maybe…maybe we should try to attend a trauma group. I know of one near us. Anthony told me about it,

tried to get me to go, but I fought it.”

He leans up and his eyes meet mine.

“A fucking trauma group?”

“Yeah,” he says with a small smile, his fingers tracking the stubble on my cheeks. “Maybe we should get some help.”

I huff, looking away, but he brings my gaze back to him.

“We can do it together.”

“Maybe,” I reply, not committing to anything. But maybe he’s not wrong. Maybe I need to fucking process what happened to get past it, or at least live with it in a more manageable way. Viktor has proven himself right most of the time. Perhaps he’s not wrong about this either.

“Okay, good. We can think about it. We don’t need to commit.”

He kisses me gently, and my chest swells, my hands clutching onto him. I need him at this moment, more than I care to admit.

Perhaps in every moment, actually.

Our kiss deepens and our cocks thicken. I want him more than I thought possible. No, I knew it was possible. It’s why I held off for so long. And he seems to understand what I need. In such a short time, he’s figured me out. Or perhaps he’s always known me. The way he used to watch me and study me when he was younger. Perhaps I should give him more credit.

“Can I fuck you?” he asks. “Can I take your mind off of the flames for a while?”

“Yes.”

His body rises and his palm presses against my chest, my dick sliding against his slippery crack. I feel the moment my dick notches at his hole and he slides down, taking me easily, as if he was made for this. For me.

Who am I kidding? He was. He was created for this.

“*Viktor*,” I moan as he rides me, looking beautiful above me, his head thrown back, his fingers curling into my skin, making everything zing with pleasure. I’m alight. Everything centers around him, my focus on the way he moves, the way he sounds.

He’s perfect. Everything about him. The broken, cracked parts of him, the pieces fitting seamlessly into all of mine.

He falls on top of me, our bodies satiated, completely at peace. The flames have receded, the smoke evaporated. He’s here with me, his strong heartbeat, the warmth of his skin. In a way, he heals a fragile part of me, holding it together in his hands.

With a fist, he could reduce me to rubble.

My eyes close as I inhale him.

I don’t sleep, just lie there, drifting in and out, my mind moving from the past to the present, and more importantly, to the future.

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18

VIKTOR

The phone rings, pulling us from our slumber. Luca's arm reaches out, fumbling for his phone, and I do the same, grabbing it before he can. We peer at the screen, seeing Anthony's name there.

Luca swipes at it and puts it on speaker, my head coming to rest once more on his chest.

"Hey," Luca says, sleep still prevalent in his voice.

"Diablo found him," Anthony says curtly.

"Well, that's a stretch," we hear Lex pipe up in the background. "We did it *together*."

Anthony pauses for a long moment and then sighs. "Diablo *and* Lex found him. And after speaking with Declan, he confirmed it. A man who looks a lot like Henry was recently kicked out of his casino and Declan's been trailing him. Apparently, he hurt his partner, Blake, and Declan isn't happy about it."

"Oh, fucking Henry," I murmur, and Luca's hand moves to my back, rubbing it gently.

"We'll head out this morning," Luca says. "Send me the address and tell Declan to expect us."

"I will. But first, let me tell you what Diablo *and* Lex found with the banking info you gave us."

"Shoot."

"Go ahead, Lex. Tell them."

“Well, hello, you sex fiends,” Lex begins and then I hear some clacking on his computer. “Well, let me start out by saying that banking information was very helpful. Henry Porter is a twenty-four-year-old male born and raised in Idaho. He moved down here when he was a teen. Parents are dead. Died in a homicide, and with what I know of Henry, he could have been the one to do that, but I have no evidence. Just know he is capable of murder.”

He clacks on his keys. “Hm, what else could be of use? Ah yes, he owned an illegal ant farm that was confiscated at one point, but that isn’t really relevant…oh!”

He clacks some more and adds, “He was nominated at his high school as most likely to charm an older woman and was very good at chemistry. Went to a couple years of college for it. So it makes sense that he’s the one possibly producing these drugs. And seeing as he’s charming, he probably was able to seduce the Sirens into working with him.”

“Is that all?” I ask when Lex says nothing else.

“Sorry, was eating another donut. Teddy is trying to fatten me up. Um, one other thing. He did a stint in juvenile hall for six months for arson. Burned down someone’s shed. Just watch out for him. He’s a wild card.”

“We will.”

Anthony’s voice filters over the phone. “You got all that?”

“Yeah, it helps to know who we’re trying to find.”

“Hopefully Declan has some useful information and we can put this to rest once and for all.”

“Agreed.”

A moment later, Luca hangs up and tosses his phone to the side. It hits the nightstand and tumbles to the floor.

“I don’t want to go to fucking Vegas,” I murmur, and he chuckles.

“You sore, baby?”

“I am, but fuck,” I groan and flex my ass. “It’s so good. I want to stay in here and just have sex.”

His fingers massage the globes of my ass, and I sigh.

“Pretty boy,” he whispers and then kisses the top of my head. “But we need to end this. I’m tired of dead bodies showing up at my doorstep.”

“Yeah. I do want to stay in bed for a week after this, though.”

“Being fucked?”

“Yes.”

Luca chuckles once more and then pats my ass. “Time to get up, princess. We’ve gotta move.”

“I know.”

I roll off him, my body sticky with sweat and cum, and stand up. My legs are shaky, my ass twinging from the dick I took last night. It’s an odd realization knowing I won’t need multiple men to satisfy me moving forward.

It seems Luca is enough for me. But I’m not opposed to them watching.

“Shit, I missed messages from the guys,” Luca says after picking his phone up off the floor. “Seems they lost Bane.”

“We’ll find him in the trunk, I bet. Napping.”

“Fuck knows. But they didn’t find out anything new from the club, so that was a waste.”

“It’s up to Declan then.”

“Seems so.”

We stare at each other, and Luca points to the shower. “Let’s wash up and then we can meet the guys for breakfast. It’s a four-hour drive and I don’t want you hungry.”

“Oh fuck,” I murmur, and Luca smirks.

“That ass.” He leans into me and kisses my neck. My cock perks up, and Luca reaches around me, teasing me with a lingering touch. He tugs on my length, continuing to drag his lips up and down my neck, making me lean against him, wanting to call this entire thing off and just spend the rest of the day in bed.

But we have things to do. I know it. Luca does too. His kisses eventually end and he drags me into the shower, washing me slowly, fingering my sore hole softly as I lean against his shoulder. Who would have thought Luca Rossi would be so gentle? Especially with me.

But he was three years ago.

And he was last night as well.

With careful hands, Luca turns me around, and I lean against his chest, his soapy fingers sliding up and down my abdomen, landing on my cock and stroking it. I’m relaxed, mindless, just letting him take care of me.

He leans forward, his lips landing on my shoulder as his hands drag down my thighs. And then he kneels, washing my legs and feet, his mouth on my ass cheeks, his teeth nibbling, his stubble abrading my skin.

I want him to eat my ass again. As sore as I am, I want it.

I arch my hips back, and I hear him chuckle.

“When we get to Vegas, pretty boy,” he says. “You’re too sore.”

“I can take it,” I hiss, and he bites down roughly on the globe of my ass.

“I know you can. But I’ll fuck that pretty hole when you’ve had a few hours to rest.”

I huff in annoyance, but when he stands and hands me the soap, telling me to wash him, I find myself slightly appeased.

I take my time running my soapy palms over his tattooed skin, making sure to spend a lot of time on his dick and ass before lowering myself to my knees and washing his legs. His dick is there, hard and insistent, and I can’t help but lean forward and lap at it.

He groans, his fingers fisting in my hair, and he pulls me forward.

“Now this you can do,” he says, and I fall on him, engulfing his dick, pulling it down my throat. The taste of him, the scent of soap, the way he fits perfectly in my mouth. I jerk myself in time with each of his thrusts forward.

He does it slowly, dragging it out, our groans pinging off the tiled walls.

When we come, it’s on an exhale, a sigh of relief, and I slump back, catching my breath.

Luca stands above me, his eyelashes wet with water, his chest heaving.

“Such a good boy,” he says as he swipes a drop of cum from the corner of my mouth.

He helps me stand and kisses me soundly, the steam from the bathroom making me lightheaded.

By the time we meet the guys in the hotel lobby, I’m famished. When I sink onto a wooden chair, my ass twinges and I grimace, making Luca smirk. *Asshole*, I think, and then lean over and kiss him.

When Jax, Quincy, and Rafe finally appear, their bags in their hands, we order enough food to satisfy me, and when it arrives, Luca makes sure to feed me as we update them on everything Lex told us about Henry. Bane, unsurprisingly, still hasn’t made an appearance.

“Anyone find out where he is?” Luca asks as he holds out a forkful of pancake.

“Nope. He disappeared. Went up on stage and did some kinky shit and then never found us afterward,” Jax says.

“Jesus. We need to put a tracker on him.”

“Probably a good idea,” I say around a mouthful of food.

“Do we just leave him here, then?” Jax asks, and Luca nods.

“Yes. We can’t wait. We need to head to Vegas as soon as possible. Bane can find his way home. He’ll be fine on his own. He’s a bit of a nomad.”

The guys look unsure, but it’s true. Bane has come out of worse situations than this one.

After finishing our food, we all pile into the SUVs and head out to Vegas. Luca insists on driving, letting me lean back in the passenger seat and give my ass a reprieve. I know he’s doing it smugly, the slant to his lips doing things to my stomach and chest. He’s proud of how he took me apart last night, how he made me beg and plead. I fought it for so long, kept my distance because I knew this was how it would be if I let him in.

And I did. I spread my legs and in turn, opened my heart.

There’s no going back after this. He’s seen me at my most vulnerable. He’s burrowed someplace between my ribs, and to extract him would be detrimental. To my mind. My heart.

I’ve wanted this for over fifteen years, and here I am.

Content and happy. For the first time in ages.

Luca must sense a shift in me and reaches over, his hand linking with mine.

“So, tell me, Vik,” he begins, and I roll my eyes, groaning. I know he’s going to ask something—something raw and deep, something that will crack me open even wider. His lips curl as he peers over at me. “Have all your dreams come true?”

I scoff and pinch the skin on the back of his hand. “Fuck you. You smug bastard.”

He chuckles. “Just wanted to hear it from you. Again.”

“For your gigantic ego?”

He grins, looking ridiculously hot. “Yeah. For my ego, baby.”

Jax chuckles behind us and then grunts when someone elbows him roughly. They know this is our time together. No interruptions.

I wet my lips, eyeing Luca for a long minute. “Fine. It was good, better than good. Hot. I want it again. All the fucking time.”

His thumb smooths over the back of my hand. “Am I it for you?”

“It? You mean, am I done with other men?”

“Yeah.”

I sigh and lean back, the ache in my ass delicious. “For now.”

He chuckles and pulls my hand up to his lips, kissing me softly. “You’re a terrible liar.”

We make it to the Morrigan in four and a half hours, stopping only once to grab gas and for Luca to get an ice cream cone. He shared it with me, sliding it across my lips and forcing my tongue to lap at it as he drove. My hole clenched around nothing as he did this, and my heart expanded almost painfully.

By the time we walk into the casino’s lobby, I have to kiss him. It’s not a want. It’s a must.

So I do it sloppily, aggressively, in front of everyone, not caring who sees.

I can’t hide it anymore. It’s the beginning of the end for me.

“Alright, kitten, calm down,” he says with a low laugh.

I press my forehead against his and take a deep breath, wanting to kiss him again and *again*. I can’t calm down. He’s awakened something inside of me. There’s no caging it anymore. This is what he gets for being my dream come true.

He’s going to have to live with it.

“I’ll take care of you after we meet with Declan,” he says, his thumb brushing over my bottom lip.

Reluctantly, and with a trembling body, I pull away from him and adjust myself discreetly. As we move further into the casino, two men meet us, both in suits, earpieces coiled behind their ears.

“Mr. Rossi?” one of them asks.

Luca nods and takes my hand in his, squeezing it gently.

“Right this way,” the man says and then turns around, silently commanding us to follow. And we do, traversing through the smoky, crowded room full of flashing lights and piercing noises. When we reach the elevators, the seven of us pile in and as we move up the floors, our eyes land on the numbers changing on the screen above the door. It’s only two floors and Luca’s hand lands on my ass. He can’t resist me either, it seems.

Leaning into him, I rest my head against his shoulder and feel that flutter in my stomach.

Detrimental.

The end.

When the doors open, we all file out and are greeted by two men who I assume to be Declan and his partner, Blake.

“Luca. Glad to meet you in person. I’m Declan MacKenna, and this is my ma—husband, Blake,” Declan says, his eyes flicking to where Luca holds my hand. “You’re both very welcome here.” He meets my eyes for a moment and the corner of his mouth curls up. “Blake rarely lets me go anywhere unsupervised, either.”

Blake grins and leans into Declan’s side, looking both smug and mischievous. “I’ve made myself indispensable. He really can’t get rid of me.”

Luca’s lips curl up on one side. “I have the same problem.”

I tug on his hand in silent annoyance but he doesn’t let me go, just holds on tighter. My heart melts, dripping into my lungs until I find it hard to breathe.

Damn him.

“It’s only a problem for me on days that end with Y,” Declan says blandly, that half-smile still teasing at his mouth, pretending to ignore Blake’s huff. “I’ve set aside a suite for you. These gentlemen will escort you.” He nods at one of the security team, who nods back.

“Thank you,” Luca replies.

“Of course. Anything for a friend. And I have something else for you. The coordinates of where Henry went. My men haven’t let him out of their sights.”

He turns toward his desk and Blake moves with him.

“I have the coordinates here,” Declan says, handing Luca a folded piece of paper. “This is in the middle of nowhere, so make sure you’re well-supplied for contingencies. I’d take care when approaching him. He’s volatile, and he’s strong. Hurt Blake’s arm, the little shit.”

Luca meets my gaze subtly, an eyebrow arching. Blake doesn’t seem to have a hurt arm. Maybe it wasn’t that bad after all. Does Declan have a penchant for exaggeration?

Perhaps. I know Luca would murder someone for touching me as well, so it’s possible he just didn’t like Henry touching him.

“We’ll handle it,” Luca replies with a nod. “Thank you for this. Seems the Costellos are indebted to you.”

“I do love a debt.”

“He does,” Blake adds. “Although, the way he calls them in can be… unexpected.”

Declan rolls his eyes as he chuckles. “Only for you, darlin’, only for you.”

Blake flushes and shoves at Declan, who pulls him into his side, holding him steady.

“Anyway, good luck. You’ll need it. This is as involved as I’ll get,” Declan says, a small dismissal.

Luca nods, reaching out his hand and shaking it. “We appreciate the coordination.”

Declan nods, and we turn and make our way from his office.

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19

LUCA

We spend the afternoon milling around in the casino, ordering food and drinks before being persuaded by Quincy to watch the beginning of a show the hotel is hosting.

"Come on, guys. It's a tiger. I haven't seen one since I was a kid and went to the circus."

The way he pleads with us, we all find ourselves in a large conference room. The lights are dim and people are sitting in chairs, watching the performance that's already started.

"Is that tiger really named Tony?" Jax asks as he watches the tiger do some tricks on stage. There is a man, nervously sweating, holding a large lit-up ring in his hand.

"Yeah, that's what the banner says," Viktor replies.

"Yeah, guess you're right. It's kinda funny. Oh fuck. The trainer looks like he's going to pee his pants," Jax adds, making Quincy snort.

"He looks ready to faint."

"Maybe he should find a new profession," Jax says.

"Seems like that might be for the best."

As they continue to comment back and forth, Viktor links his hand with mine as he sits on my lap, blushing when I lean over and whisper in his ear. "How is your ass, kitten?"

Viktor bites his bottom lip, peering at me over his shoulder. "Just right."

"Mm. You took it so good, though, didn't you?"

"I always do."

He’s right. He does. I look forward to many more years exploring his insatiable need for it. For me.

My mind drifts to earlier when we were dropping off our bags in our room. When we set them on the ground, Viktor took the lube from his suitcase and set it on the bed, leaning forward and wiggling his ass.

“You need it already? You couldn’t wait?” I asked him as I unzipped his pants and dragged them down his sexy thighs. The way his ass looked in those panties…

They’re sitting in my pocket right now. Torn to shreds. Might have even done it with my teeth.

“It’s been four hours. I’ve basically been deprived,” he replied with a wicked grin.

“We wouldn’t want you deprived, kitten.” So I spread those flushed cheeks and put him out of his misery.

I fucked that tight, wet hole without inhibition, without thought. The only thing running through my mind was how good he felt, how sexy he sounded. Our skin slapped loudly as I railed into him, our groans spilled around us, through the floor, walls, and right out the window. For all of Vegas to hear. It was electric, my entire body thrummed when I came. Viktor wasn’t far behind me, releasing on a muffled shout, his teeth sinking into the flesh of his forearm. The way his hole clenched around my cock made my vision white out.

Heaven.

Fucking bliss.

“You’re still dripping out of me, by the way,” he says, and I growl as I nip at his jaw.

“I’ll fill you up again, baby,” I reply, and he purrs as I adjust him on my lap. The show has progressed, the tiger doing tricks before us, its large paws carrying him stealthily across the stage, its head swiveling as if assessing the crowd.

“It looks pissed, like it’s going to eat us,” Jax says, and Quincy nods.

“Looks like it’s hungry.”

“Probably needs a snack,” Jax says with a shiver. “Think we’re safe back here? I think tigers can jump really far. Or is that cheetahs?”

“No clue,” Quincy says and then laughs. “But that tiger looks far too intelligent to be around people. It looks calculating. Like a serial killer.”

Just as he says it, the tiger lifts its lips in an almost smirk before lunging forward and letting out a roar.

Everyone jumps back slightly, eyes wide, screams filling the air. When they realize he's not going to eat them, nervous chuckles filter around the space.

"Fuck, that's creepy," Jax says a little too loudly, and the tiger seems to hear it. Its eyes narrow as it glances around the crowd, looking for who said that.

"I think you've offended it," I say lowly, a laugh tightening my chest. "Perhaps we should leave before you do more damage."

Viktor nods in agreement and is the first to stand up, his ass flexing as he moves. I can't help but reach out and touch it.

"It's probably time to go, anyway. It's getting dark and it will take about forty-five minutes to get to the coordinates," Viktor says, leaning into me.

"You're the boss."

"Am I?"

"The boss of the bedroom," Jax says with a snort, and I glower at him, making him shrink back. "Just kidding. I don't know what you guys do in the bedroom, and I don't want to know…" He shifts nervously on his feet, and I move my gaze from him.

"Alright, kitten. Lead the way."

I pull out a cigarette and he lights it. A well-oiled machine. My lungs inhale the bitter smoke and I see Vik grin at me as his fingers link with mine.

"You ready?" I ask, a question meant only for him, and he nods.

"We have what we need to take him down. We'll finish this. Tonight."

"Good. Let's show this fucker who's boss."

The drive into the desert as the sun sets is eerie. Shadows from the surrounding mountains cast a dusky glow on the barren stretch before us. Everyone is packed into an SUV, each of the men silently loading their guns and making sure everything is in order just in case the world goes to shit. And knowing Henry, it's quite possible. Seems he's smarter than we

realized. And he's proven to be more formidable than I ever gave him credit for.

"Shame we couldn't go to see Red Rock Canyon," Viktor says. "I heard it's a great place to spend an afternoon."

"If we make it out of here, we can go see it."

He peers over at me. "Promise?"

"I promise, kitten. Everything will be fine."

I don't know that, but I say it anyway. I need to reassure myself and my men. And more importantly, I need Viktor to know that everything will be all right. That we'll come out of this stronger. Better.

The two of us. Together.

"And when we're done, when we get back from Vegas, we'll make plans to go visit my aunt and uncle."

He peers over at me. "You that serious about me?"

"Yeah, he is," Jax interjects and then murmurs his apologies. "Just, you know, it's *fucking obvious*."

I peer back at him, and he leans back, turning his gaze to the GPS.

"Jax is right. I am serious. I want you to meet my family. What's left of it."

He flushes and nods. "Yeah, okay. I'd love that."

I pull his hand up and kiss it gently.

"Right up here," Jax interrupts, leaning forward from the back middle seat. "Or at least, I think so. This is what the phone says."

"It's probably right," Viktor replies as he turns off onto a bumpy dirt road and slows down slightly as dust billows up around us.

"Looks like it's about a mile down here. Fuck, this is shitty," Jax adds. "What a creep. Worse than the tiger."

"Way worse," Quincy adds. Rafe, on the other hand, is quiet, his eyes scanning the horizon. It's getting darker with each passing minute and soon the sun will be completely behind the mountains, making this place completely dark.

Cavernous. Deathly.

My breath hitches slightly, and Viktor peers over at me, concern in his gaze.

It's nothing. It's all in my head. I said everything would be fine. I promised.

“Park here,” I bite out, far too harshly, but needing to center myself. “We’ll walk up. I don’t want him to see us coming.”

“If he’s even there. He’s slipperier than a damn eel. And I know. I’ve tried catching one,” Jax murmurs.

Viktor parks and turns the car off, all of us sitting in silence for a solid minute. And then we exit, our eyes moving around us, taking everything in. It’s nothing but miles of flat land before us, full of sand and dry desert shrubs.

As we get closer and closer to our destination, my adrenaline starts spiking. In the distance is a rickety shack and an old, worn RV parked next to it. If we didn’t have a little light left and those specific coordinates, we’d have missed this completely. There is nothing that would indicate this was out here, and with the darkness the desert affords, we’d have never found it.

“Careful. It could be some kind of lab. Do not enter if at all possible,” I hiss. Everyone nods, and I make sure my gaze catches Viktor’s. “You, too. You stay next to me.”

He doesn’t respond, just narrows his gaze, looking forward once more. His gun is in his hand, shoulders tight with tension. The only sounds around us are our footsteps and the occasional ragged breath.

When we approach the shack and RV, we stop abruptly, eyeing the perimeter, searching for movement, for the sound of someone, but we see and hear nothing.

It’s silent, eerily so.

As if this is just a ghost of a place.

This is never fucking good, I think as I take a step forward, all of us fanning out, including Viktor, who ignores my command for him to stay near me.

Fucking hell, I think as I turn toward him, following him as he moves toward the RV. He rolls his eyes when he sees me trailing behind him, but I refuse to let him out of my sight.

I won’t fucking lose him.

Not today.

I promised.

He moves to the side of the RV, peering through the sun-battered window, and then slides toward the door. He puts his back against the side, reaches out, and tugs the door open, taking a deep breath and peering inside.

“Do not go in there,” I hiss, but he ignores me and does what he’s told not to. But then again, this is his job. This is what he’s good at. With swift and agile movements, he steps inside, my agitation at an all-time high. My stomach is churning, my vision clouding as I follow behind him. But after a few seconds, when nothing bad happens, I realize that perhaps I’m being a little too overprotective.

I stand in that empty RV and realize I’m panicking for nothing.

It’s just that I’ve finally found something…someone. Someone who makes me happy, who I crave, who I want to spend decades exploring. I don’t want to lose him.

Not yet.

Viktor, oblivious to the way my mind is reeling, steps past me, looking smug, as I grumble that he needs to listen to me.

“I’m fine, Luca. This is my job. Let me do it.”

I stop him with a fist to the collar of his shirt and pull him toward me. My lips descend on his and I kiss him thoroughly.

He needs to know.

He needs to fucking know.

Our lips part, and he stares into my eyes. “I know, baby.”

It’s a whisper, an understanding, and then the sound of an explosion rocks the shell of the RV, the cabinets flying open, plates tumbling out and onto the counters.

My heart rate spikes as Viktor pushes past me and out the door, gun drawn, his long legs carrying him away. I follow and come to an abrupt stop when I see the flames bursting from the top of the shack, the rickety roof looking like some kind of bonfire.

“What the fuck! What happened?” Viktor shouts, and Rafe and Quincy approach, gasping, their faces bleeding, soot lining their skin and clothes.

“We—Jax said he saw someone!”

“Where the fuck is he?” Viktor shouts.

“He’s inside. I told him not to go!” Quincy shouts, and before I can stop him, before I can keep him against me, keep him safe, Viktor bolts forward, straight toward the entrance. And with a single blink, he disappears.

Into the flames, into the fire.

He’s gone.

Swallowed up, the flames licking across the entrance he just ran through.

I stare at it, that dark, hellish space. The black smoke billows out, choking me. I claw at my shirt, the heat oppressive, peeling my skin from my bones. Everything collides at that moment. The past and present. I can't breathe, can't think. He's gone. Everything's gone.

He's not coming back.

He's gone.

My knees hit the gravel and pain pulses up my limbs. My hands are numb, my face too, and my throat is closing. I can feel them. The spiders, crawling across my skin, biting me, eating me alive. Someone is touching my back, shouting at me, but I can't even inhale enough to respond. I can't think, my mind is gone. I'm just that little boy again. Stuck in that cabinet, trying not to die.

Suddenly, the roof collapses, the sound loud enough to drag my swollen eyes up to that burning door. As I stare at it, gulping down painful breaths, I see Jax stumble through, coughing loudly.

But not Viktor.

He's not here.

He's gone.

Jax wheezes and falls to the ground, his head bowed, some of his hair singed.

Rafe and Quincy move toward him, all talking at once, and I try like hell to say something, to fight the panic bubbling inside of me. Because I need to get to him. I need to go in there and find him.

"Where is Viktor?" I hear someone scream, someone that is most likely me, and Jax rasps, "I dunno. I didn't see him. That place was…oh fuck, it was a maze of small rooms and junk everywhere."

Oh god. He's going to die. He's going to burn alive, just like them.

Don't leave me! Come back!

I gasp, my lungs contracting.

I inhale the flames. They're scorching. No one survives that.

No one can, not even Vik. My Vik…

My mind reels, and suddenly I'm back in that small crawlspace, listening as my mom screams for her life, the scent of gasoline overpowering as the men sneer. The gunshots, the scent of blood mixing with all of it.

I peer through the small wooden slats and I see my mom reaching for me, blood pooling at the corner of her mouth. Her lips move, and I see what

she says.

“Get him, Luca. Go get him.”

I snap out of it, gasping and clawing at my hair, tears sliding down my cheeks as I push myself up on shaking legs and stumble forward. I feel hands grab at me, but I don’t stop. I need to get him. I need to find him.

“Get him, Luca. Go get him.”

My mom’s voice is clear, as if I never forgot it.

I will. I’ll get him.

As I draw closer and closer to the flames, my gaze widens, my eyes blurry, stinging.

I won’t let him die. I’ll fight.

This time, I’m going to fight.

I step forward, the fire licking at my skin, searing my clothes, setting me ablaze, but I don’t stop.

I keep going. I have to keep going.

I won’t stop. I won’t hide.

My feet carry me forward, my heartbeat thumping loudly in my ears. The oppressive smoke makes it hard to see, and I pull my shirt over my mouth and nose as I move through the crumbling building. It’s bigger than it looked from the outside, an entire addition on the back. Jax was right. It’s almost like a maze.

“Viktor!” I shout, my voice breaking. “Vik!”

But I hear nothing, just the crackling of embers, the rush of the flames, the sound of my frantic heartbeat.

“Vik!” I plead as I try desperately to catch sight of him, his elusive ghost.

Just one more glance. One more touch.

I just want to hold him in my arms once more.

I want to spend years learning the intricacies of him. I want to memorize the entirety of him.

As I continue to move around the confusing space, I stumble over a fallen beam, catching myself on something already aflame, my hands burning, but I don’t feel it. I feel nothing, just resolution, resolve.

I have to get to him.

I turn a corner and run into something, a long table that’s not on fire yet. There are large glass containers, plastic bins, and burners. Something used to make the drugs. When the fire hits that, everything will explode again.

Fuck, I need to find him before that happens. I spin in a circle and rush into the next room, not finding him there either, just the peeling wallpaper of the olden days being devoured by the flames.

My heart rate ratchets up, and I wheeze behind the shirt over my nose and mouth, trying to quell the panic. I can lose it later.

Right now, I need to locate Viktor.

What if Henry took him? What if Viktor isn't even here?

His face appears in my mind, his lips turned up in a smile, and I feel a flutter in my chest as I trip over something on the ground. I look down at the object and that's when I see him.

His body is prone below me, flames moving toward him from the side, trying to consume him.

Fuck!

I kneel with a sob, scooping him up into my arms and holding him to my chest. *I could die like this*, I think as I stare at his handsome face. He's bleeding from a gash in his forehead, his eyes closed, not moving. But he's alive. I can feel the thrum of his pulse under my finger. So with a strength I didn't know I possessed, I pull him up off the floor, situate him over my shoulder, and stumble through the back door.

Just as we exit, the entire building begins to collapse, flames shooting out and hitting my back. The second explosion rocks me forward. But I don't feel any of it. I feel nothing but relief that I found him.

I have him.

Oh god, I found him.

Hands are on me immediately, putting out the flames moving across my clothes, but I don't care.

I just need Viktor to wake up.

Wake up. Wake up.

I lay him on the ground and hover over him, cradling his cheeks as he slumps in my arms. He's breathing, but fuck, he's not conscious.

I peer up at Jax, Quincy, and Rafe, all of them standing guard, all of them looking wrecked.

"Where is he? Henry," I rasp, and they shake their heads.

"I don't know. I thought he was in there. But he wasn't. Fuck!" Jax curses and then coughs loudly, his lungs trying to take in air. We all probably have some kind of smoke inhalation. "But this is where he was making Pink…shit."

“I saw that. Goddammit,” I growl and then push up onto my feet. “We need to leave. We need to get him to the hospital.”

I move to pick Viktor up again, but my body screams at me. The adrenaline is still pulsing through me, the panic numbing the pain, but still, I feel some of it. A buried throb, an internal ache.

“You’re burned. Let me,” Rafe interjects, but I stop him with a blunt command.

“No one touches him but me.”

Rafe nods, taking a step back, and I grunt, my arms trembling as I pull Viktor into them. His head lolls back, and I jostle him slightly, my arms under his back and knees as I take a step forward. And then another. Everything is burning, everything filtering in and out between reality and a dream.

My mom. My brothers.

My dad.

Flames. Fire.

When we finally make it to the car and Rafe drives us down that dirt road, we’re jostled by every bump and everything starts to hurt—searing, blinding pain. I grit my teeth, my jaw popping as I fist my blistered hands. My vision blurs, flickers of light making me blink wildly.

I know I’m injured. My legs, my lower back, my forearms—all attacked by the flames. But deep down, I don’t care because Viktor is breathing beside me, still passed out from the apparent knock he took to the head, but alive.

My swollen fingers trail across his bruised cheek, and I swallow the pain.

It was worth it.

All of it was worth it.

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20

VIKTOR

I wake up slowly, the beeping in the background an annoyance. I just want to go back to sleep. But my mind tells me to wake up. With great reluctance, my eyelids flutter open and I see white walls and half-open blinds—it's a hospital room.

"He's waking up," I hear a voice say, and a moment later I see Bane, his eyes wide, a bruise on his jaw. "Oh, thank God. We were so worried."

"Wh—" I begin, but my voice is hoarse, almost too low. It doesn't sound like me. I feel something in my nose and realize I'm wearing oxygen. Suddenly, it all comes filtering back to me, the wooden shack, the eerie inside, the lab equipment. And the knock to the head. I don't remember anything after that. I swallow, my throat clicking as Bane lifts a cup to my lips. I sip water from the straw, feeling instant relief.

"Where were you? You disappeared," I rasp and then blink slowly, trying to remember what happened. What happened to me?

"Oh, I was around and doing…things."

I stare at him and he thrusts something in my hand. "A wedding gift."

"What?"

"A gift. For your wedding."

I stare down at it. A toe as a pendant.

"Thank you," I say, wondering if perhaps I've died and gone to Heaven. What the fuck is Bane talking about? Wedding?

"Bane, you're smothering him," Tatum says, shooing him away and touching my arm gently. "How are you? We were so worried."

“Luca,” I say, suddenly remembering that he was right behind me when I rushed into the building. Oh god. No.

The fire.

Luca.

Tatum’s eyes flash, something I can’t quite identify moving through.

“Yes, Luca. He’ll be back soon.” He winks at me, and I’m left in a state of confusion, slightly numb as I try to recall the details of what happened. I can’t remember much, just that something hit me on the head and then everything went black. I stare down at my hands and see both of my arms are wrapped with bandages, and I wonder if the fire got me.

“You were burned. They aren’t as bad as Luca’s, but you will need to take care of them for a while,” Anthony says, walking through the doorway. He looks impeccable as always and he touches my leg over the blanket covering it. “I’m glad you’re okay.” His voice breaks slightly and he clears it. “I’m really fucking glad.”

“What happened? Where is he?” I ask, almost frantic now.

“Just being taken care of. He’ll be back shortly.”

My heart rate spikes and I feel sweat bead on my forehead. I feel like I’m going to pass out. “He…he got burned?”

“Yes. He went into the fire, looking for you.”

I can’t breathe, my chest aching. “Why?”

“To save you.”

“He shouldn’t have done that.”

“He wouldn’t have had it any other way. And neither would I.”

Just as he says that, Jax enters, pushing Luca in a wheelchair. Jax looks a bit haggard but whole, as he winks and smiles at me. My eyes slide down to Luca. He’s wearing a hospital gown, his arms, hands, and legs wrapped in white bandages, but his face is just as perfect as before, untouched, unscarred. He looks like himself, like home.

His eyes meet mine, and his lips turn down. My heart is in my throat. Everyone can see it, can hear it pounding. It’s clear from the monitor pinging loudly next to me.

“Hello, kitten. Glad you’re awake.” His voice is hoarse as well. Most likely from smoke inhalation.

My breathing saws in and out of me as he’s wheeled up next to me, and his bandaged hand reaches out and gently touches mine.

“You saved me.”

“I told you to stay near me and you ran into the flames. I had no other choice.”

“Luca.” It’s a gasp, a wheeze.

“I walked through fire for you, baby.”

“Oh my god,” I whisper as tears leak down my face.

“You should have listened to me, but you didn’t. Never again.”

“I know, but you’re not the boss of me.”

“I literally am.” His mouth is set in a frown and his fingers reach out, the bandages rubbing against the tears streaking down my cheeks.

“Not always.”

Luca arches an eyebrow at me, and I melt as his gaze meets mine. “I’m going to have to punish you when we’re better. For disobeying.”

I huff a small laugh and then cough. “Yeah, alright. I’ll accept it.”

“Good. Now I’m going to kiss you, kitten. Soft and gentle because you’re hurt, but when things improve, I’m going to make you bleed.”

“Do it. Please,” I whisper, needing his lips on mine.

He leans up from his chair and our mouths meet in a sweet, soft kiss before he falls back.

“Oh, the first kiss as husbands!” Bane cries and then slaps a hand over his mouth.

“Why the fuck does he keep saying that?” I ask Luca.

“Oh! Me! I know! He put a gun to a priest’s head and made him marry you!” Bane blurts again and then slaps another hand over his mouth, his eyes wide, dancing with laughter.

“What the fuck, Luca!”

“What?” He doesn’t move his eyes from me, unashamed and unrepentant.

“You married me? You didn’t even get my consent, you asshole. You can’t just go around doing that shit.”

“Why would I get your consent when I knew what you’d say?”

“Luca,” I say with a growl. “That’s not a thing. Plus, it’s against the law.”

“You would have said fucking yes. Why bother asking? And we break the law all the time. It’s our job.”

“You are such a shit.” I look down at my hand and meet his eyes once more. “And where the hell is my ring? Hm? You married me and didn’t deliver.”

“On order,” he replies. “Rush delivery. Don’t worry, kitten. I have all bases covered.”

“Well, I’m not saying yes. I’ll think on it.”

Luca arches an eyebrow. “You know you’re fucking ecstatic and you’re going to wear that fucking ring until we die. You’d say yes in a heartbeat if you weren’t such a stubborn little shit.”

My face heats, and I shrug. “I’m pissed at you. That’s what this is. Marrying me without consent.”

“I’ll make you fucking admit that this was a genius idea. When I get these damn things off.” He holds his arms up, and I see the bandages, really realizing for the first time since I woke up what he did for me. He must see the pain on my face because he shakes his head.

“Don’t. It was hard. But it was worth it.”

The sincerity in his voice makes me melt. “I’m still mad at you. Mostly. And I want a fucking actual wedding, when…no *if*, I say yes.”

He huffs a laugh. “Fine, pretty boy. We can have your wedding. Whatever you want, whenever you want. As long as you say yes.”

I eye him, and he winks at me.

“I think that’s a yes,” Bane whispers loudly, and Tatum nudges him roughly.

“We need to get you out of here before you ruin any more surprises.”

My gaze meets Luca’s—my husband—and I raise my eyebrows.

“Are there more surprises?”

“No, not that I can think of. But,” he leans forward and lowers his voice so only I can hear, “if I could get you pregnant, I would.”

My breath catches, and he grins at me.

“I may have to try. Fill that hole up as much as I can.”

My dick starts to perk up just as Doc walks in, looking amused.

“No more making his heart race, Luca. Honestly, keep it in your pants, you two.”

Anthony huffs a laugh, and Bane cackles. “No one likes it in their pants, Doc.”

“Definitely not you,” Doc replies.

Bane grins and wiggles on his feet. Anthony clears his throat and then nods to Tatum. “Why don’t you and Jax take Bane and get him some hot chocolate?”

Tatum nods and then links arms with Bane, dragging him out of the room, and Jax follows behind. This leaves Luca and me, Doc and Anthony.

When we're sure Bane is gone, Anthony sits on the edge of my bed as Doc checks me over.

"We will get you moved home tomorrow. The doctor says your head scans are clear and as long as we continue to monitor you for a concussion, we should be good to go," Anthony says. "But first, do you remember anything that happened?"

I shake my head. "Just that I ran in looking for Jax and before I could even start looking, I was hit in the head with something and blacked out."

"Must have been a wicked hit. Did you see anyone?"

"Not that I remember."

Anthony runs a hand over his jaw and sighs. "Jax thinks Henry might have hit you with something and fled."

"You didn't find him?"

"No, and that's the reason I didn't want Bane here. He will lose it when he finds out we were so close and we didn't get him."

"Yeah. So what do we do now?"

Anthony looks at Luca. "Well, you two will focus on getting better and while you're healing, I've asked Mikhail to come over with Angel, despite him being in retirement of sorts. He said he'd help us deal with the Sirens."

"Shit."

"He's arriving tomorrow. And then we have a meeting. We'll set them straight and if they don't listen, we burn them to the ground."

Luca winces, and Anthony lowers his chin slightly. "They're definitely the ones behind the misinformation and the distribution."

"And the dead bodies? Who's been dropping them off?"

"No idea, but I'm betting it's someone linked to either Henry or the Sirens. Either way, we'll eventually get them to talk."

"Good," I say, and Luca sighs.

"That's all we know. Now, can I have some time alone with my husband?"

Anthony stands, and Doc finishes up with me, the two of them leaving the room moments later.

Luca's gaze meets mine and his bandaged hand touches my biceps.

"Mine," he whispers, and I lean my head back against the pillow. I ache and I'm exhausted, but I've never felt more alive.

“Yours.”

Luca and I returned home the next day, and Anthony hired a burn unit nurse to come to the house to take care of Luca while he recovers. It’s not needed, but he insisted. His second-degree burns, I found out, are not only on his arms and legs, but on his back as well. They’re not as bad as they could have been, but he will have scars once he’s recovered.

And I can’t help the guilt that overcomes me every time I see him.

What he did for me. What he risked.

“Stop looking at me like that,” he grumbles, his voice still rough. “I don’t regret it.”

“I do,” I say as I gingerly touch his bandages. He’s currently reclining in bed, and even though he’s still on medication for the pain, he is handling this entire situation better than I expected. Better than I would have been. I only suffered first-degree burns on my forearms and hands. Nothing major. Nothing life-changing.

“Will you admit you should have listened to me?” he asks, and I roll my eyes.

“If I’d known you’d be this hurt, I might have given it a second thought.”

“Good to know where I fall on your list of priorities.”

I let out a small laugh just as a nurse comes into the room. Nancy is older, no-nonsense, and takes zero shit from Luca.

“Alright, lovebirds. It’s time for me to change his bandages.”

“I’ll stay if that’s alright,” I say.

“That’s fine, but no blubbering like last time.”

Luca lets out a small snort and then winks at me. “My husband does get rather emotional when it comes to me.”

“I do not.”

I sniffle, already feeling slightly emotional as I step aside to let Nancy near the bed. Luca meets my gaze and his lips turn down. “Viktor, I don’t need you to stay. Just go find something to eat while she does this. I’m sure Angel would like to catch up as well. I’ll be out as soon as I’m done.”

“You will not. You’ll rest until the pain subsides,” Nancy bites out and then arches an eyebrow as if daring him to challenge her.

Luca glowers at her but goes ignored. Anthony definitely got it right when he hired her.

“You sure?” I finally ask, wanting to stay and offer support, but also dreading having to see the reddened skin under those bandages.

“I’m sure, kitten. Now go.”

I turn and walk out, my stomach rumbling. How he always knows when I’m hungry is fucking obnoxious. He’s more in tune with me than I thought. I never stood a chance when it came to him.

“Oh! Viktor! I was just coming to find you,” Angel says, rushing toward me, his eyes wide with concern, his cheeks flushed. “I heard what happened. Oh my god, you’re so hurt.”

His fingers flutter around my bandaged arms and then fall to his sides just as his husband, Mikhail, walks up behind him. The formidable Russian mob boss, brought to heel by an angel.

“How are you feeling? How’s Luca?”

“He’s stubborn and still an asshole. But he’s fine.”

A laugh bubbles out of him and he swallows it down. “Oh, I shouldn’t laugh. I’m just so glad you’re both okay. Dad told me what happened. It’s horrific but also so lovely.”

“Yeah, he saved me. Dickhead.”

Angel’s arms go up to his chest and he clutches his heart. “It’s so romantic. I mean, saving you from the fire, marrying you while you were unconscious. Just a dream. Don’t you think so, Mikhail?”

I peer up at his husband, his stern face softening slightly. “Of course. Though I didn’t marry you without your consent, you did save me, remember?”

“I did.”

He leans into Mikhail’s chest, and Mikhail kisses the top of his head. My stomach rumbles loudly once more, and Angel perks up.

“Oh, you’re hungry. Come on. Are you up for sitting on the porch? Teddy made us some treats and tea.”

“Yeah, I think sitting would be good.”

Angel nods as we walk side by side to the porch where Anthony and Tatum are waiting, a small table set out with plates of food and steaming cups of tea. I lower myself into a chair, and Anthony tilts his chin up at me.

“I assume Luca is being difficult,” he says, making Tatum snort.

“Like always.”

He huffs a laugh and then adds, “That’s why I hired Nancy. She doesn’t fuck around. And I knew Viktor would get too emotional tending to him himself.”

“I would not. I’m a man.”

Anthony rolls his eyes. Tatum grins at me and then hands me a cup of tea. “Well, either way, it was a good choice. I heard her tell him to shut up when he was trying to boss her around.”

“Good. He needs someone to put him in his place so he can recover.”

“Oh, god, I’m so glad to be home,” Angel says with a sigh, sitting down on Mikhail’s lap. “I missed this.”

“It’s not nearly as cold here,” Mikhail says, and Angel nods, snuggling up to his husband.

“It’s not. I do miss the warm weather.”

“It will be better in the summer,” Mikhail replies, and Angel reaches back and threads their hands together.

“I know, my love. I’m not saying I want to move. Just making a comparison.”

Mikhail looks slightly placated at that when Teddy appears with another plate of small cakes. He’s trailed by a man I don’t recognize, and Angel must catch my stare because he says, “Oh, this is Jake. I brought him to show him the gardens. He’s the gardener I hired to take care of mine in New York.” He leans a little closer to me, and whispers, “And I think Teddy and him have a thing.”

My eyebrows rise as Teddy blushes when Jake smiles at him, signing something.

Suddenly, Bane appears and gasps when he sees Jake’s hands moving.

Without a word, he seamlessly interrupts with a waggle of his hand, and then Jake and Bane are chatting fluidly.

It’s amazing to watch and it confirms that I need to learn. I’ll sign up for a class as soon as my arms are healed.

Bane snorts a loud laugh, and Jake huffs, all while Teddy watches, his eyes following the conversation.

Not that he’s participating, but he is listening.

“They’re too fast for me to know what they’re saying, but it’s fine. We don’t need to snoop. It’s not often Jake has someone to chat with. Although

the guards are learning. I'm so proud of all of them," Angel says.

"They'd do anything for their little husband," Mikhail says, and Anthony puts a cup of tea to his lips, holding back a smile.

It must make him incredibly pleased to know his sons are with men who love them, who will take care of them.

"Where are the guards, anyway?" Angel asks.

"Meeting with Anthony's men. To prepare for the meeting with the Sirens."

"Oh, okay, and I know that is important, but they may be hungry…"

As they continue to speak to one another, Anthony leans forward so only I can hear, and says, "Just so you know, I've invited Luca's aunt and uncle to stay with us while Luca recovers. I told his aunt what happened and she wanted to come see him."

My heart rate picks up, my palms starting to sweat. "Oh. Oh fuck. Seriously?"

"Yes, Viktor, you're going to meet his family."

I stare down at my lap and then back at Anthony. "Do they know we're married?"

"I thought it would be best for you both to tell them."

"When will they arrive?"

"Tomorrow. I wanted you to know so you can prepare."

"Thank you," I murmur, feeling my cheeks flame and my heart pound. "Does Luca know they're coming?"

"I'll tell him after our meeting later today. We need to go over the logistics of dealing with the Sirens. I'd like you in attendance, if you're feeling up to it."

"I'll be there."

He nods and then hands me another cake. "Luca wanted me to make sure you were eating. As if I didn't take care of you all those years." He rolls his eyes slightly, and I huff a small laugh.

"He's controlling."

"He's a menace, but I love him like a brother, so I can excuse most of it."

"I get it. He's an asshole."

As I say that, Luca is rolled out by Nancy, who is chastising him pretty thoroughly. An IV pole is being pushed out with him and he looks annoyed.

“Never point a gun at me again, you got it?” she hisses and then swats at his head as she parks him right next to me and puts the brake on the wheelchair.

“Luca, what the hell?” I say. “Stop pointing weapons at people. Especially the ones trying to help you.”

“She wanted me to wait. *Longer*. I fucking waited, Vik.” He pulls out a cigarette, but Nancy grabs it and tosses it aside into the bushes.

“You’re an idiot,” she hisses.

“You’re fired,” he growls.

Nancy slaps his head again and then moves down the porch. “I’ll be back tomorrow.”

Anthony nods and peers over at Luca, who is huffing and puffing. “She is a bitch. I fucking hate her.”

“She’s the only one who can handle you,” Anthony says.

I let out a small laugh, and Luca glowers at me. “Oh, you think this is funny?”

“Kind of. You are a shit.”

“So are you.”

“Fuck off,” I reply with a cough and then blush when he leans closer and whispers, “You’re also a slut. My slutty husband.”

I roll my lips between my teeth and swing my eyes out to the large estate, seeing Jake and Bane moving out to the gardens, the two of them continuing to chat in sign language while Teddy watches on, his lips in a small frown.

But before I can think too much about that, I see Casey move up the steps, followed by a few other guards I recognize from my short trip out to Mikhail’s home. When Casey’s eyes meet mine, he smiles.

“Look who the fuck it is. So good to see you, man.” Casey touches my shoulder gently and then nods at Luca.

“Heard you two fuckers got married.”

“I was forced,” I murmur, but still feel my heart flutter in remembrance.

“Yeah, you look real pissed about it,” Casey remarks and then lets out a laugh.

“Anyway, we’re ready for a debrief whenever you are. But Aggie said she had some food for us inside.” The men behind him all sigh in relief, as if they’ve just been starved for days.

“I think they need to eat and then we can have the meeting,” Angel interjects, standing up and walking inside.

The Russian guards look at Mikhail and then turn to follow their little husband inside.

It seems we all realize who rules the roost.

When they all disappear inside, Anthony turns toward Mikhail, lifting an eyebrow.

“I know. Do not say a word,” Mikhail grumbles. “You raised a very strong son. I have lost all of my control.”

Anthony laughs lowly, and I turn my gaze toward Luca, who is watching me intently.

“What?” I ask, feeling suddenly nervous.

“Just thinking how pretty you look.” I flush crimson, and he leans a little closer to me. “Husband.”

My skin tingles as he reaches out his fingertips and brushes against mine.

“Your ring arrives tomorrow.”

I glance down at my finger, the place where it will sit, before meeting Luca’s gaze once more.

“You’ll wear it,” he says. It’s not a question, but more of a command.

“Maybe,” I reply, but he can tell by the slant of my mouth and the pounding of my pulse that I will.

Once I can put it on, I’ll fucking wear it until I die.

And for the first time since laying eyes on Luca, I realize that I have him.

He’s mine.

“Your aunt and uncle will be visiting,” I say, breaking the news to him as we get situated in bed.

We had a meeting with Mikhail and his guards, as well as some of our own, preparing to confront the Sirens. It’s going to be bloody and messy, and when we found Bane on the other side of the wall, listening in on our meeting, we realized it’s going to be chaotic as well.

This could go horribly wrong.

All of it. And I'm dreading the repercussions.

"What do you mean?" Luca asks as he gets settled in bed. "When?"

"They arrive tomorrow."

"Shit. They're going to see me like this."

"That's the point. They want to see *you*. They're worried."

"Did you call them?"

"I didn't think to. Anthony did."

"Of course he did. Asshole."

"He cares."

"Yeah, but fuck, my aunt is going to cry, and I hate it when she does that."

He peers over at me, and I can't help but smile. "If anyone should be freaking out about them arriving, it's me."

"Why the fuck should you be freaking out?" Luca grumbles as I help him rearrange his pillows so he's comfortable.

"Because I'm meeting your family. What if they don't like me?"

Luca huffs. "They already love you. Stop being dramatic. Plus, we're already married." He looks so smug right now, and I wish I could punch him, but I wouldn't dare. Not with how injured he is. Right now, I just want him to get better, stay hydrated and rest. In a few weeks, I can touch him again. For the time being, I'm going to behave. "What the fuck are they gonna say? They can't object now. It's too late."

"You're such a dick," I murmur.

"Yeah, and you married me anyway."

I roll my eyes but shift closer to him, wanting to be connected at as many points as I can. I can't wait until he's healed and I can run my hands across his skin.

"I didn't actually say yes, but I haven't divorced you yet either, so I guess that's a win in your favor."

"You won't divorce me. You're too in love with me to do that."

I snort and our eyes meet, my body warming at his intense glare.

"I never said I was in love with you," I reply, my voice a whisper.

"Yeah, but I know you are. So admit it, kitten."

"Hell no. You first." I purse my lips and huff in annoyance. "How about you submit for once, Luca?"

"Never. That's all you, baby."

We're silent a moment, the tips of our fingers skimming each other's until I finally exhale.

"Fine. I may love you. A little."

Luca's grin widens and he bites his bottom lip. "That so, pretty boy? Well, that's good because I love you too. And don't ever think of divorcing me. This is it, Vik. You and me."

His fingers caress mine and fireworks shoot across my skin.

"Yeah, seems so." I lean forward and kiss him gently. I hover over him for a minute, our noses brushing, our breath mingling. "Seems I'm stuck with you."

"Yeah, you fucking are."

He leans up slightly and captures my mouth once more, making me swoon at the intimacy of it, and when we finally part, I lie next to him, realizing that I'm a lucky man.

Married to a possessive, overbearing asshole.

But he's mine, nonetheless.

"Oh, I have something else for you," he says, reaching over and grabbing something from the end table drawer.

I stare at the red rose in his hand and feel my eyes sting.

"Fuck you, Luca," I whisper as I take it from him.

"To new beginnings."

"Yes."

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21

VIKTOR

"Why are you fidgeting?" Luca asks, and I stare down at him.

"I'm meeting your fucking family, Luca. I'm nervous."

He scoffs. "You have nothing to be nervous about. They'll love you. Already do, in fact. Annoying, but I get it."

I sigh, and he lets out a small laugh.

"Fuck off."

"I'll fuck you when I'm better," he retorts, and I roll my eyes.

He's in his wheelchair, the IV bag still attached to his arm. He didn't want to see them like this, but I insisted he stay seated. He needs to rest. His aunt and uncle have seen him at his worst. Seeing him slightly incapacitated right now won't affect how they feel about him.

I hear the crunch of tires and my heart rate accelerates. I can feel the thrum in my ears as my skin starts to sweat.

"Breathe," he whispers as a woman and man step from the car. They're older, with graying hair and wrinkles lining their skin, but they still stand proud.

You can tell from the look in their eyes that they're survivors too. From what, I don't know, but still… They've been through a lot.

"Look at you!" Lyla croons, moving toward Luca and touching the top of his head gently. "You look wonderful."

"I look like shit. Don't fucking lie."

Lyla's lips turn down and she sighs loudly just as Stephano moves up behind her.

“He does look like shit, Lyla. No need to sugarcoat the truth.”

I can’t help the laugh that escapes me, and their eyes turn toward me all at once.

“Oh, you must be Viktor. No wonder Luca is in love with you. Look at how handsome he is, Stephano. All that hair. Just glorious.”

Luca grumbles under his breath, and I feel my cheeks heat. No one has ever mentioned my hair before. Except Luca. I still haven’t cut it. He likes it longer. Likes to grab it.

Luca wheels his chair a little closer to me, knocking me in the legs and piping up, “I’d rather you not make his head any bigger than it is. Dealing with him right now is insufferable.”

I glower down at him. “Fuck off. My head is just the right size.”

Luca pulls his bottom lip between his teeth and peers up at me.

“You love me,” he mouths, and my lips quirk.

I do.

Most of the time.

Always, actually.

How could I not? I married him. Well, he married me. While I was unconscious, but still. We’re husbands.

I have zero regrets. Especially after Bane told me how upset Luca was when I was brought to the hospital. Apparently, the priest was reluctant to do the ceremony, but Bane threatened him with losing his fingers, one by one, and he acquiesced. And here we are.

Married.

We still need to file the paperwork when Luca is well enough to make the trip, but the shiny new ring on my finger is proof enough for us.

“Well, let’s go inside,” Lyla says. “I want to hear everything. Anthony was very vague about what happened that got you two injured. I told him to keep you out of trouble.”

Luca stares down at his bandages and purses his lips.

“I’m fine. And you know I’m always in trouble.”

“He is, and honestly, he’s the worst patient,” I add, and Lyla chuckles, making me relax even further. Meeting them isn’t so bad.

They seem to genuinely like me. I don’t even know why I was nervous.

“He always was trouble. Quite the little punk. Would you like to hear some stories?”

She hooks her arm through mine, and we walk inside, leaving Stephano to push Luca behind us.

"I'd rather you keep those stories to yourself," Luca bites out but goes ignored. Lyla rattles off a few small tales of young Luca getting himself into trouble after coming to live with them, only to be interrupted by Bane prancing up to us in the foyer.

"Lyla! Stephano! You're finally here! I have presents!"

They beam at him, pulling him in for a hug and accepting the jewelry he's given them—a knuckle bracelet and an eyebrow encased in some kind of liquid to be worn as a pendant. No clue how he managed that one, but still… They don each item like they're the best presents they could have ever received.

As we move into the kitchen, Agatha greets everyone with smiles and cakes. Teddy is near the island, wearing his apron and pushing a few plates full of small sandwiches and scones toward Lyla and Stephano. He remains silent as always, but his cheeks flush when they compliment him on how good everything tastes. He peers over at Jake, who is sitting at the counter, signing very animatedly with Bane, and his lips fall open.

Fuck, Teddy better make his move. Or else he may miss out.

Anthony and Tatum appear, and suddenly, the entire room is filled with noise. I can barely make out what is being said. Through it all, Lyla's arm remains hooked through mine as she chats with everyone converging before us.

The calm before the storm, I think. Everyone is in one room. All the people I've come to love. My family.

Things may not always be this easy, this nice, I think. With the inevitable clash with the Sirens looming, Bane losing his mind a little more each day, and Mikhail here with Angel…well, I don't know what's going to happen, but it won't be good. I know that much. I can feel it.

It's thick and suffocating, a darkness settling on the horizon.

I reach down and touch the fingertips of my free hand to Luca's. He wets his lips as he stares up at me.

"Don't worry, Vik. We've got this," he murmurs, reading the anxiety on my face.

And we do. Together, we can do anything.

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EPILOGUE

BANE

"Why do you think he's ghosted me? Hm?" I ask the man tied to the chair. He's lost part of his scalp and one of his eyes, but I've left his ears. I know he can hear me. I've left them on for that very purpose.

I need someone to really *listen*.

"Teddy says he was leading me on—got what he wanted and then took off. But hey, I didn't give him *anything*. Except for my ass and my mouth, but…" I sigh and pick up my phone, staring down at my messages that are just sitting there—unanswered.

I hold it up to the man in the chair and when he doesn't answer, I wrench his head back, blood oozing from his scalp.

"Take a good look and give me your opinion."

The man moans. Very unhelpful indeed.

"Come on, Carl. I know you have an opinion. Telling me the truth won't make you any less dead."

When he doesn't answer me, I let his head flop down, and stare down at my bloodied hands.

Hm. I do like that color. I want it on a car.

A bone car. One I can use to transport victims to and from the property. I've been thinking about this a lot lately. Even have an auto shop picked out—a referral from Anthony, of course.

My dream can come true.

One of them at least.

I sigh and then stare back down at my phone.

“I should just…I shouldn’t unblock him, right? Teddy would be so disappointed in me.”

The man moans, and I peer over at him.

“You’re very unhelpful, Carl. I mean, why keep you alive if you’re just going to be such a crybaby?”

I pick up a saw and turn it on, the whirl of the machine making my blood zing with excitement. I’m over this guy. He already gave Anthony what he wanted. And since he hasn’t helped me at all, I think it’s time to just be done with it.

“Time to meet your maker, you cunt.”

I let out a loud laugh as the blade meets flesh and bone.

And when the top half of the man falls to floor, the bottom still tied to the chair, I turn the saw off and step back, deciding which parts to keep and which to dissolve. I have quite the collection. I love adding to it.

It’s quite the hobby.

With a flick of my fingers, I wipe the blood from my skin, watching the rest swirl and disappear down the drain.

“Well, now I have to shower,” I murmur as I take a step backward. “Good thing I got that new soap. Really smells nice…”

As I say this, something stings my neck and the room suddenly starts to spin.

My body sags to the right slightly, and strong arms grab me and hold me up.

“Wh—” I begin, but my mouth is slack, my tongue almost two sizes too big. *This is not good*, I think as I start to fade into the blackness.

And as I do, I hear my name—a whisper.

In a Russian accent.

Thank you Eliot Grayson for letting me borrow Declan, Blake and Tony the Tiger. They were so fun to include in this book. If you’d like to read more about them you can find them here.

Lucky or Knot (Tony the Tiger)

The Alpha’s Gamble (Blake and Declan)

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Cora Rose loves any kind of romance and consumes way too many books each year. She currently lives in the U.S. and spends her days daydreaming about the characters inside her head.

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